The Hour of Ash

Reading copy · Chapters 1–25

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Chapter 1

The Reception

I had been at my father's memorial reception for forty minutes when I wrapped a square of lemon cake in a paper napkin, put it in the pocket of my good black jacket, and started for the back stairs. I had not wanted the cake. It was the third lemon cake on the dessert table and the worst of the three, dense and damp, with a glaze that had gone clear as wet tissue under the gallery lights; it had been annoying me since I walked in. Three separate people had baked for my father, and all three had thought of lemon. Somewhere, I assumed, there was a pamphlet.

The upper gallery had been emptied of its cases for the afternoon, all but a long run of Coptic textiles bolted to the floor. The food stood on folding tables down the middle: foil trays of baked ziti, a crockpot of meatballs with its cord taped to the parquet, a sheet cake from the Acme with a trowel piped on it in chocolate icing. Sterno burned blue under the chafing dishes; a woman from the dean's office kept lifting the lids to check on things that did not need checking. At the far end a slide carousel was working its way through forty years of my father's trenches. It clicked, and a wall of mud brick in Cyprus came up, and held, and slid away into black while the projector fan hummed through the gap.

I had spent most of the forty minutes beside the textiles, watching the room the way I watched a cracked pot that had come up from storage, to see where the strain had gone. It had gone into the dean, who jingled the change in his pocket whenever he heard *Emilio*. It had gone into the graduate students, who stood in a clump by the meatballs and laughed too loudly once and then not at all. My mother had sent lilies from Phoenix, with a card that said, "Thinking of you, sweetheart, today and always." That was true. It was also more than she had said about my father since 1981.

Doug Fessler had given the eulogy. He had dug beside my father for eleven seasons in Cyprus and two in Sicily. He had flown in the night before from a winter season in Jordan, his forehead and nose burned the pink of boiled ham. When he leaned into the microphone, a flake of skin lifted on the bridge of his nose and stayed up, trembling. I watched it for most of what he said.

"Anybody who dug with Emilio Reyes knows what I mean when I say the man was generous with his time," he said. "He'd give you a night. He'd give you a whole season if you needed one. You'd come to him with a problem in your section and he'd climb down into it with you, into the mud, in his good shirt, and he'd stay down there until it made sense. I saw him give a whole Sunday to a kid from the village who wanted to know if the bones in our trench were his grandfather's." He looked at his notes, and lost his place, and found it. "Generous with his time," he said again, with his palm on the lectern, and all around the room people nodded at the floor.

Afterward the woman from the dean's office found me by the textiles with a paper plate, a square of lemon cake on it and a white plastic fork laid across the top.

"You haven't eaten," she said. "I've been watching you. You have to eat something."

"Is there coffee yet?"

"Have the lemon. It's Carol's, or else the slide library's, I can never keep them straight." She put the plate into my hands, and my hands, which had been doing nothing, closed on it. "They tell you no food in the galleries. The registrar nearly had a stroke. I said, Frank, it's Emilio, what's he going to do, put us in a case?" She laughed and stopped, alarmed at herself, and tipped her face up toward the ceiling. "Is that the Sterno? If the detectors go off, the whole building empties." She was already moving off toward the food. "Eat that," she said over her shoulder.

I had been holding the plate ever since.

The carousel had reached Sicily when I put the cake in my pocket. I knew those slides. I had seen them at our kitchen table every September of my childhood, projected onto a bedsheet thumbtacked over the china cabinet, my father's shadow crossing a temple when he leaned in to point. If I stayed for the Sicily tray I would stay for all of them, then for the coffee, then for the foil going down over the ziti and the line at the elevators where everyone would want to hold my hands.

I got as far as the meatballs. The dean stepped into my path there and took my hand in both of his.

"Mara. We'll be in touch about the lecture fund. Something in his name, every spring. He'd have hated it." He smiled at that, pleased with himself for knowing it. "Do you need a ride anywhere?"

"No. Thank you."

I got as far as the chafing dishes.

"There you are." Doug had a paper plate with a single stick of celery on it. Up close the sunburn had a rim, a pale line across his

forehead where his hat had sat for six weeks. “Tell me I didn’t go on.”

“You didn’t go on.”

“I cut a whole page. There was a story about Paphos, eighty-four, I had a sherd I couldn’t place, some ugly piece of local ware, and he sat up with me in the dig house until two in the morning going through the type series. He had a flight at seven.” “I cut it because I’d have cried. I’m in a borrowed tie. Did you notice? It’s my brother-in-law’s. He sells insurance in it. Royal Jordanian lost my duffel at Kennedy, every context sheet from the season, and they keep telling me it’s in Amman.” He put the celery in his mouth and spoke around it. “It isn’t in Amman. It’s in a cage in Queens, I’d put money on it.”

“I’m sorry about your sheets.”

“No, God, listen to me. Today.” He took the celery out again and frowned at it. “If you need anything. Boxes, his offprints, anything in the office. I can do the office.”

“Thank you.”

“Are you keeping the house?”

“Your nose is peeling.”

He touched it and looked at his fingertip. “The last week of every season he’d start in about that house. The porch. He was going to jack up the porch, he had it drawn out on the back of a context sheet. Every season. He talked about you, too, you know. On site. All the time.”

I said thank you again, which was what you said, and he patted my arm twice and went back toward the screen, where Sicily had given way to Turkey.

My coat was on a rolling rack by the elevators, and beside the rack, at the table with the guest book, stood my cousin Gloria in a navy suit. To reach the coat I would have had to pass her and be looked at. I went the other way, through the door marked STAFF

and down the back stairs, poured concrete painted battleship gray, the handrail wrapped in electrical tape where the paint had worn through. The stairs let out onto a loading dock on the south side of the building, where a security guard was eating a soft pretzel under the overhang and it was sleeting.

He stopped chewing and took in my jacket.

"You want me to call you a cab?"

"I'll find one."

"You won't, in this."

I went down the ramp into the weather.

* * *

I found one on Spruce Street, after two blocks with my shoulders up around my ears and the sleet working into my collar like cold sand. The cab smelled of wet wool and a cardboard pine tree; the driver had a man on the radio talking about roses. I gave him Pine Street and Tenth and sat back with the cake squashed against my hip.

"Shopping?" the driver said.

"Shopping."

"In this." He turned the radio up a notch.

On the radio the man said burlap, you leave the burlap on them till the forsythia comes out, and I wondered whether burlap and hessian, which the English on my father's digs called it, were the same cloth with two passports, and whether hessian had anything to do with the soldiers, and then we were over the river and the water below the bridge was the color of an old nickel.

"Where on Pine?" the driver said, at Tenth.

"Here's fine."

"Here's a hydrant." He pulled up at it anyway.

Antique Row was three blocks of narrow fronts with their lights on against the afternoon. I walked it slowly and looked into

each window long enough to fog it. A tall-case clock with a replaced finial; I could see the new wood from the sidewalk, too red and too sharp. A pair of Staffordshire dogs, one of them restored badly at the ear, the paint gone the wrong white. Then, in a window lettered in flaking gold, I. SZABO · MAPS · PRINTS · SMALL ANTIQUES, a Chinese export platter on a wire stand with a crack across it and four iron staples bridging the crack. Somebody had drilled half through the porcelain from the back, a little way into the body and not a hair farther, then laid the staples in hot and let them shrink. It had been done perhaps a hundred and fifty years ago by a man with a bow drill and a steady hand who would have been out of work in my department in a week, because you could see it from the street. I stood on the wet sidewalk and could have kissed him.

The door was locked; there was a buzzer. I pressed it and a woman in the back of the shop looked up from the counter and studied me through the glass for long enough that I began to feel the sleet in my shoes. A speaker over the door crackled.

"Yes? What is it?"

"To look," I said to the speaker.

The lock buzzed.

The shop was deep and narrow; it smelled of foxed paper and the hot dust on a space heater, whose orange bars glowed by the counter. Framed prints hung frame to frame on both walls, botanical plates, a Hogarth, the Battery in 1840; the back of the room was flat-file cabinets, gray steel, the kind every library sold off in the seventies. On a shelf behind the counter a small television played a college basketball game with the sound off. The woman at the counter was in her seventies, with a white braid pinned flat around her head, a liver-colored cardigan and fingerless gloves. She did not get up.

"You are dripping," she said.

"Sorry."

"Do not be sorry. Stand on the mat."

I stood on the mat. "The platter in the window. The stapled one. Could I see it?"

"Chinese export, about eighteen-twenty. It broke, and then a man put holes in it. Stapled does not sell. Americans want a thing like new or they want it in the garbage. You can see it from there."

"The holes don't go all the way through."

She looked at me properly then, over the top of a magnifier she had pushed up into her hair, and her eyes stopped on the pocket where the napkin was showing. "No," she said. "They do not. You do this for money."

"I work at the museum. In the conservation—"

"Museums do not shop on Pine Street." She turned a page of the ledger in front of her. "And you are not buying a platter in that jacket."

"What's wrong with the jacket?"

"Nothing. It is a good jacket for standing a long time in a room."

"I came from work," I said.

"On a Saturday."

"Conservators work Saturdays."

She made a small sound that was not quite a laugh. I took my wet shoes on a tour of the walls; my feet began, slowly, to hurt.

"Do you have anything Greek?"

I had not known I was going to ask it.

"Greek what?"

"Anything."

She considered that for longer than it deserved.

"Greek coins, fake. Greek pots, worse, because a man in Athens made them last spring and buried them in his garden for a

month so they would come up dirty. I have one chart. Real, and ruined."

She walked to the flat files at the speed of a woman who had decided years before not to hurry for customers, ran her gloved finger down the labels, and drew out one of the wide shallow drawers with a steel shriek. What she lifted out lay between sheets of yellowed tissue. She carried it back on her forearms, laid it on the glass of the counter, and turned the tissue back the way you turned back a sheet from a face.

"Hold that corner," she said. "Not with the wet hand."

I held it with the dry one; she held the other end, and between us lay the Gulf of Corinth.

It was a copperplate engraving on a sheet perhaps twenty inches wide, and the plate had been pressed so hard into the paper that the edge of it still showed as a shallow beveled step on all four sides. It had been colored by hand soon after printing, the land in a wash of yellow ochre, the coastlines edged in green. The green was verdigris, copper salts in gum, a cheap brilliant pigment that ate whatever it was laid on; over three hundred years it had eaten. All along the northern shore of the gulf the paper under the green line had gone brittle and brown and then simply gone, so that the coast was perforated in long fine slots like the edge of a stamp. You could have torn Phocis off along it.

"Your green's verdigris," I said.

"I know what my green is. Three hundred years it eats. Another hundred, it finishes."

The lettering was Italian, cut in a clear upright hand. GOLFO DI LEPANTO across the water; *Salona* inland, on a river. Above the water on the north side ran a range of hachured mountains, each one a tufted hump like a sheep seen from behind. Among them was *M. Parnaso*, and below it a cluster of four tiny houses and the word *Castri*.

I lifted my corner a few inches toward the lamp, carefully, and the watermark swam up in the paper: three crescent moons in a row, diminishing.

"*Tre lune*," Mrs. Szabo said. "You know it."

"Venetian mills."

"Venetian mills, or a Dutchman pretending to be one. This one is not pretending."

In blue ballpoint, over the mountains above Castri, someone had written two lines of coordinates, 38° 31' N and 22° 32' E, and under them, in square capitals pressed so hard the pen had nearly gone through, BIBLIOTHECA? Beside it was a doorway the size of my littlest fingernail, drawn freehand, an arch on two posts with the inside scribbled dark. I turned the sheet over at the corner and on the back the words stood up out of the paper in reverse, embossed, legible with a fingertip.

"Those are coordinates," I said.

"Those are numbers in ballpoint. That is all I know about them." She sniffed. "Morosini's war. Sixteen eighty-seven, sixteen eighty-eight. The Venetians wanted the Morea and they sent their navy and their navy drew the coast, every bay, with a lead line over the side. The same people who blew up the Parthenon. They were very good at coasts." She tapped the gulf with one gloved finger, near Lepanto, not touching the paper.

"You bought it for the coast."

"The coast is right. A faker gives you the coast out of his head and it is a pretty coast and it is wrong. And a faker writes *Delfi* there, big, because Delphi sells. In sixteen eighty-seven it is a village of goats on top of the ruins. *Castri*. They write what is there."

"Kastri," I said. "They moved the village off the site in the nineties. The eighteen-nineties. The French paid."

She let the French go by. "You know Greek."

"I read it."

"You know what a man with a ballpoint pen does to a thing like this."

"He takes it from four thousand dollars to nothing."

"Not to nothing," she said. "To what I paid. Estate sale, Chestnut Hill, last October. Margaret Fenn. Old lady, no children, a house full of boxes."

"What was she like?"

"She was dead. The lawyer was not nice. He wanted the house empty by Sunday, and he stood in the kitchen with his car keys while we carried." She nodded at the ballpoint. "That is the brother. Treasure hunter." She said it in the voice another woman might have kept for *bookie*. "He went to Greece in sixty-eight and he did not come back. The sister kept his things. I buy boxes. I do not buy stories about the boxes."

"What was he looking for?"

"You read Latin also."

"Yes."

"You have read it." She kept her eyes off the ink. "A library. There is one library people dig for. Once a month a man parks a car with a metal detector in the back seat outside my door and asks me for a map to Alexandria, or else to Captain Kidd. Sometimes it is the same man."

"The library at Alexandria burned."

"Everything burned. Still they come with a pen and say, not everything, not this. It is under a mountain. Or it is down a well behind a grandmother's house, and the grandmother wants money. The one with the metal detector reads better than you would think. He is just very sure."

The question mark after BIBLIOTHECA did not look sure.

She reached under the counter and set a cigar box down beside the chart, a Phillies box, the paper label worn soft at the corners. “This comes with it. I do not split a lot.”

I put my thumb under the lid. Inside, on a bed of loose tobacco crumbs that still faintly smelled of something, lay a notebook with a black oilcloth cover, the kind with an elastic band, though the elastic had perished and lay across it in two dry pieces. The cover said A. J. FENN in the same square capitals. It was warped from damp and dried again; I closed the lid.

“I do not read notebooks,” she said. “A notebook belongs to the family.”

“You said there wasn’t any family.”

“Then it is for whoever pays.” She slid the box an inch toward me. “The rest was nothing. Navy uniforms. Forty years of *National Geographic*, which I could not give away. Also a diving helmet with no glass in it. That I sold to a seafood restaurant in Wildwood, and they put a lobster in it. The box is free. The chart is fourteen hundred.”

“It’s been defaced.”

“It has been defaced. That is why it is fourteen hundred and not four thousand.”

“The verdigris has gone through the coast in six places. One more winter in that drawer and you’ll have two maps.”

“Seven places,” she said. “Fourteen hundred.”

“Five hundred.”

“No. A dealer says five hundred and goes to the door. You have not moved.”

“Who else is going to buy it? A collector won’t touch it with the pen on it.”

“A collector will not. A decorator will. They put it in a gold frame over a sofa in Bryn Mawr. Who reads ink over a sofa?”

The coast that had cost a navy lay between us under the lamp.

"Eight," I said.

"Eight is what I paid. I am not a charity for museums." She glanced up at the screen. "I have five dollars on this game with the barber next door," she told it. "The barber says the ones in red. His nephew played for them." The man in white shot and missed. "Twelve hundred. Because you will not roll it. You held the corner like a person who has been shouted at. Twelve."

"Eleven."

"Eleven fifty. I give you a board for it, and you go home."

I said yes. I had said it before I had checked anything at all, my account or my rent or the fact that my father's estate was sitting in a lawyer's office on Walnut Street waiting for a form.

"I do not take checks from people I do not know," she said.

"I don't have eleven hundred and fifty dollars in my pocket."

"And in your pocket?"

"Cake. Lemon."

"I did not ask what kind." She looked at the napkin a moment longer and then pulled a receipt pad toward her. "License number across the top. Telephone underneath. Name."

"Mara Reyes."

She wrote it on the pad and underlined the surname. "There was a Reyes in the *Inquirer*. In January. A professor who dug things."

"It's a common name."

"It is a common name," she agreed. Under it she wrote *One chart, Venetian, defaced, with box*, and pushed a Bic at me across the glass.

The date went in first, then her name, which she spelled for me without being asked, then the amount in figures and in words, *Eleven hundred fifty and 00/100*. I signed it and copied my license number off the card. Then I wrote the phone number. I

wrote it fast, in an order my hand had known since before I could spell, and it was the number of my father's house.

I looked at it. The pen had gone in hard on the last digit and dented the paper.

Mrs. Szabo had gone back to the flat files to shut the drawer. It went in with the same shriek. I could have voided the check and written another. My eyes had gone hot and blurred, so that the blue numbers swam in their little boxes, and I held the pen very still above the check and waited for them to stop swimming, and they did not stop. "It's this heater," I said, to nobody. The heater ticked. After a while I tore the check out along its perforations, cleanly, to the last tooth, and slid it across the glass with the wrong number on it.

"The check is good?"

"Yes."

She compared the signature with the license, folded the check once and put it in the cardigan pocket. Then she cut two pieces of gray mat board on a board cutter older than both of us and laid the chart between them in its tissue. She taped the edges with brown paper tape and put the whole parcel inside a black garbage bag against the weather. She started to fold the end of the bag over and stopped, because I had put my hand out.

"It won't bend like that," I said.

"It will not bend at all if you carry it flat," she said, "which you will, to your door, in this weather, without a coat." She put the cigar box in a paper sack from the Acme. "That is your business."

On the television the men in white had won, or lost; a coach was shaking hands down a line. She spoke a word to it in Hungarian, quietly, and took a five-dollar bill out of the register and laid it beside the ledger to wait for the barber.

"Pull the door hard," she said, without turning around. "It sticks."

* * *

I took the trolley back, because I had eleven dollars and a check register I did not want to open, and walked down from Thirty-Third Street with the black bag held flat against my front like a tray of drinks. By the time I came up the museum steps it was nearly five and the sleet had turned to plain rain. The upper gallery smelled of coffee and Sterno and wet coats; the caterers were folding the tables. The dean's-office woman went by with an armful of foil pans and doubled back.

"Did you eat that cake?"

"I ate it," I said, with it in my pocket.

"Good girl," she said, and went on toward the elevators. The carousel had run out of slides, and the projector fan was still going.

Gloria was at the coat rack with a roll of foil. She was wrapping the leftover ziti in individual squares, quick hard folds with the heel of her hand, stacking them into a shopping bag; she kept working when I came in. She had both her shoes off; they stood side by side under the rack, navy pumps, one heel worn to the plastic.

"I wore two different earrings all day," she said. She held out her palm. In it lay a pearl stud and a small gold hoop. "All day. The priest looked right at me during the reading. Not a word out of the whole pew. Ray said, when I asked him, he said he thought it was a style." She closed her hand. "A style. Fourteen years."

"I didn't notice."

"You didn't notice because you were looking at the ceiling." She tore another square of foil. "Where'd you go?"

"Out."

Then she looked at me.

"There's a pencil in your hair."

"The clip broke."

"In the car?"

"In the car. A pencil was what there was."

Her eyes went from the pencil to the garbage bag held against my chest. She kept looking. It was a look I knew from the age of nine. She had been sent to stay with us the summer her mother had the twins, and she had given me exactly this look through the screen door when my father's taxi pulled away for Sicily and I went straight back inside to finish my cereal. She did not say anything at all.

"It's a map," I said.

"I didn't ask."

"It's a Venetian chart, sixteen eighties. The Venetians sounded the whole coast with a—"

"Okay." She went back to the foil. "How much?"

"Not much."

"You've got the check face. You had it at the Volvo place." She creased a square in half with her thumbnail. "Did you eat anything?"

"I have cake."

"I bet it's in your pocket." She set another square in the bag. "Doug Fessler came looking for you. I said ladies' room. Two hours, the ladies' room. And Ray's been sitting in the car with the engine running since the reading, so. Take these to the house. There's no room in my freezer and Ray won't eat ziti two days running, he says it sits." She pushed the shopping bag toward me with her stockinged foot. "And do the machine."

"What machine?"

"His machine. Tía Nilda called the house Thursday. She forgot, she's seventy-eight, she dialed him up to tell him what

time the memorial was. And there he is, telling her to leave a message." Gloria's hands stopped on the foil for a second and went on. "She had to go lie down. And it's full anyway, people call and it just beeps at them. Change the message. Put your own on it, or the plain one, the robot one. I don't care. Just so nobody gets him. You still have a key?"

"I have a key."

"So go." She found my coat on the rack without looking, unhooked it, and held it open behind me, low, at the height you held a coat for a child.

* * *

The house was on a narrow street off Baltimore Avenue, the fourth in a row of twelve, with a porch that sagged toward the middle like a hammock and a front window that still had the radiator under it. When I was small I used to kneel on the radiator cover in my socks to watch the corner for taxis. The grille printed little diamonds on both my knees, and they took an hour to fade. It was nearly dark when I got there; the streetlight in front of the house had come on and was humming. The key stuck in the lock the way it always had and turned when I lifted the door by the knob, the way it always had, and I went in with the rain behind me.

Two months of mail lay on the hall floor in a drift. I stepped over it.

In the kitchen I put the black bag flat on the table and the paper sack beside it. When I opened the refrigerator to put away the ziti, it was full already: foil and Tupperware and a Pyrex dish of something under plastic wrap, with a strip of masking tape on the lid that said DOROTHY / RETURN DISH. The neighbors had been in, with a key I did not know about. I stood in the white light of the refrigerator with Gloria's shopping bag, moving a jar of

pickles and a carton of eggs with a January date on it to make room. I put the ziti in on top of Dorothy's dish, and it was still a little warm through the foil and I put it in anyway.

I took off the wet coat; in the jacket pocket under it the napkin had glued itself to the lemon cake. I peeled it off in pieces, standing at the counter, and I ate the cake with my fingers in four bites without sitting down. It was good. It was much better than it had looked, sharp and soft, and the glaze cracked when I bit it, and I was annoyed about that too.

The answering machine sat on the counter beside the wall phone, where I had put it in December of 1991. It was the Panasonic with two little smoked-plastic doors, one cassette for the greeting and one for the messages, because the man in the store had said the two-tape kind was easier for older people and my father had been offended for a week. Its red light was blinking fast. I pressed PLAY and leaned on the counter. The tape rewound with a thin whine, and clicked.

"Emilio, it's Pat. From next door. Oh, God, I'm sorry, I'm calling the house. I don't know why I'm calling the house. Mara, honey, if you get this, I've got your Tupperware, I mean his, the blue one. He shoveled my walk. When he was home. Okay. Bye now."

Beep.

"This is the Free Library of Philadelphia, Walnut Street West branch, with a message for Emilio Reyes. The following items are overdue." A woman's recorded voice, then a man's recorded voice reading a title, flat as a train station: "*Wild Horses*." Then the woman again, cheerful. "Please return items at your earliest convenience."

Beep. It was a Dick Francis. He read them on planes.

"Emilio! It's me. Nicosia." A man, shouting cheerfully over a bad line. "It rains here like a punishment, and I found your

drawings from Kourion, the whole box, ninety-two, under my bed. Can you believe it? Under my bed. What do you want I do with them? I send, or you come and get? You come and get. We eat at the place by the walls. Call me."

Beep. He had not heard. There was no reason he should have; it was Nicosia, and it was raining.

"Hi, this is the department office, this is for Mara Reyes, I guess, or whoever's doing the arrangements. Upper gallery, Saturday the fourteenth, two o'clock. The coffee's taken care of. Thanks."

Beep. A woman who did not leave her name only breathed, said, "Oh, Emilio," and hung up. There was a long silence with a television in it. Then a crackle like paper burning.

"Ah. Hello. This message is for the family of Professor Reyes. Ms. Reyes, I hope. It's Halloran, ringing from Naples." A pause; the line hissed. "I'm very sorry indeed to be ringing about paperwork, of all things, and I'm sorry, I should have rung sooner, since January I've been meaning to. The difficulty is the permit. The *permesso* for the Campanian survey season is still in Emilio's name. The Soprintendenza want another name on it by the twentieth of April or the season lapses, and then of course one begins again from nothing, which takes, well. Years, sometimes. I wondered whether the family would be sending anyone. Anyone at all. It needn't be an archaeologist, strictly, for the paperwork. Or you could fax, if it's easier, the number at the office is zero-eight-one, five-five-two, oh, I'll give it again at the end. I'll try you again. It's six hours later here than with you, which I always forget, so forgive me if I've woken anyone. Oh, the fax. No. I'll ring. Well."

Beep. "End of messages," said a woman's synthesized voice.

I wrote nothing down. When I pressed ERASE and held it, the second tape whined back to its beginning; the light stopped

blinking and went to a solid red. That was half of what Gloria had asked. The other half was a button on the left marked GREETING, under its own little door. I knew which one it was. I had shown him.

I pressed it.

The greeting tape clicked and turned. There was a breath first, a hiss of room, and a radio somewhere in the house as it had been six years ago, playing something with violins.

"Hello, you've reached the Reyes house, which means you've reached a machine, because I'm out somewhere digging a hole in somebody else's country. Or I'm in the basement looking for the Christmas lights. Tell me who you are and where you're calling from, and say it slowly, and I'll find you." And then, a little away from the microphone, lower, in the voice he used when he thought only I could hear: "Mara? Which one stops it?"

Click. Beep. The machine waited for me to speak.

I stood with my hand on the counter. Outside a car went by slowly in the rain with its radio on, and the sound of it came up through the floor and went away down the street.

I pressed it again and listened to the breath at the beginning this time, and to the violins, which were Brahms or something like Brahms. In the middle, where he said *somebody else's country*, he smiled; you could hear the smile; it pulled the vowels wide. I listened to my name. I had been twenty-six and standing beside him at this counter with the cardboard box from the store and the instructions open, and I had pointed, and he had pressed the wrong button, and I had laughed, and he had not asked to do it over, then or ever.

Beep. The machine waited.

The third time, I pressed GREETING and listened to him with my finger on the button below it, the one marked RECORD GREETING. It needed only pressing. Hold the button and speak

after the tone, the instructions had said, beside a drawing of a little man with a speech balloon. You have reached the Reyes house. Please leave a message. Anyone could have said it. Gloria could have said it in her stocking feet.

"Mara?" he said. "Which one stops it?"

I took my finger off the button. I opened the little smoked door with my thumbnail. The microcassette sat in its well, no bigger than a matchbook, its two white hubs and the brown ribbon of tape stretched between them behind a window of clear plastic. I pressed the eject lever and it came up into my fingers. It weighed less than the cake had. I read the label, which was blank, and put it in my jacket pocket where the napkin had been, and buttoned the pocket.

Then I went upstairs, because it was the next thing.

His bedroom was cold; the radiator had been turned down. The bed was made, badly, with the spread pulled up over the pillows in a long lump. His 1966 Seiko lay on the nightstand where he had always taken it off at night, face up on a folded handkerchief, its steel band coiled beside it like a dropped ribbon. The hands said ten past four. It had stopped at some ten past four in January, morning or afternoon, and had not been wound since.

The case was scratched in fine circles where it had knocked against thirty-odd years of trench walls, and the crystal had a nick at two o'clock. My thumbnail found the crown. I turned it forward between finger and thumb, feeling the small dry ratchet of the mainspring taking up, and when it grew stiff I stopped. The second hand twitched and went on. I held it to my ear and it was ticking, quick and light. Then I set it by the red numbers of the clock radio and buckled it on. It was far too big; it slid down over the knuckle of my thumb, and I pushed it back up and it slid down again.

His Pentax sat on the shelf over the bureau, between a Cypriot lamp with a chipped nozzle and a row of paperbacks swollen from the bathtub. It was the black-and-chrome K1000, its worn strap wound around it in the same three turns for as long as he'd had it. I took it down; it had the weight of a good brick and smelled of leatherette and light machine oil. I lifted the rewind knob and the back sprang open on nothing; the film chamber was empty and clean, the pressure plate bright. I closed it. The advance lever went through its stroke with the same soft ratcheting sound the watch had made, a size larger, and I put it back on the shelf with the strap turned as he had left it.

Downstairs I did not turn on the kitchen light. Rain ran on the window over the sink. The garbage bag lay flat on the table with the chart inside it between its boards. Beside it the grocery sack had slumped open, and the Phillies box showed at the top, square and brown, the notebook in it with the dead elastic across its cover. The watch ticked loose against the bone of my wrist. On the counter the machine had found nothing in the well where its greeting belonged, and its light had changed from a steady red to a slow blink. Every second or so the red light came on and went off, and each time it lit the lid of the cigar box.

Chapter 2

Fenn's Notebook

Thanksgiving, 1967, and Margaret has decided that a scholiast is some kind of foot doctor. I explained it to her twice over the turkey. A scholiast is a monk with a pen and too much time on his hands, and when he's copying out some old Greek book and knows a thing the book doesn't, he writes it in the margin, and eight hundred years later a German prints it in little type at the bottom of the page, and then the German's book sits on a shelf with its pages uncut until August Fenn walks into the big new library at the university and does it with his thumb. The girl at the desk looked at me like I came about the radiators. Father Kostas at St. George's put the Greek into English for me for the price of a roast pork sandwich at the Terminal, and here it is the way he gave it: "The books of the Ptolemies were carried out of Alexandria by ship and taken up to the cave of the nymphs on Parnassus, and they are there." Are there. Present tense. The Library of Alexandria, Margaret, the whole works, sitting in a cave on a mountain. She asked if they'd be wet.

The chart's got Castri right where it ought to be, those Venetians knew their business, and the Army map down at the Free Library puts the cave up the mountain from it at 38° 31' N, 22° 32' E. I put that on in ballpoint so I'd have it, with a little picture of the cave mouth beside it so I'd know which hole I meant. Margaret said if I was going to write

on something that old I had to at least put a question mark, to be honest about it, so I put one, to keep the peace on a holiday. All I need now is about two thousand bucks and a better flashlight.

I read that in my father's kitchen the night I brought it home, under the overhead light, with the answering machine blinking on the counter over the empty well where his greeting had been. Fenn wrote in block capitals nearly a quarter of an inch high and retraced every stroke. He bore down so hard that every page carried a second copy of itself on the back, raised and backward, like the dots beside an elevator button; in the bowls of his R's the ballpoint had furrowed the paper and left a black bead of ink at the bottom of each furrow. It was the hand of a man who did not expect to be argued with, or who expected it and liked his chances.

I had read a good many scholia in graduate school. Most of them were a cold monk telling the page it had got Homer wrong; the one I remembered best was a complaint about the ink. A note that put the Ptolemies' books in a cave on Parnassus was exactly what a monk wrote on a slow afternoon to feel nearer to something, and I did not believe it. The coordinates were another matter. They sat in the middle of the page as plainly as a street address. When I slid the chart out of its garbage bag and lifted the top board, the blue ballpoint above *Castri* said it too, to the minute.

After that I read it in rations, an entry a night and two when the day had been bad, though nobody had told me to make it last.

* * *

On Monday I was back at work. The lamp was where I had left it the Friday before the memorial, face down in a tray of sand under the magnifier, with its nozzle beside it in a nest of tissue. It was a mold-made lamp from North Africa, second century, the clay

slipped a shade darker than its body; on its discus a hare sat up on its haunches eating a bunch of grapes. Some storeroom man had knocked the nozzle off in about 1935 and stuck it back with shellac, in a hurry and a degree out of true; the shellac had gone orange and crazed like an old dinner plate. I had used up most of February taking that man's work off with acetone poultices and a sharpened stick. What was left was a clean break, two faces of fired clay that had last been one piece under a Roman roof. On the tip of the nozzle was a crust of soot from the last night it burned, and I had kept every brush in the lab away from it.

The lab was cold, it was always cold, it was a basement. I brushed a bead of acrylic resin along one face of the break with a brush that had about three hairs left in it. Then I set the nozzle home and held it under the hood with my elbows on the bench, while the solvent went off into the fan and my fingers began to ache from the wrist down.

When it had set I switched off the overhead light and swung the raking lamp in low from the side. There was a step at the underside of the join no thicker than a fingernail paring. Under the raking light it threw a shadow you could have parked a car in.

So I took it apart. The resin let go under acetone in about an hour, which was the whole virtue of the stuff, and I cleaned both faces again and started over. The second time I held the nozzle longer and did not look at the clock. When the raking lamp went on, the seam had gone. The hare sat on its discus eating, the nozzle ran out from the body in one unbroken line, and when I drew my thumbnail across the place where the break had been it did not catch. I tried it again with my eyes shut. Then I sat back on the stool and looked at that lamp for longer than I needed to, which in my trade was most of what they paid you for. Nobody came in to see it.

At lunch I took half a sandwich up to the stacks of the university library, where food was not allowed. The German was on a bottom shelf in a run of tall volumes in marbled boards, Leipzig, 1838, the spines flaking like pastry. I sat on the floor and opened it across my knees. Two rows over, a boy in a hooded sweatshirt was eating sunflower seeds and spitting the shells into a Wawa cup. The line was at the foot of a page about Phocis, in small Greek type under a rule, and it said what Father Kostas had said it said. The leaves had been slit with something blunt, the edges furred and torn, from the front of the volume up to that page. The leaf after it was still joined at the top; so was every leaf to the end of the book. He had found his line and stopped reading.

I did not cut the rest. I was late getting back down to my lamp, with the crust of the sandwich in my pocket.

That night's ration was February 1968, and the capitals were still a quarter of an inch high.

Sold the Plymouth to a mailman in Jenkintown for six hundred, and he threw in a sack of oranges, which I took. Athens on the second of April, TWA. Margaret won't tell the girls at church I've gone to Greece to dig up a library, she says they'll all pray for me and she'd never live it down, so I'm going to Mexico instead. Never been to Mexico. Maybe after.

* * *

The band was loose enough that the watch rode down onto the back of my hand whenever I reached for anything, and on Thursday after work I took it to a jeweler on Sansom Street. He was doing the *Daily News* crossword in ink when I came in, and he wrote in the word he had before he looked up. When I showed him the watch he screwed a loupe into his eye and pushed the pins out of the band with a little steel punch, humming

something from a musical he could not get the middle of. He measured my wrist with a strip of paper. Three links went into a manila envelope the size of a stamp, which he sealed with a lick.

"Eight dollars," he said.

I paid him and went out onto Sansom Street with the envelope in my pocket beside the tape and the watch sitting snug against my wristbone for the first time.

Delphi, at last, and it isn't even the real Delphi, they picked up the whole village and moved it down the road so the French could dig. Room over a taverna. The owner's mother feeds me beans, and there's a goat that eats whatever I leave on the sill, including half a postcard. Walked up to the plateau and the cave today, four hours up and every one of them uphill, and it's a big wet barn of a place with names scratched all over the walls, a lot of them French. No books. You don't find the books on the first day.

The capitals stood upright through April. In May they began to come apart. First the letters shrank. Then they started to join, the R's running into the E's along the line, and by the middle of the month he was writing in a small lowercase hand that leaned to the right and did not trouble to close its loops. Since the first night I had turned every page over to read the copy his pen had pressed through from the front. When I turned these over, the backs were smooth.

Way in past where the good light gives out, the rock comes down low on the left and there's a kind of slot you could get your arm into. I put my hand in at the back and the air was cold in a way air isn't. I know cave cold, I was down in the sinkholes in Florida with the Navy, and this was something else, this was the icebox at midnight with the light off. It came for about a minute and then it quit, like somebody shut a door in another part of the house.

Cold again Tuesday morning. Nothing Wednesday, nothing since. The boy with the goats brought me bread and cheese and stood there

and watched every bite go down, and then took the cloth home to his mother.

Slept up there. Didn't help.

Caves breathed. The air inside went in and out with the weather, slow as a sleeper. I turned the page.

* * *

He rang on the last Saturday in March, a little after ten in the morning, while I was standing at my father's sink eating cereal out of the box because the bowls were all in the dish rack and I had not decided whose they were. The wall phone had a coiled cord that years of walking off with it had pulled straight in places.

"Ms. Reyes? Good. A real person. It's Halloran, in Naples. I've rung four times this week, and each time your machine gives me its little tone and then nothing at all, not so much as a hello. I'd begun to think I had the wrong house."

"It's the right house."

"You'll have to forgive the echo. We're leaving the flat, my wife and I, after thirty-one years, and everything's gone to the new place but the telephone, which has to stay until the new people take over the line. So I'm sitting on the floor of an empty room with the thing in my lap." He cleared his throat. "You can hear yourself think in here. It isn't as nice as they say. I'm sorry, you don't want any of that. I'm ringing about the permit."

"I got your message."

"You'll know the worst of it already. The Soprintendenza have been very good, really. They'll accept me as director for the season, that much is agreed. What they require is the cession. That's the form by which the outgoing director gives the permit up to the incoming one, and it wants the outgoing director's signature at the bottom, in ink, witnessed."

"Witnessed by whom?"

"Oh, a notary, a consul. That part was never the trouble. I explained the situation. I sent them everything, the certificate from Pennsylvania with its stamp, a sworn translation, a letter from me in my best Italian. It all came back on Thursday." The line clicked twice, somewhere under the ocean. "They'd written over it in red. *Firma mancante.* Signature missing."

I laughed. It came out of me as a bark first and then a long run that bent me over the sink, with the receiver jammed against my ear and the cord stretched straight across the kitchen. There was a clerk in Naples with a red pen, waiting at his desk for my father to come in and sign. There was my father, who had never in his life returned a form on time, being sent one more he would not answer. My elbow had caught the cereal box on the drainboard, and it had gone over the edge and was pouring itself out across the linoleum.

"Ms. Reyes?" Halloran said, a long way off. "Is that—are you crying? I'm so sorry. I'm an old fool with forms."

"I'm laughing."

"Oh." The word went round his bare room and came back down the line. "Oh, thank God. I couldn't tell which."

When I had stopped I wiped my face on the dish towel, and he told me what they would take instead: the heir's signature on a declaration, before a notary, with the certificate attached again. He would fax it to the museum on Monday. The twentieth was a Monday too, he said, and the Soprintendenza did not work Mondays in any sense that mattered, so if I could manage it by the fifteenth he would walk it over himself.

"And his notebooks," he said. "From last season. The north transects exist nowhere else, I'm afraid. He never got round to typing them up. He never got round to typing anything, did he. If they're in the house."

"They're here."

"Perhaps, when you've a moment. By the end of June, if it could be managed." The floor creaked under him. "There's no hurry at all."

I picked a flake of cereal off the linoleum and ate it.

"There's one other thing," he said. "I meant to put it in a letter, and then it seemed a thing you couldn't put in a letter. The season starts on the sixth of July. Three weeks, four. There's a room in the dig house, a decent one with a window, standing empty. You'd be very welcome. In Emilio's place, I mean. Not to work, unless you wanted to. Only so that somebody—" He stopped. "Well. So that you could see it."

"I might be in Greece."

"Greece!" He was pleased for me, as if I'd said Florida. "Sure, that's practically next door. Think about it. You needn't say anything now." Behind him a door opened and a man's voice said something cheerful in Italian, and Halloran answered it in Italian with his hand half over the mouthpiece, not cheerfully. "The new tenants," he said. "They've come to measure for curtains, and I'm still sitting here. I'll fax on Monday. Goodbye, Ms. Reyes. I'm glad you laughed."

When the line went I stayed at the sink with the receiver against my ear until the dial tone came on. Then I found the broom in the cellar way and swept up the cereal.

* * *

The form came through the lab's fax machine on Monday in a long warm curl. I signed it on Wednesday in front of a notary at a check-cashing place on Baltimore Avenue; she stamped it without reading a word and asked if I wanted a lottery ticket while I was there. I faxed it to Naples that afternoon, a page at a

time, the machine pulling each sheet in with a small sound of disapproval.

The chart went up on the first Saturday in April. I had cut it a window mat from four-ply board and hinged it in with tissue and wheat starch paste, and I carried it to the house flat in a portfolio and pinned the mat board, not the chart, to the strip of cork over my father's desk, where his site plans used to hang until their corners curled. The coast of Phocis hung over his blotter, perforated all along its green edge, with Fenn's numbers in blue on the shoulder of Parnassus.

His study was the back bedroom; it was the only room in the house he had ever kept in order. His field notebooks took up the bottom shelf of the bookcase, decades of them in yellow surveyor's covers gone brown at the spine where his thumb had opened them, each with a site and a year on it in his writing. He wrote small and fast, leaning forward, like a man running for a bus. I knelt and ran a finger along the spines from one end of the shelf to the other, each binding ticking under it in turn, and stood up again. I did not take one down. On the Saturdays after that I came to sit in his chair and read Fenn's notebook in the room with the chart, the yellow spines down by my ankles.

The June entries were short, some of them a single line, and the hand had grown so small that I brought the magnifier home to read them.

Up again. Nothing. My boots are going at the toes, and the boy's mother has a cousin who'll stitch them, she says, if I quit going up the mountain long enough to take them off.

Tired today.

* * *

I flossed in my own apartment, which by May I was using for very little else. The bathroom there had a medicine-cabinet mirror

with the silvering gone at one corner and a light over it that buzzed. On the first Tuesday in May, a little before midnight, I was working the floss down behind the last molar on the upper left, where an old filling had a lip that caught the thread and frayed it, when I stopped with the floss wound around both middle fingers and still in my teeth. I went out to the kitchen like that. I found the phone book on top of the refrigerator and turned to the airlines with my hands tethered to my own mouth, and I dialed Olympic Airways, whose number began with eight hundred. A woman in New York answered at once.

"Athens," I said, and then I took the floss out.

She had a seat from Kennedy on Tuesday the nineteenth. I gave her my credit card number standing in my nightgown in the kitchen, and when I had hung up I finished the upper left at the bathroom mirror and did the lowers properly, since the floss was out anyway.

The bag lived in my hall closet, half packed, as it had in every apartment since college: a change of clothes and a toothbrush in a canvas duffel, kept against nothing in particular. That same night the floss went into its outside pocket, before there was a ticket in the house or a passport anywhere near the bag. The passport was at the back of a dresser drawer under the warranty for a toaster I no longer owned.

A fellow off the Athens bus left a Herald Tribune on my table, a week old, and I read every word of it, the bridge column too, and I don't play bridge.

Gloria rang my father's house the Saturday after that, because I was always there on Saturdays now and she had worked it out.

"Pat says you're going to Greece."

"I asked Pat to keep an eye on the house."

"So it's true." Something behind her clanked and settled, like a garage door. "I'm in the garage on the cordless. Don't ask. Who's doing the mail? Not Pat. Pat opens things."

"I'll put a hold on it at the post office."

"And the circulars have to come in off the porch. Leave them a week and the block knows the house is empty. Dorothy's dish is still in that refrigerator, I saw it." She breathed out through her nose. "How long?"

"Till the ninth of June."

"Leave the key in the flowerpot, then. Not under the mat, everybody looks under the mat." The door behind her settled again. "And call me when you get there. Collect. Ray'll have a fit, let him."

The rest came in whatever order it came. I bought a flashlight because Fenn had wanted a better one. The department head signed my leave form against a seed catalogue and wanted to know whether the Greeks grew a decent tomato. Two boxes of granola bars were for the plane and then for the mountain, and within a day of going into the duffel they had begun to shed oats into its seams; a bottle of Advil rattled in the side pocket against the floss. The microcassette had been in my jacket since March; now it rode in a wool sock, rolled tight, in the toe of a hiking boot at the bottom of the bag. The watch needed no packing; I gave its crown its turns each morning at whatever window I was standing near, and by now I knew where the spring would begin to resist.

On the Sunday before the flight I loaded the Pentax on the kitchen table at the house. I pulled the rewind crank up until the back popped open, dropped a new roll of Kodak into its chamber, and drew the tongue of film across to the take-up spool, which needed some coaxing before it caught. When the back was shut I wound on and fired at the kitchen ceiling with the cap still on the

lens, twice, until the little window over the lever showed 1. There were thirty-six frames in it, and I had not taken one.

The back half of Fenn's notebook was blank, sixty-odd ruled leaves he had never reached. The back board had warped worse than the front, and the last leaves had cockled against it and stuck. I had let them be in March; this time I put the notebook overnight in a sealed bag with a damp blotter, and in the morning the board came away from the endpaper with a sound like a lip unsticking. Inside the back cover was a pocket meant for receipts. In it, folded in three, was a carbon on onionskin from the American consulate in Athens, dated the sixteenth of September, 1968.

Personal effects of FENN, August J., U.S. citizen: one man's overcoat, wool, gray, with contents of pockets, forwarded to next of kin, Miss Margaret Fenn, Philadelphia, Pennsylvania.

Whoever typed it at the consulate had put one n too many in Pennsylvania and x'd it out. I folded it back along its own creases and put it where it had been. The notebook went into the duffel last, on top, where I could get at it.

* * *

The night before the flight I sat at my father's kitchen table with the duffel by the door and read the last entry again. It was dated in July, in the small leaning hand, and the pen had barely marked the page.

July 21. Cold this morning, cold enough to see my breath at the slot, and it came and stayed long enough for a whole cigarette, which is the longest yet. Going in tomorrow first thing with the good flashlight and a ball of kite string. The boy's mother washed my shirts and wouldn't take a drachma for it. Back before Labor Day, and Margaret can stop telling the girls at church I'm in Mexico, because I'll be sitting on her

front steps with a sunburn and a story she won't believe until she reads it in the Inquirer.

Chapter 3

Parnassus

The thyme grew in low gray cushions up the whole slope, and whenever the wind came over the shoulder of the mountain it pressed the smell out of them and carried it down past me toward the plateau, where the bells of a flock were knocking and clanking without any tune at all and the road lay across the bottom of everything like a dropped bootlace, so far below me that a truck crawling along it made no sound.

I had been climbing for half an hour and had already stopped more often than I liked; the duffel was most of it. In all its years with me I had asked nothing steeper of that canvas bag than the subway stairs at City Hall. Now its strap had found the one place on my right shoulder where there was bone and no padding, and it was working at that place with the patience of a wood rasp. My shoulder hurt and I moved the bag to the other shoulder and then that one hurt. My lungs had spent ten years in a basement lab. The air up here was thin and clean and smelled of resin and hot stone. I was hauling it in through my mouth.

The taxi had left me at the end of the asphalt a little after nine. Its driver was a young man from Arachova with a string of blue glass eyes swinging from his mirror. Where the asphalt gave out and the road went on as two ruts of white gravel he had

stopped, and pointed at the slope above us with his whole arm, and then at the bag, and last of all at me, and laughed until he had to wipe his eyes on the back of his wrist. I paid him what he asked without understanding the number.

I had given up my room in Delphi at seven. It had a balcony the width of a bookshelf, and I had wound the Seiko out there that morning while the swifts went screaming past below my feet. The woman at the desk downstairs had asked whether I was going back to Athens. I had said no, up. Fenn had slept up there, and I had not flown across an ocean to stand in his cave for an hour like a woman in a gallery and catch the four o'clock bus.

The plateau lay below me entire. It was a long floor of new grass laid flat between the mountains and walled in by them, green in a way nothing in Philadelphia was ever green in May, a wet, almost violent green with yellow in it. The shepherds' summer huts of Kalivia stood about on it in loose clusters, rough gray stone with tin roofs rusted orange at the seams; between them were pens of piled stone and a white church hardly bigger than a garage. On the far slope the ski lifts stood idle for the summer with their chairs hanging in a row. A black plastic bag had blown against one of the pen walls and stayed there, filling and emptying with the wind.

I got the Pentax out of the end pocket of the bag and photographed the plateau from above, the whole green floor of it with the road across the bottom, because my father had always taken that picture first. It was the site from a hilltop before a spade had touched it, the house they lived in a white speck and the trenches not yet cut, and he called it the only honest picture of a season. I had sat through a great many of them at the kitchen table in the dark and thought them the dullest photographs in the world. I framed mine the way he framed his, the horizon a third of the way from the top. The shutter went; the mirror

slapped up and dropped inside the body with a clack the mountain swallowed at once, and I wound on with my thumb. I had spent a little of the roll in Delphi already, on the stadium at the top of the sanctuary in the last of the light.

The map was in my jacket with Fenn's notebook, a walker's map of Parnassus from a kiosk in Delphi with degrees and minutes in its margins; the first evening I had laid the edge of the notebook along 38° 31' and 22° 32', and the lines had met a few hundred yards from the words Ω . He had read the
map right in a library in Philadelphia in 1967 without ever having seen the mountain, and then he had come out here and found the hole where his numbers said it was.

The path was marked in red. Every fifty yards there was a square of red paint on a boulder, laid on with a brush by a hand that had not worried about drips; the paint had run in places and dried in little beads down the face of the stone. Where the path crossed bare rock it was easy to lose. The limestone up here was pale gray and fluted all over by the rain into channels and knife-edged ridges, and the red squares were the only things on it that had been put there by a person.

At one of the squares I stopped to retie a bootlace that had worked loose. Its plastic tip had come off somewhere between Kennedy and here, and the end was fraying out into a little brush. Aglet. A boy at the citywide spelling bee in 1977 had gone out on aglet with two g's and stood at the microphone in his clip-on tie with his mouth open while the bell rang. I pulled the knot tight and went on.

The goats were above the path as I came round the next shoulder of the hill, forty or fifty of them spread across the slope among the thyme and the scrub oak. They were black and brown and a few of a dirty white, with long hair hanging off their flanks in hanks. They wore bells of every size; the big ones clanked, the

small ones went *tink*, and nothing anywhere kept time with anything else. A kid was standing on top of a boulder with all four feet together on a point of rock the size of a saucer. The goatherd sat on a flat stone below it. He was an old man in a flat cap and a gray suit jacket over a sweater, with a crook across his knees, and he was shouting up the slope at one brown nanny who had got onto a ledge above the rest and was eating something there that she preferred. It was the same word every time, her name or his opinion of her, and he said it with more disgust at every return. She did not come down. He broke off for me in the middle of the word.

"Kalimera," he said.

"Kalimera sas."

My kalimera was correct, which my Greek mostly was not. I had learned the language from grammars with paper covers and could get through a page of Thucydides faster than I could buy a stamp in it. My accent did not interest him in the least. Then he finished the word, and the nanny went on eating, and the kid on the boulder watched me go by with its yellow eyes and their flat black bars.

A shepherd's pen stood beside the path, a little higher, and its wall had fallen in at one corner and been built up again by a man who had not cared for the first man's way of doing it. The old stones were set on edge, leaning into each other in a long herringbone. The new ones had been laid flat in courses with no opinion about the herringbone at all, so that the corner stood out from twenty yards off as plainly as a patch on a sleeve, and in the join, for a gate hinge, he had mortared in a length of bedspring. I photographed the join. I took it again from closer, with the bedspring sharp and the herringbone soft behind it, and I was more pleased with that one than with anything I had taken in Delphi.

Above the pen the path went into the firs. They were tall and dark and very straight, and their cones stood upright along the tops of the branches like unlit candles. The resin smell was so thick I could taste it at the back of my throat, turpentine and the pine-oil cleaner the night men used on the museum corridors. A man came down through the trees toward me with two walking poles going ahead of him like a second pair of legs. He was perhaps sixty-five and tall, with a red face, white knee socks, a red windbreaker and a canvas hat with a cord under the chin. He stopped above me on the path and planted the poles.

"Good morning!" he said. "English?"

"American."

"Ach so. Good morning all the same." He tapped the bag with the tip of a pole. "You are carrying your whole house."

"Just my clothes."

"For one night?"

"However long it takes."

He laughed, though I had not said it to be funny, and dug in the pocket of his windbreaker and brought out a stone. It was gray and a little smaller than a hen's egg, and he showed it to me on his palm.

"From the top. Liakoura, this morning, at six, with the sun coming. For my daughter. Every mountain I climb, one stone, and she keeps them on the windowsill in her kitchen in Ulm. Olympus she has. Snowdon, which is not a mountain, but it rained the whole day, so it is allowed. Her husband says one day the windowsill falls into the street and kills a man." He tipped the stone to the light with great satisfaction. "This is a good one. Look, it has a little shell inside."

It had; a ribbed fan the breadth of a fingernail, set in the gray.

My father had brought me sherds. There had been one in his shirt pocket every September, wrapped in a page of the *Cyprus*

Mail: a scrap of a cooking pot with the soot still on its belly, the rim of a lamp, a strap handle with the potter's thumbprint pressed into its root. I had kept them in a Buster Brown shoebox beneath the bed and taken them out on rainy Saturdays to sort by color. I was twenty-four and halfway through a seminar on the antiquities trade before I understood what each of them was. The box was on the top shelf of my closet now, behind the winter sweaters, and I had not opened it since and had not thrown it out.

"How far is the cave?" I said.

"For me, forty minutes. For you, with the house, one hour." He swung round and pointed up through the trees with a pole. "Follow the red. Always the red, on the stones. The yellow and black is the E4, it goes over the summit and down the other side and on, many days, to the sea. You do not want the E4."

"I'll skip the sea."

"You are a student? Archaeology? Every second person on this mountain is digging something."

"I fix pots. In a museum."

"Ah! My daughter's husband, the one with the windowsill, he fixes our cups. The handles. He glues them back on with something from a tube that smells of fish, and then you drink your coffee and the handle stays in your hand and the cup goes in your lap." He let go of one pole and crooked a finger through a handle that was not there. "Where in America?"

"Philadelphia."

"Philadelphia! Like the cheese."

"Like the cheese."

"My wife, she eats it on the bread every morning of her life, and me also." He unzipped the windbreaker and drew a camera up on a cord from inside it, a small silver Olympus whose lens slid out with a whine when he switched it on. He offered it to me in

both hands. “Bitte. One photograph, with the mountain behind. My wife is in Arachova with her knee, and she says I take the bus to the top and walk down and tell her stories. Here I am with the mountain. She cannot argue. Only press. It thinks for itself.”

The camera weighed nothing; it was all plastic and confidence. When I put my eye to it there was a little bright window with no needle in it and nothing to set. I pressed the button and it made up its own mind about the light with a buzz and a click. He stood very straight for it with the poles crossed in front of him and the firs at his back, and he did not smile, because this was evidence.

“Now you,” he said.

“It’s all right, I don’t—“

“No, no. For your mother.”

“My mother’s in Phoenix.”

“Phoenix. Good, we send it to Phoenix.” He had my father’s camera before I could think how to keep it.

I stood on the path with the bag on my shoulder and the dark trees behind me, and he took a long time about it, with the tip of his tongue between his teeth. When the shutter went, with its heavy steel clack, he jerked the camera away from his face.

“So loud!” he said. “It is like a gun.”

He gave it back strap first, carefully, and went off down the path toward the goats, poles first.

The wind was stronger once I was out of the firs and came in gusts that pushed at the duffel and flattened the grass. The slope opened out again into broken rock and thyme, and the path climbed it in long zigzags. In the lulls a bird I could not name went over and over a phrase of four notes with the last one missing. On the far side of the plateau the high summits showed now over the nearer ridges. Every gully on them was streaked with old snow. I stopped twice more. The second stop I sat on the

duffel and drank half my water and ate a granola bar, and the wind snatched the wrapper from my fingers and carried it twenty feet downhill into a thornbush. I went after it, because I could not leave it there, and tore my sleeve on the thorns getting it back, and the knuckles of my right hand with it.

I saw the cave a good while before I reached it. It was a dark arch in a low cliff of gray rock on the hillside above me, wider than it was high, with a scrub oak growing out of a crack over its lip and leaning out over the drop. I knew the shape. On the chart in my father's study, beside the coordinates, Fenn had drawn a doorway in ballpoint smaller than a lentil, two posts and a curved top with its middle filled in black, and I had taken it in March for the way a child draws any cave at all. It was this cave, copied too exactly for a guess, from a photograph in some library book, I supposed; it had the same lean to the left-hand post where the rock had broken away, and the same flattening along the top. I climbed until I had the arch at the angle of the drawing and photographed it from there, with the oak and the lean and the dark inside.

After that the arch hardly got any nearer. Somewhere on the last zigzags the Hanson song from the summer before got into my head, only the chorus, which had no words in it I had ever been able to make out, and it went round and round in time with my boots. I was hungry again, and it was too soon for another granola bar.

The last of the paint was on a boulder at the final turn below the mouth, a gray block with its face toward the cave. It had been given a red square with an arrow under it pointing at the arch, which by then could hardly have been missed.

At the mouth itself the ground was trodden bare and littered with goat droppings, black and shiny as olive pits. To the right of the arch the rock had been smoothed flat for a yard or so at about

the height of my shoulder, and there were letters cut into it, Greek capitals, so worn that the lichen had got into most of them. I put my fingers in the strokes and read them like a blind woman. , and the rest of the word lost; further along, , very clear, cut deeper than the rest. I wanted it on film. I balanced the lens cap on the little ledge under the letters for scale, as my father would have done, a black plastic disc with PENTAX across it in white. I took the inscription with the cap in the frame, and then I dropped the cap into my jacket pocket instead of fitting it back on the lens, which he also would have done.

I drank some water standing on the lip. Far down, a red speck I took for the German's windbreaker was crossing the floor of the plateau toward the road; the goats had gone over the shoulder of the hill, and their bells came up to me thinned by the distance. I capped the water and went in.

The floor sloped down from the lip, loose and stony. The light came with me a little way, white and flat, and stopped. Beyond where it stopped, the cave opened out so suddenly and so far that I stood still on the slope with the bag dragging at me and let my eyes take their time. Fenn had called it a barn. He had undersold it. It was a single hall running back into the mountain farther than the daylight could follow, with a roof that went up into darkness in the middle. The floor was full of stalagmites, pale and lumpy and gleaming, and one near the middle had grown into a great slumped mass with a dull shine on its near shoulder where hands had been laid on it for a span of years I could not begin to guess at.

The cold met me from the walls. It was cave cold, the cold of a cellar in August, damp and steady. It carried a smell of wet stone and of earth and, very faintly, of goats. I zipped my jacket to the chin. Somewhere back in the dark a drip was falling into water

with a slow, uneven tap, and another drip answered it from another place, in a different key.

The walls near the mouth were written all over. There were names cut into the rock with knives and nails, hundreds of them, crowded and overlapping. The light from the mouth came across them low and sideways and made every cut stand up in its own shadow. It was the raking light I used in the lab to find a seam. A great many of the names were French, cut in capitals with dates in the 1840s and 1850s. In several places a newer name had gone straight across an older one; a 1952 ran through the middle of a French lieutenant. Lowest of all, at the height of my hip, was a heart in blue felt-tip with two pairs of initials in it and 1996.

The French had dug this floor at the beginning of the seventies and sieved more than twenty thousand knucklebones out of it. They were the ankle bones of sheep and goats, the dice of every child in Phocis, carried up to this cave over centuries for Pan and the nymphs. The dirt was still loose and gray-brown where the spoil had gone back in, and a goat had slept in one of the hollows not long ago and left the print of itself.

I found it near the slumped stalagmite. A drip from the roof had been falling on one spot until it had washed out a basin in the floor as wide as a soup plate, and something pale lay at the edge of the basin with its top rinsed clean. I crouched, with the duffel sliding off my shoulder into the dirt, and put the flashlight on it.

A knucklebone. From the size it had come off a sheep, maybe a small goat: the ankle bone from the hind leg, about as long as the top joint of my thumb, with its two knobbed ends and its waist and its four long sides, each of the four a different shape. It lifted from the wet dirt with a small suck. The weight surprised me; it was heavy for its size and stained tea-brown through and through, not on the surface only. A modern bone off a dead goat would have been chalky and light and would have smelled of

something, and this had no smell at all. Two of its long sides had been ground flat. Under the flashlight the flats were crossed with fine parallel scratches, the marks of a stone it had been rubbed on to make it sit right, and along the edges where the flats met the curves the bone had gone glossy, the polish fingers left on a thing after a very long time.

There was a procedure. I had written a page of it myself for the interns, and it was taped above the lab sink, gone wavy from the steam of the kettle. You left it where it lay. If you had already lifted it you returned it to its own hollow, facing the way it had faced, and you photographed it there with a scale, and you wrote down where it was, and then you walked down to Delphi and told the ephorate, who would thank you without warmth and send a man up in a month. I could not photograph it. The camera had no flash; in this light I would have got a frame of brown mud. Every Monday I unpacked things that had been lifted out of the ground by men who had not written down where, and I had a speech about it that I gave at parties until people found reasons to go and refill their drinks.

I pocketed it.

I stood up too fast and looked out at the mouth, where the daylight lay white across the slope. There was only the arch and the oak and a piece of sky. I would hand it in at the museum in Delphi on my way down. There was a guard at the museum door in a blue uniform who had torn my ticket in half on Wednesday with tremendous ceremony, and I would give it to him, and explain. I kept my hand around it in the pocket. It was cold from the dirt and then it was not.

Past the slumped stone the floor began to climb, and the daylight thinned and failed behind me until the flashlight was the only light there was, a yellow oval that slid over wet rock and showed me a yard of it at a time. The floor here was flowstone,

ridged and slick, with a skin of water over it that my boots kept finding, and I went up it with one hand on the wall. On the left the roof came down. It sloped in above me until I had to stoop, and then it met a great slab that had split off the wall at some time and leaned there. Between the slab and the low roof there was a crack.

The crack ran up and down. At the height of my shoulder it was just wide enough to take my forearm, and above that it pinched shut. Lower down it widened, and along the floor it was a good foot and a half across. The flashlight went into it four or five feet and found a bend. Beyond the bend the beam ran on into black.

I reached into it. It was rock and air, cave cold, the same cold as everywhere else, and when I held my palm flat in the opening I could not feel the air moving at all.

So I waited. Waiting had been the plan all along; it was what the bag was for. The duffel went down against the slab, and I sat on it with my back to the rock, and before long I switched the flashlight off to save the batteries. The dark came down so completely that I raised my hand in front of my face and could not find it. Behind me the drips went on in the hall. Very far off at the mouth the bells reached me when the wind brought them, and then did not. I groped in the bag under me for another granola bar, past the sock with the tape in it, which had been down among my clothes since I laced the boots on at home. I ate the bar in the dark and the oats went down my front, and the Advil bottle chattered in its pocket whenever I moved. Every so often I lit the flashlight to read the watch, whose luminous dots had stopped glowing years ago, and slid my hand into the crack and held it there. At twenty past twelve the rock was still only rock.

The last dark I could remember as complete as this one was in our own cellar, the July I was seven, in a thunderstorm that knocked out the power. My father was home that July, which was itself unusual. He had taken me down the cellar steps with a flashlight to look for candles, and at the bottom he had switched it off to show me what dark was like underground, the dark his trenches went down into. I had screamed. He had switched it on again at once and been sorry for an hour; in the morning there was a Tastykake on my plate, a butterscotch Krimpet, unwrapped and laid out on a napkin.

At half past twelve I peed behind the big stalagmite and begged Pan's pardon in Attic Greek inside my head, with the correct optative, which was more than I could have managed out loud.

I had not called Gloria. I had bought a postcard of the Charioteer instead, and it was in the bag now, unwritten.

Fenn had sat here. He had spent most of a summer on this floor in the dark with his cigarettes and his notebook and his better flashlight, if he had ever got the better flashlight. Cave air moved with the pressure outside; that much was in every book on caves. The cold he had felt was the weather on the far side of the mountain, coming through the rock.

It came at twenty to two.

I had my left hand lying on my knee in the dark, and the cold came across the back of it first, from the side where the crack was, a single thread of cold so distinct that I thought a drop of water had fallen on my skin. I thumbed the flashlight on. My breath showed in the beam and drifted toward the crack, and I got up off the bag and pushed my hand into the opening, my palm toward the dark.

This cold came from somewhere behind the rock. It was dry and it had an edge, where the cold off the walls was damp and

slow. It went in through the skin of my palm and down into the bones of my fingers until they ached to the wrist. Under my cuff the steel of the watch took the cold and held it. It was the cold that rolled out when you opened a chest freezer at the Acme and leaned in for the peas. The hairs stood up along my forearm. Behind me the drip went small and distant, a drip in some other cave, and the bells at the mouth, which I had stopped hearing an hour before, I heard again only because they were going, and then they were gone. My ears filled, a pressure with no pop at the end of it. The beam of the flashlight shook on the rock.

Fenn had stood here with his arm in a hole for the length of a cigarette, and written it down, and come back on Tuesday. I was not going to stand in a cave with my arm in a crack until the cold quit, and then go down to Delphi and write it up in a notebook. I was going in properly or I was going home.

I drew my hand out of the crack. The flashlight went between my teeth. I got the strap of the bag over my head so that the duffel hung down across my chest, turned my left side to the opening, and put my left foot in.

I sank onto my knees and went in sideways with my left shoulder first and my back flat to the slab and the bag pushed down in front of me in both fists, and the rock came cold against the back of my head and my shoulder blades, and the cold closed over my face and ran down inside my collar and up the sleeves of my jacket to the elbows, and the beam of the flashlight jerked over wet stone a foot from my eyes and showed me stone and nothing else, and the last sound in the world, which was the canvas of the bag scraping along the rock, went smaller and smaller while I listened to it and was gone, and there was nothing at all, and I knelt in the nothing with my mouth open around the flashlight and my breath going out white into its beam.

Then my face went hot.

It rose out of my collar into my cheeks and the tops of my ears, there in the cold, a scalding blush of a kind I had thought I was too old for. It was the blush of a department Christmas party in Mount Airy in 1989. I had gone upstairs looking for the bathroom and opened a door on a bedroom where eight or nine strangers were sitting on the bed and the floor around a single candle, and they had all stopped talking at once and looked up at me. There was no one here. There was rock a foot from my eyes, and the cold, and the quiet. I had the word *sorry* in my mouth behind the flashlight.

I backed out.

The bag caught on the slab. I pulled it free. Then I was in the hall again, upright, and I got the flashlight out of my mouth and wiped my mouth on my sleeve.

The drip was going again behind me. The air on my face was cave air, wet and still and smelling of stone, and when I held my hand to the crack there was nothing coming out of it. I hauled the strap back on and hurried down the flowstone faster than I had gone up it, with the beam on my boots and the bag banging my hip and my free hand in my pocket, closed around the bone. The walls went by unread. The slope leveled, the slumped shape went by on my right as a pale bulk at the edge of the light, and the mouth came up ahead of me, a ragged arch of daylight.

It was the wrong color.

At noon the light had come in white and flat and stopped a few yards inside the lip. Now it reached far into the cave in a long slant, yellow going toward orange, and lit the floor almost to my feet, and every pebble on the slope had a shadow longer than itself.

The watch said ten to two.

I climbed to the lip of the mouth and stopped under the arch. The sun stood over the ridge to the west, low and swollen. It was

low enough to look at through my fingers. Half the plateau below lay in shadow, and the half still lit had gone a paper-bag brown that I put down to the light. Beyond it the high summits stood lit to their tops, and there was gray rock all the way up the gullies where the snow had lain that morning. On the slope below me the thyme was over, every flower head dried to a brown husk on its stalk. The air coming in under the arch had a chill on it that had not been there at noon. Woodsmoke rose from somewhere below on the wind. Dung, a great deal of it, close and fresh. The bells were going somewhere under the lip, big and small, out of time.

The boulder stood at the last turn of the path with its face up toward me. There was no red on it. Nothing had been scrubbed off it either; there was no ghost of red down in the pits of the stone. Lichen covered the whole face, gray-green and orange, in rosettes as wide as my hand. Lichen did not grow like that in an afternoon.

I stepped out into October.

Chapter 4

The Goats Saw Me First

The goats saw me first.

They were scattered down the slope below the lip, a few dozen, with burrs in their coats. Every head came up together and the chewing stopped. A nanny with one horn broken off short had a sprig hanging from her mouth and forgot it there. The bells went quiet a few at a time. At the back a kid went on clanking, because it was scratching its ear with a hind hoof and would not be hurried.

* * *

The boy was closer. He had been sitting against the rock round the corner of the arch, out of the wind. He came up off the ground the way a cat leaves a sofa when a door slams, already facing me.

He was nine, perhaps. He wore a brown tunic of some coarse stuff belted with a cord, and his bare feet were gray with dust to the ankle. A sling hung around his neck with its pouch on his chest, and his hair had been cut short with a knife by a person in a hurry. There was a crust under his nose. He had a stick and kept it low.

His eyes came to my face and stayed.

He hooked a finger in the neck of his tunic, pulled it out, and spat down inside it. It was a small, dry, careful spit. Theophrastus's superstitious man did that whenever he passed a lunatic in the street.

"Nümfi?" he said, and then more, low, to himself.

It went up at the end. There was a sound in the middle I had no Greek letter for. The rest was thin and quick and slid straight past me, all but the case endings. I knew those from my grammars, and I had only ever heard them in my own voice.

"Khaire."

I gave it everything, the rasp of the k and both halves of the diphthong, the way the books printed it.

"Khére." He tried it like a coin he suspected was lead.

"Sorry." It was English, and no use to either of us. "I'm sorry, but I don't speak — I'm American. I came up from Delphi this morning. There was a man with poles. He had a stone for his daughter. I won't hurt you. I'm lost."

* * *

"I am a stranger," I said, in Greek this time. "I have come a long way, and I have lost my road. Tell me, boy, who is archon this year?"

It was the sentence for that. It sat at the back of the grammars under *Useful Phrases*, between buying fish and asking the way to the Piraeus.

"Ti?"

"The archon. Who rules here? Is there a king?"

"Pothen? Pothen ílthes? Ek tou antrou?"

He said a good deal more, fast and flat, the vowels pinched and everything I expected to be hard gone soft. I caught *pothen*. I caught *antrou*, which was nearly the word printed on my walker's map beside a little black symbol.

"Yes. I came out of the cave."

He took a step back. "Pothen?" The true answer was still Philadelphia.

"From beyond the Pillars of Herakles, very far to the west. Who is archon?"

"Archon." He frowned at it, and gave me the name. "Kleodamos." He went up on his toes to see past me into the arch. "Móni í?"

"Yes, alone. Which month is this?"

"Boathoos. Ti thélis?"

Kleodamos meant exactly as much to me as Nümfi had.

"Delphoi?" I aimed a finger down the mountain.

He watched my finger and not where it went.

So I crouched and wrote it for him in the dust at the foot of the rock, Δ, in square capitals with good serifs. Above my hand the face of the rock was dressed flat and cut with letters. Their edges were sharp, and red paint lay in the bottoms of the strokes: Σ, and further along , every letter there. On the ledge under them sat a clay lamp with a sooted nozzle and three knucklebones in a row.

The boy put his bare foot on my word and rubbed it out.

"Mí! Mí gráfe."

"It is only the name of a town."

"Nümfi."

I laid my palm on my chest. "Mara." I waited, and tried his. "Nümfi?"

His mouth fell open. He folded over his stick and laughed in high hiccups, like a much smaller child. I laughed with him without knowing what at.

"Mára," he said, and then to the goats, "Mára!"

* * *

The hunger arrived all at once.

It rose under my ribs and clenched. My mouth ran with water. My knees let go and I sat down on the duffel without deciding to.

"I'm hungry," I said. "God help me. *Peinō*."

The boy had a leather bag at his hip, black with handling. I could smell it from where I sat: sour milk, smoke, something baked. The smell filled my whole head.

"Ti dósis?" He laid a hand flat over the bag.

"Anything you want," I said.

There was a Wawa on Chestnut Street with a hoagie case lit up like an aquarium.

* * *

I got the zipper open. My hands found the box by feel, under the sweater, beside the sock. The pouch was green foil and crackled when I tore it. Two bars were inside, as there always were. I held one up to him and tapped his bag.

"I am a stranger and a beggar," I said, "and strangers and beggars are from Zeus. Have you bread? *Artos*. This, for bread. It is good. Honey. It is food."

He came near, at arm's length, and took it. He sniffed it. "Ti esti?" He bit.

The bar broke in his mouth with a crack and showered oats down his front. His face changed. He spat. Every crumb went onto the path, and he scrubbed his tongue on his forearm.

"*Pheu!* Ti esti touto? *Pheu*."

"I know," I told him, in English. "They're terrible. They're supposed to be good for you."

He gave me back the rest. "*Kopros*."

I ate mine, and then his, standing up, fast, head down, crumbs going down my fleece, and licked the honey off my thumb. I was still hungry. He watched me with his top lip lifted.

He untied the leather bag. Inside, in a gray rag, were a lump of white cheese and the heel of a dark loaf. He broke a piece off the cheese with his thumb and pushed it at me.

"*Phage*."

"Thank you. You are kind. May the gods give you good things for it."

"*Phage*."

It had goat hair on it. I ate it. It squeaked when I bit down, and it was so salty my eyes ran. The bread was half barley and full of grit. I chewed and chewed, and then it was gone.

He wanted the wrapper. He stood close enough to breathe on it, in my hand, where the silver inside was catching the low sun.

"Take it." I put it in his hand. "It is yours."

"*Kalon*." He tilted it and found his own face in it, and went entirely still. Afterward he folded it small and tucked it down the neck of his tunic.

* * *

He whistled the goats together and started down. I followed him because he was going down.

The path was only a goat track now, beaten pale through dead thyme. "Where's the road?" He looked where I was looking and saw grass.

Past the firs a pen stood where the pen had stood that morning. I knew it by the bend of the track and the slab behind it. Its wall ran in herringbone right round, every stone on edge, leaning on its neighbor. The corner kept the same long slant as the rest. A hurdle of woven brush closed the gap, tied to a post with a twist of green withy.

Below us the plain lay in shadow. It was brown from end to end, with two threads of smoke going up. Low huts stood down there, roofed with brush held down by stones. Grass grew where the road had crossed. Across the plain more firs climbed in one dark mass, and the ridge above them had only sky on it.

* * *

"Is there a Kaisar in Rome?" I said to his back, when the pen was behind us.

"Késar," he said over his shoulder. "En Rómi."

"Which Kaisar? His name. Tell me his—"

He was telling a goat to get on.

The hunger had come back. My stomach made a noise the goats turned round to look at.

Halfway down he sat on the track without warning and hauled his left foot into his lap.

A thorn was in his heel.

"Show me the foot," I said. "I will draw the thorn out. I am skilled at small work."

He talked to the thorn instead, and to the bush that had done it.

"Ai! Ai, ai. Káki, káki. Kissa! Kissa, deuro. Deuro, káki."

It was a long grumbling stream, and none of it was meant for me. He broke a fresh thorn off the same bush and dug with it, frowning, his tongue in the corner of his mouth. The sole of that foot was as hard as saddle leather. When the thorn came out he held it up, pinched in his fingers. "*Ide*." He was very pleased with it. He flicked it into the dusk. One of his ears stuck out further than the other.

* * *

At the foot of the slope he stopped, took me by the sleeve, and turned me toward the dark gap between the mountains.

"Delphous. Katō, katō. Delphous."

That one I heard whole. The ending was wrong and the *ph* had gone soft, but I heard it, and the back of my neck loosened.

"Delphoi. I thank you. Down there. Is it far?"

"Makran." And to Kissa, in the same breath, "Sitta! Sitta, íkade."

"Far. Of course it's far." That came out in English. I went back to Greek. "And you. What is your name?"

The goats shoved past our legs. He took his time. He lifted the stick and sent it back uphill, the whole way, to where the cave showed black in the gray cliff with one star over it. He brought it round slowly until its end rested on my fleece, over the breastbone.

"I do not understand. Say it slowly."

He said it a third time, slowly, chin up, loud and patient, for the deaf. I watched his mouth make it. The letters surfaced from the sound one at a time. A nu. The upsilon after it was rounded tight, nothing like mine. A mu, and the phi, the same strokes as the ones cut beside the arch with the red lying in them. At the end his voice came down on an eta that was not the eta of any grammar I owned.

"Nymphē."

Chapter 5

The Sanctuary

It was most of a day down the mountain, and I spent the first hour of it walking toward a road that was not there. The boy had left me where the slope ran out and gone off over the plain behind his goats, toward the smoke. When the gap he had pointed at was as dark as the mountains on either side of it, I found a wall with the flashlight, and a dog somewhere out on the plain went frantic at the beam until I put it out. I felt my way to the wall's corner and sat down in what smelled like a sheepfold, and lay with my head on the duffel and my knees pulled up inside the sweater, and all night the dog barked at intervals without much conviction, like a car alarm on Baltimore Avenue at three in the morning. I woke with the canvas under my cheek soaked through with dew and my fingers too stiff to find the notch in the foil, and I opened a pouch from the granola box with my teeth.

The morning before, a taxi had brought me up from Arachova and across this plain on asphalt. At first light I set off back the way it had come, on foot, eastward, over stubble and dung and plowed-up stones. At the lip there was a track, two ruts with a hump of turf between them and a broken cartwheel in the ditch with its spokes weathered silver, and I was so glad of it that I touched the hub as I went by.

Where Arachova had been there was a village, lower and smaller, earth roofs stepping down the hill with smoke leaking through them, and the dogs came out to tell it I was there, and a man splitting wood stopped with his axe in the air until I was well by.

Below the village the road dropped in loops along the side of a long valley. The scrub gave way to terraces of olives walled in dry stone, stepping down toward a river that was only a noise at the bottom of a gorge. Whole families were out in them, the men beating the boughs with long canes and the olives coming down onto spread cloths in a hard brief rattle, and the knocking carried along both sides of the valley at once. The hunger from the mountain had come down with me. Some olives had rolled into the road, and I took one out of the dust, wiped it on my jeans, and bit it.

It was like biting chalk soaked in aspirin, and my whole mouth drew back from it; my cheeks puckered and clung to my gums, and I spat, and went on spitting for most of the next bend while a girl on the terrace above watched me over the rim of her basket and then shouted down, delighted, "You salt them first!" You cured them in brine for weeks; I knew to the decimal what olive oil did to the fabric of a terracotta lamp, and the rest I had learned from the backs of bottles.

The press was in a farmyard where the road made an elbow round a spur. I smelled it before the turn, crushed green fruit sharp as cut grass, over something sour and black that ran out under the yard wall in a channel alive with wasps. Inside the gate a donkey with a sack over its eyes walked round a stone basin turning the millstones, and against the far wall a great dark beam, dragged down by a windlass and by stones the size of stockpots hung off it on ropes, crushed a stack of rush baskets full of paste. A woman about my age was skimming the oil off a sunk

jar with a wide shell, her skirts kilted up through her belt and her forearms shining to the elbow.

She saw me in the gate and kept skimming.

"Kirrha?" she said, and something with a no in it, and a great deal more, fast, over the scrape of the shell. She jerked her chin at a boy of ten asleep open-mouthed on a heap of empty baskets. "Two days at Kirrha with the jars," she told him. After that came a word for a husband who was no earthly use, and the boy slept through that too. "And what's that on your legs? Who sent you?"

"I am a foreigner and hungry. I can work."

The verb came out in the form for a man laboring for hire, the only one the book had given me. She stopped skimming.

"Where's your man?"

I understood that one.

"I have no man."

"Lucky." She waved the shell at the baskets of fresh olives stacked inside the gate. "Tip those under the stones for the donkey. You eat when they're done." She was skimming again before I had moved.

I carried olives for my lunch, in rush baskets that each weighed as much as a sack of wet laundry, and I tipped them one after another into the basin in front of the donkey's slow feet, and the oil found the thornbush scratch on my knuckles and stung. When the stack was gone she tore a round of bread in half, dipped the torn side in the gutter where the new oil ran out, and gave it to me dripping. The bread was gray and crunched and the oil was so bitter it made me cough and I ate it all. "If you're going up to the god, take money," she said as I left. "They charge you for breathing up there." She crossed the yard and kicked the sleeping boy, not hard, on the sole of his foot, and when he sat up she put the shell in his hand.

Below the press the road met another climbing from the gorge, and after that I had company. A family overtook me, a man and his wife and a grown son, with a white kid on a rope that the son carried in his arms whenever it balked.

"Is this the road to Delphi?" I asked the father, because he was nearest.

He answered with his eyes on my trousers. "Where else would it go? Up there's the god and down there's the sea, and this is the road in between."

"Listen to her," said the son behind him. "She sounds like the man who reads out the laws."

"Mind your mouth," said his mother. "You don't know what she is." She put her husband between herself and me and kept him there until the road turned.

The town began with a running track below the road, young men racing its length in the dust, stripped and oiled. Past it the cliffs closed in overhead, two sheer gray faces with a cleft between them, and out of the cleft came the water. In May it had been a dry niche behind a wire fence with a sign in four languages about falling stones. Now bronze lion heads stood out from a wall of dressed stone and poured water into a long basin. Pilgrims stooped at it to wet their hair while women waited with jars on their hips and a man sat at a little table with a ladle and a dish of coins. I wanted to put my whole head under one of those lions. Every face at the basin turned my way; I kept walking, up the last of the hill and into the town.

* * *

The guide found me in the gateway.

Below the gate the town opened into a market square with a colonnade along one side, and every shop in it sold something to give the god: clay women, white wool, laurel, and at one stall

strings of little clay discs, each pierced at the center and stamped with something worn too flat to read. They were too light for loom weights, and I could not think what else they might be for. At the gate stood a stone basin on a pillar, and every person who passed it dipped two fingers and touched them to the forehead, the woman with the kid, the son, the kid. My hands were black to the wrist with olive paste, and I kept them at my sides and went by.

He fell into step beside me talking, a lean, bandy-legged man in a brown cloak that had lost the pin of its brooch, so that he had fastened the brooch through the wool with a long thorn instead, neatly, years ago. He walked backward up the paving in front of me; his feet found every broken slab on their own.

"From Italy? From Sicily? No, look at the legs. From up past Thrace, somewhere they wear those. It makes no difference. You'll want the bull first, they all do, and then the treasuries, and then the temple, and you'll pay me at the top what you think it's worth, which will be two obols. And don't buy wool from that woman with the basket, she washes it in the horse trough."

He stopped in front of a bronze bull on a high base.

"This is the bull of the Corcyraeans. You will ask me why a bull. On Corcyra there was a bull that went down to the shore every day by itself and stood bellowing at the sea, and the herdsman followed it down and found the tunny running in the bay so thick a boy could have walked out on their backs. They could not get one fish into their nets until the god here told them to give the bull to Poseidon. So they gave it, and from a tenth of the catch they set up this bull to Apollo."

It was a speech he had given ten thousand times, worn smooth, in a town Greek far nearer my books than the boy's had been on the mountain, and I lost none of it. I would have paid him for that alone, if he had stood still once in his life to be paid.

"Who made the bull?" The folds of its dewlap had been chased so fine that the tracer's marks showed.

He stopped, put out. "Who made it? Nobody asks that. A man from Aegina, and they paid him." He carried on backward up the hill. "They want the fish, the people who come here, not the man from Aegina."

The bull was polished bright, with gilded horns and eyes of white stuff with a dark stone for the pupil. The marble men were worse. Their skin had been tinted a warm brown and their lips red, their eyes painted in with black lashes drawn on one by one, and a girl on a column with a basket on her head had painted earrings and pink nipples showing through a painted dress. I had looked at polychromy through a stereo microscope for most of my working life. For a museum open day I had once painted a plaster cast of a marble youth from the published pigment analysis, and been proud of myself for liking him.

Somewhere above, a goat was going up to its death, protesting, and a flute was playing it up.

"Don't listen to that one," said the guide, without turning his head. Across the Way a short man in a green cloak was talking to a family with his hand on the father's shoulder. "He tells it all wrong, and he's from Amphissa."

"I heard that," the man in green called over, without taking his hand off the father.

"You were meant to," said my guide.

Along the top of the next treasury ran a frieze of gods fighting giants against a hard bright blue. A few grains of that blue off a sherd from Kourion had once glittered under my lens like ground sugar, and here it was by the bucketful behind a giant having his head bitten off by a lion.

"And here stood the boxer from Thasos," the guide said, "whose statue killed a man, which is another story and costs

extra. Everyone beats somebody at Delphi, and then they come and put it up where the others have to walk past it."

My feet hurt. The boots had been bought for mountains, and the paving had been worn glassy by so many soles that I climbed it with my toes clenched inside them, and somewhere in the boxer I had stopped listening to anything but them.

"And here," he said, "the runner from Kroton, three times at Olympia."

He had stopped walking backward and was pointing at a base, and he went on with the speech for the man who was not there.

"Look at the calves on him, and the veins standing up on his arms, and his mouth open, you would swear you could hear him breathing. They say he outran a hare on the beach at Kroton, and the sculptor made him run the stadium twenty times while he watched, to get the knees right." He cupped his palm in the empty air above the base, about where a hip would have been. "Bronze. With gilt on the wreath."

It was a block of limestone as high as my waist, with an inscription cut deep and filled with red saying that the people of Kroton had set up this man for the god. There was no man on it. Its top had two sockets cut into it in the shapes of two feet planted for a stride. Around the lip of the nearer socket the stone had sheared off in a curved flake, where something had been driven in under the edge and leaned on, and at the bottom lay a crumb of lead, chopped through.

I dropped the bag in the road.

The flake had come away clean, its face raw crystal, sparkling, and the rest of the block around it was old weathered limestone, pitted, with a rosette of lichen in one corner as broad as a coin. No dirt had got into the scar, and no lichen. Along the lip of the second socket ran chisel bites, short square cuts where the lead

had been hacked out to free the bronze foot, still sharp enough to catch a fingertip. Below where the feet had been, faint green streaks ran down the front of the base, the stain that copper left in stone when rain had run over it for centuries, and the bronze that had fed them was gone. The streaks were the oldest thing on the block; the holes were the newest.

There was another base past this one with two holes in it, and another beyond that with a single heel still in its socket, the rest of the foot gone above the instep and the cut bronze faced green-brown and fine-ridged from the saw.

"The singer," the guide said above me.

He had come close, and his voice had dropped out of the speech into something flatter.

"He came for the games and sang for us, and we gave him the crown. And afterward his men came up the Way with crowbars and ropes, and five hundred of the god's bronzes went down to Kirrha in ox-carts and onto the ships. They took the Thessalians off their horses and left the horses, because the horses were bad bronze. The god's own."

"And the god allowed it?"

He turned his whole attention on me. "The god took his time. He's dead now, isn't he, the singer? Dead in a ditch outside Rome with his own knife in his neck, and the bronzes standing on somebody's doorstep over there, and here I am giving the speech for them still." He regarded the empty sockets the way a landlord looked over a room the tenant had skipped out of. "What is a stranger going to look at? The holes?"

Nero had come to Greece for the games in sixty-six and stayed into sixty-seven. He had died in the June of sixty-eight, in a freedman's villa and not a ditch, with the freedman's hand helping the knife. It was at least that late, then. The lead in the socket had dulled to a skin of gray, but when I scored it with the

edge of a coin from my pocket it was soft and bright underneath, and that meant two or three years of weather at the very most.

I unzipped the end of the duffel for the Pentax and spent a frame on the base, close, with the sockets filling the viewfinder and the curved scar sharp in the side light. The shutter fired like a slammed drawer and the guide flinched. “What was that? What did it do?”

He held his hand out at the bend above.

“Two obols.”

My jeans pocket had three coins in it from the taxi, and I found the biggest by feel and gave it to him. It was a hundred-drachma piece of the Hellenic Republic, brassy, with a young man’s head on it in profile and his hair blowing back, and he read the capitals round its rim where it lay on his palm, with his lips moving. He read them perfectly well. They were his own letters.

“A hundred drachmas! Who strikes a hundred in brass? And this one with the hair, some king from past the Istros? Where do they spend these?”

“Friend,” I said, in my best Attic, slowly, with every aspirate and every accent where the grammar had put it, “I come from very far away, and I have no other silver. Take it, and may the god be kind to you.”

“Friend!” he called across the Way to the man in green, in my voice exactly, with every aspirate blown and the pitch rising and falling on the accents like a schoolboy reciting for a master with a cane. “Listen to this one. I come from very far away, and I have no other silver!” He put his hand on his heart. “May the god be kind to you!”

“Is it the Pythia’s grandmother?” his rival shouted back. “Has she come down to tell the girls they’re doing it wrong?”

“She pays in brass, too!”

The woman selling wool took it up and sang the end of it after them, and two pilgrims who could not have known what was funny laughed along because everyone else was.

I had the next sentence ready. It was a good sentence, with an optative in it. I put it away.

"Keep the coin," I said, in English.

He stopped laughing and gave me a look of real interest; then he tucked the coin inside the cloak and set off for the gate to meet the next stranger. I shouldered the duffel and kept climbing.

Above the bend the Way doubled back and climbed past more treasuries crowded shoulder to shoulder with their doors shut. The Athenians' was one of them. In May it had stood white and alone on its terrace, the one on all the postcards; I went by it now without knowing it. Above them ran a great wall of stones fitted together in curving shapes and written over in lines too small to read walking. At the top of the ramp beside it stood an altar of black stone edged with white, with smoke going up from it and a priest's assistant sluicing blood off its step from a bucket. The goat I had heard bleating its way uphill was tied to a ring at the foot of the step, alive, stripping the leaves off somebody's laurel branch; the blood on the step was some other animal's. Behind the altar stood the temple.

It had all its columns.

I had known it would; on Wednesday I had seen it as everybody saw it, six gray columns on a long platform with the cliffs behind them and the light going, two hundred tourists photographing them from the same place on the path, and I had stood among them and wished the light would stay. Here it was entire, and it had been painted. The columns were dressed in a fine creamy stucco, but above them everything had color. The grooved blocks along the frieze were blue so dark it was nearly black and the panels between them red, the cornice was picked

out in bands of red and blue and gold, and gilded shields hung all along the front and flashed when the smoke moved. In the pediment the god stood among his family with their skin tinted and their hair gilded, and at the corners of the roof stood gilt figures against the sky.

The Mummers had got at it.

I crossed the terrace to where the path had been on Wednesday, the spot everybody stood on, and turned to face the temple, with the light coming low across it, and I waited for it to turn into my temple. It stayed red, and the shields went on flashing in the smoke. The god in the pediment looked out over all our heads with his gilded hair and his painted mouth, and the word that came to me for all of it was English: ugly. I checked the faces of the pilgrims going up the ramp straight away, in case one of them had heard.

The people who built it had seen it like this and meant it like this, and they had been right about their own temple, and I had been wrong about it for twenty years in a library. I had come the whole way back to see it alive, and I preferred it dead.

* * *

So I went up to give it its due.

The steps of the temple were a mason's steps and not a person's, each one as high as my knee, and I climbed them with a hand on each, like a child getting onto a bus. Between the columns it was suddenly cool, and the noise of the altar dropped behind me. Under my palm the stucco of the nearest column was fine and hard and very slightly gritty, marble dust in the lime, beautifully laid. Along the foot of the porch wall ran a low molding, painted with a key pattern in red and blue. The blue was the Egyptian blue again, coarse enough to feel under the ball of my thumb. A flake had lifted from it, and under the flake was

another blue, older and paler and laid on finer. The new blue had been slopped over the edge of the old border by a painter in a hurry who had missed a whole hand's breadth behind the column, where he thought no one would crouch. The god's house had been touched up. Badly. I had my thumbnail at the edge of the flake, and I was smiling.

A hand took me by the collar of the fleece and hauled.

I came off my heels and round. The man holding me had a white tunic with a purple stripe and a staff in his other hand, and two more men had come up behind him.

"Off the god's step! Who let her up here unwashed?"

"Whose is she? Does anyone know her?"

"See the legs on her? She's run off from some house."

"In the god's house, with her hands on it!"

"Get her down before the priest comes out."

One of them said a word I had never seen written down, and the others laughed. Pilgrims had stopped on the steps to watch.

"Get your hands off me. I wasn't hurting it. Your molding's been retouched and it's been done badly, that's all, the blue's slopped right over the old border, I was only looking at the—"

"What's she saying? Is that Syrian?"

He dropped my collar and took hold of the duffel instead and pulled. I held on to the strap. "The rod!" he shouted behind him. "Bring the rod!"

The slave took the steps two at a time. He was barefoot and thickset, with a cropped head and a peeled rod in his fist as long as my arm.

He hit me across the shoulders.

I was down on one knee on the stone. The bag slid. I held the strap. He hit me again across the back, and the fleece took it, and then across the forearm I had put up, and that one I felt to the bone. The strap tore out of my hand. I was on my feet. "Down."

He hit me on the hip. I went backward off the top step and down onto the next, and the next, sitting, my hands on the stone. The bag came down the steps after me and hit my legs. I took it by the handles. I stood. He came down after me and swung and caught my wrist and the watch on it.

I ran.

I ran down the platform past the altar with the bag clutched to me, and he came after me as far as the head of the ramp, hitting what he could reach, and the people on the ramp pressed back to the parapet to let us by. At the head of the ramp he stopped. I kept going. I took the ramp and the bend and the treasuries without looking back, and at the turn where the Way doubled on itself I looked.

He was standing at the top of the ramp with the rod bent open in his two fists where it had split, showing the split to the man in the purple stripe, who was watching the queue on the ramp over his head.

"Look at it," the slave was saying. "Split end to end, and they'll stop it out of my bread."

* * *

I sat on the edge of the colonnade in the market square below the gate with the bag between my feet. There were two hot stripes across my right forearm, and the skin had split on one of them in a short line beaded with blood. When I moved my shoulders the back of the fleece pulled at something underneath that had begun to stick.

The woman selling clay figures from a board at the next pillar had moved her board six feet farther off.

I began to shake. It started in my knees, in the full sun, and when I told it to stop it went on, and it was still going when a

man two pillars along bought a string of the clay discs and beat the seller down by an obol.

The herald stepped out of a door at the end of the colonnade a little later, a stout man with a staff wound round with white wool, and a boy behind him carrying a wax tablet. He climbed onto a block outside it and opened his mouth, and the noise of the square sank under his voice.

"Hear, people of Delphi, and you strangers in the god's city! Letters have come up from Corinth with the ship, and the council has received them, and the council bids me cry it."

His was a big slow voice, every word set down by itself and every ending given its full weight; it carried.

"Titus Caesar, son of the Emperor, has taken Jerusalem of the Jews by storm. Their temple is burned and their city is thrown down to the ground, and the war in Judaea is ended by the favor of the gods."

A man near the money-changer's table called out *Kalōs!* The boy put the tablet into the herald's hand. He raised it at the full length of his arm and screwed his eyes at it, brought it closer, and pushed it away again.

"Therefore," he read, "the archon Kleodamos, and the council and the people of the Delphians, have resolved that on the fourth day from now oxen shall be sacrificed to Pythian Apollo, for the safety and the victory of the Emperor Titus Caesar Ouespasianos—"

"Autokratōr," said a thin man in the doorway behind him. "Autokratōr Kaisar Ouespasianos Sebastos. And for Titus Caesar his son."

The herald lowered the tablet and did not turn round.

"For the safety and the victory," he said again, at the same great volume, "of the Emperor Caesar Ouespasianos Sebastos, and of Titus Caesar his son, and of all their house. And the

citizens to walk with garlands from the council house to the god's altar. And every householder to set a lamp in his door on the eve, and to keep the day as a feast. And the strangers in the city to keep clear of the altar while the god is served. And the meat to be given out in this square to the citizens."

"Citizens only?" a voice called from the back.

"And the rest of us?"

The herald climbed down.

"The rest of you can smell it cooking," the man by the money-changer's table answered for him, and the back of the square told him what he could do with his nose.

Ouespasianos. It took me the length of the whole repetition to get it. It was Greek trying to say a Latin name that began with a sound Greek did not have, and doing it the way the coins did, the coins I had cleaned with a cocktail stick, a thick-necked man with a nose like a doorknocker. *Vespasianus.* Vespasian.

Titus had taken Jerusalem in the late summer of seventy. The temple had burned in August and the upper city had fallen in September; I had read it in Josephus in a seminar in my second year, in a hot room on the third floor with a radiator nobody could turn off. News like that came to Greece in weeks, by sea, and the sea was still open, and the olives were coming down in the valley behind me. It was the autumn of the year seventy.

I did it on my fingers, because it was the kind of sum I made mistakes in. Nineteen ninety-eight, less seventy. One thousand nine hundred and twenty-eight years.

I had told Gloria the ninth of June.

"Is it for the women too, the meat?"

The woman with the clay figures had come back her six feet and was asking me.

"Was it the god's men did that? What did you do to them?"

"No idea," I told her, in English.

She stayed where she was. “Those are a man’s boots,” she said. “My husband makes these.” She tilted the board toward me to show the clay women, each with her hands on her breasts, all pressed from one mold, with the same thumbprint on every hip. “Since the bronzes were carted off there’s no buying. Everybody’s poorer. You’d think the god would want more of these, with his own gone, but no.” She took her board away again, still talking, round behind the pillar.

The herald handed the tablet back to the boy, said something short to the clerk in the doorway, who pretended not to hear, and stumped away along the colonnade with the boy trotting after him. The square came back up to its noise. My hands were lying in my lap; all through the proclamation I had been working the olive paste off them with my thumbs, one finger at a time, and they were clean, the creases still dark and the nails black, but the backs and the palms rubbed sore.

The sun went off the square an hour after that, and the stallholders put up their shutters. Two men at the fountain at the bottom of the square were still talking about the oxen. They were in no hurry, and I could follow most of it.

“Four oxen, he says. For the whole town? Who’s going to get a mouthful off four? The council will have it all before it’s cooked.”

“Last time, for the Nemean thing, it was one ox and a sheep, and my brother’s wife got a hoof.”

“That’s because your brother’s wife stood at the back.”

“She stood at the back because your mother was at the front with a basket.”

“Where are the Jews, anyway?”

“Over past Syria somewhere.”

“And is it true they burned their god’s house?”

“So he says.”

“Then that god will want paying for it.”

"Not from us, he won't. It's four oxen."

The herald had said the fourth day, I was nearly sure, and nothing about four oxen. Either they had heard him wrong or I had.

I was waiting for the square to empty so that I could think where to go, and a man came across it in the dusk and planted himself in front of me with his thumbs in his belt. He was younger than I was, with a good cloak and a bad smile.

"On your own? Lost your people? It gets cold in this square after dark." The question was finished before his look was, in a way I understood without any Greek at all. "There's a house down past the stadium road that takes in girls on their own. Clean, and you'd eat. Come on, I'll carry the bag for you."

He put a hand on the strap.

"No. I'll carry it."

It was English, and the words were nothing to him; the voice was enough. He took his hand back. "As you like. You'll think better of it when the dogs come round." He said something sideways to a man I had not seen in the shadow of the colonnade. I slung the bag crosswise and walked out of the square the way I had come in, toward the cleft in the cliffs, and when I looked round at the corner he was still standing by the fountain, watching me go.

Under the cliffs the light was nearly gone. The pilgrims had gone in to their suppers and the table with the ladle and the coins had gone with them, and the water had the place to itself, pouring out of the lions' mouths in five white ropes that fell into the basin with a noise much bigger than they were. Air came down the gorge smelling of moss and cold water.

I knelt on the lip of the basin and put my face in the water.

The cold of it stopped my breath, and I surfaced gasping and went under again, and scrubbed at my face and neck with both

hands. I pushed the sleeves of the fleece up and laid my forearms flat in the basin, where the cold bit into the welts, burned, and went numb. I drank out of my cupped hands until my stomach hurt, and leaned on the lip with my sleeves dripping, and made a plan. In the morning I would go back up. The boy's track climbed from the plain, and the pen was by the firs, and the firs were below the cave, and if the cold had leaked from that rock at one-forty on a day in May it might come again on some other day, if I sat there long enough with my hand in the crack. I had the rest of the granola, and now I had water.

A woman appeared on the road with a jar on her head and a lamp in her hand.

She did not see me, but walked the length of the basin to the far end, where the overflow ran out through a channel in the stone, and unloaded herself there in one movement, lamp on the lip and jar on the paving, the way I came in at my own door and got rid of my keys. She leaned over the basin and fished out of it with her bare arm a garland gone limp, white flowers on a ring of twisted wool, shook it once, and flung it out into the dark down the slope as far as it would go.

"Boeotians," she said to the dark.

She kicked off one sandal and put her foot under the overflow and stood on the other leg with her skirt held up. She let the water run over her foot, then changed feet and stood quite still while it ran. Her face in the lamplight was broad and brown and lined across the forehead, a woman of fifty with gray hair dragged back under a dark kerchief, and her eyes were shut. When she opened them she saw me on the lip of the god's spring in trousers, with my wet hair in my face.

"Out of the basin," she said. "People drink that. Use the trough at the end."

I got off the lip.

She stepped back into her sandal and filled her jar at the nearest of the lions, holding its mouth up under the stream until the note of the water changed and it ran over, and then she came along the basin to me with the lamp.

"Who beat you?"

"A man with a stick, at the temple. Over a paint job."

She heard the English without any change in her face, and looked at my arm with the stripes on it.

"Hands."

I held them out. The flame was close enough that I could feel its little heat on my fingers.

"Turn them."

I turned them palm up, and she bent over them. They were clean from the basin, and soft, and pink. There was a scar on the side of my left forefinger from a scalpel, and the scratch the thornbush had given me across the knuckles of the right, and the smooth tight shine that years of acetone had left on the pads of my fingers. The only hard place on either of them was a pen callus on the side of my middle finger.

"Open your mouth."

I did not understand her at once. She showed me, drawing her own lips back from her teeth, and I opened my mouth, and she looked in with the flame under my chin.

The last person to look into my mouth with a light had been Dr. Pinsky on Walnut Street, in February, with a paper bib on a beaded chain round my neck and the oldies station on the radio, and he had told me I was brushing too hard and wearing the enamel away at the gumline, and I had gone home and bought a softer brush that same afternoon at the Rite Aid on Chestnut, the one with the angled head, because he was right, and that was worse than the enamel.

She was looking at the upper molars on the left, and I knew what she was looking at: I had a filling back there, an old one, silver gone dull, with a lip on it that frayed the floss.

"What's that? Lead?"

I closed my mouth.

She stood back from me, and I could see her deciding something and disliking it.

"Who saw you come down here?"

"No one." In English it came out all at once and kept coming. "There isn't a person on earth who knows where I am. I work in a museum in Philadelphia, in a basement, I glue lamps back together for a living, I came to Greece for three weeks on a credit card because of a dead man's notebook, and my cousin expects me home in June. I walked out of a cave yesterday. I was in it ten minutes. My father's Seiko says it was ten minutes." The voice went on me there. I stopped and waited for it, and it came back thinner. "I don't know what you're asking me. I don't even know your name."

She let me finish, and pointed at the jar.

"Can you carry water?"

I took the jar by its two handles and lifted it. It was as heavy as a child of four, and it rose off the paving full to the lip and slopped over my wrists and down my front. I got it as far as my chest and could get it no higher; I stood there with it against the fleece and my arms beginning to shake.

"On the head," she said. "Not like that. Like this." She put the flat of her hand on top of her own kerchief and walked three steps with her back straight and her neck long, carrying nothing, and walked back.

"Can you card wool?"

I knew the word. The women in the palace on Ithaca did it all day, and that was the whole of my acquaintance with it.

She saw that without my saying it. “Weave?”

I shook my head.

“Grind? Cook?”

“Eggs. I can do eggs.”

She took that for a no, which it more or less was.

“I’ve a houseful of Thebans,” she said, “and the girl ran off at the vintage.”

I stood with the jar.

“Whose are you?”

It was the word the shouting men had used on the temple steps. She said it quietly, with her face lit from underneath.

“Mine.”

She turned and started up the road with the light.

“Bring the jar,” she said.

I carried it on my hip, which was wrong, up the dark road behind her, with the water slopping out at every step and running cold down my leg into my boot.

“Where are we going?”

“The step,” she said, and the step was there, and I found it with my shin.

A short way above the spring the road turned off between houses into a lane so narrow that the jar scraped the wall, and halfway along it she stopped at a door and banged on it with her fist until a man opened it a crack with a lamp of his own.

“It’s dark, woman.”

“My sieve.”

“Now?”

“It’s been in your house a month. Your wife borrowed my good one to strain her must, and it was to come back next morning.”

“She’s asleep.”

“Wake her.”

He shut the door. My arms were on fire to the shoulder. I shifted the jar to the other hip and nearly lost it and caught it on the wall, and she stood at the door waiting, perfectly patient, with her lamp. After a while the door opened again and a hand came out with a sieve in it, a round wooden frame with a mesh of fine horsehair. She went round the mesh with one finger before she said anything.

"There's a hole in it."

"It had a hole when we had it."

"It had no hole. Mend it. Your wife and I fill our jars at the same spring."

The door shut.

She walked on to the end of the lane, where there was a gate in a wall, and behind it a courtyard with a pomegranate tree in the middle and a staircase up the outside wall to a gallery, and from somewhere above a man was singing, not well, a song with endless verses about a girl from Corinth. There was a smell of lentils and smoke. Doors opened off the court on every side; behind two of them lamps were lit and voices were talking, and behind a third a man was already snoring.

"Kallia!" A head leaned out over the gallery rail. "Is there any more of the lentils, or have those Thebans had it all?"

"Pot's on the hearth," she called up. "Scrape it yourself."

"Who's that you've got?"

"A pair of hands."

"Can she sing? We've had that song since sunset."

"She can carry."

Kallia, then.

She led me to a hearth under a lean-to roof, where a pot sat in the embers and a big jar stood by it.

"Water in there," she said. "Ashes out before the light, and the hearth swept. Water again from the spring before they wake,

two jars. Then the floors, the court first, and the Thebans' pots from tonight, which they'll have left in the trough for the god to wash."

I tipped my jar into the big one, and it filled the big jar to the shoulder.

"Don't touch the oil. Sleep there."

She showed me a low doorway under the stairs with her lamp, a room with jars and sacks in it and a mat on the floor, and then she took the light away with her, because lamp oil was lamp oil, and crossed toward the singing.

* * *

The storeroom smelled of oil and dust and mice. The flashlight was somewhere in the bottom of the duffel, and it could stay there; Kallia was not going to come back and find a light under her stairs that burned nothing. I found the mat with my feet, and finding it I barked my hip on the shoulder of a storage jar, and something dry hanging from a beam brushed my hair. When I crushed a leaf of it between my fingers it was oregano.

Kallia came back once, in the dark.

"Blanket," she said from the doorway, and something heavy landed across my legs, and she was gone again; I had thanked her in neither language. It was goat hair, as coarse as a doormat, and it smelled of whoever had slept under it last.

I unlaced my boots by feel and stood them against the jar. My right sock was soaked from the water I had slopped down my leg. I worked it off and reached into the bag for a dry one, and my hand closed on the sock and the hard little oblong in its toe. I let it be and drew out the sweater instead, folded it for a pillow, and lay down. The welts on my arm had stiffened; when I lay on my back the fleece came unstuck from the place on my shoulder with a small tearing feeling, and I turned onto my side, facing the door.

Upstairs the man was still singing; he had got the Corinthian girl as far as Sikyon. A voice from the gallery told him to shut up, and he sang the last line again, louder.

The watch was loud in the dark an inch from my ear, and I lay and listened to it and worked out how early I would have to have the ashes out and the water in to be on the cart track by full light, with the plain to cross after that, and the long climb to the firs, and the cave at the top of it by noon. Somewhere among the jars a mouse had found its way into the barley, and I lay in Kallia's storeroom on Kallia's mat under the goat-hair blanket with my wrist under my cheek, and listened to the mouse and the watch going about their two small businesses in the dark, one of them in the sack and one of them close beside my head, until I slept.

Chapter 6

Snow at the Cave Mouth

I had scraped the floor of the crack down to bare rock as far in as my arm would reach, and now I knelt at the bend with Kallia's ash shovel, chopping at a crust of earth that had frozen into plates. Each plate came up with a skin of rime on its underside. Below it the dirt was black grit, packed hard.

Everything in there was cold. In May this rock had let out a cold of its own, and my skin had singled it out at once. Now the whole mountain had turned to cold, down to the iron of the shovel, which had taken the skin off the pad of my thumb some while ago. Nothing could have come through that crack that I would have known from the rest.

I dug anyway. The shovel was meant for ashes, with a blade the width of my palm, and every time it struck the rock underneath it gave a flat little note that ran off along the hall behind me and answered itself, late.

The torch spat. Its light jumped up the face of the slab and dropped again.

"Your fingers are white," Valens said.

"They're fine."

He let it pass. He was standing on the flowstone a little below me with his feet set across two of its ridges, holding the pine up

and off to one side so that his own shadow fell away from where I was working. He had stood like that since we came in. When a torch burned down he lit the next from it and ground the stub out under his boot, and went on standing. At his feet my duffel leaned on the slab, zipped, the strap laid ready over it. My flashlight was in there, under everything, and I had let him burn his pines rather than have him see it.

I pressed my hand flat in the bottom of the bend. The tips of my fingers went white and then stopped hurting, which was worse. Nothing moved across them.

"What hour is it?"

"The light's off the mouth. Past the middle of the day."

"The hour. On the watch."

He found it in the pouch at his belt and let me see it in the torchlight, lying on his palm, its steel gone dull with the cold and the band hanging down between his fingers, and he kept his thumb on the end of the band.

Ten past one, or near it; I had set the hands on my second day at Kallia's by the shortest shadow of her gatepost.

In May the cold had come at twenty minutes short of two, by Athens time, which ran an hour and more ahead of this sun. It was nothing to go on, and I had nothing else.

"Wait until the long hand is at the eight," I said.

"How long is that?"

"From Kallia's gate to the spring and back. With a full jar."

"Most of a pine, then."

I bent to the shovel again.

"There's snow coming over the ridge," he said behind me. "I saw it from the mouth. We're off the stair before it comes, or we're up here till morning. There's nothing up here for the mules."

“Take the mules and go down. Leave me one of the pines. I will find my own way.”

“You came up that stair holding the gray’s tail.”

“I shall not need to come down.”

He was quiet so long that I heard the drip, far back in the hall, falling into its basin.

“You won’t get over the top in this,” he said.

“I said so yesterday. I am not crossing anything.”

“You’re coming down with me. I’m paid for the down as well as the up.”

“Give me until the long hand stands at the eight. Only that. Stand there and hold the light and give me so much, and if nothing happens, I will come down with you, and I will not say one word between here and the widow’s gate. And you may have the shovel also.”

“It’s not your shovel.”

“It is the widow’s. She shall have it back.”

“You brought the bag in,” he said. “Into a hole in a rock.”

“Yes.”

“It goes back down on the other mule, with you on the gray. I’m not carrying it up here twice.”

The plate under the blade came away whole, and under it there was rock, the same gray rock, with a little water standing in a pit of it under a lid of ice. I broke the ice with a knuckle. Water. Only water, and cold, and my own breath going white over it in the torchlight.

“Two more pines after this one,” Valens said. “Then down, whatever your hole’s doing.”

* * *

The afternoon before, he had brought a string of mules up Kallia's lane, loaded to the ears with split oak, and stopped them short of the gate, and walked on by himself, looking at the ground.

The ground was ice from the gate to the turn, and the ice was mine. Twice a day for most of a month I had carried water up the lane on my hip, because I still could not do it on my head, and every step slopped a little onto the stones; since the nights had turned, the slops had stopped drying and begun to freeze, one coat on another, like the paint on a fire escape.

My plan at the spring had not lasted the first day. I had the hearth cleared and two jars in before light, as I had meant to, and Kallia was waiting for me in the court with the broom. After the court there were the floors; after the floors the pots the Thebans left, and a Theban who wanted his cloak beaten, and then it was dark. On the fourth morning I reached the top of the town with the duffel before it came to me that I had no idea how to get up onto the plain. I'd come down by the long road round, and between the plain and Delphi stood only cliff. I went back down and did the floors.

Since then the snow had come a little lower on Parnassus every night. I watched it at the lions while the second jar filled, first the summits and then the shoulders and then the rim of the cliffs above the sanctuary, white along its edge like a glass dipped in sugar. I had spoken no Greek aloud since the guide on the Sacred Way. Kallia gave me orders my hands could understand without me, and I followed them, and whatever got away from me got away in English, and Kallia worked on through it.

He walked back to his mules. I was in the gateway with the empty jar on my hip.

"Ashes," he said. "For the ice. Before they come up."

A woman in a gateway with a jar was whoever you asked for ashes, so I went and got them. The pail stood by the hearth where

I left it every morning, half full, with Kallia's little iron shovel upright in it. He took the pail from me at the gate and went up the lane throwing the ashes in low, flat fans, so that they fell where a hoof would come down and nowhere else. A scar the length of my finger ran over the back of his right hand. Whoever closed it had been in a hurry and set the stitches too far apart, and it had healed in a ladder, every rung raised and white. It was an older hand than the rest of him.

He brought the mules up singly. They were big, dark, dusty animals with the oak lashed onto wooden packsaddles, and each one stopped at the edge of the ice, put a forefoot on the ashes, and considered. The last was a gray who would not consider anything. He leaned on her shoulder, and she had to brace a foot under his weight. He spoke into her ear, low and level, in Latin. *Ambula, asini filia.* Walk on, daughter of a donkey.

It was the plain truth about her, and I laughed.

The gray walked on.

Kallia was in the gateway behind me.

"Not in my court, Valens," she said. "Unload in the lane."

She had put her back against the trunk of the pomegranate, with her arms crooked out from her sides, like a crossing guard who had lost her sign.

"She had that tree to the height of her head last winter," she said.

"That was the brown."

"Then she can stand in the lane and think about the brown."

So we unloaded in the lane. Kallia pulled a split off the first load and smelled the cut end of it.

"Wet."

"Split this month," he said. "It'll burn."

"It'll spit. The last lot spat a coal on a Theban's cloak, and I paid for the cloak."

"That was pine. This is oak."

"Then it'll spit oak." She pointed the split at me. "You. Under the stair. Bark up."

I carried. He unlashed the loads and handed the splits down to me in armfuls, and I built the stack under the outside stair with the ends laid crosswise, two this way and two that, so that it would stand on its own and not lean on Kallia's wall, which had enough to hold up already. On my fourth trip he looked at the ends.

"Who showed you that?"

"Don't wait for an answer," Kallia said. "She doesn't talk."

He handed me the next armful.

"Five the load," he said to Kallia, when the last of it was in.

"Four. It's wet."

"Five. It's oak."

"Four now, and the fifth when I've seen it burn without spitting."

She paid him from a knot in the corner of her kerchief, and after that Kallia went at him in Phocian too fast for me to follow, and he answered her a word at a time, until he gave her one coin back. I thought it was for the spitting. She tied the knot up again, more slowly than she had untied it.

"Is the sea shut yet?" she said.

"The last ship went out of Kirrha eight days ago."

"Did anything come in from the east before it went?"

"Oil. Wine from Crete. A man with dogs to sell."

"Letters."

"I don't carry letters."

"Nobody asked what you carry."

"Kallia!" A Theban hung off the gallery. "Are those lentils ever coming?"

"When the hearth comes," she shouted back, and went in to it, and I was alone in the lane with him and five empty mules.

He was working along the string, tightening girths. Above the roofs the cliffs had gone gray-blue and the snow along their rim had turned pink, and that was nearly all the day had left.

"You go up on the mountain," I said.

The sentence left me with all its breathings in, in the voice of a woman reading aloud to a seminar.

He finished the girth he was on. "For wood. Not high."

His Greek was as foreign as mine. He spoke it slowly and flatly, every ending in its place, a man setting things down one by one where he could find them later, and I followed all of it without reaching.

"Higher," I said. "Above the cliffs and over the plain. To the Korykian cave."

"Pan's cave. What's up there?"

"Where I came in."

He turned round from the mule then.

"The charcoal men had a story this autumn," he said. "A goat boy up there saw a nymph walk out of Pan's cave in trousers and eat his cheese."

"He gave me the cheese."

"That's not how he tells it."

"He spat out mine. I gave him something to eat and he spat it out on the path."

"He tells that part." He looked down at my boots, which had carried me off the mountain in October and had not had a day off since. "So you walked over the mountain. In the autumn. Alone."

"From in there. Not over anything."

"And now you want to go back into it."

"Tomorrow."

"Not in snow." He moved on to the next mule. "Look at it."

I had been looking at it for a month.

"The stair's ice from the second turn," he said. "The plain's snow. Nobody's up there now but the charcoal men, and they're coming down."

"How long is it to the cave?"

"In summer, a morning. In this, a morning and more."

"And down again?"

"Before dark, if you're quick in there. Why tomorrow? It'll be there in the spring."

"I will not. I will go up without you."

"You'll go off the stair where the ice starts. The widow carries her own water again. In the spring somebody goes up to bring down what's left of you."

"The danger is mine."

"It's his. Whoever goes up in the spring."

"I can pay."

"With what?"

I had two taxi coins left in my jeans, and I offered him the bigger. He pinched it up off my palm and tipped it to the last of the day: brass, and the head of an old man with a beard.

"Who's that?"

"A poet. From farther away than you would believe."

"That buys nothing up there. Or down here." He returned the coin. Then he looked at my hands.

They had been soft at the spring a month before. Now every knuckle had split from the cold water, and a blister was healing on each palm where the jar handles rode. They were still not a working woman's hands, and he saw it, and he saw that I knew he had.

"Those never carried a jar till this month," he said.

"No."

"You talk a schoolmaster's Greek. You've got Latin." He meant the gray mule and my laughing. "You've got that coin. Who's coming after you?"

"No one is coming after me. In Delphi not one person knows my name. Kallia has not asked it."

"A husband."

"I have no husband."

"A father, then."

The clasp was stiff with the cold. It took me two tries to spring it, and then I had it off my wrist, and I passed it to him across the gray mule's withers, still warm on the inside of the band.

"This was my father's."

"You took it from him."

"He does not need it."

He was a long while over the back of it, and over the band where the three links had come out. Then he turned it face up. The thin seconds hand was going round. He watched it make one full circuit, and his face stayed as it was.

"Something's going in it," he said.

"It tells the hours." I had no word for it except an old one. "A *hōrologion*."

He looked from the watch to the sky over the lane, where the pink had gone off the snow, and back to the watch.

"Where's the shadow?"

"It does not need one. It needs no sun and no water. It goes in the dark."

"By itself."

"If it is wound. Every morning." I pointed. "Here."

He tried it. His thumb covered the crown entirely, and the rest of his hand closed round the case to keep it still, and with great care, slowly, he turned the crown the wrong way. It gave the

small loose click it gave when you went backward. He stopped to listen to the click. Then he turned it again, with the same care, the same way, as if the click were what it was for.

My father had wound it at the kitchen counter on the few mornings he was there, while the percolator went, talking all the while about something else.

I let him turn it twice more. Then I had my voice.

"Stop. The other way."

He stopped and let me at it, the watch lying flat in his palm, and I turned the crown forward for him, three turns, until I felt it tighten.

"That way. Until it will not go any more. Never past that."

He did it himself. Forward, the click was finer and closer together, and the crown pushed back against his thumb when the spring was full, and he felt it and stopped.

"How long does it go?"

"A day and a night. A little more."

"And if a man forgets?"

"It stops. You wind it, and it goes again."

He tried to put the band round his own wrist. It would not go halfway. He dropped the watch in the pouch at his belt and drew the string.

"Paid now," he said. "Not up there. Now."

"Yes."

"Before light, if the sky stays clear. If it snows in the night, we don't go. I take you to the cave and I bring you down. Nowhere else."

"And if I am not ready to come down?"

"You'll be ready when the pine's gone. Can you sit a mule?"

"I have never tried."

"You'll know tomorrow. The road over to Boeotia's under snow. All of it."

"I am not going over."

He was tying the last mule's lead into the tail of the one in front.

That night I did not sleep much. I lay under Kallia's blanket in the storeroom with the duffel beside me, packed, which was no trouble, since it had never been unpacked. Some time after midnight I got up and did the morning. I cleared the ashes by touch and swept the hearth, made the trip to the lions twice in the dark, and topped up the big jar so that nobody would be short when the house woke. I folded the blanket in four on the mat, hoisted the duffel, and took up the little shovel from the pail.

Kallia's voice reached me from the dark at the top of the outside stair.

"The shovel comes back."

I stood in the court with it. My Greek did not run to what I needed to say to her, so I thanked her for the blanket in English.

"Shut the gate behind you."

Valens was waiting at the turn of the lane with two mules, the gray and a dun, with nothing on their saddles but fodder sacks and a coil of rope and a bundle of pine splinters bound with withy. He took the duffel from me and weighed it on one hand.

"Everything," he said, and lashed it onto the dun. "Does Kallia know you're going?"

"She knows the shovel is going."

We went through the sleeping town and out past the high corner of the sanctuary wall, where the dogs knew him and kept quiet, and onto a path that went at the cliff in short zigzags, cut steps and worn rock and loose stone. It was too dark to see the drop. I heard it in the way the mules' breathing came back off the rock. At the first turn he put the gray's tail into my hand.

"Hold that. She'll pull."

I climbed the cliff above Delphi in the dark being towed by a mule, and the mule thought nothing of the arrangement, and by the third turn neither did I. My nose ran and I used my sleeve and it ran again.

I talked. I had not meant to. The drop was on my left from the first turn to the last, and the tail was coarse and warm in my fist, and he could not understand one word, so I went on, low.

"My name is Mara Reyes. I'm thirty-three. I make the cracks in old pots disappear, and I'm good at it, which nobody here is ever going to find out. I have a cousin who wore a pearl in one ear and a gold hoop in the other through a whole church service, and her husband thought she meant it. I've got an apartment with a radiator that knocks all night in February, and the rent is due on the first, and I'm behind by now, I suppose, unless they've given it to somebody else. That watch in your pouch was my father's, and he came home when he said he would maybe twice in my whole life, and I've wound it every morning since March, which hasn't helped him or me. I have no idea what happens if it's shut. I've lain awake on Kallia's floor every night for a month working it out, and the furthest I've got is the water. I'm getting better at the water. If that cave is open today I'll walk down to the hotel on the main street in Delphi and stand under a hot shower until it runs cold, and then the first bus out and the first plane to anywhere, and call Gloria collect from Kennedy and let her yell at me, and then the train home to Philadelphia, and my own kitchen, and never—"

"Philadelphia," Valens said.

I stopped talking. The gray stopped too and stood with her haunches against my knees.

"There's a Philadelphia in Asia," he said. "Past Sardis. A man I knew came from there."

"Farther," I said.

"Past Asia there's only Parthians."

"Past them."

He clicked his tongue at the gray, and we went on up.

Two turns up, the ice began. He halted, got sacking out of a fodder bag and bound each of the mules' hooves in it, crouched in the path with the hoof between his knees, pulling the twine tight with his teeth.

"Step where she steps," Valens said. "Not where I step."

"Why not where you step?"

"She looks where she puts her feet."

Daylight arrived while we were on the last of the cliff, gray along the valley, and showed me the whole fall of the mountain below us, terraces and roofs and the sanctuary laid out down its slope like a model under glass, with the temple in the middle of it, very small. From up there the paint did not show. For the space of a breath it was nearly the gray one on the postcards; then the sun cleared the ridge and found the gilt on the roof.

"They paint it again when the snow's gone." Valens had stopped to let the mules blow. "The priests hang a man off the roof on a rope, with a pot of red."

"Who paints it?"

"The same man every year. He came off the corner at the last painting and broke his arm. They had him back up there in a month with the arm tied to his side."

"Is he any good?"

"He's cheap."

On a bend near the top he stopped. Far below us a man with a donkey was coming up the zigzags with a load on its back.

"He's been on the path since the town," Valens said.

"He has a donkey."

Valens watched him through two turns of the path, and then three. The mules shifted. I stood holding her tail with my fingers

going dead, and the man below came up to a fork and turned off toward a thread of smoke on the slope, where somebody had a kiln going, and Valens went on up without a word about it.

"Who did you think it was?" I said.

"Somebody for you."

"I told you. There is no one."

"You told me."

Where the cliffs ended there was the plain, under snow, a hand deep where the wind had left it alone and up to the knee where it had drifted along the walls. The huts I had seen from above that first evening stood about in it with their brush roofs weighed down and not one of them smoking. The crust took my weight for a step and then let me through.

"Get up," he said, and put me on the gray, and walked at her head, reading the ground under the snow by the lie of the walls and the tops of the thornbushes. "Sit back. Hold the saddle, not her mouth. Let her find it."

I sat back. The gray found it.

"What's her name?"

"She hasn't got one."

"What do you call her?"

"The gray."

"And the one who ate Kallia's tree?"

"The brown." He kicked the snow off a stone with the side of his boot. "A name's for calling. They come when they see the barley bag."

"Why do you talk to them in Latin?"

"They came from Corinth. They don't know any Greek."

"Mules do not know any—"

"Ditch." He had the gray's head down before I saw it, a line of softer snow across our way, and she gathered herself and hopped it and landed me on her neck.

"These know Latin," he said, when I was back in the saddle.

"And you? Where are you from?"

"North."

"What's in it that goes?" he said.

It took me a little while to understand he was asking about the watch. Then I tried to tell him, in a Greek that had no words for any of it.

"Inside there is a strip of metal. Very thin. Rolled up on itself, round and round. When you turn the crown it rolls tighter."

"And when it's tight?"

"It wants to open again, the way a brooch pin wants to spring. There is a little wheel that goes back and forth, so, and lets it open by one tooth, and then the next, and no faster. Those teeth turn the hands."

I did the wheel for him with my hand flat on the gray's neck, rocking it.

"Who makes them?"

"Men in a country you have never heard of. Thousands of them."

"For hire?"

"For sale. Anyone can buy one."

"Anyone." He tried the crust ahead with his heel before he trusted it. "And the little wheel. What stops it rocking?"

"The spring running down. Dirt. Cold. Being dropped."

"I won't drop it."

By the pen under the firs I knew where I was. Its stones still stood upright on their edges, each propped on the next all round, with snow lying along the slant of every one. Somebody had tied the hurdle shut with a fresh withy since October.

"Snow by afternoon." Valens was looking at the sky over the summits, where a long bank of cloud was standing up behind the ridge.

The cave had not moved. Its arch was half full of snow, blown in under the lip and shaped there into a long smooth wave that ran back into the dark. In the dressed rock by the arch the letters were still red at the bottom of their strokes, and snow had settled in the strokes, white in red. The ledge below held only snow.

"What does it say?" he said.

"To the Nymphs. To Pan."

"That's what the goat boys say it says."

He tied the mules in the lee of the rock, broke a corner off a crust from his bag, and left it on the ledge.

"It's his house," he said.

"Pan's? You believe in him?"

"I pay him."

"That is not an answer."

"It's what I do." He was already in the mouth with his back to the wind. "How long will you be in there?"

"Until it opens."

"Until what opens?"

I left that where it was.

He made fire with a steel and a flint and a lump of dried bracket fungus, striking until a spark caught and he could blow it red. It was slow work.

"Can you not go faster?"

"No."

When the first pine caught he stood up and came in behind me, and I took the slope of the floor and crossed the hall without waiting for him, by the great pale lump of stone with its shoulder shining, and climbed the flowstone, and the torchlight followed.

The slab was there. The crack was there. I stood the bag by the slab and worked my hand in between the two faces of rock and kept it there, palm to the black.

Rock. Air. Cold that was only cold.

I went down on my knees in the bottom of the crack, and began to dig.

"What's in there?" he said.

"Nothing yet."

* * *

The last pine but one was burning when I gave up digging. Nothing was left at the bend to dig; I had it down to rock on every side. I pushed my fingers into the gap, flat, as deep as they would reach.

"Please," I said to the rock, in English. "I did the water this morning. I've done the floors every day for a month, and everything anybody asked me. Please."

The rock was cold. Behind me the torch flame stood straight up.

"The hour," I said.

He showed me. Five to two.

I looked at it until his fingers closed over it. My fingers came free of the gap and I straightened as far as the roof let me. My knees had stopped feeling the rock some time before, and when I rose they gave a little and then held. I set my hand on the slab. Cold. I hit it. I hit it with the side of my fist and then with the heel of my hand, and the skin came off the heel, and I hit it again.

The noise I made had no word in it.

It went down the hall and struck the far wall and came back, and the cave went on giving it back after I had stopped, smaller and farther, from places I could not see.

After it, the drip, and the torch hissing.

Valens laughed.

It was short and surprised, and ran on briefly after, a laugh with nobody at the end of it.

"Good," he said.

He dug into the front of his tunic and came up with a round of flat bread, broke it in two across his knee, and gave me half.

It was warm. He had carried it the whole climb inside his clothes, against his skin, and it was exactly the temperature of a person.

I ate it. It was barley, mostly, coarse, and whoever made it had salted it with conviction, and the crust had a scorch across one side where it had sat too near somebody's coals. I ate it bent under the low roof of the crack with my bleeding hand held away from it, and he ate his half watching the torch.

"Why did you laugh?" I said.

He finished what was in his mouth first.

"All day you were careful with it," he said. "With the mountain. With the hole. You put your hand in slow and kept it still. Then you hit it."

"And that was funny."

"It was the first thing you did up here I understood."

"And before? What did you think I was doing with the shovel?"

"Digging up something you'd hidden."

"Hidden what?"

"Silver. Whatever you ran with. People who run bury it, and come back for it later."

"Had I any silver, you would have had silver."

"You'd have kept the silver," he said, "and paid me in the watch."

"I am not a thief."

"I didn't say thief." He brushed the crumbs off his knee into his palm and ate them. "I was at the turn of the lane before you came out to me. I heard you at the spring, twice, in the dark. A thief doesn't fill the widow's jar before she goes."

I had no answer to that. When the bread was gone I could have eaten the same again, which after a month of Kallia's lentils was nothing new.

"Eat the crumbs," he said. "You'll want them on the stair."

He lit the last pine from the stub of the old one and held it while I got into the duffel's strap. I left the shovel lying in the crack. He went back for it.

At the mouth the snow had come. It was falling through the arch in the gray light, big wet flakes, so thick that everything below the lip was gone, and the tracks we had made coming up were already going soft at the edges. The mules stood in the lee of the rock with snow on their backs. The crust on the ledge wore a cap of it.

The gray took me down into the white with Valens at her head.

Below the mouth there was only snow and wind and the gray's ears ahead of me, the flakes settling between them. The light went off the snow so slowly that I could not have said when it was gone.

"What were you digging for?" he said, somewhere on the slope.

"Cold. I was looking for cold. A wind, out of the rock."

The gray went a dozen steps before he answered. "It's cold all over this mountain."

"I know that."

"Wind all over it."

"I know."

The gray dropped her head, blew, and shook the snow off her ears all over me.

"Who were you meeting up there?" he said.

"No one. It was not a who."

We came in among the firs, where the wind couldn't reach, and the snow fell straight down between the trunks, very quiet.

"Where do you sleep?" he said.

"Under Kallia's stairs. With her jars."

"Dry?"

"Dry."

"Does she hit you?"

"No."

"She feeds you."

"Lentils."

"Stay where you are. She'll keep you while you work."

"Why did you bring me up," I said, "if you believed I was followed?"

"The watch."

"Only that?"

"It's a good watch."

"Sell it back to me. When I have found silver. Real silver."

"You paid it to go up. You went up."

"It was my father's."

"You said he didn't need it."

I had said that. The gray picked her way down between the trunks with me on her back, and I held on to the front of the packsaddle with both hands.

"Then wind it." It was the wrong language. I had to fetch the Greek, and my voice would not stay level for it. "Wind it. When you wake."

"Forward. Till it stops, and not past."

Past the pen we crossed the plain, and I did not see the huts. At the top of the cliff path there was a red glow off to the left, low in the snow, and a smell of smoke that was sour where woodsmoke would have been sweet. The man with the donkey had his kiln there, a long hump of earth and turf with smoke

seeping from every seam, and he sat beside it on an upturned basket with a sack across his head and shoulders. The donkey stood in its lee with its eyes shut.

"Mule-man!" he called. "Come and warm yourselves. She won't mind."

Valens would have gone by. But the gray had already turned for the warmth, and I was on the gray.

"Nine days she's been at it," the man said, "and now this." A flake hissed where it landed on the turf. He got up and stamped a seam shut where a tongue of flame had shown in it. "Easy, girl. Hold it in." He raked a few chestnuts out of the edge of the embers with a stick and pushed them across the snow to me with his foot. "Eat. They're split already."

They burned my fingers, and I ate them anyway. He talked fast, in the mountain Greek, and I lost words out of everything he said, and none of Valens's answers.

"Did you get any of the god's ox?" The rest ran on past me. I caught the number four in it, and the council, and a grievance about meat.

"I was at Kirrha."

"So you ate what we ate. Smoke." He peered up at me in the glow. "That's her. The nymph. My cousin's boy saw her step out of Pan's cave at the olive beating."

"She's the widow Kallia's," Valens said. He had gone to the other mule's forefeet to strip off the wet sacking and bind on fresh. "Down by the spring."

"Since when has Kallia got anybody?"

"Since the olives."

"In trousers?"

"She came off a ship."

The next part he said slowly, and to me. "The boy says you ate his cheese and paid him in a cake made of hay."

"It was oats," I said.

"It's all hay to a boy." He saw my hand then. "And what's she done to that?"

"She hit Pan," said Valens.

The sack across the man's shoulders shook, and the donkey opened its eyes and shut them again.

"Sleep here by her," he said. "You'll not get down in the dark."

"The widow wants her shovel," Valens said, and stood, and gave me the mule's tail again.

Below us the whole valley had sunk into gray, with a few lamps showing far down in it where the town was. Going down was worse than coming up. The mule sat back on her haunches and let herself down from step to step, and twice my boots went out from under me on the ice and her tail held me up. Valens went in front with the second mule, sideways to the slope, talking to both of them in Latin, low, about nothing I could hear.

"He'll have you all over the town by the next market," he said, when the glow of the kiln was out of sight. He kept his back to me. "So here's what I make of you. You came down off the top in the autumn, by yourself, in trousers, so the road wouldn't take you for a woman. Your hands never worked. You read the letters on the rock without spelling them out. You've got Latin. You had a thing on your wrist no smith in Achaea could make, and you won't give a name, yours or your people's. That's a big house. Corinth, or Patrae. Somebody there wants you back, a father or a husband, and whoever he is, he's got the money to look. And there's one man in Delphi who'd take a mule up Parnassus in the snow."

It was the most he had said all day. Most of it was true, and the whole of it was wrong.

"It is a good story," I said. "It is a better story than mine. If I told you where I came from—"

“Don’t.”

“You would think me mad.”

“Keep to the wall,” he said. “The edge has gone along this bit.”

“You have not asked my name either.”

“No.”

“Where did you learn Latin, then?”

“On the road.”

“Latin is not learned on this road.”

The sanctuary dogs let us by. The lamps of the town were close now, yellow in the doorways, with smoke lying low over the roofs and the smell of somebody’s supper in it. At the first houses he stopped the mules in the shadow of a wall and went round the dun, unlashing my bag.

He gave me the duffel. Then he gave me the shovel.

“Men will come asking,” he said. “You went up by yourself. You never had a watch.”

Chapter 7

The Laws of Belonging

A woman in Phocis in the second year of Vespasian belonged to somebody, and the first thing the town did with a stranger was work out who. Nobody asked it unkindly, or not often; it was asked the way a clerk at a counter wanted a zip code, because the form had a box for it. The women at the spring looked past me to see who had sent me down for the water. Men who met me alone in a lane slowed their step, to learn whether anybody was coming along behind me, and went on at their own pace only when Kallia turned the corner with the bread. A woman with nobody behind her was a piece of luck lying in the road for whoever bent down first.

I gave Kallia her shovel back at first light on the morning after the mountain, and because there was no help for it now, I gave it back in Greek.

"Your shovel. I have turned the edge on it."

She took the handle in her fist and sighted down the blade to the spot where the god's rock had rolled the iron over in a small lip, and after that her eyes came round to me, which she did not often trouble to do.

"On what?"

"On the god's rock. At the cave."

"Let the god put an edge back on it." She stood it upright in the ash pail where it lived, and pointed at the pail.

That was all she said about the mountain that morning. Two days after it she came to the storeroom door with a bundle over her arm and stood in the doorway, saying nothing, until I understood that I was to take off what I had on.

"All of it goes in the bag," she said. "The shirt with the buttons as well."

The jeans went in first, folded, with the fleece over them and the shirt over the fleece. Under all three lay the flashlight, where it had lain since October, unseen by a soul in that house. Out of the bundle came a tunic of undyed wool so long I could stand on the hem, a plaited cord to take it up at the waist, and a himation of wet-sand brown, which Kallia shook out by two corners with a crack like a sail filling and dropped over my shoulders from behind.

It was heavy and not new, and it smelled of somebody. Under the woodsmoke that was in everything Kallia owned there was lanolin, and under the lanolin there was a girl: sweat gone stale in the fold that had lain against an armpit, and some hair oil with a sweetness in it, quince or something with ambitions to be quince, soaked into the edge that went up over the head. A long hair, darker than mine and crimped from a braid, had caught in the fringe. The cloth was good, woven on an upright loom with the starting border still tight across its upper edge, and one corner had been darned in a browner wool by somebody in a hurry, with long slack passes that pulled the weave into a pucker. At the elbows it had bagged into the shape of another woman's arms.

"That was the girl's," said Kallia. "She took herself off when the grapes came in, in what she stood up in."

"Will she want it back?"

"Not to carry water in. The hem hides the boots if you walk right. You don't walk right."

She gave her lessons in the court between the hearth and the gate, in the slack hour after the lodgers had had their bread, while the Thebans hung on the balustrade upstairs to watch and offered their advice, which she ignored as she ignored them in everything except their money.

"Shorter."

The toes of the boots still showed at each step, two scuffed brown noses poking out from under the wool and drawing back in.

"Shorter. From the knee. You're not going up a mountain."

"I have been up a mountain."

"So the town says." She went the length of the court ahead of me with an empty jar balanced on her head and her eyes on the paving a few steps ahead of her feet, and the wool round her ankles hardly stirred. "Your eyes go there. On the ground in front of you. Not on the street, and not on the men in it."

"How am I to see where I am going?"

"You see their feet."

"And if one of them speaks to me?"

"You've no ears. I answer." She lifted the jar off her head and handed it to me. "Now you."

A jar on my head was still beyond me. A full one I could carry the length of the lane on one hip; an empty one stayed up for a few steps if the court stayed quiet, and then it slid and I caught it in both arms, while up on the gallery a Theban with a voice like a bassoon called down, "Put a cushion under it, and another girl under the cushion!"

Sitting was worse, because sitting was the one thing Kallia never did in my sight. She hooked the low stool out from the hearth with her foot and lowered herself onto it, knees together,

the himation drawn down over them, one hand laid on the other in her lap and her gaze on the embers; for one breath Kallia sat in her own court like a woman carved on a grave. She was up again before the stool had stopped rocking.

"Like that. Not like a carter in a wine-shop."

"I sit like a carter?"

"You sit like you paid for the bench."

The eyes were the hard part and the part that mattered, and she taught them in passing, between one job and the next. A man brought cheese down out of the valley villages, and I watched his face while he named his price to her, the way I would have watched anybody's, and when he had gone Kallia came and stood square before me with a pot in her hands.

"You looked at him."

"He was talking."

"He was talking to me. Look at a man out there and you've asked him something. And somebody answers."

"And in here?"

"In here you look at the pots."

Some lessons the town taught for her. In my first week, still in trousers, I had gone looking for the public latrine and found it beside the market: a long room with a marble bench round three walls, holes cut along it at a sociable distance over a channel of running water, and a sponge on a stick standing in a bucket at the entrance. Four men were sitting in it at their ease, deep in the price of oil. "Thirty-two the jar at Kirrha, and he has the face to tell me that's because of the Jews' war, and I said to him, what have the Jews got to do with my—" The price of oil stopped. I was back in Kallia's lane with my whole face burning, and that night she showed me, without comment, a lidded pot kept beside the jars, and in the morning the dung heap at the lane's end where it went. Delphi's women, so far as I could tell, had no bodily needs

at all outside their own walls, and the men had a marble room to discuss it in.

The one door in that house I was not let near was at the end of the gallery, past the lodgers' rooms, where they never went. Every morning, before she did her own threshold or the court, Kallia swept that one, the boards outside a shut door, and when it was swept she left the broom lying across the doorway and did the rest of the house with the other one. Once, in my second week, I borrowed it off those boards to do the gallery. She came up, and with no word to me it was back across the same boards at the same slant, and she was on the stair again.

The bath stood below the sanctuary near the running track, and the women had it from first light until the sun was over the cliffs; after that the men came down from their exercise and it was theirs. Kallia took me on a morning when the frost was still on the paving. She paid the bath-keeper's wife at the door, who took the coin and eyed me over it, and in the changing room she showed me a niche in the wall for my clothes and a pair of wooden clogs, because the floor of the hot room would take the skin off a bare sole.

It was full of women and steam and talk, and I had not been looked at so thoroughly since the day I came into the world. They looked me over for weight and for flaws, and they made no secret of it.

"Look at her legs."

"She's let herself go like a widow."

That was a baker's wife with a soft heavy body and a red clay lamp in her fist. "I've been in here since before light," she told the room, "and I'll be in here till the men come and throw me out, because his mother has moved in on us for the winter, and that house was never built for two women who both know best." She

came at me through the steam with the lamp held up. “Stand still, I’ll singe them for you. It doesn’t hurt if you don’t jump.”

I jumped.

“Singe your own,” said Kallia, who was washing standing up. “They keep them like that where she’s from.”

“And where’s that, where they’ve no lamps?”

“Over the sea.”

“Everything’s over the sea with you,” said the baker’s wife. “Last winter you told us your Thebans came by ship, and they walked here from four days up the road.”

They found the pale band on my wrist next, the white stripe where the watch had lived under its steel band since March, and a girl with a mole on her chin took my hand and turned it toward the window to look. “What’s this white, then? Has she had a fetter on?” It was the baker’s wife who found the scar, high on my left arm, a round pitted mark, puckered in the middle, and she put her thumb on it.

“Somebody’s marked her.”

“Is she bought?” said the girl with the mole. “Is that where they put it, over there?”

“Pox,” Kallia said. “When she was small.”

“Pox doesn’t take one place.”

“It took one on her.” She poured a dipper of water over her own head and shook it off. “Your bread’s burning, or your husband’s mother is eating it.”

The woman with the lamp gave me my arm back. Kallia had been nearer the truth than she could have known. It had been a pox, a cow’s pox, scratched into my arm on purpose by a nurse at a pediatric clinic in West Philadelphia when I was too small to object, and it had kept the other pox off me all my life.

On a shelf by the door of the warm room stood a dish of gray powder, and as the women left the heat they wet a finger, dipped

it, scrubbed at their teeth, rinsed, and spat in the drain. The girl with the mole offered me the dish.

"What is it?"

"Horn. Burnt and ground. Goat's is best."

It smelled of a farrier's yard, of singed hoof. I looked at the grit in it, which showed without my bending close; I had seen burnished slip scoured to a dull fog by less, and the girl stood there smiling at me with every tooth in her head, and all of them sound. I said no, and when she held it out again I said it a second time. That afternoon I clambered down the hillside under the spring, where the lentisk grew in dark clumps among the rocks, and cut a straight twig the length of my hand. I chewed the end of it at the trough until the fibers came apart into a stiff little brush, which tasted of pine resin and of the gin and tonic a friend's husband had once made me in an apartment on Rittenhouse Square. The toothbrush, purple, with a rubber grip, joined the jeans in the duffel.

* * *

The Greek I had brought with me was correct, and in Delphi that winter correct was an accent like any other, and a funnier one than most. I had been taught it as every American student was, in the vowels a Dutch scholar in the fifteen-hundreds had decided it ought to have, and the Greek of Delphi had not waited for him. Where I said the ai of aisle, the town said something near the e in egg. My eta, long and careful, was halfway to an i, and up in the mountain villages it had got there.

Indoors, since the morning of the shovel, I had been talking, and Kallia let me, the way she let the Thebans sing, and she corrected me the way she did everything else, by doing it. If I asked for the lentils and gave them their name from the book,

every letter in its place, she said the word back to me as a different word with the same lentils in it.

"Why do you say it so?"

"Because it's what they're called." She was raking the embers. "Go and buy salt. The jar's nearly at the bottom, and the Thebans salt everything twice."

I went to the market with an obol in my fist, Kallia's basket on my arm and my gaze on the ground in front of me, past the colonnade and the stalls of clay women and white wool, to the salt-seller: a broad woman on an upturned measure behind a heap of gray salt with a wooden scoop in it. I asked her for an obol's worth in the Attic of the books, careful with every syllable, and I added please.

She cupped a hand behind her ear and leaned across the salt toward me.

"Say it again."

I said it again.

She threw up both arms, scoop and all, so that the salt went in a shower over her lap.

"Antigone!" she shouted down the row. "She's come down off the stage for a scoop of salt!"

The woman at the next stall, who sold sprats out of a basket of wet leaves, never so much as raised her head from her fish. "Tell her to bury her brother first, the salt will keep."

The whole row laughed. I nearly laughed too, because it was a far better joke than any I had ever made in Greek, and it was aimed with real skill at a tragedy I had read through twice in the original; then I saw a man at the fountain laughing along with them, his eyes on me and not on the women, and the laugh went back where it came from. The salt-seller filled Kallia's basket with more salt than an obol would buy and pushed the coin back at

me, still wiping her eyes. “Come again tomorrow and ask for pepper. My sister’s never seen a play.”

I carried the salt home through the town, and for a month after that, outside Kallia’s gate, I said nothing to anyone if I could help it.

It was easy, the easiest thing I had done since the cave. At the spring I filled my jar, and when a woman spoke to me about the cold I looked at her feet until she gave up. The baker’s hatch took Kallia’s tally stick and handed back loaves without my opening my mouth. In the lane I gave way to men without looking up, and the lane gave way back. A silent woman with her eyes on the ground and a jar on her hip was the most ordinary thing in Delphi, so ordinary the eye slid off her, and the town, which had been so curious, lost interest in me in about a week.

“At the spring they say you’re simple,” Kallia said, one night over the wool.

“Do you mind?”

“Let them. Simple girls don’t get asked anything. Tighter than that; you’re making a bird’s nest.”

The lodgers had gone up, and the hearth had burned low, and Kallia carded beyond it on her feet, with the basket of fleece propped on her hip.

“Where you come from,” she said, “who carries the water?”

It was the first question she had ever asked me about the place, and it was about water.

“No one carries it. It comes into the house through a pipe in the wall, and you turn a handle and it runs, cold, or hot if you turn the other handle.”

“Hot.”

“Hot enough to scald you, at any hour of the night.”

“And the wool?”

"Bought. Spun and woven already, and made up into clothes, in a shop as long as this lane."

"What do the women do all day?"

"They go out to work, the same as the men. My work is pots older than this house, that somebody has dug up."

"Who pays for a pot that's broken?"

"A city does. The whole city pays me, and I sit in a room under the ground with a lamp and make them whole again for it."

She stopped carding and looked at me across the embers, with the two combs held apart and a skein of fleece hanging between them.

"There's no such country," she said.

"There is."

"Then why aren't you in it?"

Hers was a question I could not answer by doing something.

"Do you not want to know where it is?" I said.

"I want that basket done before the lamp goes."

I bent over the wool. Some while after, I asked her who slept in the shut room upstairs, and she said, "It's swept," and then, "Tighter, I said."

Halfway through my silence Valens brought his mules to the gate for the fifth coin. I was going out for water, and I knew it was him by the mules before I knew it any other way. What I saw of him was his boots: rawhide, laced to the shin, one lace broken and knotted where it had broken, the knot standing up like a little fist.

"It burned," he told Kallia.

"It spat."

"Oak doesn't spit."

"Twice. Once on my good hearthstone and once in the lentils. When it's done a month without spitting, you'll have your coin. And keep the gray's teeth off my tree while you wait."

The boots turned a little, toward the gateway where I stood.

"She's taught you to walk," he said.

I kept my eyes on the knot in the broken lace.

"You've stopped talking."

"She's simple," Kallia said.

"No," said Valens, and the boots took themselves off down the lane with the mules after them.

I watched the heels go as far as the turn. My father's watch was in his belt pouch. The hour had been lost to me since November; I had morning, noon by the shadow of Kallia's gatepost, and the day's end by the lamps. I stood there wondering whether he wound it before he saw to the mules or after, and whether he remembered which way.

Four days after that I broke Kallia's second-best jar at the spring. It was the end of the afternoon, when the women had mostly gone up with their water and the drovers brought their animals down to the trough at the bottom of the basin, and I had my jar under the third lion with my eyes on its mouth and the water drumming in it. A string of donkeys came in along the basin behind me, and their driver came with them, and he stopped at my elbow instead of at the trough.

"Here's the one that doesn't talk."

There was green weed growing on the lion's lower lip, combed all one way by the water.

"Kallia's simple one. Is she simple all over, or only in the mouth?" He had a voice from somewhere west, Amphissa or beyond it, and he smelled of donkey and of the morning's wine. "Look at me."

I looked at the jar. The water came up into its neck.

His hand came down on the handle beside mine. Then he took my wrist instead, the one with the pale band round it, and

turned it over, the way the girl at the bath had turned it, only not for looking.

I let go of the jar.

It hit the stone rim of the basin and broke in three. The water went over both our feet. His donkeys threw up their heads at the noise, and he dropped my wrist to swear at them. I stepped back. I stepped back again, out onto the road, and stood there in the girl's wet hem with my hands at my sides.

"Leave Antigone alone."

It was the salt-seller, descending the steps with her own jar up on her head and one hand raised to steady it.

"She's nothing to you," the drover said. "She's nothing to anybody. Ask round this spring."

"She's Kallia's."

"Kallia's what?"

"Kallia's, and Kallia has a tongue on her and the council's ear, and you've got four donkeys drinking the god's water at the wrong end of his basin. Take them down to the trough where they belong, before somebody fetches a priest to them."

He went. The salt-seller drew her water at the next lion and never glanced my way again, and I picked the three pieces of Kallia's jar out of the wet and carried them home in a fold of the himation. It had broken cleanly, along the coils it was built from, and every edge was sharp and unworn; I could have had it whole again in a week with a pot of hide glue and some string, if Delphi had any use for a jar that had been broken once.

Kallia was at the hearth. When I laid the pieces on the hearthstone she looked past them, at my wrist.

"Who?"

"A man with donkeys. From the west somewhere."

"Did he touch you?"

"Only my wrist."

“That jar came up from Kirrha on my own head, eleven summers ago, and I’ve not had to buy one since. Go back down and fetch the water in the old one. It leaks.” She swept the pieces off the hearthstone into the ash pail with her toe.

* * *

In Delphi a person was whatever the council’s clerk had scratched into wax, and that winter the clerk was scratching in everybody. The talk at the spring was that the new emperor meant to take back the freedom Nero had given Greece, and freedom, it turned out, had meant chiefly that Greece paid no tribute; nobody at the spring knew when, but the council wanted every house in the city on tablets before Rome put a governor back in Corinth to ask for it. Each household was to be entered, and everyone in it, and what manner of person each was.

Kallia told me what I was that same night, from the storeroom doorway, with no lamp.

“Tomorrow, the council. You’re my husband’s brother’s girl.”

“Am I?”

“From Syracuse.”

I sat up on the mat.

“West, by water. Past Corinth, past everywhere,” she said, as though I might not know where it was. “Your people died, and you came on one of the last boats before the sea shut, after the vintage.”

“What was he called? Your husband’s brother.”

“They talk strange over there; nobody here has heard enough of it to say how strange. If he asks you anything, you’ve a cold.”

“Who told you I came on a boat?”

“The whole spring knows you came on a boat. Bank the hearth before you lie down. It went out on me twice this week.”

I had heard the boat invented. Valens had made it up at the kiln for a charcoal burner; it had come down off Parnassus with the charcoal, gone the rounds of the spring, and reached Kallia's mouth with a city tied onto it, and now it was mine. I knew Syracuse, as it happened, from his slides: a quarry deep enough to stand a church in, a fountain full of papyrus and ducks, and his voice in our dark kitchen telling me the gelato there tasted of nothing but cold.

The council met in a long hall beside the square, with benches round the walls and a brazier going in the middle, and householders stood in a line from the door to a table at the room's end: men in their good cloaks with their sons behind them, here and there a widow with her people, all waiting in the smoke. Just ahead of us stood a man with three sons and a quarrel over a boundary wall, which he rehearsed to the sons the length of the room. Behind the table sat the thin man I had last seen in a doorway correcting the herald on the emperor's titles. He had a hot brick wrapped in a rag under his feet and a stack of wax books at his elbow, and a boy beside him with no other work than to take the brick to the brazier when it cooled and bring it back.

"Sosandros," Kallia said, at the head of the line.

"Kallia. The lodging over the spring." He kept his head down. "Boy, the brick. Who's in it?"

"Me. Four Thebans till the thaw, and they're no concern of yours, they're on the Boeotian list. And her."

That brought his head up.

"Bought, born in the house, or free?"

"Free."

"Kin?"

"My husband's brother's girl. From Syracuse."

"Syrakousai," he said, correcting her, and opened a fresh page of the book.

The wax had gone hard in the cold; he held the leaf over the brazier until the black surface took on a shine, then set it flat and drew the stylus, and each letter surfaced pale in the dark wax where the bare wood showed through. I had read upside down across a good many desks in my life, and I read this one.

"Resident since when? On what business?"

"Her people died. She came on one of the last boats, after the vintage."

"Name," he said, to me.

"Some of us have a wall coming down, Sosandros," said the father behind us.

"Your wall has been coming down through three councils. It will stay up for one widow."

Kallia opened her mouth beside me and shut it again; I caught it at the edge of my sight, with my gaze on the table's rim. She had taken me in at a spring in the dark, fed me lentils for two months, put a runaway's clothes on me and taught me how to sit, without once asking what I was called; now she stood before the council's clerk with a line of householders at her back and not a thing to give him. The stylus waited over the wax, and the boy came back from the brazier with the brick.

"Mara," I said.

It was the first word I had said outside her gate in nineteen days, and the vowel in it was as flat as Philadelphia.

"Sicilian," Sosandros said, content with himself, as he might have been at a coin he had placed by its mint. "They all talk like that over there. I heard a Syracusan at the Pythian games once, and half the stand had to help him get a cup of water."

He wrote it. He wrote an alpha after the mu and then an iota after the alpha, without a pause and without a question, as easily

as a man spelling a name he had known all his life: MAIRA. It was an old name, as old as Homer, who had a Maira among the Nereids who rose from the water to mourn with Achilles' mother, and somewhere else a second Maira, a dog, who found her master's body under a tree and was put into the sky for it. The clerk had made me a Nereid or a star with four legs, and had not asked which.

"Daughter of?"

"Aimilios." The Greek of it was out before I had decided anything about it. That was how his name had been printed on the offprints from Nicosia, Aimilios Reyes, and he had pinned one to the corkboard by the telephone for a joke and left it there for years.

"A Roman."

"Half Syracuse is Roman," Kallia said.

Sosandros wrote that down as well, without comment. "And who answers for her? A free woman wants someone to answer for her."

"I do."

"A woman can't answer for—"

"Who stands for my house, if I don't? You've had no other name on that line for years. Write me."

There was a splinter of lentisk between my back teeth on the left, a long stiff fiber off that morning's stick, wedged between the molar with the old filling and its neighbor, and my tongue had found it, gone to it, and would not leave it alone. It was the size of nothing, and it took up my entire mouth. I worked at it while Sosandros and Kallia settled what I was; when the room came back to me he was writing, the father behind us was back on his wall, and she was undoing her kerchief knot for the fee.

I read the line as the stylus finished it.

Maira, daughter of Aimilios, of Syrakousai; free; kinswoman of Kallia, of her house and in her keeping.

"Two obols," he said, "and don't tell me the god pays for wax." He shut the book on me, added it to the stack, and said, "Next," and the boundary wall came forward with its three sons.

I managed the doorway and the step outside. The step was stone, worn into a dip in the middle by everybody who had ever left that room, and its cold came straight through the himation; I took it for a seat, with the square going by, pulled the borrowed wool up to my eyes, and laughed into it without a sound, with my shoulders. The wool against my mouth smelled of quince and woodsmoke and of a girl who was somewhere else. For ten years I had sat at a bench keeping things from being wiped smooth, and I had just been written into wax that the council would warm and scrape and write over for next year's list, the least lasting surface in Delphi; it was the only thing in that whole country that had ever said I was in it.

Kallia stood over me with the basket and waited. She did not tell me to get up. When I stood she started home, and I followed her, two steps behind and one to the side, watching the backs of her shoes.

In the court she asked it with the basket still on her arm.

"What did he put?"

"That I am free," I said. "That I am your husband's kin, from Syracuse, and of your house, and that you keep me. And my father's name, and mine."

She listened to it with her hands still.

"Say your name for me."

"Maira," I said.

She said it after me the Delphian way, with the middle of it gone soft, so that it sounded nearer Mera, light at both ends. She looked at the store jar, which was low. "Maira. The water."

* * *

What it cost to be somebody's was mostly small, and it went a little at a time, like the oil in a lamp. Before the month was out I turned my head for Mera at the water. My eyes went to the ground in the lane and kept there, and I knew the men of Delphi by their feet. I chewed my lentisk at the trough every morning in front of the Thebans. "Kallia, is she a goat, that she eats the hedge?" one of them asked, and Kallia answered that the hedge was better company than he was. Supper was lentils and I ate it and it was all right.

English went with the rest, and one night near the end of the month I learned how much of it was already gone, lying on the mat in the storeroom with the lamp out and one of the Thebans snoring somewhere along the gallery. I said my address aloud, the way I had given it across a hundred counters, at the dry cleaner's and the circulation desk: the number, the street, the apartment, Philadelphia, P-A. After the two letters came nothing. Five figures had followed them every time I had said them in my life, and I listened for them under the hanging oregano. A one came, and then a nine, and after the nine only guesses. I had to go back for the zip code, the long way. Under my breath, for the Thebans' sake, I started again at the street door and took myself through the vestibule, past the mailboxes, where mine had my name inked on a bit of tape, and up the stairs, saying the whole of it over from the house number, and somewhere on the second landing the figures turned up again in their right order. Twice more I said it through to be sure of it, and from the next night I kept even my own company in Greek. The girl's himation, which I slept under as well as wore, had stopped smelling of quince. It smelled of smoke and lanolin and, under them, of a woman I had to think about before I knew her.

Mrs. Dunphy cried at her desk for a whole afternoon when I was in fourth grade, in a green cardigan short of its second button. She was a substitute, and she had been teaching us long division until just past lunch, and then she stopped in the middle of a remainder and sat down and put her hands flat on the blotter and cried without any noise at all, with her face uncovered, looking at the back wall. None of us went for the principal. We did the problems on the board, all of them, and then we did them again, and the room was full of the sound of thirty pencils, and at three o'clock the bell went and she wiped her face with the backs of her fingers and said we could go.

On the last morning of the month, with the frost white on the court, I came back with the morning's water and found Kallia up on the gallery with the broom, doing the boards in front of the shut door. She swept them out to the edge and over, and the dust fell past my head in a little gray shower. Then the broom went across the doorway at its slant.

"At midwinter the women climb Parnassus," she said, at the bottom.

I carried the jar to the hearth under the lean-to.

"Which women?"

"The god's women. Dionysos's. Every woman in this town who's any good, and a few who aren't. They go every other winter, and this is the winter. You'll come. You've the boots for it."

"How high?"

"Onto the plain. In the snow, at night, with torches, and a skin of wine for every three of you, and no man past the last house." She was at the woodstack, pulling out splits for the morning. "Bind your feet in rags over the boots, and bring the girl's himation. It's the warmest thing in this house."

"And what is it for?"

"Dance. Drink. Freeze. Not as high as your cave."

I tipped the water into the store jar and watched it climb to the shoulder. Over Kallia's roof the cliffs were white to their rim, and past the rim, out of sight from the court, lay the plain under its snow, then the firs, and above the firs the dark arch and its painted letters. In November the gray mule had needed the better part of a morning to carry me from the cliff top to the cave. How far was it, at night, on foot, from wherever the women danced to the cave?

Chapter 8

The Thyiades

"And once we're above the last house you say nothing about men, not husbands and not sons, whatever they've done to you this winter," Kallia said. "Up there you talk about your feet, or the cold, or you hold your tongue. Wind it harder than that, or it'll be round your ankle before you're halfway up the stair."

She was down on her heels at the hearthstone with one foot drawn in against her, winding a strip of old blanket over her shoe, beneath the instep and up round the ankle and back, and her hands did it while her eyes were on the pot. I had strips off the same blanket and my boots under them. The first one I pulled hard enough to satisfy her came apart in my hands.

"Why nothing about men?"

"Because it's the mountain. Tear another; there's more blanket than there is evening."

"And if they ask me things? Where I was born, and who my people are?"

"They'll ask you everything, every step up and every step down." She jerked the knot at her own ankle to try it. "You tell them what I told the clerk, and not a word over."

It was a few days past the turn of the year by my private reckoning, and the coldest week since October. The frost had not

gone off the court all day. Overhead the Thebans had their shutters closed and were singing behind them, the song about a girl of Corinth that they had been improving all winter without making it any shorter. The singing stopped, and a shutter opened.

"Bring us back some of the god's wine, Kallia, and we'll pay you the month early."

"The month's due on the day, wine or none," Kallia said. "If the house burns down, you'll pay for the house."

I left the flashlight at the bottom of my bag under the stair. I was dressed in the girl's clothes, with her brown himation pinned at my shoulder and drawn up to cover my hair. Kallia had twisted two rings of ivy off the terrace wall below the spring. She set hers on her kerchief without ceremony; the other waited on the woodstack for me, and it was wet, so that when it went on my head cold water ran down behind my ear.

"Where on the plain do they dance?" I said.

"Where they danced the last time." She caught the pin, two fingers on the bronze and none on me, and moved it higher.

The lane had filled with women. The Thyiades, the town called them, the god's wild women, though the ones in sight were mostly worried about their hems. They spilled from every gate in twos and threes, torches unlit, cloaks pulled up; the talk went back and forth between the walls as loud as a market. Midway along the lane a small quick woman with a mass of black hair came out and fell in beside us, holding her skirts clear of the frozen slops in two fists.

"Kallia, it's not going to snow, is it? Tell me it's not. I've my husband's sister's sandals on."

"Then you should have borrowed her boots."

"She's no boots. Who has boots?" She glanced at mine, which showed for a step under the hem, a bundle of gray rag, and lost

interest, satisfied that they were nothing. “She’ll have my eyes if they come back spoiled. They’re new. She’s not worn them to the spring yet.”

“Nikaso,” Kallia said, “you’ve a sieve of mine to mend before you borrow anything else in this lane.”

This, then, was the wife of the man with the sieve. The night I came, I had stood in her lane with a jar of water dragging at my arm while Kallia banged on her door, and she had been asleep. I had imagined her older, and someone had once broken her nose, which had mended a little to the left, so that her face seemed always to be on the point of asking something.

“Is she the Syracusan? Does she talk?”

“When she likes.”

“I talk,” I said. “Not well.”

“Who talks well, up there? You’ll be our third, then, for the wine; it’s one skin to three of us. Kallia carries it and I hold it, and you drink what’s left. And these squeak, do you hear them? New leather squeaks. If it snows they’ll stop squeaking, and then I’m a dead woman.”

“Do it at the top, where it’s flat,” Kallia said. “I’ll not lay you out on a stair.”

At the head of the lane we came out on the street that climbed through the upper town, where the other lanes emptied into it, and the noise doubled at every gate. Men stood in their doorways to watch. Some held torches over the street to see their wives and daughters off, and the light went along the faces under the hoods, each in turn. A boy ran beside us in the gutter shouting his mother’s name until she cuffed him home.

At the last gate but one, an old woman sat on a block of stone by her door with a basket of barley in her lap and threw it over the frozen ruts a fistful at a time. The crows had dropped to it out

of the dusk, a dozen and more, black on the white rime, walking about with their shoulders up.

"Black thieves," she was shouting at them, "every one of you. That's not for you." She threw another handful. "Go on, then. Take it. Choke on it."

She kept her free hand on her knee the whole time, and her eyes on the crows.

The street ended high in the town at a long low building with a stable at one end, the last roof in Delphi, and there the men stopped. A man stood at its corner holding a gray mule by her headstall, with her face turned in to the stable wall so that the torches would not set her off. It was the gray, so it was Valens; he had his own back to us as well, like every man who had come that far, and I saw only the mule's ears go back and forward at the drums and his hand go up her neck.

The drums had started at the front, out of my sight. There were two at first, then four: round frames of hide struck with the palm. Under them a pipe climbed and fell on two notes and never seemed to stop for breath. At the front a woman carried fire in a pot. The women approached it by turns, and the light passed from torch to torch toward us. Kallia held hers to the woman ahead and came away with it burning; Nikaso lit hers from Kallia's, I lit mine from Nikaso's, and the pine caught.

The path took the cliff in its switchbacks, as it had in November. That time I had climbed it in the dark behind the gray; now I had a torch in my fist, and the women ahead of me took the turns at a pace I would have called reckless on a stepladder, singing. Every drumbeat arrived twice, once from the drum and once off the rock. Above me the torches folded back on themselves at each turn. Below me the town shrank to a smudge of smoke with a few sparks in it, and after that I watched the rock.

Ahead of me a tall woman wore a fawnskin knotted over her cloak at one shoulder, dappled side out, and its little black hooves knocked together at her hip as she climbed. It had been tawed with the fat still on the belly, and the hide there had gone stiff as card and was splitting where the ribs had been. Half the women near me carried a stalk of giant fennel instead of a torch, with ivy wound down it and a pine cone jammed on the end, and they leaned on them on the steep parts, which I suspected was not the intention.

Near the front an old woman had a winnowing basket riding on her head, a broad shallow scoop of woven reed with a cloth tied over it, and she carried it up a cliff without putting a hand to it. An empty jar would not stay on mine the length of Kallia's court. I watched that basket for most of the climb, and not one turn unsettled it.

"They've stopped," Nikaso said, at the third bend.

"What has stopped?"

"The sandals. They've stopped squeaking." She held up a foot into my torchlight. The snow had begun there, on the cliff path, a hard old crust in the angles of the rock, and her red straps had gone dark with it. "That's the wet getting in, and she'll know; she knows if I've so much as breathed on her loom."

"Why not wrap them over, as we have?"

"Over new sandals? What's the good of them, wrapped?"

"Who is there to see them, in the dark?"

"The god," she said. "And Philista, who leads us up, and she tells everyone at the lions."

Kallia climbed past both of us with the wineskin slung across her back on a cord, and her stride never altered for the ice.

"Snow caught the women up here once, when my mother was a girl," Nikaso said behind her. "They sent men up in the morning to fetch them, and the men's cloaks froze so hard on the

climb that they broke in two when anybody tried to unfold them."

"Is it true that in Syracuse the women go to the baths with the men?" said Nikaso, on the next turn, with no breath to spare for it.

"Not in my family."

"His sister says they do. She says the Romans have spoiled everything over there, and the women walk about the streets with their faces out like men." She considered it for the length of a switchback. "She's never been anywhere. She's never been to Kirrha."

Philista was waiting at the head of the cliff with her drum on her hip: lean, old and upright, her hood thrown back, posted at the top of the path like a teacher at a classroom door after the bell. She inspected each of us as we came onto the edge.

"No Athenians," she said, by way of a greeting. "The roads are shut, they say. They say it whenever it suits them. For once he'll be woken properly, and nobody from Athens standing at my elbow to tell me how it's done in Athens."

Behind us the woman who had offered to singe my legs at the bath hauled herself onto the edge on all fours with her torch kept clear of the drop, and stood, and shook out her skirts.

"I've left his mother the dough," she said to anyone who would listen, "and if she lets it rise past the rim, I'll smell it from here. She'll do it to spite me. She'll stand over it and watch it go."

"Sostrata, is it true he comes to the new brides first?" said a girl beside her, very young, with her ivy crown down over one eyebrow. "My husband says he does. He says I'm to tell him everything after."

"Your husband says plenty, Timo, for a man who's been married since the vintage. Tell him nothing; that's how mine's lasted twenty years."

"Husbands," said Philista. "On my cliff, and the god not woken."

"He comes to whoever's awake," Sostrata told Timo, a good deal lower.

The plain lay gray under the stars, with the black line of the firs along its far side. The drums set the pace, and the women crossed the snow at something between a march and a run, torches leaning back, breath going up white into the light. Before we arrived I had guessed where we were going. Below the pen at the foot of the firs lay a stretch of level ground, swept bare by the wind and ringed with rocks. Philista went to the largest rock, and the old woman lodged her basket on top of it.

Everybody who could had carried wood up on her back. I had one of Kallia's bundles, split oak, roped in a sling across my shoulders, and the whole length of the cliff I had wanted to be rid of it. The women piled it in the middle of the ring, with much argument about how it should go. A girl brought the fire up from the pot and blew on it, and the oak caught slowly, and then with a roar.

The drums stopped, and the pipe went on alone a while on its two notes, and stopped too.

"What is in the basket?" I said to Nikaso.

"Him." She said it as she might have said water was wet. "That's his cradle. You'll see."

Its bearer untied the cloth. In the basket there was a round loaf, a wrinkled apple out of a winter store, a twist of raw wool and a sprig of ivy. She lifted it in both hands.

"He's heavy this year," she said.

"He's had a good autumn." Philista bent to the basket. "Wake up, little one. Your brother's gone away for the winter and left you the house. Wake up and have it!"

She began a cry, high and long, *euoi*, and every woman at the fire answered it, and up went the basket. It was the winnowing toss, a lift and a jerk to let the wind take the chaff. The loaf jumped and came down again. The apple rolled.

"It is bread," I said.

"It's bread as well," said Nikaso.

Up it went again, and again, with the women crying out at each toss, and the drums came in under the cry.

After that it was dancing.

The drums went faster, and the women went about the fire, each by herself, with her head back and her torch or her fennel stalk held out at the full stretch of her arm, stamping, turning, crying out when Philista cried. "He's been asleep three months," she was shouting. "Louder!" Hair came down and hoods fell back. A woman went by me with her mouth open and her ivy over one ear, and another came past with both arms over her head and her torch held so far back that the woman behind her had to duck. The snow at the ring's edge was kicked into the fire and hissed. The whole business was loud and clumsy, hot on the side toward the fire and freezing on the other, and the smoke kept changing its mind.

Kallia pulled off her kerchief. Her hair came down gray to her shoulder blades. I had seen it only once before, plastered flat at the bath, and I had begun to think of it as something she did not have. She stepped into the ring stiff-elbowed, with her chin up, and she danced as she scoured a pot, all of her at once, with no expression on her face.

Nikaso worked the thong loose from the neck of the skin, drank from the leg, and passed it across. The wine was thick and black and unmixed. It tasted of the pitch the skin was lined with and, a little, of goat, and it landed in my stomach like a coal. I

passed the skin back; she drank again, and shoved it at me once more.

"Kallia's share," I said.

"Kallia's dancing. Look at her. If it sours in the skin while she's at it, who gets the blame? Me. Drink."

The second mouthful went down easier than the first, and after it I joined the ring, mostly for the sake of my feet.

"Stamp," Sostrata told me, going by at a heavy trot. "Harder. I've his mother under each foot, and look how warm I am."

My feet went with the drum as well as they could, and my arms did whatever they liked. The women circling the fire circled me as they circled each other, and none of them looked to see whether I was doing it right; when the cry went up I cried out with the rest, a word I had met in Euripides and never had cause to say out loud, and my mouth made it Delphian.

When the oak had gone to coals, the women came in little knots to put new pine to them. I lit mine with theirs, took a second off the pile as some of the others did, and headed out between the rocks beyond the ring, where women had been slipping off into the night all evening in pairs and coming back hitching up their skirts. Nobody watched them go, and no one watched me. Kallia was in the middle of the ring with her back to me and her gray hair swinging, and Nikaso had the skin.

Beyond the pen the firs began, and the drums went behind me into the trees like a party through the wall of the next apartment. Under the firs the snow was deeper and softer, and there was no wind in it at all. My torch lit the trunks nearest me, red on one side; every other trunk was black. The path the mules had taken lay buried under the snow, and I climbed by the slope of the ground and the dark gap overhead where the trees thinned. The climb went on and on. My breath was loud in my

ears and the rags on my boots were heavy with snow, and twice I had to stop and knock it off against a root.

The drift inside the arch had grown, long and smooth, nearly to the lip. I crossed its crest crawling, with the torch held out to one side, and slid down the inner face into the cave on the seat of my borrowed himation.

Inside, the wind and the snow stopped at the arch, and the drum with them.

I crossed into the hall at a walk, and beyond the middle of it the floor rose. I climbed the ridged rock keeping a hand to the wall, which was cold and furred with damp. Twice before I had been this far, and I knew the roof would come down on my left before it did. When it came I stooped under it, and there was the slab in front of me, propped against the wall as before, with the crack running the height of it into blackness.

At the bend, low down, there were pale marks on the rock: short raw scratches through the gray, all slanting one way. They were the only new thing in the cave. They were mine; Kallia's little shovel had made them in November, after the last of the earth was out. The rock had been unmarked since it was rock, and in one afternoon I had scored it like the bottom of a saucepan. I laid my thumb in one of the scratches. It was an ordinary feeling, the edge of a scratch in stone.

At the crack's widest, at the floor, I sent my hand in to the wrist.

The torch burned. Deep in the hall the drip fell, and fell again. My knuckles were on stone and my palm was in the dark, and the two of them were as cold as each other, which was January cold and no more. I kept my cheek on the slab while pitch from the torch crept down my thumb; I left my hand in there until I had been fair to it.

I withdrew the hand and tucked it inside the himation, under my arm, where it ached as it warmed.

I stayed on my knees. There was nobody to laugh. When the torch began to gutter I changed it for my last pine, and in the new light I looked at the crack again: a black gap the height of the slab. My knees were soaked. Down on the plain Nikaso would be drinking my share.

I retraced the ridged rock, the hall and the slope to the arch, and crawled back over the drift. Outside, the stars had gone. The dark beyond the trees was soft and close. The first flakes drifted down through my torchlight, large and far apart, and the drums had stopped.

Once I was clear of the trees the flakes were close together and the wind had got in among them. The ring below the pen was full of moving torches. Women were hunting for their hoods and their fennel stalks in the trampled snow, and Philista stood on her rock beating her drum flat and hard like a cook banging a pot to bring the household in. The fire had sunk and was hissing.

Nikaso found me before Kallia did. She squeezed the skin flat between her hands, and the leg gave up nothing.

"I kept it for you as long as I could," she said. "Then I couldn't."

"You drank all of it?"

"A little was left in the bottom, and the skin was getting cold, and either way it was my fault."

Kallia came up behind her with her kerchief back on and the gray hair pushed up under it anyhow. She looked at the knees of the himation, which were black with wet, and went to help Philista get the women into a line.

"Your ivy's slipped," Philista said to me as I passed her rock. "Put it straight. I bring my women down crowned." Then, to the rest: "Torches lit, all of you, and down, before it shuts the stair."

We straggled toward the cliff with the wind at our backs. The snow came past us sideways and lit up in each torch as it went by, and between the torches the dark was total, with only the voices in it, the women in front calling out the names of the women behind. Nikaso held on to a fold of my himation. I held on to Kallia's.

"Your knees are wet through," Kallia said.

"I knelt."

"In there." Then, further on, because the wind had dropped for a breath and she could be heard without shouting: "Did you find what you went for?"

"No. It was shut."

She let a dozen paces go by.

"If it's something you want out of that mountain," she said, "there's a god in the town who answers questions. He doesn't answer them in winter. Once the road's clear of snow he sits down in his house and answers whoever's paid."

"Women?"

"Women can't go in to him. A man goes in for you, with your question in his mouth, and brings you out the answer."

"What man would go in for me?"

"Whoever you can get." The wind came back, and she raised her voice over it without seeming to raise anything. "It costs."

"How much?"

"More than you've got. Ask a priest. He'll tell you more than it is."

"Have you asked him anything? The god?"

"Who would I send in?"

She walked on, and the wind took her flame flat and let it go again.

At the head of the cliff the line bunched and stopped. Philista had gone to the edge, and two younger women had climbed

down with torches, down the first of the switchbacks. We stood in the snow and watched their two lights go down the rock and stop at the turn. One of them came back up alone. She had snow to the thighs and her torch was nearly out.

"The next bend's gone," she said, high and clear, so that it carried down the whole line. "There's a drift across it to the height of my head. I got under the edge of it, and there's ice under that, and when I pushed my stick beyond the ice to feel for the path, there was none."

The other woman came back after her, slowly, on her hands and knees.

Everybody talked at once, and for a while I could not sort one voice from the next, until single ones came clear of it. A woman behind me began to cry. "My two are with his mother. She'll have them in her bed with the dog."

"They'll be warmer than you," said the woman next to her, "and glad of a night without your feet in their backs."

"Could we go down the long way? By the villages?"

"In this? You'd be under a drift by the second village, and the shepherds' dogs would be the ones to find you."

"Give me a light, someone. Mine's gone out."

"Mine's going. Hold it close to mine, then, and don't breathe on it."

"My brother will bring the men up the stair in the morning," another woman said.

"No man comes up here," Philista said. "Not tonight, nor any night. If one comes up in the morning, he can carry my drum down. We stay. Back to the pen. Get under its wall, and bring every stick that will burn."

"And the god in the basket?" I asked Kallia, once the line had started back. "What becomes of him now?"

"He rides down on her head in the morning, and they put him back in his house till the next time." She shifted the empty skin on her shoulder. "Somebody has to carry him, as somebody hauls the water."

We recrossed the plain with the wind in our faces now. I bent my head into it, followed the gray heel of Kallia's rag in front of me, and thought about money. All the money I had in the world was two brass coins from 1998 with a poet on the bigger one; everything else I had was either borrowed or could not be shown. In Philadelphia my pay had turned up in a bank downtown every other Friday without my lifting a finger, and what I was worth in Phocis was anybody's guess.

The shepherds' huts were the width of the plain away, somewhere in the dark. The pen had walls of edge-set stone to the height of my chest and no roof, and a drift in the corner nearest the plain. We kicked the drift out through the gateway, dragged the hurdle aside, and built the fire in the gap, so that the wall took the wind and the fire took the gate. There was not much left to burn. The last of the oak went on before anything else. After it the fennel stalks went on singly, ivy and pine cones and all, and the god's wands gave us mostly smoke. The pith in them took the fire and nursed it a long while before any flame showed. Prometheus had stolen fire in one of these; I had always pictured it blazing in his fist, and it must have smoked under his cloak.

Then everybody took off her shoes.

They did it together, sitting on their cloaks, unwinding rags gone stiff with ice and working sodden sandals off their feet, and they set the sandals soles-in round the embers to dry. The ring of them steamed. In the firelight they were one dark leather and one shape, a whole ring of the same sandal, and the women put their

bare feet to the fire with their toes spread and groaned at it. For a while the talk was all of feet.

"Look at that. I've three toes gone white."

"Mine are blue. Look, there, the little one's blue."

"Put them on Timo. She's warm; she's still burning from the wedding."

"Take your feet off me," Timo said. "Get them away. They're like fish."

"If I take them off they'll freeze to the ground, and then you can explain it to my husband."

"You said a man," someone objected from the wall. "Up here."

"I said husband. A husband isn't a man."

Nikaso set the red sandals in the place of honor, nearest the coals.

"You'll cook them," Sostrata said.

"Cooked, she can't prove anything. Wet, she'll smell them from the lane."

"Not so near," I said. "If leather dries too fast it shrinks. It will curl and crack."

"And if I leave it wet it rots on my feet and I lose a toe, and then she has my toes and the sandals both." She pushed them a finger's width nearer, as a concession to me. "Who taught you sandals?"

I kept my boots on. I unwound the outer rags from them, which were ice, and left the inner ones, which were only wet, and I drew my hem across the whole bundle and tucked my feet under me. The others had their own feet to think about. Kallia crouched beside me with her shoes off and her rags hung over her two hands toward the fire, turning them like flatbreads on a griddle.

Across the fire a big woman sat with her feet out and a black goat-hair cloak round her like a tent, the shepherds' kind, with the snow lying unmelted on its shoulders. I would not have known her face. But she had kept her sandals by her own feet instead of at the fire, and I knew the sandals: the left strap had been patched over the instep with a square of paler leather, sewn on with a thong and set on askew. I had studied that patch at the spring every morning for weeks, while the woman who wore it stood beside me and talked about the cold, and I had given her nothing but the top of my head.

She was chewing something she kept in a fold of her cloak, slowly, with her eyes shut.

The trouble began when Timo's skirt caught.

It was only the hem, which she had spread out to dry too near the embers, and it only smoldered. But she shrieked and leapt up.

"I'm burning!"

"You're smoking," Sostrata said. "It's not the same thing."

The women near her had leapt up too, and the pen rose out of a ring of sandals and settled again in a different place. When they reached for their sandals there were fifty-nine sandals and a stone.

"Who put a stone in the ring?"

"An Athenian," said Philista.

"That's mine."

"Yours had a nail in the heel. Feel it. That's no nail."

"Who's got the one with the strap through the toe? I want the one with the strap through the toe."

"You've two right feet on you, girl. Look at them."

Timo examined her feet. She had two sandals on that both bent the same way, and she rolled on the cold stones in them like a sailor. Sostrata reached over, pulled one off her and tried it on herself. Her heel stayed out.

"Some child's hopping home barefoot for want of this."

"It's off my mother," Timo said, "and she'll want it back."

"And on the left?"

"How should I know? It was next to me." She stuck the foot out at the fire. "It's got a patch on the strap. Who has a patch on her strap?"

"Not that one." The big woman spoke without opening her eyes. "Mine are here."

Kallia said nothing through any of it. She let it go by her like weather, until a sandal landed in the fire, kicked by a heel in the scramble, and lay on the coals with its strap beginning to fry. Then she reached across and fished it out with a burning fennel stalk, flicked it clear, and fed the stalk to the fire.

"And who's going down that stair barefoot in the morning? Who's to carry her?"

The sandal went unclaimed after that. It lay smoking faintly on the stones while each woman in the pen decided it was some other woman's.

It was Nikaso who wept. She had snatched the red pair out of the ring when Timo caught fire, and now she had one of them in her lap. It had done what wet leather did by a fire. The sole had curled up at toe and heel, and the red straps had shrunk tight and shiny and turned liver-dark. When she tried it against her foot it sat on her toes like a hat.

"She'll have my eyes," Nikaso said. "Both of them. She'll have them out with a spoon."

"Let me have it," I said.

"What for? It's ruined. Look at it."

"The other one is not ruined yet. Give me the other."

"Give it her, and hush," Kallia said. "She'll do it if you hush."

Timo had a little flask of hair oil in her bosom, warm from her skin, and she surrendered it silently when I asked for it, which I

would not have done in her place. I put a drop of it on the second sandal, where the sole was beginning to lift, and worked it in with my thumbs, slowly, out of the fire's reach, coaxing the leather flat again and holding it there while it warmed in my hands. It smelled of Timo's hair and of hot hide.

"What are you doing to it?" said Nikaso. She was as wary of my hands as a market woman with a pickpocket in view.

"Wet leather keeps whatever shape it dries in," I said. "So you choose the shape while it is still soft, and then you wait."

"How long?"

"Longer than you will like."

I bent and held, bent and held. I kept the strap wound round two fingers until the sole lay nearly flat on my palm, and then I let her have it.

Nikaso put it on, and it went on. She put her weight on it, with the other foot bare on the cold stones, and waited for it to fail.

"Now I'll have one eye," she said.

I leaned back on the wall, and the himation cracked. The drift at the arch had soaked it, and while I worked on the sandal the side turned from the fire had frozen; where it folded under my arm it broke along the fold like a biscuit. It had set hard from the shoulder to the hem. I had taken Nikaso's story on the stair for nerves, and I sat in the god's pen with a cracked cloak on my knees and owed her an apology.

Sostrata's cloak had done the same. She got out of her cloak and stood it on its hem in the snow, and it stayed there by itself, the shape of her shoulders, with nothing inside it.

"There," she said. "It can keep the wind off you while I thaw."

"Stand it by me," said Nikaso. "It's warmer company than his sister, and it's got her shoulders."

The last of the fennel was going when Philista stood up in the gateway and struck her drum once, hard, with the butt of her palm.

"He's woken," she said. "He's had his dance and his wine, and he's gone back into his basket to sleep it off. The rest of the night's ours. Say what you like."

"I'll go first," Timo said, and did, at once, as if it had been waiting in her mouth all night. "He's a potter's son, from the lower town, and we were married at the vintage, and he cried in the doorway when I left with the torches. He wanted to walk me to the plain. I said, you can't, you're a man, and he said he'd walk behind with his eyes shut. He's to wait at the top of the street when it's light, with a hot stone in a cloth for my feet. He promised."

"Mine would bring a cold one," said Nikaso, "and ask me where his supper was."

"The baker will be asleep on the flour sacks," Sostrata put in, "with his mother's dough climbing out of its pan beside him, and the two of them snoring at each other." She had her feet in Timo's lap, and Timo had let them stay there. "Not a man in this town will climb that stair with a stone for your feet, Timo, not if the god himself sent for him."

"Mine will." Timo leaned to me across the fire. "And yours, Maira? Did he mind you coming?"

"There is no he."

It went quiet in the pen. Timo's mouth stayed a little open. A woman behind Nikaso, nobody I knew, stopped wringing out her rag to look.

"No husband?" Timo stared. "At your age?"

"Not even a dead one?" asked Sostrata.

"Not even that."

"Who sends you up mountains, then?" Nikaso said.

Kallia was no help. She had supplied dead people and a boat that got in ahead of the winter, but no husband, and she did not add one now.

They were all looking at me, and in the light of the last fennel there was no telling which way it was going to go.

"Well," Sostrata said, "she can have the loan of ours." And she began to sing.

It was a baker's song, with a tune that lifted at the end like a question, and all of them knew it but me. "My man gets up in the dark for his oven," she sang, "and he's home in the dark when he's done, and his mother's in the bed between us, keeping it warm."

"Knead it, knead it," the pen came in, slapping their knees on the beat, "the oven's gone cold!"

"Nikaso's man sleeps in his sandals," she sang, "and his feet are warm, and the rest of him's not."

The refrain came round again, louder.

"That's a lie," said Nikaso. "He takes them off for the bed."

"Just the one," said Sostrata, and went on. "The bride's man went to bed at the vintage, and he's feeling about for the bride there still."

Timo screamed and threw a sandal at her, and it was somebody else's.

"Philista's man went off to the Athenians—"

"He did," Philista said. "And they can keep him."

"Knead it, knead it, the oven's gone cold!"

Sostrata worked her way round the pen like that, with a verse for every woman there who had a man, and when her eye came to Kallia it went past her without a verse to the woman beyond, which suited Kallia; that was as near as anyone in the pen came that night to keeping Kallia's rule. Then Sostrata turned to me, held up her hand for quiet, and got it.

“The Syracusan’s man stayed home in Syracuse,” she sang, “and he—“

She stopped, with her hand still up, and waited.

They all waited. Even the big woman had opened her eyes. Behind me the snow whispered down on the wall, and the fennel ticked in the fire.

“And he was so small,” I said, into the gap where the tune should have gone, since I could not sing to save my life, “that I lost him on the boat.”

The pen went to pieces. Timo went over sideways into Nikaso, and Nikaso’s good sandal went out into the snow. Sostrata beat her own knees with both fists and had no breath left to sing the next line, so Philista sang it for her and beat her drum with it, and the women roared the refrain at the sky, louder than they had roared anything for the god. Kallia bent her face over her rags and did not raise it. I was laughing too. The laugh started down under the wine, and when it was done my face ached in the cold.

“Was he?” Timo said, when she could. “Truly? That small?”

“Smaller,” I said. “I have made him bigger for the song.”

“Again,” said Timo, with her face wet. “From the oven. Give her a verse of her own.”

They sang it twice more, and by the last of them I had the refrain.

The fire was down to embers in the gateway with nothing left to give it, and the night came in over the wall like water over a sill. Philista went round on her knees and pushed us together.

“Close,” she said. “All of you, with your backs to the wall, and your cloaks over the lot. Any woman who sleeps by herself tonight wakes up dead, and I’ve never lost one yet.”

They lay down where they were in one long heap under the wall, legs over legs and backs to bellies, with their cloaks thrown

over everything and the stiff ones laid on as lids. Kallia lay down at the outer edge, on her side, with the wind at her back and her dried rags folded under her cheek.

"Wake me when it's light," she said. "Those Thebans will have the pot scraped dry by now, and burnt the scrapings."

I sat at the end of the wall in the cracked himation with my knees drawn up and waited to be told where I went.

The stranger lifted her head out of the heap.

"You," she said. "You at the lions."

"Yes."

"Each morning I tell you about the weather, and each morning you look at my feet." It did not seem to have troubled her much. "You're letting the cold in at this end." She took my wrist and pulled, and raised the edge of her cloak with her other arm. "Come here, and bring your feet."

Her cloak came over me and shut out the snow. Beneath it was her heat, a great store of it, and the coarse black hair of the cloak against my face. Somebody's shoulder settled against mine. Somebody's hand came across in the dark and drew the cracked edge of my himation down over my boots and withdrew, and I could not tell whose it was.

"It was worse the winter the spring froze," the stranger said, into my hair. "The lions had ice in their mouths a hand long. We broke it with a hammer to get at the water."

"It is very cold," I said.

That was the whole of what I had said to her in a month of mornings.

"This? This is nothing. You should have been up here the time before last. We had a woman lose the end of her nose." She worked her knees in behind mine. "Not that she ever used it much."

Soon she went heavy against my back, and she was asleep. Under the cloak it was as warm as a laundromat in February.

"Maira." It was Nikaso, on my other side, very low. "Where did you go, before? When we were dancing."

"To the cave."

"On your own? At night?" She thought about that. "What for?"

"To see if it was open."

"It's a cave," said Nikaso, and yawned against my shoulder. "It's always open."

The snow hissed on the cloak over us like sand thrown at a window. Further along the heap Timo was whispering to Sostrata, and Sostrata was whispering back, near enough that I got about half of it.

"And if his mother's in the house when I get back?"

"Give her the stone, before he can, and say it was your idea. The baker's mother let me off a whole burnt batch for one, the first winter."

"And the second?"

"Go to sleep."

Sostrata talked in her sleep, a word of it about the dough, and Nikaso's bare foot found my calf and kept to it for the warmth, and from down the wall, now and then, Timo said her husband's name under her breath, until Philista lost patience.

"He can't hear you from Delphi. We can."

When I woke the snow had stopped. I pushed the stranger's cloak up an inch and saw the pen in the first gray light: the fire a black ring in the gateway, and Nikaso's one good sandal standing up in the snow outside it where it had landed. Everything else was white and still. All down the length of the wall the women lay heaped together asleep, and the steam rose off them into the cold.

Chapter 9

The Polygonal Wall

In the archonship of Kleodamos, in the month Poitropios, Xenon son of Euangelos, a Delphian, sold to Apollo the Pythian a female body. Her name is Aphrodisia, she is home-born, and the price is three minae of silver, and he has the whole price. Aphrodisia has entrusted the sale to the god, on these terms: that she be free, and not to be laid hold of by anyone all her life, doing what she wishes and going to whom she wishes. But let Aphrodisia remain with Xenon as long as Xenon lives, doing what she is told, so far as she is able, without complaint. If she does not remain, or does not do what she is told, let Xenon have power to punish her as he wishes, by beating and by selling, and let the sale to the god be void. Guarantor according to the law: Damon son of Aristion. Witnesses: the priests Euthydikos and Nikandros; of private persons, Babylos, Eudoros, Philon son of Philon.

The letters had been cut that winter. All round them the wall was written over from the paving to as high as a man could reach off a ladder, freedom after freedom, each one fitted to the face of whatever block it happened to fall on. A line would run to the edge of one stone, jump the joint and carry on in the next. The old ones had weathered soft, and the round letters in them had filled with green like wells. Aphrodisia's stood out pale and sharp among them. The cutter had scored himself guidelines with a

point before he began, and they still showed above and below each line, fine as the scratches on a long-playing record. In the third line he had cut a wrong letter and made it into the right one with two more strokes; the mended letter stood a little fatter than its neighbors.

I had climbed the Sacred Way that morning to find a priest, and I was standing under the temple terrace with my head back, reading a woman's freedom, when a chip of limestone dropped into my hair.

"Mind yourself down there," a man called. "That's a soft block. It flies."

He sat a few stones along, on a plank laid across two trestles. His legs hung down, and he was floured all over with stone dust, with a mallet in one fist. He was cutting the next one, and he had reached the archon.

"Did you cut this?" I said.

"All that end. Everything you can read without stooping. You read, then?"

"Yes."

"Read me the end of the second line, there. He made me leave his grandfather off. Saved himself the letters, and now he reads like something that grew in a field."

"Xenon son of Euangelos."

"And son of Xenon, it ought to say, which is a whole word I've not been paid for." He blew into the cut he was making, and the dust went past my face. "They all do it. A man frees a girl and haggles with me over his own grandfather."

"Who is she?"

"Xenon's girl. Born in his kitchen. She's been putting it by since she was small, an obol here and an obol there out of what the lodgers gave her. Last month she brought it up here in a pot and paid it to the god, and the god paid it to Xenon."

"So that nobody can say she bought herself."

"And the god doesn't want a girl to cook for him, so she's free."

"And then she went home with Xenon."

"Where else would she go? It says. He's forty, and eats for two. She'll be free the day they carry him out past here to the tombs, if she's not under a stone of her own by then, and after that she can go where she likes."

"And if he sells her before then? To some man in Amphissa who has never—"

"She brings him up here and stands him in front of it, and he reads it, and his money's gone." He struck, and a flake sprang past my ear and ticked away down the steps behind me. "The wall's for that. A tablet gets lost, or a man says it did. I've never had to cut one of these twice. She paid me an obol over the price, from what was left in her pot, to cut hers deep. She can't read a letter of it. I read it out to her the day I finished, twice through, and she listened to the whole of it and went home." He tilted the mallet at the Way. "That's her."

A young woman was passing along the Way with a basket of washing on her head, in a tunic dyed a cheap blue that had faded in streaks. She went by under the wall, near enough to touch, with her gaze on the steps.

"Which of the priests would tell a woman what the god costs?" I said.

"Any of them would tell you, and add a bit. Euthydikos. His name's at the foot of half this wall; he likes it in stone. He lives over the gymnasium lane, the house with a bay tree in a pot at the door. You'll hear him before you find it. He's got the smith in this morning over a lamp-stand."

I took the gymnasium lane, putting my question together. The god was supposed to answer in verse, and I had no verse to

give him back. What I had was a mountain with a crack in it that had let me in and would not let me out, and no Greek for the middle of that story. *Where is the way back?* was too short; any god could answer it by pointing down the road to Kirrha. *Where is the door I came in by, now it is shut?* was nearer. I tried it over in a murmur, and it sounded like somebody patting her pockets for a key. Whether I believed in Apollo was beside the point. He kept the one window in Phocis that took questions about doors, and the cave had been shut to me twice.

* * *

The bay tree stood in its pot, and a slave on a stool beside it, shelling beans into his lap, looked at my feet first, as everyone in Delphi did, and then worked his way up. Beyond the door a man's voice was raised in complaint, and another man's answered it, both at once, and under the two of them the wheeze of a bellows.

"The temple's up the hill," the slave said.

"I have a question for the priest Euthydikos."

"Everybody has a question." He tipped the beans off his lap into the bowl and went in. He left the door open. I came after him as far as the threshold and stood on it.

The court was paved, with a colonnade down two sides and a well-head in the middle under a wooden lid, and it smelled of charcoal. A boy by a pot of coals worked a goatskin bellows with both knees. The smith was short and wore a leather apron, and his eyebrows had long since gone into somebody's fire. He was down on the paving beside a sack, and on the sack lay a bronze stand of the kind that held a dish of coals for the incense: three lion's feet joined at the heels, a shaft fluted like a column, and at its top a shallow bowl under a pierced lid on a chain. Standing, it would have come to my hip; it lay on its side. The shaft had

snapped across just above the feet, and the smith was pressing wet clay round the stump in a fat collar.

On the step of the colonnade stood the priest, in a white himation, with his hands up its sleeves. His beard was long and gray, combed out and cut square at its end, so neat that it looked put on over his own. He was telling the smith that his grandfather had given that stand to the god.

"Your grandfather bought it cast too thin," the smith said, "and the clay's nearly on."

From the threshold the bowl was in plain view. Where it sat on the head of the shaft a band of duller metal ringed the join, gray where the rest was green and brown, smooth where the rest was pitted. It was lead. Somebody had broken that bowl off once and run solder in to fix it on again; it had been neatly done, dressed down level afterward, and a little of it had crept away into the flutes.

"If you heat it," I said, "the bowl will come off."

The slave swung round in the doorway and stared at me as though I had ridden in on a mule.

"Who's that?" the smith asked.

"Kallia's Syracusan," said the slave. "She wants the god."

"Ask her what she means by it," the priest said to the slave.

I answered over the slave's shoulder. "The bowl is held on with lead. There, where it is gray. When the shaft is hot enough for new bronze, the heat will climb to the top, the lead will let go, and the bowl will drop into his coals."

"I know it's lead," the smith said. "I put it there."

The priest's hands emerged from his sleeves. They were red and swollen across every knuckle with chilblains, tight and glossy as cherries, and he inspected them with distaste and withdrew them again.

"Yours, is it?"

"Nine years back, for your father. It's held, hasn't it?"

"And if the bowl had dropped into your fire this morning?"

"I'd have put it on again. It's no trouble to me." The smith turned round on his knees to have me in front of him. "And you know lead, do you?"

"That it runs long before bronze does," I said. "And that the bronze at the break is full of holes. Look at it."

Everyone had looked at it but the priest. The broken face of the shaft was gray and granular, pocked all over with little round cavities where gas had been caught in the metal as it cooled. The casting had been bad since the day it was poured, and new metal run against it would have had to fight its way into every hole, and it would have lost.

"What would she do instead?" said the priest.

"No forge," I said. "I would put a rod inside the shaft, across the break, so the two halves sit on it. And I would fill the crack over with wax until you cannot find where it was."

"Wax." The smith spat beside the sack. "On the god's bronze. It'll stand till the first warm day and then lie down in the incense."

"The rod takes the weight. The wax is only for the eye."

"And when some slave knocks it over again?"

"It will come apart along the same line," I said, "and in no new place, and the next mender will have nothing to undo but wax."

Up to then Euthydikos had looked at the slave, or at the smith, or at the air a little behind my shoulder, where a husband might have stood. This question he asked of me.

"Where does a woman learn bronze?"

"In Syracuse," I said, which was where I was from, now.

"And for this rod and this wax, what does she want?"

"Tell me first what a question to the god costs."

He sought the answer from the slave, and the slave had none for him, having no beans left to examine.

"For a Syracusan? First the pelanos, into the god's treasury, before he'll hear you at all. What a Syracusan pays I'd have to send to the archive to learn, to find whether your city ever made terms with the god, and if it did, whether anybody in it remembers. Call it a stater."

"Call it two," the smith told his clay.

"Then the goat. Cold water goes on its head at the altar, and it must tremble from the hooves up, every leg of it, or the god isn't receiving that day; it goes on the fire whatever it did, and home you go, and back you come next month with another goat." He considered the next item with his eyes half shut. "And a Delphian to stand for you, since you aren't one, and he'll expect a present for his trouble. And a man to carry the thing in, since you aren't that either."

"I know about the man."

"The rest is only money."

"Mend it for a stater," I said.

"A stater. For wax."

"For a stand that stands when the god comes home."

He spoke to the smith over my head. "Your price?"

"Three drachmas, and the clay found."

"And three more for the bowl, when it fell in your fire." He brought his gaze down to me, or near me. "A smith's price is for a smith's fire. I have wax from my own bees."

"It is not a smith's work. That is why it will last."

"Half."

The boy gaped at me over the bellows. Above us somebody had stepped out onto the gallery to listen. She showed me nothing but a hem at the balustrade, and the hem stayed perfectly still.

"When I have finished," I said, "look for the break. If you find it, pay me nothing. If you cannot, pay me the smith's price."

"In what light?"

"In any light you like."

He kept silent while the smith began scraping his clay off the stump. It came away in one piece, with the print of the flutes on its inside.

"Pay the smith for his clay," he told the slave, and then, from the house door, "In Syracuse, what do they do for chilblains?"

"Wool on the hands," I said. "With a place for each finger."

"Like a slave at the olive picking." He went in. "Daylight," he said, from inside.

The smith slapped the collar into his bucket and got his bellows under his arm. On his way out past me he stopped.

"When it lies down," he said, "send to me. I'll bring the lead."

* * *

The rod came from the smith in the end, by way of the slave at the door and two of the priest's obols.

They gave me the corner of the colonnade nearest the rear gate, where the light was good until the middle of the afternoon, and an old slave to watch me, who kept the priest's bees in a row of clay hives along the back wall and cared for little besides. He sat on an overturned basket by the hives and talked to them in an undertone. Now and again he rose and laid his ear to the end of one.

"There's a woman at the master's bronze," he told them, the first morning. "From Syracuse. Don't mind her."

The shaft had been cast round a core of clay, and the core was still in it, burnt black and gone to grit. I raked it out of both halves with a bent nail the bee-man found me, a pinch at a go. With a twist of dry grass I swept both faces until the cavities were empty

and the gray crystal of the metal caught the sun. Then the rod. A hardware store off Fortieth Street sold pins like it singly out of little wooden drawers, with a cat asleep on the counter scale; the smith had sent his second-best file with this one, I think in the hope that I would ruin it. I filed along the rod, gave it a quarter turn and filed again, and now and then I tried it in the mouth of the shaft, and the rod refused. It was too fat, and I filed it, and it was still too fat.

Late in the day the rod went in. It slid into the foot end of the shaft to half its length and stopped, snug, and when I lowered the upper half of the shaft over the part that stood out, it went down with a faint push of air against my fingers and the two broken faces met. No fingernail would go into the crack. Where they met there was a line a hair wide, running round the shaft and through every flute, and from a pace off the line was all I saw.

"Have you any wax?" I asked the bee-man. "Raw wax, not off a tablet."

"From them?" He considered his hives. "They'll want to know what for."

"Tell them it is for the god."

In the morning he brought me a yellow cake of it wrapped in a fig leaf, and a sherd with lamp soot in it scraped off the kitchen wall.

I broke off a piece of the wax and worked it between my palms until it gave, and it smelled of a red crayon left on a schoolroom radiator until it slumped and shone, and I kneaded the soot into it until it was dark enough to pass for bronze in the shade. I warmed the blade of the bee-man's knife over the lamp, pressed the wax into the line round the whole shaft and polished it down with a pad of wool.

It was a good fill; in the colonnade's shade it disappeared. I carried the stand into the open to see it as the priest would, and

with the low sun slanting over it the line came back as a thin gold thread, because the wax shone and the old bronze had stopped shining in the priest's grandfather's day.

On the second try I put in more soot and a pinch of earth from the bay tree's pot, and dulled the fill afterward with my thumb instead of the wool. In the sun the thread had gone. But the wax was soft, and by noon the sun on the paving was warm enough to make it softer, and close to, my own thumbprint showed in it, the whorls raised in the fill.

"Out it comes," the bee-man said. "He'll not know the difference. He couldn't find his own feet in that beard."

Early in the afternoon a woman descended the gallery stair into the court, and the bee-man woke and was suddenly very busy at his hives. She was much younger than the priest, and she kept her himation up over her head in her own house; under it her hair was crimped in rows as regular as the flutes on the stand. She came and stood over it.

"Does it hold?"

"It holds. It is the seam I am taking out."

"He wants it in its place for the god's return. He's told half the town his grandfather's stand will be back by the altar." She had something wrapped in a napkin against her breast, and she opened the napkin far enough to show me: the handle of a bronze mirror, a little woman standing on a tortoise with her arms raised to hold up a disc, and no disc. "The rest is upstairs. It came off on the stair at midwinter. It was my mother's."

"I can join it again."

"Not now." She folded the napkin over the little woman's face. "Not in his court."

She climbed back to the gallery, and the bee-man watched her to the top of the stair.

I scraped the second fill out. Wax by itself was never going to be hard enough; it wanted resin. The priest's lamps burned oil, and his kitchen burned oak.

At the back gate Valens was unloading split wood off a line of mules into the priest's woodshed.

The gray stood tied to the gatepost apart from the others with her load off. A little pot hung from the post by its handle, and he was working what was in it into a sore place on her withers where the saddle had galled her. Her ears were flat. When she swung her head round to bite him he put her nose away with his elbow and went on working.

"Is that pitch?" I said, at the gate.

"For her back. The new saddle's rubbed her."

"Will you sell me some? A walnut's worth."

"What for?"

"To harden wax. Mine is too soft. It takes a thumbprint."

His eyes left me for the court: to the stand on its sack in the sun, and to the old man on his basket by the hives, who had gone to sleep sitting up.

"That's the god's," he said.

"The priest's. He is paying me to mend it."

He wiped his fingers on the gray's mane, unhooked the pot and broke the cake of pitch in it with the haft of his knife, and gave me a piece. It was almost black, cold and brittle, with a mule hair in it.

"Will it stand?" he said.

"With this in it? Years. If nobody knocks it over."

"Somebody will."

"What do I owe you?"

"An obol."

"I have nothing until he pays me."

"He'll pay." He bent to her withers again.

I melted the pitch into a lump of the wax in a sherd over the lamp. When it ran I drew the shaft off the rod, poured a little of the hot mixture into the mouth of each half and seated them again while it was soft. That held. Once it had cooled I could have lifted the stand by its bowl and swung it round my head.

The third fill went in dark and hard and took the soot well, and when I rubbed it down it went as dull as the old metal beside it. In the shade it was gone and in the sun it was gone. I knelt and brought my eye down level with the shaft and sighted along it toward the sun, and the line was there. The bronze had a skin like an orange's, pitted with the small pits the years had put in it, and my fill was smooth.

I dug it out a third time, too fast, and the knife skidded off the hard fill and laid my thumb open at the base. I sucked it until it stopped.

"She's cut herself." The bee-man was smoking a hive. "On his bronze. Don't tell him."

The sun had left the court by the fourth fill. I pressed it in, and before it could harden I pricked the whole face of it with a bundle of bristles from the bee-man's brush, rubbed soot into the pricks with a fingertip and took the rest off with the wool. I had lost it myself. If I sighted along the shaft I thought there was something, and it might have been only the light going.

"He'll look at it in the morning," the bee-man said from his basket. "When the sun's on the court. He said the sun."

I wanted one more try at dawn, before Euthydikos came out. I set the stand on its three feet on the paving. The bowl sat level, and the lid hung still on its chain.

* * *

I bind Glykera the weaver, and her loom, and the warp on her loom, and the weights that hang from the warp, and her two hands and her

eyes. Let every thread she throws go slack and every thread she pulls snap, and let what comes off her loom come off crooked, and let nobody buy it. I give her down to Hermes below and to Earth, and I nail her under the lead.

The boy who found it was fishing in the mud at the drovers' end of the spring basin, where the trough emptied into a culvert, lying on his belly with one arm down it. Kallia wanted the jars filled before she lit her fire, and I was at the lions with the first of them; the stand would have to go to the priest as it stood. It was barely light, and the water bit where it ran over my wrist; the almond trees on the terraces below the road had come into flower in the last week, and the water was still in January.

He scrambled up with something gray and folded in his fist and ran with it to the women at the lions.

"Put that where you found it," one of the women said. "It's been given to the ones below, and they don't want it handed round."

None of them would look at it, so in the end he brought it to me.

"Is there money in it?"

It was a sheet of lead about the size of my palm, folded twice over and pierced through every layer with a bronze nail. It had lain in the mud till the creases went white. I worked the nail out and opened the folds slowly, because lead that had lain in wet ground tore like old cloth, and the writing was scratched in capitals beneath the white, crowded, every line running uphill at its end.

"What's it say?"

"It is a curse. Somebody wants a weaver's cloth to come off the loom crooked."

"Which weaver?"

"Glykera."

"There's no Glykera at the spring." He studied the lead, deeply cheated. "Is it worth anything?"

"It is lead. The smith will give you something for it."

I closed it up and handed it back to him, with the nail, and he ran off up the steps toward the town, past the women and their jars, holding it out in front of him.

* * *

Once the sun was full on the court, the priest came out with his beard combed and the bee-man behind him, and he circled the stand before he bent to it.

He knew roughly where it had snapped; he had stood on his step and watched the smith pack clay round the stump. He went to the foot of the shaft first. He studied it close, and then from farther off. Then he sent the bee-man to the kitchen for a lamp, though the court was full of sun, and held the flame beside the shaft himself and moved it slowly up and down.

"Here?" He had a swollen finger on a flute a little above the line.

"Lower."

The finger slid down the flute, past the place, and up again.

"Show me."

I put my fingertip on the line at the back, where the fill crossed the deepest flute. He put his face so close to it that his beard brushed the bowl, and looked at my finger and at the bronze around it. His lips were moving. When he straightened at last he gave the lamp back to the bee-man.

"The smith's price," he said.

He kept his purse on a cord round his neck, under the white wool. He brought it out and loosened it and took the coins out coin by coin with his red fingers. I held out my hand, and he let them fall into it from a little above, so that his fingers stayed clear

of my palm. The last one struck the edge of my hand, went off onto the paving and rolled under the stand.

It had stopped against a lion's foot, and I hooked it out with a finger. When I stood again the bee-man was holding out a square of linen to his master, and the priest was wiping his fingers on it, each one, the thumb last.

Above us the hem was at the balustrade again.

My palm was black in every crease with soot and wax, and the coins lay on the black. He had not touched it. Perhaps it was the soot.

"Thank you," I said, and bent my head to him as well.

"There's that smith's lead in the top that wants cutting out," he said, already on his way indoors. "When I send, come back and do the bowl."

The bee-man walked me to the rear gate.

"The mistress says," he told me there, "when you come for the bowl, come round to the kitchen door."

He went off to his hives.

Kallia was in the court at home, scouring the big pot with sand. I opened my hand over the hearthstone and tipped the coins out on the stone.

"Into your hand?"

"Onto it. From above."

To that she gave no word at all. She filled the basin at the jar and stood it on the hearthstone beside the coins. A lump of the gray washing clay went down next to it.

I washed. The water in the basin went black, and the black worked into the clay, and the cut in my thumb came open in the water and put a thread of red into the black. I cleaned round it. It went on coloring the basin for a while, fainter each time my hands went in, and then the water stayed black.

"He says a stater for the god," I said, with my hands in the water, "and a goat that shakes, and more after that."

The sand hissed round the belly of the pot.

"Who takes the goat up?" said Kallia.

"The man, I suppose."

"Then you'll want a man a goat will walk for. They don't, for most."

When my hands were as clean as they were going to get, I knotted the priest's coins into a rag with the two brass ones from 1998, the poet and the other, and the whole of it lay in my palm and weighed very little. Kallia's sand had gone quiet while I tied it.

* * *

Runaway from the household of Quintus Arrius Celer at Corinth: a Thracian, answering to the name Lupus, the property of that household. About thirty years old, tall, broad in the shoulder, with a scar on the back of the right hand from a wound badly stitched. He speaks Latin, and Greek like a foreigner. He has been in the arena; whoever takes him should take him with others. To whoever brings him back to the household at Corinth, five hundred drachmas. To whoever shows where he is kept, in a sanctuary or in the house of a man able to answer for him, three hundred. Copied from the notice posted at Corinth in the month Dadaphorios.

It was painted in red on a board whitened with gypsum, pegged to a pillar of the colonnade in the square, beside the door the herald used. The brush had dragged in the gypsum, and the red had run a little at the foot of every upright.

My errand in the square was to price a goat.

The goat man had his animals penned in hurdles at the lower end of the square beside the fountain, a dozen of them, and he was eating a heel of bread.

"For the god?" he said, with his mouth full. "It's a shaker you're after." He reached across the hurdle and took a young she-goat by the horn, dipped his cupped hand in the fountain trough and threw the water down her spine, and she shuddered from her ears to her tail and stamped. "There. Like a bride. Mine all do it; I keep them warm, so the water surprises them. The fellow out beyond the stadium keeps his on the hill all winter, and you can pour a river on them and they'll only look at you."

"What does she cost?"

He looked at the rag in my fist, which was the shape of what was in it. "More than that."

"How much more?"

"For that you can have the shake and not the goat." He shook the rest of the water off his hand. "Send whoever's leading her up, with the money. I'll keep her warm till then."

The men at the board were why I went to read it. There were five or six of them, and they had the look of men who had been standing there since it went up and had settled among themselves what it said. They talked across one another, and what reached me came in pieces.

"Five hundred drachmas."

"At Corinth. You'd have to walk him to Corinth for it, every step."

"Walk a Thracian to Corinth? He'd walk you into the gulf."

"Three hundred, then, for saying where he is. You don't have to walk anybody for that."

"Who'd give up a man in his own town for three hundred?"

"I would. For three hundred I'd give up my landlord, and hold the rope."

"When did that go up?"

"With the oil from Thebes. First carts since the snow, and the clerk had it on the wall before the oil was off."

"Lupus. What sort of name is that for a man?"

"It's a wolf."

"A Roman will call a slave anything. My cousin's master in Patrae called his cook Victory."

"There's a Thracian sells eels at Kirrha."

"That one's sixty, and he couldn't take a kid off its mother."

They drifted away toward the money-changer, arguing about the eel-seller, and I stepped in among the pillars with my rag of coins and read the board through.

I read it through again. The rag had gone damp in my fist.

Valens came into the square at its upper corner, with the gray behind him on a slack rope. She carried nothing. He came along the row of pillars, past the votive stalls, at his ordinary pace. The men from the board had their backs to him.

He halted at the board.

I had moved to the next column. He stood with the gray's nose at his shoulder while a slow man might read it once, and then as long again.

He turned his head and found me there by the column. I was looking at him. I looked at his face.

He looked back at me while a cart came in at the top of the square and rolled down past us, oil jars roped in straw, the carter swearing at his ox. Then he took the gray down the square at a walk, past the men still at the eel-seller, to the trough below the fountain. I had his obol in the rag. I kept my place.

He let the gray drink first.

Chapter 10

Kallia's Letter

The letter had been folded down very small. It came to the gate just after noon, held out between two fingers by a pilgrim from Elis, a young man with a peeling scalp who had been sick on the boat from Aigion and wanted it known. One end of it had stood in wet somewhere and dried with a brown tidemark across it. The thread round its middle was knotted under a thumb of gray clay.

"The wine-seller at Kirrha had it on a nail behind his jars," he said. "Since the autumn. It came over from Corinth on a coaster at the back end of the sailing, and then the sailing stopped, and nobody he'd trust was bound for Delphi. Whoever let rooms near the lions would stand me a cup for carrying it, he said."

Kallia had it out of his fingers and held it shut in her hand.

"Where from?"

"Syria. He said it might be bad, a letter that sat so long."

Her face gave him nothing for that.

"Water," Kallia said to me.

I filled the dipper at the jar. The Elean drank half and returned the dipper with the rest still in it.

"He said a cup."

"That was a cup."

"In Elis a cup has wine in it."

"Then drink in Elis."

"Have you a room? I'm here till the god opens his house."

"Full."

"I'll give two obols a night."

"The house is full."

"Three, then, for anywhere with a roof on it. I was sick over the side from Aigion to Kirrha, and I've slept two nights on a deck with a Corinthian's goat." Behind her the gallery was hung with other people's cloaks. "Three obols."

"There's the houses by the stadium."

He went away toward them, coughing. Every room on the gallery had been taken that week by people come early for the god. After the noon bread nearly all of them had climbed to the sanctuary to stare at the temple.

She pushed the letter down behind her belt, against her stomach, and returned to the pots. It rode there through the scouring and the lodgers' washing water. The corner of it showed over her belt when she reached up for the oil. Once, going past the jar, she touched the place through her clothes. The man from Patrae, who had stayed behind with a bad foot, came down late for his bread, and she gave it him twice over; he took it twice and kept his mouth shut. In four months I had seen nothing come to that house that could be read. Whatever was in a letter, I thought, a person read it at once, standing at the door it came to, and the pots could wait. I scoured what she gave me to scour and asked her nothing.

Halfway through the afternoon she brought her spindle and a basket of carded wool into the court. It was the first afternoon of the year with heat enough in the sun to work without a cloak. She stood in it beside the lean-to that held the hearth and all the kitchen the house had, and spun.

She went to the front of the lean-to, where a reed blind hung rolled up under the eave, and pulled the slip-knot on its cord one-handed. The blind dropped open to the ground between the jar and the sun, letting down a winter's soot and a dead wasp. She came back to her place.

I sat on the step with a basket of chickpeas on my knees, picking out the grit. The spindle dropped and turned and came up again under her fingers. Presently she let it hang. She drew the letter from her belt and held it toward me across the wool at the length of her arm.

"You read the clerk's wax," she said.

The clay broke from the knot at the first push, and the thread slid off over the end. Unfolded, the papyrus was mostly creases and needed both my hands to keep it flat. The hand inside was small and level from top to foot.

"Ariston to Kallia, his mother, greeting, and many of them. Before everything I pray for your health, and every day I make an offering for you to the gods of this place, though you would not know their names."

"There's gods enough here," said Kallia.

"I am well. Know that I was with the cohort before Jerusalem from springtime until the city was taken. I have come out of it alive and whole, all but the left arm, which a stone off the wall broke above the elbow. It has knit, but it will not straighten. On account of it the prefect has given me my discharge before my time, and paid me out what I had saved at the standards."

"Which arm?"

"The left."

"He was never any use with the left," Kallia said.

Jerusalem had fallen in the summer just gone, and its temple with it, burning. I knew it the way I knew the Armada, as a date on a page with a fire in it.

"Forgive me the two years."

"Two and a half," said Kallia. "At the vintage."

"Nobody was going west, and after that there was the war. The year before it I took a wife here: Shalmath, the daughter of Iamblichos, who sells horses to the cohort. She is a good wife to me, and keeps my house well. Her father has no son, and he calls me his."

Kallia corrected none of it. The Greek was his, from beginning to end.

"Is she Greek?"

The name told me nothing a Phocian would have wanted told. "Her father is called Iamblichos. It is a name from that country."

"Can she weave?"

I ran my eye to the foot of the papyrus, looking for a loom.

"It does not say. He says she keeps his house well."

"Anybody keeps a house." The wool went out between her fingers in a thread so fine it could hardly hold the spindle up. "Go on."

"She is with child. Her mother says it will come before the middle of the winter. If it is a boy, he will be named for her father, as they do here."

"Here it's for the father's father."

Kallia yawned. The yawn took her in the middle of the court, enormous. It stretched her face and shut her eyes, and when it let her go her eyes were running with it. A second came behind it, as big. She had been on her feet since the dark, and the Elean had come at the worst of the day; I read the next part faster.

"In the evenings the whole house goes up on the roof. From there you can see the river, and the mountains past it, which keep their snow until the summer. With the money from the cohort and what came with her, I have bought land on the river half a

day below Emesa. It is wheat land, with olives along the bank already, and water runs past the door in a channel all summer. I have a yoke of oxen, and a man to drive them, since I cannot."

Emesa was Homs, on the Orontes, and the mountains with snow on them would be the Lebanon. I had river and range laid out as they lay on the map, with the road running west from the town through a gap in the hills to the sea, and the oxen and the man to drive them went by while I was still on that road. Kallia had not left the roof.

"A roof you sit on," Kallia said. "Where does the rain go?"

"It runs off, I suppose. They have less of it there."

"They'll have enough."

"The man," Kallia said. "Bought?"

"It says only a man."

"The middle of winter's gone by."

"Yes."

"It's come, then, whichever it is."

She wanted no reply to that, and I made none.

"Greet for me Nikaso and her husband. Tell Philista I have not forgotten whose drum it was I put my foot through. Greet the baker and Sostrata, and his old mother, if she is living, and Thrasyllos who let me take his mules to the harbor, and Glauke's girls at the spring, both of them."

"She's living," said Kallia. "Thrasyllos died when the olives were in, the year after. *Let me take*, he says. He took them, at ten years old, and told nobody, and Thrasyllos walked to Kirrha after him in his bare feet. Glauke's girls are married. The big one's in Amphissa with a potter, treading his clay for him."

She was answering the letter, and I raised it for her.

"I pray for your health, mother, and that the gods keep you. Farewell. Written at Emesa, on the twentieth of Hyperberetaios."

There was no more. I looked on the back to be sure. There, in the same small hand, was the address: to Kallia, at Delphi, at the lodging above the Castalian spring, from her son. He had found room for the old woman who slept between the baker and his wife. For the house there was no line, nor for anything under its roof. Kallia stood in the sun with the wool in her hand.

"He says the arm has knit," I said.

She drew a fresh pull of wool from the hank, and let it run back.

The chickpeas had gone warm in their basket. A lodger's tunic was drying on the rail above us.

"Which is his name?"

I turned the papyrus to her and showed her the opening word with a fingertip. She looked at it from where she stood, and came no nearer. From there, in that hand, it was any name in Phocis.

"Keep it out of the smoke," she said.

Somebody came in at the gate at a run. It was Nikaso, from along the lane, with flour on her hands and her black hair half out of its pins.

"Kallia! That boy from Elis is at the lions telling everybody he brought you something written, from as far as Syria. Is it him? Is he living?"

"He's living."

"The gods be thanked." Nikaso put both hands over her mouth, and when she took them away there was flour on her lips. "He'll be home for the god's day, won't he? And your sieve still at my house with the hole in it. Who'll he hear that from first? His mother. And then it's me that put a hole in his mother's sieve."

"He sends you greeting. You and your husband."

"Me? He remembers me?" She looked at the papyrus in my hands as if it might say so again. "He used to drop snails in my water jar."

"He's married, in Syria, and there's a child."

"A child. And you out here spinning, with a grandson in Syria. I'd have been in the lane with it already, telling every woman with a jar."

"That Elean was promised a cup of wine for carrying it, and got water."

"I'll stand him two," Nikaso said. She was already calling to somebody outside as she passed the gate. We heard her at the next gate, and the one after, and fainter at the bottom: Syria, and a wife, and a child.

Nobody else in that court or in that lane could read a word, and I might as easily have made the roof into so much talk about rain and left out the father with no son of his own.

The chickpeas wanted soaking for the morning. I tipped the cleaned ones into the crock by the jar and covered them with water.

"How old was he, when he went?"

"Put a plate on those, or the mice will be in."

The one on top was the cracked one but it fit.

"I can write, as well as read. If you want to send him word, when the boats go east."

"On what?"

"Papyrus. The priest's household would sell me a sheet."

"The horse-seller," Kallia said. "His name again."

"Iamblichos."

"And whoever carries it to Syria?"

"Somebody going east would take it for a cup. As the Elean did."

"Tell him," Kallia said, and wound the yarn up, all of it. At the foot of the stair she stopped.

"Tell him the baker's old mother is living."

She felt in her belt for an obol and set it on the bottom stair, where I would have to pass it. “For the sheet.”

The papyrus still lay open in my lap. I watched her climb, and pass the lodgers’ doors. A pair of wet sandals stood outside one of them with their soles to the sun. The last door was the oldest on the gallery, gray planks gone silver at the foot where the light reached, with a wooden latch and a loop of cord dropped over the latch-peg. Kallia lifted the broom off its boards and swept them. At dawn they had been swept already; I had been carrying out the ashes when she did them. She took it to the lip of the gallery in short strokes, and nothing came over, and back to the door. Once more she went over them, along the grain, and then she laid the broom over the threshold again, the head against one post and the handle against the other, and came down.

Her good himation hung on the peg by the storeroom. She covered her head with it, kerchief and all, and closed it under her chin.

“That Elean will have been all round the stadium by now,” she said, “and the houses there are full to the tiles. He can have Ariston’s room, at the three obols. If he comes to the gate before I find him, he waits in the court.”

The gate came to behind her and bounced once. Up at the last door the broom still lay over the threshold, from post to post.

I read it all to myself, from the greeting down to the date, and rolled it up. In the cold end wall of the lean-to was a niche where Kallia kept the good knife and a twist of cumin. I put the letter in behind the cumin.

Half the basket was still to clean, and I pulled it back onto my knees. Out in the lane a woman was shaking her blanket over the neighbor’s wall, and the neighbor was telling her where else she might shake it. The step was in shade. It was a good while yet till the lamps.

Chapter 11

Valens's Yard

On the other side of Praxias's wall, while he made up his mind what to charge me, a mule yard was already at work in the half dark: a shovel went along cobbles in long scrapes, buckets were being set down on stone, a boy was telling some animal at the top of his voice that it was the worst mule between Parnassus and the sea, and once, very low, a man spoke, and the boy answered him with three questions before he had finished. Praxias heard none of it. He sat on the bench outside his door with a quail in the crook of his arm and named me his price.

"Five drachmas," he said. "That's for family. A stranger I'd charge eight, and he'd pay it, because who else has he got?"

He was Kallia's cousin on her mother's side, a well-fed, slow-spoken, early-rising man who kept his beard clipped to a fringe, and Kallia had sent me to him on the Kirrha road before the lamps were out, because after first light he would be at his olives and not to be found. The quail was a fighting bird; it sat with its feet folded under it and its eyes nearly closed, and he smoothed the feathers of its back with a fingertip, from the neck down, all the while he talked. Somebody in Phocis had bred that bird for courage, and it had the expression of a toll collector at the end of a shift.

"I have three," I said.

"Three is a goat. Or it's the god's cake, if the priest's in a good temper. It isn't a man on his feet in the god's own house with all Phocis behind him, saying a Syracusan girl's question out loud." The finger traveled the bird's back again. "They laugh at any man that carries for a woman. I'd be hearing it at the ring till the vintage."

"Kallia said you would stand for her house."

"For Kallia I'd do it for nothing. Kallia never asks for herself." He looked at me with real kindness, as if he were sorry about my arithmetic. "You're the one asking."

"Two now," I said, "and two more after the harvest."

"By then you'll have sailed for Syracuse, little cousin, and I'll be here with my palm open." He said it without any malice at all.

There were three drachmas in the rag at my belt, all that the priest had paid me, and everything the god wanted had to come out of them. If Praxias would not do it for three, nobody in Delphi would do it for three. Kallia had one cousin, and I had just spent him.

"There's the Corinthian," Praxias said, and tipped his head at the wall. "He'll carry anything for anybody. Wood, oil, a priest's mother-in-law. He'd put your question in a pannier and bring the answer back up with your change."

"Is he Corinthian?"

"His mules are. Five, little cousin. Think it over while you fill your jars."

It was forty paces along his wall to the gate of the yard, and the boy got louder at each of them.

The gate stood open on a square of cobbles and trodden dung, with a long stable down one side, rubble below and timber above under a roof of reeds, and a shed at the end of it with its door propped on a stone. A trough ran along the wall under a spout.

The water spilled over the lip and ran off down a gutter to the road; a yellow dog lay on the dry side of the gutter, watching it go. By the house door at the back a young fig grew in the bottom half of a big jar, sawn off at the shoulder and packed with earth. It had not a leaf on it.

The boy had a shovel taller than he was. He was a thin one of twelve or so, with straw in his hair. He had me in his eye before I was well through, and came straight at me with the shovel.

"Are you Kallia's? You're the one he took up to Pan's in the snow. Did you hit Pan? Which hand? Was there much blood?"

"Felix," said a man by the trough. "The black's water."

The boy went off with the shovel, still asking, as he went, which hand.

Valens was sitting on the end of the trough with a knife on his knee and a whetstone in his fist, putting an edge on the blade in small circles. Now and then he spat on the stone; his cloak was thrown back off his shoulders, and the hair at the back of his neck was wet from the spout.

I untied the rag first and held out the obol.

"For the pitch," I said.

He took it and tucked it into his cheek, the way the men did in the market when their hands were full.

"I need somebody," I said, "to carry my question in to the god."

He kept the stone going.

"You have not heard what I would pay."

"Three drachmas." The obol made a small lump in his cheek when he talked. "Praxias has a voice for selling. Half Delphi will have heard him."

"He was not shouting."

"He doesn't have to. On the god's first day the whole sanctuary's full. Every man in Phocis with a question, all of them

watching each other. A priest writes down the name of whoever goes in."

"They will be looking at the god. Not at the man with the goat."

"In a line a man looks at the back of the man in front of him. All morning. He's got nothing else to look at."

"Stand at the back, then."

"There's no back on the god's first day. There's a crowd, and a slave of the god's with a rod, sorting it."

"There is the board in the square, too."

"I heard it read out."

"Who read it out?"

"Whoever stood by it. There's always one." He started on the blade's other face.

From the stable came the boy's voice, telling the black she could drink or die of thirst for all he cared, and a bucket going over.

"Then sell me back the watch," I said.

"With the god's money?"

"Have you let it stop?"

He loosened the drawstring of his belt pouch with a finger, looked into it, and left the watch where it was.

"The short one's past the nine," he said. "The long one's at the two."

The shadow of the spout was on the trough's lip, and by it the morning was nowhere near so far along. Since the mountain he had kept it going, every day, and he had not put a finger to the hands.

"It is fast," I said.

"It hasn't stopped." He pulled the pouch shut.

Close to, a white nick ran through one eyebrow, across the grain of the hair. He tried the knife's edge on the back of his forearm, and it took the hair off clean.

Behind him on the shed wall hung a breeching, the strap that went round under a mule's tail to keep the load from running forward on a descent. Its stitching had gone at the turn, the place the grit worked into most, and the break had been bound up with twine. Beside it on the same peg was a girth with two of its thongs cut half through by their own holes.

"That will break on the first steep road," I said.

He glanced back at it. "It's been breaking all winter."

"I can mend it."

"I never asked for it mended."

"I have not asked to be paid."

He sheathed the knife at his back and crossed to the stable.

The shed held a bench under a window hole, a packsaddle on a trestle, and a shelf with a pot of pitch on it and a coil of flax thread. An awl with a horn handle lay among the dust on the shelf. Its point had been blunted on something harder than leather, and I worked with it as it was. The breeching was oxhide, oak-tanned and gone stiff along the edges, and the old thread had been sawn through, a little at every downhill step, by the grit in the stitch holes. I picked the old thread out with the awl, pitched new thread on the pot's rim, and sewed the turn through twice, with a needle at each end of the thread, so that every hole was filled from both sides.

Felix fetched me bread at noon and stood first on one foot and then on the other while I ate it.

"What's he got in his pouch that ticks? Yours, is it? Each day before he's had his bread he does something to it, with his back to me, and if I ask he sends me for water. Does it live? He won't let

me near it, and I held a fowler's hawk down at the harbor, bare-armed, and it never put a claw in me."

"It is mine," I said. "He is keeping it for me."

"He doesn't keep things for people," said Felix, and was gone.

Valens came in for the breeching at dusk, before I had the thread put away. He looked at the turn without touching the stitches and took the strap to the stable door, where a beam ran across under the reeds; over the beam it went, and with an end in each fist he hung his whole weight from it, his feet off the cobbles. The beam creaked, and the strap held.

"Who sewed it last?" I said.

"I did. At Kirrha, by a fire."

"It lasted you to the olives."

He brought the breeching back and hung it on its peg himself. "There's a heap more under that bench."

"I know. I have had my feet on it all day."

He went to see to the gate, and I made my way up to Kallia's by starlight.

In the morning the awl lay on the bench beside the girth, and somebody had put a point on it that would have gone through a sole.

* * *

For a week I mended his harness.

I had Kallia's water in before the sky was gray and was on the Kirrha road before the sun was on it, going down while the pilgrims came up. There were more of them every day, all of them early, on foot and on donkeys, a family of Achaeans with a grandmother in a basket chair slung between two poles. Most mornings Valens had a string out on the road already, to Kirrha for oil or salt fish and back up, and the yard was Felix's, which meant that it was loud. Felix did nothing at a walk. He climbed

the rubble of the stable to the reeds to fetch down a sack and dropped back down it, though the door was beside him; he ate standing; he sang, and broke off singing to ask me something.

"Where'd you learn leather? Off your father? Had he mules? There was a sailor told me in Syracuse they eat octopus raw. Raw!"

"Cooked," I said, but he was already on the roof.

One day the string came back before noon with nothing on it but empty jars, and Valens took the shed step to eat. He had bread and a string of dried figs, threaded on a rush through their stalks with their necks all lying one way. He broke one off and passed it to me without looking round.

It took some chewing, and it was very sweet.

"These have been too long in the sun," I said.

"They're Caunian. They're meant to be like that."

"A fig ought to give when you press it."

"A fig that gives has gone to the wasps." He bit one in half and examined the half in his fingers. "You pick when the skin splits by itself. A day in the shade first, on the tree's own leaves. After that the sun, whole, on a rush, turned every morning, and in at nightfall, ahead of the dew."

"In my country they split them and press them flat, in rounds, with a leaf on top."

"Where's that?"

"Syracuse."

"They don't, in Syracuse."

"Split, the dust gets in," he said. "And the flies. They go hard at the cut and stay wet in the middle, and come the spring you've a jar of mold."

"Pressed, they keep a year."

"Pressed, they're a cake. If I want a cake I'll buy a cake."

"The wasps go for the whole ones as well."

"Not if they're turned."

"What has turning them to do with wasps?"

"A wasp likes a thing that keeps still."

"Chian are bigger," said Felix, going past with a bucket.

"Chian are for men who've never had a Caunian."

"I never had a Caunian till this winter," Felix said.

"That one's Caunian." Valens pointed with the half fig at the tree in its jar. Its twigs had come green and hard at the tips, like the ends of kitchen matches. "From a cutting. In a pot, it goes where I go."

"When does it fruit?"

"When the summer's done, if it's any good. You dry them your way, and I'll dry mine, and we'll open the two jars at midwinter and see."

I put the awl through the girth and drew the thread after it. By then, if there was any justice anywhere, I would be standing in a kitchen in Philadelphia with a tap in it.

"Somebody else would have to open mine," I said.

"Then I'm right." Valens ate the rest of it.

It rained a bit the next morning and then it stopped. While it rained the string stayed in, and Valens sat on an upturned bucket in the shed doorway with the mules' bells heaped in his lap, stuffing the throat of each one with a twist of wool.

"Why stop them?" I said.

"Road's full of strangers on their way to the god. I'd sooner hear them than have them hear me."

He did three bells without saying anything else. Then he said, "The thing in my pouch. Has everybody got one, in your country?"

"Most people."

"Children?"

"Once they are old enough to be late."

"Late for what?"

"For whatever they are going to. Lessons. Work. Each other."

He pushed the wool into a bell with his thumb and shook it, and it gave a dull clank with no ring left in it. "Why does anybody need the hour that close? The day's got a middle. Everybody knows where it is."

"So that two people can be in the same place at the same time, and neither of them stands there waiting."

"They could meet at dawn."

"Not everybody is awake at dawn."

"I am."

"The rich," I said. "And people who work all night, and sleep in the day."

He watched the rain on the cobbles. "Who keeps the door, while they sleep?"

"A lock does. In my country every door has its own."

He was on his feet then, and the bells were in my lap, the lot of them, and he took the last of the rain on his back to the stable.

After the girth came a headstall with a cheekpiece sewn on by somebody who had never seen one sewn, and a packsaddle pad whose straw had gone to powder; I emptied it on the dung heap and Felix stuffed it again, elbow-deep, from the barley straw in the loft, complaining throughout.

Valens was taking the string to Kirrha without Felix one morning, and Felix took it hard. He stationed himself in the shed door to take it hard in front of me.

"There's boxing at the gymnasium before the god sits. A Thessalian, and a man from Elateia who killed somebody at Thebes, they say, with his fists, with one blow. Everybody's going. Kallia's lodgers are going. Can I go? I'll have the stalls done before noon."

Valens had come into the shed for a pad off the trestle.

"The yard's yours till I'm back."

"It costs you nothing. I'll walk there and back, I'll be here before the string is. I'd go a round with the Thessalian myself, if they'd let me in the ring. Have you ever seen a man killed with one blow?"

"No."

"You've never seen anything." Felix took himself off to fork out the stalls, and forked them so hard that the dog left the yard.

Valens left for the string with the pad under his arm.

The black came back lame that evening, at the tail of the string, nodding at every other step, her head going up hard each time the near forefoot came down. Valens tied the others and had Felix trot her the length of the yard and back. He watched, and said, "Again," and the boy ran her up and back once more.

"Near fore," he said.

He laid his hand flat on her shoulder and ran it down the leg, slowly, to the fetlock, kept it there a while, and then took it on to the hoof. The hoof was hot; even from the shed I knew it, because she snatched the foot away from him and stamped, and threw her head up so that the whites of her eyes showed.

"Do you want the twitch?" Felix was already halfway to the shed. "I'll get the twitch. I'll hold her ear; nobody holds an ear better than me. Or the rope on her hind leg?"

Valens was watching the hoof, and Felix stopped short.

Valens left the foot alone. He stood at the black's shoulder, a hand on her neck under the mane, and talked to her. Very little of it reached me, and what did was the same few words over and over. It went on until Felix gave it up and perched on the trough. I had the headstall over my knees, and I put no stitch in it. At last the black shifted her weight off the sore foot of her own accord, to rest it, and as it left the cobbles his hand was under it, and he had it against his thigh, sole up, and she let him keep it.

"Lamp," he said.

Felix had it there, lit. Valens cleaned the sole with the point of his knife and searched it under the light, and found a black spot near the toe, a lentil's worth. He pared round it in slivers, and stopped whenever she shook, and went on when she stood. Once she brought her nose round to the back of his neck and blew there, and he let her. When the knife went in far enough a thread of gray matter welled from the sole, with a smell I could taste, and the mule held still on her three good legs and let it come.

"That's the bad in her, coming out?" Felix had the lamp up so close to the hoof that Valens put his wrist against it and moved it back. "All of it? She'll go to Kirrha tomorrow, won't she?"

"Not tomorrow."

"Bran," he said. "Hot."

Felix brought it in a bucket with a sack. Valens packed the hot bran into the sack, stood the foot in it, and bound the sack round the fetlock with a strip of rag, and the black waited with her foot in it and her head down, and he stood at her head.

"Why not the twitch?" I said, when Felix had gone for more bran.

"She'd remember it."

"She is a mule."

"That's why."

It was full night at Kallia's gate. She stood over the pot with the ladle, and gave me only the side of her face as I came past her.

"That yard's on your himation," she said. "Whose water washes it?"

"Mine. I will carry it."

"Is he paying you?"

"No."

The ladle made its circuit of the pot. “There’s women in this lane twenty years married who’d not do that much for a man for nothing.”

By morning a fresh sack was on the foot, and Felix was waiting in the gateway.

“He was up all night with her. There’s three sacks gone, and I never heard him once. Why won’t he let me? I know poultices. Did he say anything to you about me doing it?”

* * *

Praxias came down to the yard with his quail in his arm. He stood in the gateway until he had priced the place.

“Four,” he said. “For family, four, and the standing thrown in.”

Felix left his bucket and went to him.

“That’s the one? From behind the stadium, that blinded the Amphissan’s bird in one eye? The left, I heard. Did it fight again after, the Amphissan’s?”

“It did not,” said Praxias, who liked him at once.

“I have less than three now, Praxias,” I said. “And the god’s share comes out of that first.”

“The god sits every month now till the winter. Go to him next month, when you’ve four.” He shifted the bird to his other arm. “Three and a half, then. I’m robbing my own children.”

I told him no. Going out, he stopped at the trough.

“Mule-man,” he said. “That Syracusan of yours is a hard woman.”

He went off uphill, telling the quail about it.

Valens was at the trough with the black’s foot in a fresh bran sack.

“What did he want?” he said.

"To carry my question for four drachmas. And then for three and a half."

"He looked at the string. He looked at the house twice."

"You had your back to him the whole time he was in the gate."

"He turned uphill. Not to his own door."

"Perhaps his olives are uphill."

"Felix."

The boy was out of the gate and after him. Valens put the bran sack in the bucket, and walked to the back of the yard, where the wall gave onto the olive terraces and the goats had pulled a gap in it, and he looked at the gap for some time. Then he set two stones back into it that would not have kept out a hen.

Felix was back before the shadow of the spout had left the trough, out of breath and full of it.

"He went to the wine-seller under the plane tree, and he had a cup, and he told the wine-seller the Syracusan had haggled him down to nothing, and then he went to the ring back of the stadium, and he put two obols on the Amphissan's new bird against the baker's, and the baker's won, and he called the baker a thief, and the baker said—"

"Did he go up to the square?"

"The square? There's no quails in the square." Felix took a breath. "The baker feeds his bird on wine, everybody says so. Wine, to make it brave. Would it work on a mule?"

"He wanted my three drachmas," I said. "Only that."

"He's got a wall on my yard." Valens returned to the black's foot.

That evening he had two mules of split wood to take up to the priest's back gate, and we climbed to the town together with the mules in front. The pilgrims were all in by then. The ones who had found no roof had made fires on the terraces under the

olives, and their suppers were cooking, and a child was crying in Thessalian, which sounded much like crying in anything else.

"What happens on the god's birthday?" I said.

"Everybody comes."

"I meant after they have come."

"The priests go down to the spring to wash, in the dark. After the goat, the doors. Delphians in first, and the rest as the priests like."

"How do the priests like it?"

"Paid."

"Where would you stand, in all that?"

"Thessalians at the front. They push. Boeotians at the back, drunk by noon. Men off the islands selling figs nobody ought to buy. And men with nothing to sell, watching the line."

"Watching it for what?"

"Whatever's in it."

"You have been in yourself, surely. Or sent a question in by somebody else."

He answered neither. "Why not?" I said.

"I don't want anything he's got."

"Suppose he has nothing for me."

"You've lost a goat." The mules had stopped to look at a fire, and he whistled them on. "What are you asking him?"

"That is between me and the god."

At the edge of the town he took the priest's lane with his wood, without anything more, and I went on to Kallia's alone.

In the morning the yard gate was shut and barred, and I had to call over it. Felix let me in and dropped the bar back into its sockets, and did not like it.

"Who's coming? The Amphissan, about his bird? We've never had it barred in the day, not since I came. Is it you?"

"Leave it barred," Valens said from the stable.

"The Amphissan, though?"

Valens took the string out an hour late that morning, by the back way over the goats' gap and the olive terraces, and was back by the same road at noon.

"You came in by the olives," I said, when he brought the string into the yard.

"The road's dusty."

The olive path was twice the distance and too narrow for one loaded mule to pass another, and all week he had used the road.

Felix spent the afternoon climbing the gate to look over it, and calling down what he saw. "Nobody. A cart of oil. Some Thessalians, lost. Nobody. I can see clear to the bend from up here, and past it if I stand."

I had been writing my question on a sherd. In the evenings under Kallia's stair I scratched it into a piece of broken jar with a nail, and at noon in the shed I had it out of my belt and turned the words round, and scraped half of them off with the edge of the awl, and scratched them in again. Kallia's obol for the papyrus was knotted in with the remains of the priest's money; I had never gone up to the priest's house to buy the sheet, and her son's line was still unwritten, and every evening I scratched at my own instead. *The door that let me in is shut. Where is another?* It was the best I had, and that noon I left it on the bench, face up, while I took the mended girth across the yard.

Valens was in the shed on my return, and the sherd was as I had left it.

"Take out the door," he said.

"What?"

"The priests will ask what door. Whose door, and where it is, and what you were doing going in by it, and they'll write that down too." His eyes stayed off the sherd. "Ask for a road. A road they'll answer."

"You read it."

"It was on the bench."

"You said you heard the board read out."

"I did hear it."

He went to the trough. On the back of the sherd I scratched it again, slowly, with the nail: *Where is my road home?* It was shorter, and it said less, and a priest would have nothing to ask me about it except where home was.

Felix put his head in at the window hole.

"What's that, writing? A curse? Who's it on? Can you write me? Big?"

On the shelf lay another piece of the same jar, no wider than my hand. I scratched his name on it in capitals, the way they cut them on the stones in the sanctuary: .

He was in at the door to look, and carried it to the window two-handed, and stuck his head straight back out of the window hole.

"Valens! She's written me! Come and see what I look like!"

Valens came as far as the shed door with the bran bucket.

"Read me," Felix said, and pushed the sherd at him. "Go on, then. Say me out loud."

"How would I know what it says?" said Valens. He let Felix have it back and took the bran to the black.

I kept quiet, and Felix brought his questions to me instead.

"He can't. Nobody in this yard can but you. Is that one me, with its arms on its hips? Will it wash off, if it rains?" He tipped it toward the door. "Nobody at Kirrha's got his name written down. The Cilician called me Boy from Side to Kirrha. Has he told you about the Cilician? He bought me off him on the quay at Kirrha. He paid more for me than he paid for the black, and she's four years old and sound, or she was. The Cilician laughed and said nobody had ever paid him so much for a boy with a cough. You'd

think he hit the Cilician. He never. He just looked at him, and the Cilician gave him a drachma back. You've seen how he looks at people." He returned the sherd to me, and took it back again to look. "The name's his. Felix. It's lucky, in Latin. He talks to the mules in Latin, did you know that?"

"I knew that."

"He said I could go wherever I liked, and I said where, and he said wherever I liked, and I came here." He laid the sherd face up on the bench, his name to the light. "Can I keep it? The dog's never seen a name."

"Did he take you to the priests," I said, "and have it cut on the wall?"

"What wall?" he said, and went out with his sherd to show the dog.

* * *

On the last evening of the week I finished the breastband, in the shed, by the lamp. Its felt lining had matted to the hardness of a hat brim and rubbed a bare place on the gray's chest that I had found and the gray had not forgiven me for finding. I had cut the old lining away and sewn in a new one of fleece, wool side in. Valens had come in with the black's halter, and he stayed, with a foot up on the bench, to put a new lace in his boot.

"Is that the last of it?" he said.

"The last."

"That's the heap gone, then."

"Felix says you freed him on the quay at Kirrha," I said.

"Yes."

"Before whom?"

"The Cilician. Somebody selling eels."

"There is no paper."

"No."

"Who is to say he is free, then?"

"He can say it."

"And if somebody takes him? If somebody says he is a runaway?"

He was a while silent.

"Paper gets taken off you," he said.

"Who took yours?"

He ran the lace on up the shin and tucked the end in.

I had the last two stitches to put in, where the breastband joined the saddle strap. I put one in and drew it up, and the second wanted pulling hard against something.

"Hold this end," I said. "Hard."

His fist closed on the end of the strap. I drew the last stitch through and pulled both threads tight against his grip and knotted them, and cut them off with his knife, which was lying on the bench, and lifted my head, and his face was there.

The lamp was on its nail behind me; it lit him and left me in the dark. The nick in his eyebrow showed. He came nearer, and my face lifted to meet his.

Short of it by the width of a finger, he stopped, and stepped back. The shed was small, and the one step put his shoulders in among the girths hanging on the wall behind him.

I sat down. The packsaddle had been on its trestle at my back, and I was on it, with the cut ends of the thread still pinched in my hand. Everything in me that had been held up came down, and I was hungry. I wanted bread, and whatever Kallia had in the pot, and I wanted it now.

He took the lamp down from its nail and looked at the wick, and pinched off the char with his fingers, and hung it back up. He was out in the yard next, and out there, where he must have taken himself to be unwatched, he stretched, both arms straight

up over his head, until something in his back went with a crack I heard from the packsaddle.

I went out after him.

The yard was blue with dusk, and the string was in its row, eating. Felix was in the end stall with the black. He had sat down in the straw to do something, by the look of him, and the something had not got done: he was asleep, with his back to the stall's wall and his head fallen sideways against her belly, mouth ajar, and the sack he had been sent to change still in his fist. The black stood over him. All week she had swung her rump at him, and kicked his bucket over every evening, and stood on his foot whenever he gave her the chance. Now she was standing square on all four feet, the bad one as well, which she had not done since it went lame, because to take her weight off it she would have had to shift, and he was asleep against her.

Valens stood and looked at the two of them. He went in beside the boy and eased the sack out of his hand without hurry, and the black let him, and he came out again without waking either of them.

"He's been up since before it was light," he said.

"Will you wake him?"

"He'll wake when he's cold."

"Who's your Delphian?" he said.

"Nobody. I cannot meet Praxias's price."

"Praxias lost two obols on the Amphissan's bird. He'll stand at the door for a drachma, if his name's said out loud."

"Who told you what Praxias lost?"

"Felix."

"At the door. Inside, though?"

"I'll take it in. The day he first sits this year. His birthday, the priests say."

"The priest will write your name down. You told me so yourself."

I waited for him to tell me why.

"Why?" I said.

"What name does the priest write?"

"The clerk wrote Maira."

"And you?"

"Mara."

He had it, and he kept it.

"Which one does the priest get?"

"The clerk's."

"The goat," he said.

"The goat-seller in the square wants more for his she-goat than I have."

"He prices for pilgrims. At Kirrha there's a man brings them over from Aigion on the boats, at half his price, and he lets you pick your own out of the pen."

"How does a goat get from Kirrha up to Delphi?"

"On its feet. Felix goes in front with a fist of barley, and it follows the barley."

He went to bar the gate, and the dog got up off its side of the gutter and went with him.

"We take the string to Kirrha for oil the day after tomorrow, at daybreak," he said. "Bring your drachmas, and wear something you can walk back up in behind a goat."

Chapter 12

The Kirrha Road

"Lupus? By the Twins, it is. Lupus, walking behind mules."

The man had been gaining on us since the bend, two others at his heels, and now he was at Valens's left side as though he had been asked. He was short and sunburned, and the dust of the plain was on the hem of his cloak. He had a pleasant, creased face, and he looked at Valens the way a man looked at a horse he had once had money on.

"You want somebody else." Valens kept walking.

"Do I? Show me your right hand, then."

The hand stayed at Valens's side.

"Corinth. The year the emperor was in Greece. You had a Gaul on his back in the sand in front of the whole colony, and the emperor rose in his box to see it finished. I was on the benches. I had two drachmas on the Gaul." He laughed. "I've forgiven you."

He kept pace beside us with his hands behind his back. "These two never saw you fight. I told them about it the whole crossing. I said, you'll know him by his hand. There's not another hand like it in Achaea." His glance dropped to it, and rose again to Valens's face, and he was still smiling. "And here's the hand."

My own hand was inside my himation, on the camera strap.

Ahead of us the string went on between the terrace walls, six mules with their jars of oil packed in straw. At the front of it Felix held his fist out behind him as he walked, and the goat came after the fist with her neck stretched for the barley in it.

"Go on up to the boy," Valens said to me.

One of the other two had come round on my side. He was big, and he carried a stick of olive wood, and he had no eyes for me. He was watching the back of Valens's right hand.

"My brother's a butcher," he said. "He's got two like that."

I heard the third one behind us. His sandals on the stones.

"And good day to you, lady," the first man said across Valens, to me. The third one laughed, low, at nothing.

"*Rudiarius*." The first man took Valens by the arm.

Valens stopped.

The man's other hand came from under his cloak with a knife in it.

I saw the knife. I saw Valens's hand shut on the wrist above it.

The mule behind us flung her head up and hung back against her rope. Something in her load cracked. Oil came down her flank.

The stick went past my ear. It came down across Valens's shoulders. He went forward into the man with the knife, and the two of them pitched off the edge of the road together, into the ditch below the terrace.

The ditch hid them. I heard them.

My himation came tight across my throat from behind. I was pulled back against somebody. Wine. Sweat.

"Be still, mistress. Be good."

"Mara."

From the ditch. Something struck stone down there, twice.

The strap was round my neck under my clothes. My hand was on it. I dragged at it, and the camera came clear of my clothes, and I twisted round in his grip and swung it at his head.

It caught him above the ear. I felt it in my wrist.

He let go. He walked into the wall, and slid down it.

I had the camera up again by its strap. Nobody came at me.

The cap was off. It went rolling along the road on its rim, small and black, wobbling and righting itself over the ruts with the white letters on its face going under and coming up again, past the mule's back hooves, past the big man's feet, until it met the edge of the oil and tipped over in it, face up.

In the olives a bird was saying the same three notes.

In the ditch somebody was breathing hard, and then nobody was.

The big man was at the edge of the ditch with his stick up.

Valens climbed out with the stick coming down at him. It landed on his forearm, and he kept coming, and the big man dropped it and ran. He went scrambling up the bank among the trees. The one I had hit pushed himself off the stones and went after him, holding his head together in his two hands.

The stick lay in the road. Valens stood over it. There was a knife in his hand, and it was not his own.

I wound the strap round the camera. I wound until there was no strap left, and held the camera against me with both arms.

Somewhere above us the goat was crying. Felix came running back down past the mules with his fist open and nothing in it.

At the road's edge he stopped dead, over the ditch, and looked.

One of the man's feet showed past the lip of the ditch. It was a good sandal, new, with the thong tied in a bow across the foot. The foot was turned out.

Felix went to the wall. He was sick against it, neatly, propped on one arm against the stones. He dragged a forearm across his mouth. Under the dust his face had no color in it at all.

"Who gets his knife?" he said.

Valens came past him to me.

"Are you cut?"

"No."

He looked for blood on me regardless. Then he dropped into the ditch. I saw his back, and his arm working at something low down, and when he shifted his weight I saw the man's face past him, turned up the bank, toward me. It was still a pleasant face. When Valens climbed back up he had a purse on a cut thong. He had left the man everything else.

"Get the string on to the ford," he said to Felix. "Water them. Keep the goat out of the stream."

Felix went.

Valens went to the mule with the cracked jar. Oil still ran from the straw. I went to her head without being told and held her by the headstall while she rolled her eye at me, and he cut the ropes on that side, and the jar came off into his arms, and he heaved it over the terrace edge, down among the olives. The mule stood with her hind legs braced and her ears flat. He laid a palm on her neck beside mine and ran it back along her flank where the jar had broken, and picked a sliver of pot out of the hair there and threw it after the man.

"Somebody will come by," I said.

"This is the god's road." He was looking up the slope into the olives. "Let the god's people find him."

"They will think it was robbers."

"That's what it was. A traveler with his purse cut."

Far down toward the sea, where the olives ended, a smudge of dust was moving, and in the dust a donkey, and people walking at a donkey's pace, coming our way.

"Now," he said, and slapped the hindmost mule on, and she went stiff-legged after the others.

I could not make myself look toward the ditch again, and did not try. I went past where the cap lay in the oil, its letters dark with it, and kept going.

The thong of my left sandal had pulled out of its toe-hole, and the sole slapped the stones each time it landed. The oil had got onto that one. The smell of it rose off my foot, thick and sweet, and my feet carried me on through it, one slapping and one not.

Valens came behind me with the last mule.

The camera was still in my arms.

Before the bend, the noise of water.

* * *

The ford was where a stream came down out of a cleft in the hill and crossed the road under stepping stones. Plane trees grew along it with their buds just broken. Felix had the string in the shallows below the stones, and the goat tied to the last packsaddle, up on the dry, and he was not saying anything to any of them.

Valens climbed the cleft by a goat path, and I followed.

Higher up the cleft the stream poured over a chest-high lip of rock and fell in a rope into a clear pool over pale gravel.

He untied the pouch from his belt and put it into my hands. Through the leather the watch was going.

He held his hands in the fall.

The water broke on them in spray. There was blood over the backs of them, the dead man's, gone brown already, and the

water took the top of it and ran pink down his forearms into the pool. He turned his hands over in the fall. He turned them again.

They were shaking.

It started in his shoulders and ran out along his arms, and the water jumped off his fingers with it. He tried to work the blood from round his nails with his thumb, and the thumb kept slipping off the nail. He gave that up and held his hands still under the water, and they would not be still.

He was breathing through his mouth. He shifted round on the stones to put his shoulder between me and the hands, and I saw them anyway.

I let the camera hang on its strap, and put the pouch inside my himation, and waded in. It was snow water, and my feet stopped belonging to me. I took his wrists, one in each hand, and pressed them flat to the stone beside the fall, so that it poured over my hands as well as his.

The shaking went into my arms. Under my right palm his old scar was a raised line, and I could feel in it the marks where each stitch had gone in. I held on. The shaking outlasted anything I had thought a body could do, and I held on through all of it, with the cold climbing my legs and water in my sleeves, and I did not speak.

It stopped by degrees.

He let his forehead come to rest on my hair. He stayed there.

When he lifted his head, I took my hands away. His stayed flat on the stone. He took them down himself. There was a graze along his cheekbone with grit in it. I had missed it on the road, and he plainly knew nothing about it.

I had trodden on a clump of flat leaves at the edge of the pool, and they smelled green and sharp under my heel. “Onions,” Valens said. “They hung them under the eaves. In strings, to dry.”

He drew the stranger's knife from his belt and washed it in the falling water, running his thumb along the groove to clear it.

I climbed out and sat on a rock with my feet in the sun.

The camera hung against the front of my himation. I looked it over. Somebody's hair was wound into the little crank on top, a few dark curls of it, and a smear lay on the top plate that had been wet and was not any longer. I worked the hair out with a thumbnail and wiped the smear away with the hem of my chiton. The ring at the front of the lens had taken the blow and was pushed in at one point. In the finder the plane trees stood upright and in focus.

I had carried it since the lodgers came. All week men had slept along Kallia's gallery in rows, Thessalians and Achaeans and a priest's cousin from Elateia, and my duffel lay below the stairs among their bundles, and I had heard strangers turn over in the dark a yard from it. The camera was the thing in that bag a thief would take first, and the thing I could least explain to anybody who took it, so each morning it went under my chiton on its strap and rode there till night, knocking me whenever I hoisted water. Its cap was still in the oil by the ditch, where I meant it to stay.

"Is it broken?" he said, still facing the rock.

"Only the rim is bent."

He stripped his cloak off. One side of it was stiff and dark. He held it out to me behind him.

I took it into the pool and pushed it under where the water fell, and worked the dark side against itself with a handful of gravel from the bottom. Cold water. Hot would have set it.

"They gave me the wooden sword at Corinth," he said.

He was washing his forearms. Across the left one a welt stood up where the stick had caught it, red and raised, and the knuckles of that hand were split.

"He had the year right, the one on the road. The emperor wanted the Greeks to see a proper fight, so they gave him one. I'd been in that sand five years by then. When there was somebody to impress, they put me up."

He did the backs of his hands.

"The Gaul was older than me, and slow on his left side. Nobody on the benches knew that. The emperor never got out of his chair. I put the Gaul down, and he sent the sword out to me across the sand, and a magistrate wrote my name in his book. The lanista had a copy made for me on a tablet. I kept it in a box."

Down at the ford Felix was telling the mules something, and the goat was answering him.

"After the sword I needed work. Celer was legate then, on the proconsul's staff. He wanted a man to walk behind his wife, one that people would know from the sand and stand back from. Plautia. I swore to her in his atrium, in front of his household gods."

The water off the cloak went pink and then went clear. It was good wool, fulled hard, darned at the hem with green thread.

"Two years I walked behind her. To the baths. To her mother's house. Out to Kenchreai, to the Egyptian goddess, on her days. When he was away I slept across her door. Nobody laid a hand on her in two years. I was a good bodyguard. That was the use of me."

He sat on the lip of the pool with his boots in it.

"By then the emperor had given the Greeks their freedom, and Celer's post had gone with it. He'd stayed on at Corinth with nothing to be legate of. He had debts. He'd bought a house he couldn't pay for, out where the cypresses are. The year of all the emperors, in the summer, he had me called to the atrium at night and said I'd been in her bed. He was sorry about it. He said so, more than once, with her standing there. She didn't look at me.

Two of his house slaves said they'd seen it. One was the girl who did her hair, and she cried all through it. They'd been shown where to stand."

I held the cloak down in the fall, and the water went through it.

"Put a wife away for that, and you keep a share of what she brought. Her father had given plenty with her. They flogged me in his courtyard, by the fishpond, where the house could watch. While they were at it, his steward went through my box and took the tablet."

The cold had my feet again.

"After that Celer said the sword was nothing. His story was that he'd bought me from the lanista the month before the games, so the lanista had no right to free me, and the magistrate had written down a mistake. So I was his. A slave who'd been in his wife's bed. The magistrate's book is still in the record office at Corinth, with my name in it." He moved one foot in the water. "I was over his garden wall the same night. A fisherman took me across the gulf for my belt buckle. I carried on the Kirrha quay that winter. They asked my name and I gave them Valens. The mules came after, off a Corinthian dealer who couldn't feed them till spring."

"Her brother took her home," he said. "Celer kept the boy."

I wrung the cloak out. It took both hands, twisting against each other, and a long pour of water ran out of it and splashed round my feet. I shook it and spread it on a rock in the sun.

He was watching me do it.

"Last autumn a freedman of her brother's found me at the harbor," he said. "I was loading. The brother's gone to law for her dowry. He wanted me to come and stand up and tell the court it was a lie. I said I wouldn't. He'll have told them where he found

me. Inside the month that notice went up in Corinth. You saw the month on it."

"Yes."

"I saw it too."

"I read it twice," I said.

"And still came to the yard."

"My question wanted carrying."

"There was Praxias."

"Praxias wanted half a drachma over three."

"Five hundred for me walking," he said. "Whoever wants five hundred brings a rope. Those three brought none. He doesn't want me back. He wants me in a ditch."

He reached for his cloak. It was still wet through. He put it on anyway.

"He had you by the cloak."

I felt for it. The skin was raised in a line across the front of my throat where the edge of the wool had dragged, and it stung.

"It is only the wool," I said.

He was first down the goat path to the ford.

* * *

The string had drunk and was standing in the shallows, nosing at the plane roots. Felix sat on the bank with the goat's head in his lap. He had found a crust somewhere and was giving it to her a crumb at a time, and she was letting him.

Felix had chosen her at Kirrha that morning. The Aigion man kept his goats in a pen of hurdles at the root of the mole, where the first boats of the year were tied up with the new pitch still soft on their seams; the goats had crossed the gulf in one and were not yet sure of the ground. Felix was in among them before anybody could stop him. He came back holding a brown she-goat

with a white blaze by the horns, the one that had put her head into his stomach, while she tried to do it again.

"This one," he said. "She's got a temper. The god likes a temper."

The Aigion dealer told Valens his price. Valens left it to me, and I paid it myself, out of my rag into the man's palm, and the rag was thin after it. We had eaten first, sprats a woman was frying at the mole and selling in twists of fig leaf, and Valens had paid her for all three, and Felix had eaten his own and half of mine and talked through both. A boat from Lechaion had come in on the morning wind and was unloading at the mole's end. Valens had stood on the quay the whole while with his back to it and his eyes on the pen, while the oil men brought his jars along the mole and argued with him about the straw.

At the edge of the ford I washed the oil off my foot, and pushed the thong of the sandal back up through its hole with a twig, and knotted it underneath, double, to hold at least as far as the top of the hill.

Felix had seen the camera. It hung outside my clothes now, against the front of the himation, where I had forgotten it.

"What's that? Is it silver? I saw one of them go off through the olives holding on to his head. You hit him with it?"

"It was my father's," I said, and it went back inside my clothes.

Valens had left the string for the bank. Felix had the water skin off the last saddle; he drank, and spat, and drank again.

"It was that crust," he said. "It was off."

"Don't give the goat any more of it," Valens said. "If anybody in the town asks, we came on a man in the ditch below the ford, and the road had been at him before us."

Felix lowered the skin. "I could say I saw them run. Two of them, into the olives, and I chased them with a stone, and the tall

one had a sword, and I hit him over the head and he dropped it." His voice was coming back. "I could have the sword."

"You came on a man in a ditch."

"That's nothing to tell."

"Tell it anyway."

Valens chose a stone from the bank, near a jar's weight, and roped it opposite the single one on the mule that had lost hers.

At the stepping stones I gave him back his pouch. He put the purse in my hand.

I opened the purse. There was silver in it, Roman denarii, some so new that Vespasian's heavy face had hardly been rubbed, and Corinthian bronze underneath. What the goat had left in my rag would not have bought the god his cake. This would, with plenty over.

"It is more than the god wants," I said.

Valens was down the string, checking girths. "Keep what he doesn't," he said.

I untied my rag and tipped the dead man's silver in with the little that was mine, and knotted it again. Apollo had been taking money from men with blood on them since Orestes, and had never been known to send any back. I let the empty purse go in the stream. It sank among the stones, and the current took the thong out straight behind it.

The walkers reached the ford while it was sinking: a gray-bearded man leading the donkey, two women behind with baskets on their heads, and a boy. He let the donkey drink, standing in the water beside her, and considered the mules, and us.

"There's a dead one below," he said. "In the ditch, past the terrace. Somebody's had his purse."

Felix was on the bank with the goat by the horns.

"We came on him," Felix said. "His purse was cut. We came on him and came on up, because of the oil."

His chin was up, and he spoke it to the graybeard's face, and the graybeard took it as it was given.

"It's been like this since the freedom. Robbers off every boat." His glance went to Valens. "You've been in the thorns."

"There's thorn all along this road," Valens said.

The younger of the women had set her basket down and was telling the other about the sandals on him, how new they were, what a shame. My rag hung at my belt with his silver in it. I kept a palm over the knot.

"My son's run back to Kirrha for the headman and a cart," the graybeard said. "Somebody ought to sit with him till they come, and it won't be me." He clicked the donkey on over the stones. The women took up their baskets and followed, and last the boy, looking back at the goat.

"He believed me," Felix said, when they were round the bend above. He sounded surprised.

"He'd settled on robbers back on the road," Valens said.

The goat would not go.

She had found the barley he dropped in the road and eaten every grain of it while we were busy. She stood at the foot of the climb with her head low. Felix pulled. She lay down.

"She's doing it on purpose," he said. "Is she? Is she ill? Are goats sick when they see a dead man?"

"She is full," I said.

He looked at her, and at the road climbing away above us, and then he got his arms under her and stood up with her across his shoulders, her forelegs in one fist and her hind legs in the other, as the shepherds carried them on the mountain. She blinked and let him.

"I'm calling her Spicula." His voice came from under her. "After the murmillo. The one the emperor gave a house to."

"She is the god's," I said.

"The god won't mind what she's called."

The goat was heavy and he carried it. With her across his neck he looked like the Calf-Bearer in the museum on the Acropolis, if the Calf-Bearer had been twelve and in a temper. For the first part of the climb he asked nothing whatever, which in my hearing he had never managed before. At a hairpin under a wild fig he waited for me, red in the face under her.

"Did you see him do it?"

"I heard it."

"Quick, though?"

"I was watching something else."

His look said I had cheated him. He took the goat on up to where the string had stopped to blow, and waited there for Valens, and put the question to him instead, straight.

"Did he go down straight off?"

"No."

Felix went on in front with the goat.

Above the ford the road took the hill in bends, stony, between walls. Overhead the two great cliffs over Delphi had the sun full on them and had gone tawny. Traders came down from the town against us, going to sleep at Kirrha for the boats, and others were coming up behind, and each of them said good evening and got good evening back. A man with a tray of lamps on his head asked whether he would reach Kirrha by nightfall.

"If you don't stop," Valens told him.

He walked at the tail. Twice I glanced back, and he was walking half turned about, watching where we had come from.

At the next bend I stood aside for the string until he came up.

"You need not take it in," I said. "The question. There are other days. Next month would do as well."

"Three days," he said.

"They will be there. Those two, or others."

"A knife in the precinct would have a hundred men on it. They'll want me on a road, not in a crowd." He shoved the tail mule over by the rump. "The goat comes to the yard the evening before."

We walked on. "When it's over, the mules are for the high grazing," he said. "Above the cave. Up there you see a man coming a whole morning off. I'll stay up the summer."

The sherd with my question on it was in my belt, against the knot of the rag. Its edge found me as I walked.

"Kallia will hear at the spring tomorrow that a man is dead below the ford," I said.

"She hears what the donkey man heard."

"I am not telling Kallia a story. She gets the whole of it from me, or nothing."

"Kallia, then. Nobody else."

It was three days to the seventh of Bysios.

Ahead, Felix had stopped at the turn of the road to shift the goat on his shoulders. She was asleep. Her head hung beside his ear with the eyes shut, and her jaw kept moving.

Valens was at the outside of the bend, where the wall was low. He was looking down. I joined him at the wall.

The whole plain lay under us, bare and darkening, from the foot of the hills to the shore. Out past it the gulf still held some light, and the boats were in at Kirrha with their sails furled. The road ran white over the flat to the first of the terrace walls. I knew the spot by the turn of the wall below the olives.

A cart had stopped beside the ditch.

Chapter 13

The Seventh of Bysios

The morning on which Apollo would first answer anybody that year came in under a frost so hard that Kallia's jars rang on the paving at the spring, and the water from the lion-head spouts smoked in the dark. The priests were higher up, at the rock basin, and they were more noise than shape: water slapped onto bare skin, a man praying through his teeth, and another man telling him the god had heard enough and to get his tunic on before he froze in it, while a torch went along above them and stopped. Down at the lions it was Kallia and me, and the cold, and the long noise of the water.

I had not had her to myself in three days. All that week the house had been full to the eaves. Thessalians slept in the court in their cloaks with their feet to the ashes, an Achaean snored a yard from my mat, and every hour of daylight had somebody in it who wanted bread, or hot water, or the way to the stadium. The donkey man's story had reached Kallia the morning following, through this spout: a stranger robbed and dead under the terraces, and Valens's string come on him with the oil. She had heard it out, and kept it to herself, and gone on with the pots.

I held the first jar to the spout, and while it filled I told her the rest.

I told it in the order it had been given to me. The man on the road who had known Valens from the sand; the knife; the ditch. What I had done with the thing of my father's that I carried inside my chiton, which I called only that, a heavy thing from my bag. Then the fall in the cleft, and what Valens had told me standing in it, from the sword they had sent out to him on the sand at Corinth to the painted notice by our colonnade, as near his words as I could keep them; they were plain words, and they kept. I left out his hands, which were his.

Kallia filled her own jar at the lion beside mine while I talked. Halfway through it a Thessalian came yawning down to the basin with a jug, and I stopped; Kallia sent him to the far trough with four words, and I went on when the dark had him again. At the man's death she spat, quickly, into the fold of her dress at the breast, and kept her eyes on the water and listened. At the notice she said, "Five hundred," very low, and at the wife she shifted her jar along the step with her foot. When I had come to the end of it she put the pad on her head.

"The girl that dressed the wife's hair," she said. "What became of her?"

"He did not say."

"Sold on, or sent out to his farm." She swung the jar onto the pad and found its balance one-handed. "A girl who's said that sort of thing in an atrium doesn't stay in the house after to do the hair. Bring him to the court after; the Thessalians will be up at the sanctuary till dark, and there's a pot of lentils wants eating."

I got my own jar up and went after her. The lane was still black, and the frost on every wall-top had caught what little gray there was in the sky, so that we walked home between two white lines.

"The floors will keep," she said, at our own gate. "Go up once it's day. Be home ahead of the Thessalians, or you'll be on the stair half the night with their dinners."

By the time the sun was on the cliffs the Sacred Way was solid with men.

They went up between the treasuries with wreaths of laurel on their heads, the leaves still green and the wool hanging down behind in white tails, each with his question learned by heart or folded in his belt, and an animal or a cake to go with it. A Thessalian family had a black ram that would not climb, and three sons pushing it. A man off one of the islands was selling dried figs by the handful from a basket on his hip and swearing to each new face that they were Chian. Under the Way the almonds on the terraces were all in full flower now, white, every tree together, and the smell reached the road thin and bitter, like the inside of a stone.

The women stood along the lower edge of the terrace below the temple, where the rods had put them. I found a place on the wall from which the altar and the steps were both in view, and kept well away from either.

While the terrace was still in shadow two priests brought a woman up the ramp between them. She was old, and veiled to the eyes in white wool, with a sprig of laurel in her hand. They had her by the elbows, a man to each arm, and went at the pace of her slowest foot. At the foot of the temple they halted on every step while she brought her second foot up beside the first. The crowd on the ramp made a lane for them unasked.

"That's her," a woman along the wall said to her neighbor. "She'll be going down now."

The doors took the three of them in.

The light crept down the cliff face while I waited, a gold edge sliding toward us over the gray. It found the temple roof first,

then the gilt shields along the front, shield by shield, so that they lit in a row like windows down a street at dusk; last of all it reached the columns and the altar, where a priest was already feeding the fire with split pine, and the first smoke went straight up in the still air until a draft from the gorge found it and laid it over toward the theater.

Felix pushed out of the press at the ramp with the goat on her rope. She had been at the yard since sundown yesterday, as Valens had said she would be, and Felix had walked her up while it was dark behind a handful of barley; now she had a fillet of white wool tied between her horns, which he had bought for her at the foot of the Way with an obol of his own. He had washed his face for the god and missed his neck.

"That's him," he said, before he had even reached the wall. "Over there, with the Thessalians. The one from Elateia, with the ears, look at his ears. He knocked a man down at the gymnasium yesterday that had a head like a jar, and the man didn't get up till they threw a bucket on him. Would he show me his hands, do you think, if I asked him? After?"

The Elateian wore his laurel on top of ears like two folded pancakes, and was praying very hard over a cake.

"After," I said.

The cakes were sold at a stall below the altar, honey and meal, each pressed flat and stamped, on trays with a laurel leaf burned into the wood of the rim, and the stall-keeper sucking his fingers between sales. Valens stood below the altar steps with Praxias and a cake. He had a wreath on too, and the leaves sat on his cropped head like something another man had put there while he slept. The scrape on his cheekbone had crusted brown. On his left forearm, where the olive stick had landed, the welt had spread into a bruise that was purple at its heart and yellow toward the elbow, and that hand's knuckles had scabbed over, all

four. He held his shoulders carefully, all of a piece, and when he wanted to see behind him he brought his whole body round, hips and all.

Praxias had left his quail at home, but his left arm kept the crook of it anyway; now and then his fingers went over nothing there, smoothing.

I paid him first, at the wall, out of the rag, in coins from the ford, into his hand. He weighed the silver in his palm and found it enough. He glanced at what the road had done to Valens, and back at the coins, which were plainly the only part of the morning that concerned him.

"Even money she stands like a post," he told me, of the goat. "They do, in a frost. A frost-morning goat will take a spring's worth on her head and think about her dinner."

"If she does?"

"Next month. And then you pay again, Syracusan," he said, and liked the sound of that.

I had the Advil in my belt, down to its last two. Before Valens could follow him up the steps I tipped both into my palm where my himation hid them, and offered them low between us, where nobody else could see what they were.

"For the shoulders," I said. "Take them with water, and inside an hour you could turn your head without your hips."

He did not touch the two small white things in my palm.

"After," he said. "I want my head, in there."

I put them back in the bottle. He was watching the crowd past my shoulder while I did it: the ramp, the steps, the faces at the wall.

"Have you seen them?" I said.

"Not yet." His eyes went on to the wall's end. "If you see the one you hit, send the boy to me in the line. Stay among the women."

"And the boy?"

"The boy does as he's told."

The altar was the great one the Chians had paid for, dark stone with a lip of white marble along it, gone brown with old fat where the fire was. The priest at it was a thin man with his himation pinned high on one shoulder. A boy stood by him with a bronze jug beaded with cold. Felix led the goat up, and Valens had the rope from him on the last step. The priest spoke to the god in a voice the noise of the terrace took away, tipped the jug, and let a thin stream run down between her horns and over her face.

She stood. Water dripped from her ears and her beard, and she shut her eyes against it.

He poured again, along her neck this time. One ear flicked. That was all.

The women round me had stopped talking. Below the steps Praxias was telling the nearest man that he had said so.

The priest spoke short to the boy, and the boy went at a run. He came back under a full jar, from wherever they kept the water, and the priest lifted it off his shoulder and emptied the whole of it along her back, from the fillet to the tail, in one long cold sheet.

She shook. It began in her hooves and climbed through all four legs and went through her body to the end of her tail, and her whole hide jumped with it, and the water flew off her onto Valens and the priest and the boy. The priest told the terrace in a loud voice that the god was receiving, as if somebody might want to argue the point.

It was the most comforting thing I had seen in Delphi. The god could be helped along. It took a jar.

The priest's knife was quick, and Valens kept his grip on the horns until it was over. Felix stood at the side of the altar and watched all of it, the cut and the blood going into the dish and

the boy beginning on the skin, in silence. Later he was over among the Thessalians by the Elateian, studying his hands.

Valens went with Praxias into the line of wreathed men at the foot of the temple ramp, and the line closed behind them.

* * *

He told it in Kallia's court, well on in the afternoon, with a bowl of her lentils going cold on his knee.

For once the court was empty, the lodgers all still up at the sanctuary, eating their sacrifices or arguing over what they had been given, and the house had gone quiet, after a week of being loud, with the lodgers' blankets hung airing on the gallery in the sun. Kallia had put him on the stool by the woodstack with the wall at his back and set the bowl in his hands, and returned to the lean-to, from which she could hear every word.

Felix had the bottom step of the stair, and I had the hearthstone.

"Praxias called his name at the door," Valens said. "Praxias son of Kleon, of Delphi, for the house of Kallia. He gave it out twice, the second for the Thessalians' benefit."

"They wrote it down?"

"A priest at a table wrote it. Beard cut square." He ate a spoonful of the lentils. "He put his nose a hand from mine to make me out. He was slow about it, and he knew the face."

"He puts his nose that close to everything," I said. "He could not find the join on his own grandfather's incense stand with a lamp held to it."

"Euthydikos," Kallia said, inside the lean-to.

"He asked was it the mender. The Syracusan of Kallia's who did the stand." Valens scraped at the bowl. "I told him yes. He said it over as he wrote: Maira, of Syracuse, of the house of Kallia,

a kinswoman. He asked the carrier's name after that, and I gave him Felix."

"Me? In the god's book?" He was up. "In the priest's own writing? Where did he put me, under her? Under Praxias? Was it wax he wrote it on, or the other, the—"

"Wax," Valens said.

"What did it look like?"

"Small."

Felix stood with that. He sat down again on the stair, slowly for him, and asked nothing more. His ears had gone red to the tips.

"There's writing on the wall in the porch," Valens said. "Big. Men stop at it and move their lips."

"What's it for?" said Felix.

"Know yourself," I said. "And another. Nothing too much."

Felix waited for the rest of it. "That's all? On a god's house? My mother could have told them that." He stopped, surprised at himself, and scowled at the pomegranate.

"After the writing, the doors," Valens said. "Inside it's dark. You come in out of the sun and for a while there's nothing; there's the smoke. They burn laurel on a hearth in there, and barley on top of the laurel, and it gets in your eyes. The floor slopes to the back, not much, but a man with bad feet would feel it. It's polished in a path where they walk, and on the right-hand side the stone's darker, where men have stood to wait."

"Darker with what?" I said.

"Their feet." He set the bowl on the stones by his foot. "There's one door. I looked for another. There's a bench along that side, and a man with a rod at either end. You sit on it and wait your turn, and nobody looks at anybody. There was a Boeotian next to me wouldn't stop praying. There's a chair by the

wall too, iron, old, that nobody sits in. The Boeotian went to sit in it while he waited, and the rods moved him."

I knew what that chair was. A poet had sat in it to sing for the god, five hundred years ago, and they had kept it for him ever since against his return, and the poet had been a Boeotian.

"Was he angry?" I said.

"He said a chair was a chair."

"Nothing else? In the whole room?"

"Smoke. Men."

"The stone," I said. "Rounded on top, about so high, carved over with a kind of net. It must be in there."

"There's a stone."

"What was it like?"

"Stone color," he said. "It had wool on it, tied over in a net, and it came to my waist. Somebody had hung a wreath on it. A man was posted beside it watching the bench from start to finish, and I didn't care for him, so I watched him." The bowl by his foot was empty. "He had a cough."

I would have given a year of my life for ten minutes in that room with a lamp, and the most famous stone in the world had reached me as a man with a cough standing next to it. On the stair, Felix would have liked to hear more about the cough.

"Where was the woman?" I said.

"At the back there's a step down, and a screen in front of it, wood, with a cloth over. She's down there where nobody sees her. They call you off the bench, and you stand at the screen, on the spot they give you, and the priest stands between you and it, sideways, so he can watch both. He reads the question off the wax, at the screen, in an ordinary voice. When he got to Syracuse the Boeotian stopped praying to say ask a ship. After that you wait."

"For how long?"

"The Boeotian started up again at my back. He'd had his already: a boundary stone his brother moved. The god told him to plant olives down the boundary and let the trees argue it." He was facing the wall across the court. "She talked, in the end, from down under the floor, a woman, not loud. It went on a while, and then it broke off partway, and stayed broken off. The men on the bench started to look at each other. Then it went on again, quicker, and stopped for good."

"What did she sound like?"

"Hoarse. Higher than I'd have put her." He thought. "Tired."

"Did you hear her own words, or only the voice?"

"Some. Not to keep." He touched the crust on his cheekbone, found it there, and took his hand away. "There was a word in it I didn't know, not Greek, and she gave it twice, slower at the end."

"What word?"

"I didn't keep it. It wasn't in what he gave me."

"Try."

"It's gone," Valens said.

"Surely the priest heard it."

"He had his hand up as long as she talked." Valens lifted his scarred hand, flat, the palm out toward the woodstack, about level with his ear, and held it so. "Like that, to the screen. When she finished he put it down and turned to me and said it."

"In her words."

"In his. Hers were fewer; that much was plain. He listened to all of hers, and after it he gave me his. At the end he asked had I anything to put to the god on my own account, while I was at the screen, seeing the goat had shaken."

"Had you?"

"I told him the goat was hers."

"Did anybody stop you, coming out?"

"Praxias, in the porch. He wanted it for the quail ring; there's men there lay money on what the god tells strangers, and a Syracusan's worth something to them. I told him it was hers."

* * *

Outside, the morning went on without him.

The line at the foot of the ramp moved by fits, and in between not at all, and those who had stood in it since first light began on the corners of their cakes. Delphians had gone in first. After them a man with a rod appeared on the ramp and called the next lot from the head of it by their city, and the men of that city rose off the steps where they had been sitting, all together, and gathered up their cakes and their questions and went, and the rest shifted along. The rod came out again and called Phocians. Valens and Praxias were well behind the Phocians, behind Achaeans and Locrians and a whole ship of Coans who had paid to go ahead of somebody.

The women talked about their questions, having no other use for them until the men came out. Next to me a woman from Amphissa had sent her husband in about a well. "North of the house, or south," she told us. "South is where his mother planted her fig."

"North," her other neighbor said. "Always north. The south dries out."

"He'll put it so the god says south," she said. "To spite me. You'll see." She turned to me. "And yours? What's yours about?"

"A road."

"Roads are easy," she said, comforted on my account. "He likes a road. Which is yours, in the line?"

"The tall one. With the bruise on his face."

She found him and gave him some thought. "Is he yours?"

"He is carrying for me."

"I said that about mine," she said, "and look where it got me."

My feet were cold and the wall was cold and I stayed on it. I let myself have it then, for the length of the line. A road: a cleft behind the mountain, a cave I had missed, a day in the summer when the shut rock would breathe. I would go through it the way I had gone in, crawling, in the dark, and come out into cold air off the plateau with a road below it that had a white line painted down its middle, and there would be the bus, and a phone in the café at Delphi that took a card. In my apartment the heat would be off, and I would turn it on and stand over the vent in the hall in my socks until it ran warm, and eat whatever was in the freezer, standing, with a fork.

Toward midday the slave who shelled beans on the stool by Euthydikos's bay tree came along below the wall, looking up into each woman's face in turn, and stopped below mine.

"You're Kallia's," he said. "The mender."

"Yes."

"The bowl wants doing when the god's finished for the year. The one with the lead in it. You're to come up when you're sent for." He had a look at me, and at the women round me, who were all listening. "You'll be sent for."

"The lead has held it this long," I said. "Another year will do it no harm."

He went on to wherever his errand took him next. It was a season's work, if I wanted it, cutting the smith's lead out of that bowl without marking the bronze, and I wanted none of it. Before the bowl's turn came I meant to be gone.

Below where we stood a man had a board of clay ears on a trestle, for anybody who wanted the god to hear him better: little pink ears with a hole at the top for hanging, all of them from a single mold. They were all left ears. I checked the board twice over to be sure, and there was not a right ear on it, and somebody

had given each one a dab of red paint inside, and I was asking myself whether he had lost the right-hand mold or never owned one, or whether there was some reason a god should only care to be spoken to on the left, when Felix vaulted the wall beside me.

He went straight between the women and down the bank and into the crowd at the foot of the ramp. I saw what he had seen a breath after he did: a man standing among the Phocians with a strip of linen wound about his head, covering an ear, and a dark stain on the linen.

I scrambled down the bank behind him.

When I reached them Felix had hold of the man's cloak. He was a head taller than Felix and very young, a boy with his first beard, and he stared down at Felix with his jaw hanging. The stain on the linen was wine.

"Fell off his donkey," said the friend beside him, delighted, with an arm round his neck. "Riding in from the plain. Drunk as a Boeotian, and singing."

"I'm a Phocian," said the one in the linen, and one of the rods came along to see what the noise was, and Felix dropped the cloak and was at my side before it arrived, admiring the sky.

"I took him for the one you hit," he said, as we made for the wall again. "I'd have had him."

"Blood goes brown when it dries," I said.

"I never said about your father's silver thing," he said. "To anybody. The Elateian asked me yesterday at the gymnasium what the man was hit with. He'd heard about the man at the ford. A stone, I told him." He was quiet for three steps. "It wasn't a stone, was it?"

"It was heavy," I said.

Felix vanished again before long, and returned with his right hand held stiff before him like something borrowed.

"He let me," he said. "The Elateian. Feel. No, feel there, on the knuckles; that's from Thebes, that knuckle killed the man. It's harder than wood." He held it away from his side until we had our places on the terrace again. "He said I'm too thin. He said come back when I've eaten."

My neighbor's husband came out and walked straight past her to the men he had climbed with. He told them first, all three; they laughed and clapped him on the back, and afterward he came over to the wall and told her it was to be south. She heard him out.

"North, then," she said to me, when he had rejoined his friends. "I'll dig it at night, and tell him the god changed his mind."

Valens came out past noon, alone. Praxias had gone off up past the theater toward the stadium and the quail ring with his wreath still on. Valens came under the terrace with his wreath in his hand. At the wall he searched the women's faces, and the men's behind them, and came to a stand before me.

"Well?" I said.

"Not here."

"Is it bad?"

"At Kallia's." He had gone on down the Way, and I went after him with Felix at my heels.

"He goes like this when a mule dies," Felix told me, low, at the second hairpin.

"Has one died?"

"Not this year. Not that he's told me."

Valens was silent the length of the Way, past the treasuries and the bronze bull and the stalls at the gate, and the farther we went in silence, the surer I was of what it was. If the god had given me a road, a breath on the terrace would have held it. A road could be said in front of anybody. What wanted a roof and a

wall round it was the other answer: that there was no road; the hole I had come in by was the only one and it was shut; that I was a Syracusan now, and the god had looked at the registrar's tablet and agreed with it.

By the lions I had it settled. I was almost calm.

* * *

When he had told that much, he got to his feet.

He had not been asked to stand. Out in the center of the court, beyond the shade of the gallery, he set his feet apart under him with his weight on both of them evenly and his hands open at his sides, and fixed on the wall above the woodstack. The words came in one breath, with the stops in them where the priest must have put them, in a voice that was new to me.

"The road home lies under the mountain of vines by the western sea, where the dead go out of the city, at the door painted on a dead man's house."

He stood on a little longer, listening for more, and when there was none he sat again.

The hair had stood up along both my arms under the wool, to the shoulder, and it would not lie down again. Over the woodstack the wall was bare but for a lizard, flat in the sun with its toes splayed.

It scanned. Most of it went in the measure of Homer, the long line, and the last part hung off the end of it like a suitcase roped onto the roof of a car that was already full. The priest was in it as plainly as the god.

"Somebody was paid to paint that door." Kallia had not come out from her pot. "Somebody's sons paid him, and argued the price."

"That's the whole of it," said Valens. "That's how he gave it."

"Didn't the priest say more?" Felix said, on the stair. "You were in there two men's turns."

"After, he said she was a Syracusan, wasn't she, it was on the wax, so it was plain enough. Her own mountain, he said. The one that burns behind her city, with the vines up its sides. He said that was a fine answer for a Syracusan and I was to tell her so. I'm telling you."

The priest had read Syracuse off his own wax and found my mountain for me, the one that smoked behind my invented home, and the god had very kindly agreed with the clerk and Kallia and the whole of the lie. Except that Etna stood above the eastern sea, the one Syracuse looked out on, and the god, in the priest's verse, had said west. The priest held a lamp to things in full sun, and I did not suppose he had ever looked at a map.

"Did the priest give you anything about when?" I said. "A month, a year. Anything."

"No."

"West of what? West of here? Everything is west of here."

"Is your country west?" Valens said.

"Very far west. Farther than any of this."

"Where do they put the dead, there?"

"In fields," I said. "With fences round them, and the grass kept short, and a stone with the name on it for each. In the towns, some of them, among the houses."

"Inside the walls?"

"There are no walls."

"Where does the town stop, then?"

"Where a board by the road says it does," I said.

"Italy's west," said Felix, who had left the stair. "What if it's Italy? They've the schools at Capua in Italy, the big ones, a sailor at Kirrha says, with the iron gate, and the fighters eat meat every

day and they've a doctor all to themselves. They take boys if they're quick. If it's Italy, can I come?"

Valens rose and took his bowl to the lean-to, and put it in Kallia's hands.

"The string's had no water since daybreak," he told Felix, on his way back.

Felix looked from him to me and back, and went. He went backward as far as the gate, and from the gate he ran.

Kallia scraped at the pot. "The boats go west at the new moon."

I had seen a tomb's painted door once, or a photograph of one, thrown six feet wide in our kitchen one September night, when my father had his carousel out and a bedsheet tacked across the china for a screen: the rear wall of a chamber at Tarquinia, cut into the soft rock under a hill, with a false door on the plaster in dark red, shut, and a mourner at each side of it, palm to his forehead. He had clicked the carousel round to Volterra while my question about what lay behind it was half out, and the fan in the projector had gone on breathing out its smell of hot dust in the dark room. "Every road out of every town in Italy has tombs along it," I said. "That is where they bury, outside the gate, beside the road out, so that anyone going anywhere goes past the dead. Tombs with their doors painted on. In Etruria they painted whole rooms under the hills, and doors on the back walls of the rooms, and Etruria is by a western sea, with vines on its hills." I heard myself and kept on. "Or Sicily after all, or Massalia, or Spain. There is a mountain with vines on it beside every sea the Romans have ever reached. It is not an address. It is a description of the empire."

"It's what he said."

"I know it is."

"Then it's something."

"It is a riddle," I said. "A riddle is nothing. I might walk ten years with it and find a plaster door every other mile."

He had his eyes on me, the bruised side of his face to the sun.

"You'll try the cave again," he said.

"Tomorrow."

"It's shut."

"I want to see it shut for myself."

The court was quiet.

"Only the mountain part," I said. "Say just that piece again, from its beginning."

He began, and broke off. He began over at the very first word, and came forward through it at the same pace, every stop in its old place, as far as the sea; there he stopped himself, and his hand lifted an inch from his knee, the way you would check a man walking beside you.

"You cannot start it in the middle," I said.

"A trainer at the school called the forms. Eight or ten cuts at a breath, in a string, and you answered him with a practice blade of wood, cut for cut, in his order, out in the sun. Get one wrong and you started again from the first. You don't go in at the fourth. I can't take it from the sea onward. I'd have to start at the beginning."

"Do not," I told him. "It is in my head."

It was. I had it word for word, first to last, in his voice and in the priest's measure, and it was as much use to me as a bus ticket with the town torn off.

"Why his name?" I said. "At the table."

That took him a while, or whether to answer it did. "The boy wanted it written down somewhere."

"Yours?"

"Mine's written. At Corinth."

Kallia left the lean-to with the pot on her hip and the sand in her other hand, and stood over him.

"You'll not go down that road tonight," she said.

"The string, though."

"The boy can sleep with the string. He'd sooner. You'll sleep here."

"Your house is full to the roof."

"There's floor," said Kallia, and took the pot to the jar to scour it.

* * *

The jug boy was at the gate while Kallia was still scouring the pot.

I knew him for the boy from the altar, who had run for the jar. The front of his white tunic was dark with spilled water, and he had a cloth-covered basket hooked over one arm; he stopped at the gatepost. He took in Valens on the stool and Kallia at the jar, and saved his longest look for me.

"The Syracusan," he said. "The woman that asked about a road. Theano wants her."

"Who is Theano?" I said.

"The god's woman," said Kallia. "Up the street, almost to the end of it. She'll have you carry her water up while you're there. She does that."

The boy shifted the basket on his arm. "Now. She said now, before her knees set."

Valens stood.

"Her by herself," he told Valens, and the rest came fast, to Valens and not to me. I caught "no men" in it, and "muleteer", and something about the crows.

"She'll not eat her," Kallia told Valens.

Valens did not sit down again. He left the court before we did and halted at the corner where the lane met the street. There he

set his shoulders to the wall with the whole climb of the street in front of him, to the head of the town and every gate along it; he was standing so, still, when the boy and I came by him on our way to the top.

"The house with the crows on it," he said as I passed, watching the street above. "Just under the top."

Supposing she wanted money, I climbed. Most things in that town did, and the god's woman would want more than most, for something the god had already said. The street was empty of men, who were all still at the sanctuary or asleep after it, and the women had thrown their doors open to the sun, so that I climbed past a row of rooms laid open like cupboards: a woman carding wool on her step, a girl plucking a hen into a basket, an old fellow asleep upright against a wine jar with his chin on his chest and a kitten in his lap. The boy walked in the middle of the street, well clear of the eaves. Every so often he lifted a corner of the cloth to make sure of whatever was under it.

"Forty-one jars," he told me. "Since the dark. Spring to altar and back, and the jug besides. Your goat took a jug and a jar. Most take the one jug." He hitched the basket higher. "The Thessalians' ram took two jars, and then it ran."

"Did the god receive it?"

"He received it after they caught it."

It was the house next to the highest. I knew it before the boy stopped. A squared stone was set at the door, cut by some mason long ago and gone round at the corners with being sat on, and along the ridge of the roof above it a dozen crows waited in a row, hunched against the cold, beaks to the wind.

She was on the stone, old, in a dark himation that had been good once, with a farmer's hands, square, the nails broken short, and a face the sun had burned brown and crumpled under the

eyes. Under the hem her feet were bare on the stone, broad, cracked at the heels, feet that had walked behind a plow.

"Give it here," she said to the boy, and he gave her the basket and was off downhill, glad to. She took the cloth off, and it was barley, the parched kind. A laurel leaf was burned into the rim of the basket, small and brown.

She flung a fistful over the ruts, and the crows dropped from the ridge in a black slither.

"Look at that," she said. "Robbers. The minute a woman sits down." Another fistful. "Get off, you, you've had yours. You're the Syracusan."

"Yes."

"Syracusan," said Theano, as flat as a price for a lame ewe, and left it at that. "Sit down; my neck won't go back that far. Not there. That's the cat's." She waited until I was on her doorstep, below her, and went on slowly, taking her breath where she could get it. "Seven steps down into that hole, and seven to climb again, and the priests stand about at the top with their hands in their sleeves, chattering of the god's breath, and not a man of them will carry a stool down after me. They've stools; they've a stool for the square beard, so he can sit and scratch at his wax. I asked them for one at the vintage. They said they'd put it to the council. The council! For a stool! And meanwhile down I go on these and up I come on these, all morning, with a goat's worth of waiting at the top before every one. My husband dragged this stone here for me before he died, so I'd have somewhere to sit outside my own house, and it's the best thing he ever did, and he did it with two oxen and a lever and a deal of cursing, and he'd have carried a stool down a hole for me, he would, and held my arm on the steps." She pressed her knees with the heels of her hands. "Listen to them. You can hear them from there, can't you?"

I could not hear them.

"Which is worse for them," I said, "the steps down or the steps up?"

"Down," said Theano, to the crows. "Up, I can lean on the wall. Fourteen years I've had that god, since my husband went. He's no worse than any man you work for: he wants you there before it's light, and he's never satisfied with the goat, and he takes the credit. When I started there were three of us to take turns, and my turn came one month in three, and between turns I was home milking. Now there's only me, every month he sits, and nobody milks, and the ewes are my sister's son's, and he sells the cheese at the stadium and keeps the price of it."

Behind her the door stood open on one room, swept, with a loom against the end wall and a half-woven blanket on it, brown and white in stripes, and a cat on the hearth asleep in the warm ash with its paws tucked under it. Nothing in it was the god's.

The bottle had ridden in my belt all day. I shook the two pills out of it and held them up to her where she sat on her husband's stone.

"What's that?"

"For the knees. They take the ache down, for half a day. Swallow them whole, with water, and do not chew them."

She looked at them, and took them off my palm with two fingers. A cup stood at the stone's foot. She put both pills in her mouth at once, drank from the cup and swallowed, wiped her mouth on the back of her wrist, and threw another fistful of barley at the crows.

"That's my own barley," she said. "Off my own field, below the stadium. I wouldn't give them a grain of his."

"Why give them any?"

"Because they come." She shook the last husks off her fingers. "They were up on that ridge the day my husband went out of this

door feet first, the whole row of them, and not a crow of them made a sound, which the mourners never managed. A thing that'll sit quiet at a burying can have my barley."

The brand on the basket was by her foot. I left it there.

"That big one that stood up for you," she said. "At the screen. You hear them from down there, every man of them, shifting about over your head like a mule in a stall, scraping, changing feet, and there was a Boeotian this morning prayed the length of my talking. Yours stood. I'd have said nobody was there, except the floor gave when he stepped to it. The rest of them, I can tell you what they ate before they came."

"He is careful where he stands," I said.

"They put a mountain in it," said Theano. "And a sea, and a painted tomb, and something to tap your foot to. They always do; whatever I bring up from down there, they take it and put shoes on it. He said it short and he said it plain. Nobody pays to travel down from Thessaly for short and plain."

"My carrier heard a word in it that was not Greek. Twice, he told me. You gave it twice."

"Not Greek, so not the god's, says the square beard. The smoke talking, or the woman down the hole. The god's been everywhere; he gets about more than they do."

"What was it he said? Down there, before they dressed it."

"That's not what you climbed my street for."

"You sent for me," I said. "Why?"

"Because my knees hurt," said Theano, "and I wanted to tell somebody who hadn't heard it. Ask."

It was in my mouth already, the thing I had wanted since the rock shut on me, and all morning at the wall on the terrace it had sat there, behind the road.

"When?" I said. "On which day is it open? The road."

“That’s not mine to give you.” She dusted her palms together. “Or it was never given me. Which of those it is, is mine to know.”

“I can pay. There is silver.”

“Keep your silver. Whatever’s paid on this hill goes to the priests, and I get the steps.”

“Was there a day in it? Was there one, and they cut it?”

“You’ve had your answer to that,” said Theano, watching the crows. “Ask the other.”

I had one question left.

“Which city?”

Theano shifted on the stone, and grunted with it. “Pompeii.”

Chapter 14

What Pompeii Means

I knew the year. It came to me on Theano's doorstep, before her mouth had quite closed on the name, and it came whole. Seventy-nine, late in the summer, in August. Behind it the god's verse lay down flat and pointed one way. The mountain with the vines on it was that mountain. Its sea to the west was the bay under it. The dead of that town left it by its gates, like any town's, and lay along the roads outside. A crow walked over my foot looking for barley that was gone. Theano told it to get off, and it stayed, and she let it.

She had nothing more for me. She had me carry her water instead.

Inside her door, beside the loom, her big jar stood empty, with a small one turned upside down on its mouth. The fountain was where the street turned below her house, a lion's head in a wall with moss under its lip. I held the jar under the spout until it was full. I kept on holding it. The water came over the rim and ran down my wrists into my sleeves and on down my ribs, very cold. A woman with a jug of her own waited at my back till her patience gave, and told me the whole street was thirsty, not only Syracuse. I got the jar up onto my head on a rag ring and took it uphill past the open doors. The jar was heavy and I got it up there

and she said nothing of it at all. She was indoors already. I tipped it into her big jar; the cat opened one eye at me. I left, and the crows were back on the ridge.

On the corner Valens was still leaning on the same wall. He pushed himself upright when he saw me.

"She kept you."

"Theano's jar was empty."

He gave the crows' house above us one look. He came along on the house side, half a step behind. From the turn above Kallia's lane the sanctuary showed beneath, the god's roof with the sun going off it. I wanted to throw something at it, and my hands were empty.

At Kallia's the Thessalians had come home with their share of the sacrifice wrapped in cabbage leaves. They were roasting it in the court and arguing over whose fault the ram had been. Kallia asked me nothing. She put an end of bread in my hand and the scrapings of the pot in a bowl, and I ate on the end of the woodpile while the Thessalians argued. It all went down. I finished the bowl and wiped it round with the bread.

* * *

Valens was asleep across the door of the storeroom.

Kallia had laid his blanket there herself, crosswise on the threshold, between my mat and the court. He had lain down on it in his cloak, facing out. He slept on his side, the bruised arm uppermost. His breathing was slow and even, and very quiet for so large a man. Beyond him the court was crowded with Thessalians. One of them talked in his sleep, a long grievance with a girl's name in the middle of it. Kallia's oil jars stood round my mat, and the barley sack, and the smell of both.

I had the whole town from above, the way a plan in a book had shown it to me. It was a lopsided oval on a spur of old lava,

walled. The forum lay long and narrow at the west end, and one straight street ran east from it nearly to the far gate. An Italian in the 1850s had cut the place into regions and blocks and doors and numbered every one, like sherds in a tray. I had known the best houses by those numbers before I had any other name for them. The rest went by the names the diggers had given them: the House of the Faun, for a bronze faun in its pool; the House of the Tragic Poet, for a mosaic of actors.

What anybody in that town called a single street was beyond me.

There were the tombs. A famous row stood beyond the gate toward Herculaneum, with stone benches round to sit on; every postcard showed it. More lay along the road toward Nuceria, and odd ones elsewhere. I tried for most of an hour to call up a doorway done in paint on any of them, and got only the benches.

* * *

Behind my mat the wall was mud brick under a skin of lime plaster. It was thin in places and never floated smooth. In the dark my fingertips found the ridges the trowel had left, and a stalk of straw standing out of the surface, and a patch beside the jamb where it had come loose and been pressed back with something softer.

In April of 1979 some of the casts had crossed the Atlantic. My mother took me up on the train to see them on a Saturday. I was fourteen, with a head cold and a book report due on the Monday. They had been laid out in a long, dim gallery on platforms behind a rope. A man lay on his side with his knees up. His tunic had rucked at the hip, and the folds of it stood out in the plaster. One sandal had pressed its laces into his instep. Near me a woman in a fur hat told her husband she had thought they would be bigger.

Further along, a dog lay twisted on its back with its legs in the air and its collar still on.

We stayed until a guard came through ringing a hand bell. In the station my mother bought me a pretzel from a cart. I ate half of it and carried the other half in its paper as far as Trenton.

Kallia's plaster was cold. I took my fingers from it, and some while later they were back on the patch by the jamb.

* * *

The day was in two letters, as much of it as one man set down for Tacitus nearly thirty years afterward. I had put both into English once, for a Latin examination, with a dictionary at my elbow. The mountain opened at midday. Stones fell on the far shore all that afternoon and all night. Roofs went in under them. In the morning came the thing the letters had no good word for. Their writer had been seventeen that summer, across the bay, reading Livy, by his own account, and making notes. He was a boy of nine now, somewhere in the north of Italy, at his lessons.

It was the year seventy-one, by a count nobody here used, and the spring was only started. From here to that August was eight years and a little over.

I lay with my face to the roof beams. The god had not said when. Theano would not say whether he had. The cave had opened for me on one afternoon in May, at one minute of it, and not since. A door that opened when it pleased could open on any day in eight years. This summer would do. For all anybody could tell me, it stood open tonight, on a road of tombs in the dark, with nothing going past it but a dog.

* * *

The bay had a Greek town on it. Neapolis. Halloran had rung me from there in March, sitting on the bare floor of a flat he was

leaving. He had offered me my father's bed in the house the survey rented, a room with a window in it, for the season.

I had said Greece, perhaps.

My father went to the past every summer of my childhood. He came home lean and dark, with his boots in a grocery bag and his head still full of somebody else's century. Every year it was going to be next year, and then next year there was never a spare bed. His last permit had been for Campania. I had signed it over to Halloran in April.

And the god of Greece had heard my question out, with a gladiator standing for me at the screen, and found me a place in Campania after all. He had outranked Halloran. He had picked the town.

The laugh was loud, the loudest I had made in that house in all my months there. It went straight out past Valens and over the court. A Thessalian stopped snoring. I put my wrist across my mouth and it came round the sides anyway, in bits, high, with a squeak in the top of it that I had never heard myself make. My eyes stayed dry. The muscles under my ribs hurt. It stopped some while after the funny part had gone out of it.

* * *

On his blanket Valens was up on one elbow. He had moved in silence.

The knife from the road was out of his belt and lying back along his forearm, point to the elbow. He was facing the court and the gate and the black beneath the gallery. He spoke under the sound of the Thessalians' breathing.

"Was that you?"

He left the knife where it was.

It was there. It had been there all evening, the word, behind my teeth, with everything that came after it. He had carried the

god's half of it out of the temple himself, and risen under Kallia's gallery and said it all to me without a syllable out of place, and he had no more idea what it was than the cat on Theano's hearth.

"A woman on the terrace this morning," I said. "Her husband went in to ask the god where to dig a well. The god said south. She means to dig it where he was told not to, in the dark, and let him think the god thought better of it."

The knife went back into his belt.

"The moon's down by midnight," he said. "She'll dig it crooked."

He lay down again, facing out, and pulled the cloak up over his ear. He slept almost at once. One of the Thessalians said the girl's name again and was quiet.

My hand crossed the dark between us. It hung above his shoulder with the warmth of him coming up into my palm from under the cloak. One word, and he would be awake again. He would ask where it was and how far, and whether the road was good, and how the ground lay round it, and none of it would be the question. I drew the hand in.

I said the word once with no sound in it, toward the jars. To everybody under that roof it was a town in Italy where they made fish sauce.

* * *

Some hours on, I needed the pot by the water jars.

There was no way out of the storeroom but over Valens. I gathered the chiton up in one hand and went across him in a single long step, and he slept on, or let me think he did.

The court was cold and smelled of the god's mutton. Overhead the stars were thicker than Philadelphia had ever let me see them. The cliffs blacked out half the sky. Somebody had a lamp lit by the drain in the far corner. It was the father of the

family that had pushed the ram up the Way. He was a big man with a black beard. He sat on his heels, his youngest son's head on his thigh. The boy was being sick into the drain, steadily; he had been at it since dark. Kallia was over them with a cup. She gave me the lamp to hold and went for salt.

The boy drank the salt water and was sick with it again. Kallia filled the cup again.

"It was the ram," the father told me across the boy's back. "From Larisa it never wanted to come. Every mile, it told us."

"He ate the fat off the god's share. His own and his brothers'," Kallia said.

The boy had nothing left in him at last, and the father carried him back to the cloaks. Kallia emptied the cup into the drain and took back the lamp.

"What did Theano want with you?"

"She wanted somebody to hear about her stool," I said.

"One of those priests could carry it down for her," Kallia said. "It isn't their knees."

She went into her room and was back with her own blanket on her arm. It was brown, with a burn at a corner where a coal had caught it. She dropped it over Valens's feet and went back in and shut her door.

I stayed out in the court until the cold was in my soles. I climbed over Valens again and got under my blanket.

* * *

I made the plan while my feet warmed.

The silver off the dead stranger was in my rag. It was more money than I had held in that country. It was still short of a sea crossing and a year's keep at the other end. Euthydikos's bowl would make up the difference. I had told his slave the bowl could keep another year. It could wait for the god to close his doors for

the winter, and I could wait with it, and cut the old lead out of the bronze a hair at a time, and be paid.

Silver was the easy part. In Delphi I had needed a man to stand at a door for me before Apollo would hear a word I said. A ship's master at Kirrha would want the same, and a landlord in Italy, and any magistrate. A husband or a brother; failing those, an owner. The one man I had was asleep within reach of my hand with a price on him in Corinth. His own freedom was a line in a book in a record office there. All he wanted in the world was a high pasture and nobody coming up it. I left him out of the plan. He kept being in it.

Whoever took me to that town, the plan left him there. Felix had asked that afternoon whether he could come, if it was Italy. It was Italy. The plan had no boy in it, and I kept it so. Eight years was plenty of time, I told myself. Men went where the work was. A muleteer went wherever mules were wanted, and that was everywhere.

The sailing season closed with the autumn and opened again in spring. The boats going west at the next new moon were for people who had the fare and a man. Next spring, then. Saint Paul had made the crossing ten or eleven years before, in chains. His grain ship went aground on Malta, and another Alexandrian that had wintered there brought him in to Puteoli with the spring. If the grain ships would carry a prisoner, they might carry a woman with a man's name in front of hers. From Puteoli it was the coast road round the bay to a town I had never stood in and could have drawn blindfold. Out through one of its gates to the tombs and along them, looking for a door that was only paint, and through it on whatever day it chose, years ahead of the mountain.

A year to get there. Seven, after that, to watch a door in. It was more time than I had been given for anything in my life. A town that size had lamps that broke and bronze that cracked. I could

join a thing so the join never showed, and a mender who could do that would eat while she watched.

It was a good plan. I said it over once more, bowl to door.

* * *

That left the cave. There was no need of it now, if the god meant what Theano had made him mean. I lay and argued it both ways. The last time I had been up there, the crack had given me back my own arm, cold. That was all it had given, and a spring morning was unlikely to have changed its mind. If it had, there was no need of Italy at all. That door went home with no sea in the way, and no town.

I wanted it shut. Before I crossed a sea away from that cave I wanted to stand in it in daylight, with my fingers on the crack, and feel nothing come through. After that the one door left in the world would be the door the plan ended at, and I could stop listening for the other.

I meant to go up as soon as it was light, with Valens and the mules if he would come, and alone if he would rather sleep.

* * *

Long before the gray, the half moon had dropped behind the western hills, and the court was black to the walls. I watched Parnassus's eastern shoulder until the sky there began to pale, and somewhere after that I slept.

I woke to an empty doorway. Kallia's blanket lay on the threshold, folded in four. The fire was lit under the pot. The ashes had been carried out and the hearth brushed, which was my work, and the two water jars stood full beside the wood, sweating. Kallia stood at the gate, ready to lift the bar.

"He's gone down for the mules," she said. "You're to wait for him at the bottom of the climb. There's bread in the cloth."

She took the bar down and let me into the lane. Above the end of it the two cliffs were coming clear of the night, gray at their feet first and then, very slowly, a paler gray along the rim, with the path to the plateau scratched up the rock in its short turns and nobody on it yet.

Chapter 15

Summer Pasture

Bells came ahead of the light, the herdsman's ewes moving about the hollow's farther end in the dark and cropping as they went, so that their bells sounded in no order at all, one, then three together, then a long space of nothing; behind the bells came the cold, which on that flank of Parnassus rose from the turf at the end of every night however hot the day before had been; and behind the cold came the thyme, crushed under my own feet as I picked my way past last night's fire to the edge of the grass, where the dew had soaked the straps of my sandals by the tenth step and grayed every stem as far down the hill as the eye went. The summit took the sun first and held it, gold, while everything under it was still blue.

The light worked down the long screes, finding the firs on the western ridge, then the hut, then a hump under a cloak in the lee of the woodstack that was Felix, who slept out every night from choice and had never yet been awake for this. Below the hut the string stood at its hobbles, cropping in a line with their backs to the cold. Valens was already among them, going down the line with a hand laid on each rump in turn; at the black he stopped to lift her near fore and look at it.

"Is it hot again?" I called down.

"Cool. She'll do the troughs." He let the foot go and went on.

We had been up on the grazing since the snow left the high ground. In the month after the consultation a stranger had sat most of a morning on the step at the lion spouts in Delphi, with a rag tied round his head under his hat and a Corinthian's way with his vowels, asking the women at the jars, "Which house keeps the tall foreigner, the one with something heavy and bright inside her clothes?" Kallia had answered him herself from under a brimming jar, with half the lane listening.

"Gone," she had said. "Gone to Kirrha at the turn of the month and onto a boat for home, the god go with her. She ate more than she carried, that one, and broke two of my jars."

That night Kallia packed my bag for me in the storeroom, folding each thing smaller than I would have folded it. "On the mountain you'll milk for your bread, or carry for it," she said. Before light I was at Valens's yard, and I kept to his loft for some weeks; on the evening the mules started up for the summer pasture I followed them in a carter's hood, walking behind the dun, which carried Valens's fig in its sawn-off jar, roped upright between two water skins and nodding at each step.

It was July now, by my own count, which nobody else on the mountain kept.

Below the edge of the grass the mountain fell away in long steps of rock and scrub to the plateau, which lay at the bottom of them as flat and pale as the lake bed it had once been. On its opposite edge, where it ended against a low brow of cliff, a patch of shade stayed where it was while the light moved; I had been inside it once since the consultation.

Valens came up below the cliffs on the morning that followed, with two mules and a bundle of split pine, and we climbed.

"Keep to the inside at the third turn," he said, at the second. "It's ice under the wet there." And at the top: "The snow's rotten in the hollows. Walk where it's gray."

The plateau was still half under snow, gray and sunk in the hollows, with water running beneath it everywhere, and all of it ticked and trickled. At the cave, melt was coming off the lip of rock above the entrance in a broken, glittering sheet; we passed under it with our heads down and were through with our shoulders soaked.

I had brought the flashlight, which all winter had lain in the deepest corner of my bag; that morning I had put it uppermost.

The snow at the mouth threw the daylight in behind us. Valens followed with a pine he had not troubled to light, and farther in, the dim gave out, and I dug in the bag for the flashlight and slid the switch forward.

The beam was yellower than it had been in May, and narrower, with a brown edge where the batteries had begun to tire. I shone it along the crack. The beam reached past the bend and stopped a yard beyond, on a face of gray stone that closed the crack from wall to wall. The stone sweated, and along its foot lay a crust of something pale and soft-looking, like old bread; on its face, in a clot the size of two fists, hung a crowd of daddy longlegs, all threads and joints, which began in the light to come apart, unhurriedly, one leg at a time.

"That is the end of it," I said. "It goes no further."

"Did it ever go on?"

"Once."

That was the whole of the crack: a yard of it past the bend, a wall, the spiders, and behind the wall the mountain going on into itself as far as the mountain went.

Valens's steps had halted when the beam showed; presently I heard them start again, and he arrived at my shoulder and

watched what the beam was lying on, the wet stone and the long legs moving over it, while I held it there, and he left the light to me.

It was shut, as I had wished it, and I switched the light off, and we stood together in the dark, and I waited. The melt had gone through my himation at the shoulders and lay cold down my spine. I began to shiver with it, slowly, from the middle outward, then hard enough that he heard my teeth.

"The lip's running hard," he said in the dark. "We want to be out under it before it's on us properly, and off the cliff while the sun's still on the turns, or they'll freeze under us."

On the way down he spoke of the path, and in Delphi of the mules; since then, four months, not a word about the light.

Below me now the shade under the cliff was going, and the plateau was gold from edge to edge. I left the grass and made my way down to the fold, where the herdsman, Mnason, sat with the pails.

The fold was a ring of thorn hurdles on the floor of the hollow, with one gap in it the width of a ewe. He sat at the gap on a slab of rock, in a goatskin cap with the ears still on it, and as the ewes came through he caught each by a hind leg and milked her from behind into a pail between his feet, her tail switching at his face and his face not caring; I had the stone opposite. In two months I had learned to do it badly and then less badly, to take the kicks on my forearm rather than in the pail, and to talk.

"Talk to her," Mnason had said over the gap on my first day there, and on every morning after. "Talk, and she lets down. Sing, if there's nothing in your head. It makes no odds what, so it isn't sad. Sad, she holds it back."

My ewes heard about whatever came into my head, in Greek, and took it no worse than his. The milk rang on the bottom of the

pail and then hissed into the froth, and the steam stood up off it in the chill.

"Not her." A ewe with a torn ear had come through on his side of the gap. "She kicked me at the shearing. You have her."

She kicked me too, once, on the forearm, and then let down for me as sweetly as any of them while I described a snowplow to her. "It is a wagon with a blade on its nose and no animal pulling, and in my city it goes up the streets all night pushing the snow into walls, so that in the morning every man has to dig out his own wagon."

When the last ewe had gone through, he poured both pails into the great pot outside his own hut and peered into it with his cap pushed back.

"That boy of yours sleeps through anything," he said. "A wolf could walk off with him, and your man would be up at those mules with his back to it. I've said so. Nobody listens to me up here but ewes." He wiped his knife on his thigh. "Wants turning."

He crossed the hollow toward our hut, where Valens's fig stood in its jar on the sunny side of the wall, inside a ring of stones built round it against the mules. Valens was there before him, with the string left to itself behind him.

"A twig," said Mnason. "Off the end, there, where it'll grow again. My mother turned her milk with fig, and hers did."

"Cut your own."

"There's no fig nearer than the gorge, and that's half a morning down and the whole of one back up."

"The gorge, then."

"One twig." He measured it for him, a finger's length, with his thumbnail. "You'd not miss it."

"It would."

The jar was between them. The tree was two hands taller than it had been in the yard below Delphi. It had put out broad

lobed leaves, and under the leaves a dozen figs, small as olives, green and hard and furred.

Mnason went to his own hut and fetched out a dried kid's stomach on a string.

"You had rennet in there from the start," I said.

He cut a piece of it into the milk and hung over the pot, and told me about it in a voice I had not heard him use to the ewes.

"My mother never did it so. Fig, she turned it with, every day she lived, and it set as sweet as a girl. This'll taste of kid. You'll put it in your mouth and taste the kid in it, and you'll know whose doing that was."

"He's had his eye on that tree," Valens said, once the old fellow was out of earshot, "since we got here."

"He wants to make cheese."

"He'll be over those stones some night."

"He is sixty if he is a day," I said, "and I have seen him walk into his own fold in the dark, looking for the gap."

Valens touched the figs in turn with a fingertip, lifting the leaves to come at them. Felix had drifted across from the woodstack with his cloak still round him and stood watching that, instead of going for the water skins.

"When are they ripe?"

"End of the summer."

"What's in them now? If I had one now, what would it do to me?"

"There's a milk in them while they're green. It takes the skin from your mouth."

"Does it? Did it yours? Would it take a mule's?"

"Eat one and find out." Valens left us for the mules.

* * *

At noon Felix drove the string down to the troughs under the plateau's rim, which was half a day's errand there and back, and Mnason lay down in the shade of his hurdles with his cap over his face, and the hollow belonged to the flies.

Valens was shaving, as was his habit every few days at midday, sitting on the woodstack with a bowl of water beside him and his knife, by feel, with no glass. He drew the blade up his throat against the grain in short scrapes, rinsed it, went over the place with the flat of his left hand, and moved on. I sat against the hut wall in its strip of shade with a sandal of Felix's that had lost its sole on the scree.

"He'll walk the next one off as well," Valens said, of the sandal.

"He goes down a scree as a goat would, if a goat were late for something and wore sandals," I said.

The sun stood straight overhead, hot enough that the thyme smelled from where it grew, with nobody treading on it.

"The light in the cave," he said, between strokes.

The flashlight lay on top of everything in my bag in the hut, where it had ridden since spring. I went in for it, and on my return he finished the stroke he was on, rinsed the blade and wiped both hands dry on his tunic before he would accept it. It was gray plastic, ridged along the barrel for the grip, with a switch that slid under the thumb, and it weighed about as much as a hen's egg. He held it a little off from his body, flat on his palm.

"Under your thumb," I said. "Push."

It lit, and in the noon sun it made nothing anyone could see; then he cupped his other palm over the front of it, and his fingers lit red along their edges, all of them, with the dark of the bones down their middles. The batteries were the kind with the pink rabbit on the packet, the one in sunglasses who went drumming

through other people's commercials and would not stop. He lifted the palm and laid it on again, and the red came and went in his hand.

"It's not warm," he said.

"It never is."

"What's in it, then?"

"Two tubes, with something shut up in them that makes the light out of itself, bit by bit, till there is none left."

"When it's used up?"

"At home you buy two more, in any shop, for less than a loaf. Here there are none to buy."

He found the switch again with his thumb and slid it back, and the red left his fingers.

"What's it for, there? In your country."

"For the dark. For finding the keyhole when you come home late, and the fuse box when the lights go out."

"Don't burn it, then," he said.

"I never came off any ship," I said.

"You'd no salt on you."

"Or out of Syracuse. Kallia made Syracuse."

"I know that too," he said. "You said a name on the cliff. In the snow, the day we went up. Philadelphia."

"That is my city."

"In Asia."

"Further than Asia. Further than anywhere you have heard of, and that is the smaller part of it." I had the flashlight in my lap. "Where I live, they count the years from the birth of a man in Judaea, and by their count the year I left was nineteen hundred and ninety-eight."

Half his face was shaved and half was not, and he turned the whole of it on me.

"Counted from what?"

"From a teacher in Judaea. The governor there had him killed, forty years ago or so, and his people went on talking about him after. Long after, half a thousand years after, a monk did the arithmetic back to his birth and started the count from there, and got it wrong by four years, most likely, but by then nobody minded."

"Judaea," he said. "Titus has just burned it."

"Not that part. That part goes on."

He waited, and I did the sum aloud.

"From now," I said, "nineteen hundred years, and twenty-seven more. Twenty-six, and some months. I left in May. It is a month we have; it comes after April."

"I know May."

He still held the knife, with water running off the blade. A fly was walking on the rim of the bowl, and I watched the fly and told him the rest in one go.

"The cave on the plateau," I said. "It had a door in it. For one afternoon. Nobody could have seen it; it was a cold, coming from the crack where no cold should be. I crawled in there in May, in my year, with my bag on my front and that light in my teeth, and I crawled out of it into yours, in the autumn, with snow on the way. Then it shut. It has stayed shut. You have seen it shut, in the spring. You saw the spiders."

He was looking past me at the cave's dark mark across the plateau, down there in the heat, until I thought it had all gone by him.

"Do they still have mules?"

"Yes," I said. "Fewer. In these mountains the olives still come down on them. At home there is a gorge so deep that the river at the bottom of it is a whole day's walk down, and people pay to be carried down it on mules, and back up, to look."

"Who leads them?"

"Men in hats. They walk in front."

He wet the knife and started on his left cheek.

"Who's emperor?" he said, under his ear.

"Nobody, on my side of the world. There are a few kings left, who cut ribbons on bridges and wave from carriages."

"So the legions went home."

"There are no legions. Armies. Every country keeps its own."

"The roads. Does anybody mend them?"

"Everybody pays a little to the town, and the town pays men to mend them, and they are never finished."

"Somebody's paid, then. Where's the god gone?"

"His house fell in, centuries before I was born. An earthquake had some of it, and men wanting stone for their own walls had the rest. People come from everywhere to walk about in what is left of it, and they pay to."

"The spring?"

"It is dry. There is a fence round it now."

He shaved along the line of his cheekbone, where a graze had healed into a pale seam no longer than a barley grain, and went round it. "Is the sea still salt?"

"Yes. Dirtier, and with fewer fish in it."

"Who's looking for you, there?"

"My landlord, by now. And somebody at my work will have rung my telephone, and got my own voice on a tape, saying I am not at home."

"That's true, then."

He finished, rinsed the knife and sheathed it at his back, then sat with his clean face turned up into the heat.

"The heavy one," he said. "Felix's silver."

I wore it next to my skin still, and it had rubbed a raw patch on my breastbone that I had stopped noticing. I unslung it and gave him the camera by its body. He put the wrong end to his eye

first and got nothing but his own lashes in the glass. “Not that way,” I said, and he found the plateau with it, and the shadowed notch, and the cliff above it.

“It makes everything small,” he said.

“It keeps what it shows.”

“Where?”

“Inside it, in the dark, on a strip as long as you are tall. Not a soul in this world can bring it out.”

“The boy says it was your father’s.”

“It was.”

“He’ll be wanting it, then.”

“He will not,” I said.

His thumb went toward the glass, toward the dent in the rim, and I had his wrist turned aside before it got there.

“One print on that glass,” I said, “and I might as well never look through it again.”

I slung it on again and fed it in at the neck of my chiton, where it lived.

“At Alexandria there’s a fellow,” he said, “builds a temple door that opens by itself when the priest lights the fire on the altar. A shipmaster off the grain run saw it open, with no man behind it.”

“This was not made in Alexandria.”

“It was made somewhere.” He picked a thread of thyme off the woodstack and put it in his mouth. “The way back, then. The god gave you a mountain and a tomb. And Theano? What was hers?”

“The town.”

“Which?”

“Pompeii.”

He tried it over. “Where’s that?”

"In Campania. On the bay below Neapolis, below a mountain they grow wine on. A day from Puteoli by the coast road, or less."

"I've heard of Neapolis. Puteoli." He had a scuffed patch of earth before the woodstack, worn bare by his own boots, and he drew in it with the heel of one. "Here's the gulf, and here's the heel of Italy, and the coast goes round from it to Puteoli." He made a mark. "There?"

"Short of that. There."

He moved the mark. "What sort of town?"

"They elect their magistrates every year and paint the candidates' names on the house walls in letters a foot high, and the bakers vote for whoever likes bread. There is a forum with a temple at the top of it, and tombs along the roads out of every gate, and out among the tombs, somewhere, the door I want."

The rest of what I knew stood behind the name: eight years on from this summer, and a few weeks over. I left it standing where it was; his question had been about the road.

"You go in at this door," he said, "and come out in your year, counted from the Judaean."

"Yes."

"With the light, and the box you look through."

"Yes."

"How will you know the door, among all those tombs?"

"If it is open, by the cold, as I knew it at the crack. If it is shut I shall not know it from any other wall."

He had heard all of it and put it away as Kallia put away a lodger's tale of a sister who married a magistrate.

"My paper," he said, "is in Corinth. The book with my name in it."

I hiccuped, out of nowhere, and my shoulders jumped.

"Hold your breath," he said. "I'll want that book in my hand before I set foot in Italy."

"Celer is at Corinth."

"So's the brother. Her brother. His house has a porter on the door and a dog in the porch. The freedman told me which house. I'll stand up in the brother's court for his sister when it's heard, and he'll get me into the archive for it, and pay the road."

"You told the freedman no."

"That was last autumn."

"If the record is not there? If Celer has had it taken out of the book?"

"There's the men who saw me get the sword. Half Corinth sat on those benches. They've not all died."

"And she will be in the house," I said. "His sister."

"It's her brother's house."

"That is not what I asked."

"She'll be in it."

I hiccuped again, with my cheeks full, and it burst out through my nose.

"In that court I'll have the brother's men on the benches round me," he said. "Celer's men chose a road for it." He took the thyme from his teeth and looked at it. "When the grazing's done, in the autumn, we leave for Corinth. Before the rains. We winter there. The sea opens in the spring, and we sail. As man and wife."

The hiccup took me exactly on the last word of it.

"As man and wife."

"That's for the shipmaster, at the gangway."

"Is that all it is? Something to say to the shipmaster?"

"He asks it before he asks the fare," Valens said.

"In Corinth, then? All winter, in the brother's house? What am I there?"

"My wife. The porter will ask, and the brother, and his cook, and that's what they'll all be told."

"I meant to winter in Delphi. Euthydikos has a bowl for me when the god closes for the year. It would have paid my crossing."

"Delphi thinks you're on a boat. Let it."

"His man will come down to the lane for me when it is ready."

"Kallia will tell him you sailed."

"And the money?"

"The brother pays his witness's road. There's the silver from the ford. And the string comes down with us. What's not wanted I'll sell at the Isthmus, where they'll pay for mules hardened on a mountain."

I had it in my head already: Euthydikos's bean-sheller off his stool by the bay tree, down at the lane gate some winter morning, and Kallia at the pot telling him the Syracusan had sailed. The priest's bowl could keep its lead; it had kept it this far.

"And Felix?" I said.

"He comes."

"When I find the door," I said, "I shall go in by it. You understand that. I shall go home."

"Why?"

"Because it is my own," I said. "There is a house with my father's things in it that nobody else will know what to do with, and my work, and my name on a door. Because there I know where everything is kept."

"I'll wait outside it," he said.

My hiccups were gone.

* * *

In the worst of the afternoon heat I took the skins up to the seep above the hut, where a thread of water ran from the rock into a basin somebody had cut for it before Mnason was born. I filled

them, and then sat on the basin's lip with my skirt pulled up and looked at my legs.

I had not shaved them since my last morning in Philadelphia, with a pink plastic razor out of a bag of ten, and in the nine months since, the hair had come in along my shins dark and soft, the longest it had been since I was twelve. Kallia's neighbors argued over theirs at the spring, over the jars. "Hot pitch, and off it comes in one pull," a grandmother had said, "and you're smooth for the whole summer," and another held out for a lamp flame. I had listened with my jar and done nothing. I turned my shin to the sun and studied it as I would a bronze left too long in its crate after a dig. Inside that one look I decided it was pitch or nothing, and that I would not stand in a herdsman's hollow tearing out my legs with hot tar for a muleteer, and that was the end of it.

I washed instead, all over, standing in the basin with my chiton spread on the rock, in snowmelt so cold it emptied my chest, and the sun had me dry before I was dressed again.

The string returned up the hollow in the long gold of the afternoon with Felix at the head of it, talking to the black, who walked with her ears laid back so as not to hear him. He had found a stick of juniper on the way and peeled it while he walked, and its white showed from far down the hollow.

"Pick that foot up for me and they'd race you at the Isthmus," he was saying when the string reached the hobbling line. Valens met him there, and told him while they took the halters off.

"When the grazing's done the string goes down to Corinth, and we winter there. Come spring, there's a ship. You're with us."

"Ship where? Italy? Is it Italy after all?"

"Italy."

"Capua's in Italy."

"Italy's long," Valens said.

"Corinth, though!" Felix let the black's rope go, and the black wandered away to roll. "The real one? On the neck, with a sea each side? One of the boatmen told me they drag the ships across from one sea to the other on a stone road, whole, on rollers, with the masts still in them. Will we see that? Who'll have the string while we're there?" More came after it, faster than my Greek would go, some business of a boatman's cousin and a wager, and I caught up with him at the arena. "An arena, at Corinth, a proper one, in stone? Have you seen the fights in it?"

"Once or twice."

"Once or twice! I'd have seen every one. You'd never take the lot to Corinth. Which would you sell?"

"Some."

"Not the black."

"Nobody'd give me anything for the black."

Felix looked at her, rolling with her four hooves at the sky, the lame one kicking as high as the sound ones. He seemed to find that satisfactory, and swung round on me.

"You'll know it, then. You'd have passed through it, from Syracuse. Everybody from Syracuse comes through Corinth, or round by the cape, and nobody goes by the cape if he can pay for the road. Which way did you come?"

"Another way."

"There isn't another way." He had the juniper stick by its thin end and was swishing the air with it. "When are the games at the Isthmus? This spring coming, or the next? They have a boys' race. Has anybody told you? A whole race of nothing but boys. I've beaten the dun from the troughs to the top three times since the full moon, and she was carrying."

"Was she trying?"

"She was carrying," Felix said, and the dun got no more from him than that.

He made for the junipers along the hollow's upper rim, and soon the sounds that reached us from there were the sounds of a fight. I watched it while I helped Mnason lift his new cheese out of the pot. Felix had Mnason's wicker drainer on his left arm for a shield, and he was fighting the biggest juniper on the slope, which had the reach of him. He kept his feet planted wide, lunging and dancing back out of range and lunging again, and calling out his own name to the crowd each time he struck: "Felix! Felix of Kirrha!" The crowd was ewes.

"When you've beaten that," Mnason shouted up at him, once he saw what had become of his drainer, "you can fight my cheese."

The juniper won. Felix lunged too far on a patch of loose scree, his front foot went, and he sat down hard in a long rattle of stones with the drainer bouncing after him. When he limped down to us both his shins were skinned down the front from the instep up, with grit ground into them, and he had his chin up.

"It slipped," he said.

"The juniper did?"

"The ground." The drainer's rim had parted from its weave for a hand's length, and the loose withies stuck out of it in a fringe.

"That was a good drainer till you had it," Mnason said.

"It's nothing," said Felix.

I washed his shins at the water skin, with a rag and cold water, until they bled clean.

"In the boys' race they run up the stadium and down it again," he told me, unasked, staring at the sky. "A man said the Corinthian boy won it last time by a head, and they gave him the pine, and his father cried in front of everybody. I'd not cry. Would you cry, if it was me?"

"I might."

"Only a little," Felix said. "Not in front of everybody."

Where he could see me looking he never flinched. When he took me to be looking elsewhere, he did, each time. Valens was splitting pine round the side of the hut by then.

"Did you see?" Felix called to him. "I had it on its back foot."

"I saw the juniper," Valens said.

At sundown Mnason brought the cheese over to our fire, in its rush basket, with the whey still weeping out of the weave onto his wrist. He set it on the stone by the fire, sat down on our woodstack, which in fairness was his, and cut the cheese into four with the knife he had meant for the fig.

"Kid," he said, chewing. "Right through it."

"It's good," Valens said, which was the most I had heard him say to Mnason in a week.

It tasted of milk and salt, fresh and squeaking against the teeth. On Ninth Street, in the Italian Market, a man in a paper hat had once passed me a knot of mozzarella across his counter on the back of a knife, still warm, and it had squeaked the same; the herdsman's was sharper, and had a hair in it. The cheese was good and Mnason said it was not and ate most of it.

"Green fig'll strip your lips," he told Felix, through a mouthful. "My brother ate six once, at the vintage, for a bet."

"Six! Was he sick? Did his lips come off?"

"He won the bet," said Mnason.

"Do you know Corinth?" Felix said. "When were you there last?"

"Once. It was full of Corinthians."

"Where do you go in the winter," I asked him, "when the snow comes up here?"

"To my son's, at the foot of the gorge, where his wife can count every mouthful into me. Six months of her, and then the

snow goes and I come up here to the ewes, who don't count." He licked his thumb. "My son's wife is from Amphissa."

He said it as though that told me the rest, and perhaps it did.

Felix ate standing, with one shin held clear of the fire.

"Sit down to it," I said.

"Fighters eat on their feet," he said, "so nobody catches them sitting."

We had barley bread Valens had baked in the ashes that morning, black on the bottom, and a fistful of the bitter greens Mnason picked along the rim and boiled with salt, which I had come round to, and a little of the wine from the skin, which I had not. The sun dropped past the western ridge, and the plateau filled with dark until only the summit at our backs still had light on it.

Mnason heaved himself up, put his knife away in his belt, and eyed Valens over the fire.

"Your man's shaved," he told me.

He was off to his ewes on that, and the answering was left to Valens.

"He's called me that since our first night." Valens had his face to the fire.

"You never told him otherwise," I said.

"He never asked."

Felix lay down where he was, between the fire and the woodstack, with his cloak pulled over him and his skinned shins sticking out of the bottom of it toward the warmth. "I'm not tired," he said. "The ships on the rollers. Do the sailors stay on them, going over the land? Do they row?"

"They walk alongside," Valens said, but by then Felix was asleep, openmouthed.

The herdsman's dog barked once near the fold. "I'll have your hide for a pail," came Mnason's voice out of the dark, and it did not bark again. Valens laid a root of juniper on the embers.

"You do not believe a word of it," I said.

"I believe that cave had a light in it with no flame. I was there to see it."

"And the rest?"

"The rest is yours."

"That is not believing."

"It'll get you on a boat."

"Suppose you see it open? The door."

"Then I'll believe it," he said.

* * *

While he walked the line in the dusk, as he did every night, trying the hobbles and standing a while where it ended, his face to the dark of the plateau, I took myself into the hut.

It was dry stone shoulder-high, roofed with fir poles under brush and turves, and so low that I could stand upright only under the ridge pole. Mnason's rush baskets hung in a row from pegs, and the smell of whey was in the stones. At the back he had made a bed by driving four forked stakes into the earth floor and laying poles across the forks, with cut bracken heaped on the poles and three fleeces on the bracken; all summer it had held me, and I had never looked underneath it. Enough light came in at the doorway from the fire to see shapes by, and the shine of things.

When Valens passed the doorway once more I said his name, and he stopped outside it.

"Come in."

"The boy," he said.

"The boy is asleep with his mouth hanging."

He ducked through the doorway with his head down and straightened a little too soon, so that the top of his head met the roof poles and dry needles and earth rained on the pair of us. He told the roof something in Latin, and stood with his head bowed between the poles, picking a needle out of his eye, and I laughed, not much.

"Mind the roof," I said, too late.

I had meant to be graceful about the rest of it, and I got my belt off well enough. Then I took the chiton by its skirt and dragged it upward past my face, and at the top the cloth caught on itself and trapped my arms inside it. While I fought it my elbow went out sideways in the dark and found something that grunted.

"That was my eye."

I fought free of the chiton with my hair in a tangle, and there, on its strap, between my breasts, the Pentax hung as it had hung all evening.

"You wear it to bed."

"I wear it to everything."

He took the strap two-handed and drew it off me, slowly, keeping it clear of my hair, and hung it on the peg beside the cheese baskets with the lens turned to the wall. With the weight gone, the raw place on my breastbone stung in the cold, and he put his thumb on it. His tunic came off, and he was very large in that small hut, and pale where the sun had not been at him. I took hold of his belt where he had dropped it and laid it away in the corner, so that his hands would find no work in it.

We got onto the bed by stages: I lay down first and drew him by the arm. He followed me down with his elbow hitting the wall, and he had not yet trusted the poles with his weight when the fork at the head of the bed split along its grain with a dry crack.

The poles at that end rolled out of it, and the head of the bed went down, and my head with it. His palm was under my skull before the floor was, and the floor took the back of his hand instead; the bracken and the fleeces and the two of us went sliding down the slant the poles made and fetched up in a heap by the stones of the wall, with my feet still in the air on the good end and one of the fleeces across my face.

He laughed.

It started low in him and went on, helpless, and shook the poles under us; more of the bed gave way, and that set us off harder. I laughed with my face against his ribs and could not stop, nor could he; every time one of us had nearly stopped, the other started again.

"That's the fork," Valens said, when he could.

"You have had the whole summer to look at that fork."

"I was watching the figs."

A pole at the foot rolled off its fork on its own and hit the floor, and we were gone again. His teeth showed by the doorway's glow, square and even. I had flossed every night of my adult life and still paid to be scolded twice a year, and I lay in the wreck of the herdsman's bed and held them against him.

His hand was still under my head; I drew it out and looked at it in what light there was. The skin had gone from two of the knuckles, and there was earth from the floor in the raw places, and a splinter of bracken stalk. I picked the bracken out with my teeth, then the grit, spitting it aside; I put my mouth to the place, and somewhere in that his laughing ran out.

His breathing was loud in the hut, and the fleece had slid off my face. His knuckles stayed at my mouth, and he was quite still.

"Here?" he said.

"Here."

For a while his hands were not careful. They came at me hard, on my back and in my hair, and his mouth with them; then they remembered themselves and were careful, which was worse, and better.

He kissed me, and his mouth tasted of the herdsman's wine and of thyme. I pulled at him until his weight was on me properly, and what poles were left under the fleece shifted and creaked and took it. The night air at the doorway was cold on my arm, and he was hot from my shoulder to my feet, rough with hair across the chest, and his palm traveled down my side over my ribs and my hip, stopped there, and waited; I put my own hand over it and took it where I wanted it. He learned me after that as a man learned a road he meant to take again at night, feeling where it led and where it gave. His mouth went down my throat to my breast, and lingered. His jaw had roughened again since noon, and it dragged on my skin.

Nothing in that hut stood between me and a child but luck, and I had lost count of my month somewhere around October; it went through me, and I did nothing to stop it.

I had him in my hand, and a sound came from him against my breast, low, that I had no name for. I drew him into me, slowly, all of him, and he held there on his forearms with his mouth by my ear until I moved under him first.

It was slow, and stayed slow, and the pole under my back rocked on its one good fork. Down in the hollow a ewe woke and complained, and her bell went, once, and stopped. The bracken crushed under us and gave up a green, bitter smell, and through the fleece its cut ends pricked my back in a hundred small places that I felt together and each one separately, as I felt the doorway's draft and the heat of him and the grit of the earth floor under the soles of my feet, and the sound of the fire outside, and

the catch that came into his breath each time the pole rocked, and came into mine.

I came with my heel hooked behind his knee and a fistful of the fleece, and he held still for me through it, as he could hold still for anything; then the stillness left him, the whole of it at once, and the care went with it. He drove into me hard, and I wanted it, and pulled him to me, and he made a sound into the fleece, long and broken, and all his weight came down onto me and stayed.

The bed lay as it had fallen, the fork split, the poles off it, half the fleeces on the floor, and he lay in it with his arm across me and his cheek on my shoulder.

"Was it the pole?" he said, some while later. "Under your back."

"It was everything under my back. The herdsman will want his bed."

"He can have the end that's standing."

The fire outside had sunk, and his heart was slowing under my palm.

"In your country," he asked, "do they marry at the gangway?"

"At a table, mostly. In front of a clerk. Somebody writes it down. And here?"

"Here you say it before witnesses, and then everybody eats. Corinth has clerks."

His arm went heavy.

Some time after that I eased out from beneath it by inches, found my himation by feel among the fleeces, and stepped barefoot onto the wet grass. The stars were down to the ridges all round, more of them than there was dark between, and the summit stood black against them with no light on it anywhere. The string slept on its feet in a row along the hillside, and the fire had gone to embers.

Felix had turned over in his sleep. He lay on his back now, snoring, with his skinned shins to the coals and one arm flung over the grass toward the fig's jar, and his lips had swollen fat and shining in the ember light. In his open hand lay one of Valens's green figs, with one bite taken out of it.

Chapter 16

Plautia

"Have you seen his back?" Until then she had talked in Greek, a Greek so finely made that I lost it a clause at a time: the rain, and her brother's roof, which leaked over the north colonnade, and a regret that his household had made me no better welcome in all these weeks, in sentences that went on taking new parts into themselves long after I had found the verb and lost hold of its subject. The question was short and plain, and all of it reached me.

"Yes," I said.

I had had my palms on the ridges of it most nights since July. The heat went up my neck into my ears, and she watched it go.

"Good," said Plautia.

She sat by the brazier in a chair with a high curved back, her hands folded one into the other, and nothing of her moved but her eyes. She had fewer years on her than the woman I had made up for myself in the dark: thirty, or a little under, her hair dressed close to the head and pinned there, her face kept from the sun all its life. Her left earlobe had been torn through once, by an earring dragged or worn too heavy, and had grown back in two soft points with a notch between them. She wore no earrings. The room held a chest, her chair, an empty loom under the window,

no web on its beam, and the stool where her maid Myrrhine sat shelling lupins into her skirt; and all round the walls, at the height a woman could reach, bronze hooks with nothing hanging from them.

I had lived under her brother's roof since the first of the autumn rains, and until that morning I had seen her three times, each time from behind and at a distance. In the first week a dish of honey cakes had been sent down to the rooms over the stable for the wife of Valens, and I had given it to Felix, who ate every cake and asked, "When's the next? Every week? Does she know it's me eating them?" If Valens had lain with her, then all of his telling by the stream had been a story, and he could tell me whatever he liked. If he had not, no woman alive sent honey cakes to a muleteer's wife. Every night, lying beside him, I went round it and came out where I had gone in.

"Have you?" I said.

"Anything I have seen is a matter for the court," she said, still in Greek, and went on from there at length, and I lost her at the second bend of it, somewhere between a lawyer's fee and a difficulty about witnesses, and found her only at the name of a month.

"Lady," I said, "my Greek is from Phocis, and there is not much of it. When it runs, I lose it."

Plautia's hands came apart.

"Then we will try another," she said, in Latin. "My brother has it from your husband that you were brought up at Syracuse, among people who kept their Latin as some families keep a tomb, swept, in good repair, and visited on the proper days, and that you can read it, and Greek besides, and write both. Can you?"

It was book Latin, slow, with the verb held back for the end, and each clause was mine before the next arrived.

"I can," I said. Mine came out stiff. "I have spoken it to almost nobody."

"You are speaking it to me. Not as anybody speaks it in Syracuse."

"No."

"My brother spent a year there as a boy, with an uncle who salted tunny," said Plautia. "Speak Greek in front of him."

"You sent cakes."

"You did not eat them."

"The boy ate them."

"All of them, the cook tells me, and then the honey off the dish with his thumb." She did not smile, quite. "I have wished to see you since you came. I did not send for you, because I supposed you would find some reason to climb my stair and look at me before the winter was out, as anybody would, and you have found none; and now the winter is half gone, and my brother is at Patrae for ten days about the suit, and my patience has run out before my pride. You have been looking at the hooks."

"Something has hung from all of them. The bronze is worn bright at the bend."

"My son was seven at the vintage." It came in the same voice as the rest. "He is in his father's house, where the law says he must be. Twice in three years I have had sight of him: once at the theater, from the women's benches at the top, and once in the street, being taken to the baths, before anybody thought to turn him down another one. At the Saturnalia I sent him a ball of painted leather, red and green, wrapped in a cloth, and the porter at that house took it in at the gate. Would a porter keep a child's ball?"

"A porter would be asked where he got it."

"So I tell myself." She looked at the brazier. "Your husband wants a leaf out of a book in the proconsul's record office. This

house wants the same leaf, for the suit, and I believe the man I was married to has thought of it as well."

"The governor's?" I said. "Not the colony's own?"

"Since the emperor took back from this province what Nero had given it, the colony's magistrates have had their books kept in that office beside the governor's own; the men who keep them are the proconsul's freedmen. My son's father is among the proconsul's people again this year, now that Corinth has a proconsul to be among, and he has been kind to those freedmen all winter."

"Kind."

"His steward lends them money and forgets to ask for it back, and he greets each of them by name in the forum, which a freedman values more. My brother's freedman asked at the door before the Saturnalia and was told the office was shut for the holiday. He asked after it and was told that the book he wanted was out with a copyist."

"Copied by whom?"

"Our man is a freedman, and so is the clerk, and one freedman does not call another a liar at his patron's door," said Plautia. "The clerk was smiling. Our man came away."

"Can your brother not—"

"He can, and he has. The proconsul received him with every kindness, and asked after my health, and after my son's, and said that he would look into the matter of the copying as soon as the year's business allowed, and my brother came home and broke a cup."

"And the proconsul?"

"Dined that evening with my former husband. Our cook has a cousin in that kitchen."

"What made you send for me?"

"Because you read." Her eyes left the coals. "And because I wished to see you. The second came first."

"To see what?"

"What he had chosen," said Plautia, "when at last he chose anything. Everybody who climbs that stair wants something of mine. My brother's advocate wants my mother's silver for his fee, and says so in a very pretty way. The cook wants my old cloak for his daughter, and does not say so, and looks at it—"

"He looks at it every time the chest is open," said Myrrhine, in Greek. She had caught the cloak and the cook, and no more.

"As for my brother," said Plautia, "he would have me married again by the summer to a man in Sicyon with a vineyard and a cough. And you?"

"The leaf," I said. "For him."

"That is his want. And yours?"

"I have known you a morning. There is nothing of yours I want."

"That would make you the first," said Plautia. "You are lying."

Myrrhine got to her feet with her skirt full of skins and shook them onto the coals, and the room filled with the smell of their burning.

* * *

We left the grazing on the last fair day of it, when the turf in the hollow had burned yellow. Mnason had gone down the gorge the week before, his ewes in front of him and his cheese pots slung on a donkey, to his son's wife and her counting.

Valens led the mules on through Delphi by daylight, by the road the town knew him on, to his yard below it. I left them at the cliff foot and sat out the afternoon above the stadium in a fold of rock, with Felix's spare cloak round me, while the shadow of the western mountains took the gulf and the plain and climbed the

olives toward me. When it reached me there were lamps in Kirrha.

When the town had gone in to its suppers I took the stadium path down in the darkness, skirting the theater and the god's shut house. A dog joined me from among the treasuries and walked at my side to the precinct gate, and stretched across it there, its duty done. The lane was black. I had it by its walls, by the step halfway along that had turned my ankle when I was new, and by Nikaso's door, which had never shut flush and laid a blade of light on the paving.

Kallia's gate stood ajar. She was in the gap holding the lamp low, a sandal in her other fist, studying the stone of the step; as I reached her, something small and yellow went along it with its tail curled up over its back. She brought the sandal down on it, twice, and kicked the remains into the lane.

"There's its brother in the woodstack somewhere," she said.

Kallia held the gate for me, and barred it behind.

The pomegranate had its fruit on, split on the branch, the seeds gone brown inside where the wasps had been at them. Overhead somebody coughed in his sleep, with long gaps between, an old man's cough.

"Did he bring them all down?"

"All but two. He sold two at the bottom of the gorge, to a farmer with olives to bring in."

"The boy's going?"

"Felix is coming with us."

"When's the boat?"

"In two days, from Kirrha, if the wind holds. Across to Lechaion, and the road up to Corinth."

She put her foot in the sandal and worked the heel down.

"He fed you, up there?"

"Barley bread out of the ashes. Milk. Greens the herdsman boiled."

"Burnt underneath, the bread."

"Every time."

"His mother never showed him a griddle," Kallia said, "or he never looked."

"I have your obol still," I said. "The sheet was to come from Euthydikos's people, and then it was the mountain. At Corinth there are ships for the east, out of the other harbor. I will buy a sheet there and write it, and find somebody going to Syria."

"Pay him when he's aboard," Kallia said. "Not before."

I unpinned the himation. Through the summer it had been my cloak by day and my blanket at night; it had been through thorn, scree and Mnason's fold with me, and showed it. I folded it lengthwise and then across, the darned corner inside, and gave it to her past the lamp.

Kallia looked at it. She took it from me by its folds, as she would have taken a pile of a lodger's bedding, and carried it into her own room, and the lamp with it, and the court was left to the dark. Her shutter stood a crack open on the court. The light stayed in it.

I found the storeroom by the feel of its jamb. Inside, the mat was in its corner, and somebody had beaten it since the spring; the dust was gone from it, and it smelled of the sun. I lay down in my chiton with my bag under my head, and slept.

* * *

I wrote Kallia's line in Plautia's room four mornings after that first one, on a sheet of papyrus from a stall at the top of the Lechaion road, with ink the stallholder ground for me in a shell while I watched. I wrote it out twice because the first one blotted and the second one was not better.

Plautia had sent down for me two more mornings running. Both times she talked Latin to me for an hour about very little, mostly the price of charcoal in a wet winter, and in the middle of it asked me one thing straight out.

"There is a man laying a floor in the dining room below us, whom this house pays by the day," she said on the first of those mornings, "and he has found out that a floor laid drunk takes twice as many days. Do you sleep, in a stable?"

"Better than in a lodging house. Mules do not talk in their sleep."

"Were you afraid of him, at the beginning?" she said on the second.

"Of his size. For about an hour."

"When the hour was out?"

"After the hour he was rude to me about a woodstack."

She had returned to the charcoal after that. Today she watched me cut the reed.

"Nobody in this house writes a letter except to ask for something, or to refuse what somebody else has asked," she said. "Whom is it for?"

"A woman in Delphi, to her son. He lives in Syria now."

"Is it money she wants of him?"

"She wants nothing of him. It is the news of her lane."

"Nothing of herself."

"Not a word."

"A son in Syria has the whole of Syria to look at, and a lane in Delphi must be very small from there. Does he write to her?"

"He has written once," I said, "in more than three years."

"When his letter came, did she weep?"

"She swept a floor."

"What is she to you?"

"She found me on the step of a spring at night, and took me home, and gave me her husband's brother for a father, and the clerk wrote it down." I blew on the ink. "She had me most of an autumn before she wanted my name."

"What did she ask you?"

"Whether I could carry water."

"Can you?"

"Now."

Plautia put her hands out to the coals. Her sleeve slid from her left wrist, and there was a band of gold round it, plain, the breadth of a fingertip, closed so that its closing was hidden from me. In the lab I had held bracelets by the trayful, in cotton gloves: a hinge at one edge and a pin at the other, the pin a wire run through the knuckles of the hinge from top to bottom, and the knuckles always showing, however good the work. On this one I found neither. The gold went round her wrist like a ring round a finger.

"How is it closed?" I said. "I can find no hinge. I have never met a hinge that kept itself hidden."

Plautia turned the band round her wrist until a line showed in the gold, a seam as fine as a hair; she opened it along the seam, and it lay in her palm, and she held the palm out to me.

"No," I said. "Lady, I only—"

"You admired it." The band went onto the table beside the sheet, clear of the wet ink, and she stood. "You will forgive me. The smoke has got into my eyes."

She passed the curtain into the next room.

The curtain was heavy and dull red, and it hung still behind her. Through it, after some time, her sound reached me. It was quiet and regular and it went on: a sound held in, then loosed, then held once more, and a long one, and round again to the start.

Myrrhine rose from her stool, came to the table, and eyed the bracelet without touching it.

"A drachma," she said, in Greek. "I'll give you a drachma for it, which is a good price for a thing you never paid for."

"It is not for sale."

"Everything she gives away is for sale again by morning. I had her mother's cloak back off a rope-maker's wife at the Saturnalia, and her good shoes off a girl at the baths. Two drachmas."

"Does she know you buy them back?"

"She knows her shoes are on her feet." Myrrhine returned to her stool and watched the curtain.

I took the bracelet up. It was heavier than it looked, and soft, as the old gold always was; a fingernail would have marked it. Near the clasp, on the outer face, just where the band would have lain across the inside of her wrist, the gold carried a small crescent of dents, and the opposite edge another: two marks above, two below, set close, with a gap in the middle of each pair. Over the years they had worn smooth at their edges. At work I would have measured them and drawn them and written them up on a card.

Someone had cut his teeth on it.

Behind the curtain the sound had stopped. I went in.

It was a small room with a bed in it, and a window high up with its shutter closed, and a lamp on a stand. She was sitting on the edge of the bed with her hands folded, and her face was wet and perfectly composed.

"You will think me very badly governed," she said.

"I saw the marks."

She looked at the gold in my hand.

"He had two teeth at the bottom by midsummer," she said, "and two at the top by the vintage, and he would not take the breast unless that arm was across him, so that I wore it day and

night for most of a year, and his mother told everyone who dined with us that I nursed my son like a fuller's wife. Which was true. Will you wear it?"

"Yes."

"On the left. It was made for the left."

I put it on. I found the seam with my thumbnail, and the gold opened along it and shut again round my wrist with a click, and after that the seam was gone from under my nail.

She put out one finger and touched the marks, and let it rest there.

* * *

Kallia's lamp was still alight when I woke.

From my mat I had it in the open doorway: a small flame on the sill of Kallia's window, blue at the root, standing in a court that was still more dark than gray. The himation lay folded on my bag inside the door. I opened it out across my lap.

All summer my pin had pierced the cloth at one spot on the left shoulder, and the weave there had parted round it into a hole, with a fringe of broken threads I had meant every week to mend. The hole was gone. Kallia had closed it into a round eye, working a gray thread about it in turns laid so close that no cloth showed between them, and had run a second thread through the weave all round, to keep the hole from going any further. The hem was turned where the scree and the thorn had frayed it, from one corner to the other, and stitched down. The stitches were small and even and all alike. Toward the second corner they grew a fraction longer, and then, at the very end, small again.

I put the pin through the eye, and it slid home without catching.

I took my bag and left the storeroom. The top of the court was gray and the bottom still dark, and Kallia was in the lean-to, her

back to the court, raking last night's embers forward under the pot. She came out carrying the broom. I stood aside on the paving, and she swept the storeroom step where I had just come over it: quick strokes, outward, the grit off my sandals skittering away past my feet. Two strokes more along the sill. She hung the broom back on its nail beside the fire, and went to the jar for water.

The court grew light, and the flame on the sill went from being the brightest thing there to being only one of the things in it. I brought out the Pentax.

I opened the lens wide and turned the dial down to the slowest speed I could hold steady, and set my shoulder against the pomegranate's trunk. In the finder the window was a square of dark, its shutter ajar. On the sill below it stood the lamp: a round belly of brown clay, a nozzle black to the lip, the flame standing up off it, and above it a long tongue of soot climbing the plaster of the reveal to the lintel and broadening as it went, one night's burning laid over years of others.

I held my breath and pressed the release.

The shutter clacked, louder in that court than anything since the scorpion, the mirror clapping up and back behind the glass. Kallia was facing me from the jar with the dipper in her hand. She looked at her lamp, with the look she gave a jar when a lodger had been standing too near it. The lamp was unchanged.

She crossed to the sill, wet her fingertips at her mouth, pinched the flame out, and turned to her pot.

* * *

The rain held off for three days at the end of that month, and on the second of them Plautia set out for the baths.

I sat on the porch bench, across the street from the fuller's door, with the dog, which had decided by then that I belonged to

the porch and lay with its chin across my foot. Myrrhine came out first with the bundle of towels and the oil flask on its strap, then two of the brother's slaves in their cloaks, then Plautia, veiled, holding the hem of her cloak clear of the step's puddle.

At that same moment Valens appeared out of the lane by the stables with a sack of barley on his shoulder, Felix behind him with another.

He stopped short of the step. He let the sack slide to the paving, and before it had settled he had looked the street over both ways, slowly. He stood aside against the house wall, a little to the right of the step, facing the turning.

Plautia had stopped on the step when he stopped. She waited there, with her hem in her hand, until he had looked, and until he had moved; then she stepped down and passed him on his left, so that he was at her back, and walked on with Myrrhine and the slaves toward the end of the street. At the turning she moved her head, not far, to find him.

He was where he had been, by the house wall, the sack at his feet.

She was gone round the turning. He watched the empty turning a while, then climbed the step, and saw me. He came to the bench and looked at my face. Behind him the street might have been a wall.

"Your feet are wet."

"The dog is lying on the dry one."

"Is that gold?" Felix was on the step behind him, his own sack still on his shoulder. "On your arm. Real? Where'd you get it? If you bite it you can tell; if it's real your teeth go in. Hand it over, I'll show you."

"Someone has done that already," I said, and kept the arm in my lap.

Valens looked at the band, not long. "She gave you that."

"Two days ago."

"She's done it before. Give it to her woman tomorrow, early, and say nothing to her about it. She'll be sorry by dark."

"She told me to wear it. On the left."

He took longer over it now.

"Wear it, then," he said.

"How heavy is it?" said Felix. "Can you feel it there when you lift your arm?"

Valens turned to Felix. "Take the sacks round. Fill the dog's bowl; it's foul."

"The man at the stable says there's fights at the amphitheater after the games. Proper ones, with a lanista from Patrae and a Gaul that's killed four. He says the Corinthians built it in a hollow so the noise goes up and the whole forum hears it, and that you got your sword there."

"There's only the one."

"Will you show me where you stood? Not in it. Only the gate."

"The sacks," said Valens.

Felix started for the stables with one load up and the other dragging at his heels, and the dog followed for the bowl's sake.

"Will you take him?" I said. "Only to the gate."

"He'd want in."

"Would that be so bad?"

"He'd stay in."

"Where have you been all morning? The barley is sold two doors down."

"Near the forum. The brother's freedman walked with me." He sat next to me on the bench, his forearms laid along his thighs. "The proconsul's office is at the end of the long colonnade, across the forum from the old temple. Two doors. One onto the colonnade, with a porter on a stool and a slave asleep at his feet.

One at the back, onto a lane, with a baker's oven built against it and a step down."

"You went to see it."

"I went for barley. The porter on the colonnade is the proconsul's. The baker's not."

"How do you know the baker's not?"

"He sold me bread. He asked was I from the games at Nemea, and I said no, and he said I had the look, and gave me back too much."

"Did you give it back?"

"I bought another loaf with it."

He had the loaf inside his tunic, and he took it out and broke it, and handed me half, warm still in the middle.

That afternoon I climbed Plautia's stair without being sent for.

She was alone. Myrrhine was in the kitchen seeing to the lamps, and Plautia sat in the high-backed chair doing no work, with the shutter open a little on a pewter sky. Her own wrist was bare. She saw the band on mine.

"I have come for nothing," I said.

"Then sit."

I took Myrrhine's stool.

"What is he called?" I said. "Your son."

"Marcus. For his father's father, who held the consulship two months in a bad year. He has his father's ears, which stand out, and my mother's temper, which does not, and before he was four he could say the Muses, all nine, in order, and could not be got to say the Graces at all, because he said they were only girls."

"Ours can tell you every man who ever won a fight in Corinth, and none of the Muses."

"Your boy has a mule's manners and two good hands. I watched him at the well. Does he laugh? Your husband."

"Not often."

"I walked in front of him for two years and never heard it."

"In the summer a bed fell in under us," I said, "in a herdsman's hut on the mountain. It was the herdsman's own bed, and it put us on the floor with the fleeces on top of us. He laughed then."

A sound broke from Plautia, short, surprised; she glanced at her own lap as though she had dropped it there, and it broke from her again, and that time she let it.

"The herdsman?" she said.

"He is at his son's for the winter. He will find out in the spring."

"Come up tomorrow," said Plautia. "Come up when you like. Myrrhine will complain, and you will not listen to her."

* * *

We went over the gulf a day after Kallia's lamp, in a boat that carried oil jars from Kirrha to Lechaion and anything else that would pay: a broad black coaster with a patched sail, and a master who chewed mastic and spat it into the sea when the taste went. Our mules were tied in the waist between the jars, heads short to a rail, straw kicked down under their hooves, and the fig rode roped to the foot of the mast in its jar.

Halfway across, the mules were sick, as far as mules could be.

They had no way to bring it up. They stood with their legs braced wide against the roll and the sweat coming out dark on their necks and flanks, and groaned, all together, a long low sound like furniture being dragged across a floor upstairs. The dun hung her lip and let it hang. The black kept trying to lie down, folding at the knees and catching herself, and every time she started, Valens got a shoulder under her neck and talked her up again.

Felix, who could, was sick into the sea for the lot of them.

"Why don't they spew?" He straightened from the rail, his face gone white as whey. "Wouldn't it help them? Does it hurt worse, if you can't? Is that why they're making that noise? Would a horse?" And he was at the rail again.

"They can't," said Valens. "It stays in them."

"Every bit?"

"Hold the dun's head up. If she goes down on this she'll not get up till Lechaion."

I cupped the dun's jaw, and she gave the whole hot weight of her head to me, groaning into my himation, and her ears flattened and lifted with every roll. The drugstore at Twentieth and Walnut had sold bands for seasickness, elastic, with a plastic bead sewn in to press on the inside of the wrist; Gloria's Ray swore by them, and had been sick in a pair from Lewes into Cape May. The dun groaned again. I rubbed the flat place between her eyes with my knuckles, and the master watched me do it over his mastic and went aft to tell the boy at the steering oar something about foreigners.

"If a mule dies on my deck," the master called forward to Valens, "you pay for the deck to be scrubbed, and the jars it falls against, and the god for the trouble."

"She won't die."

The wind went down with the sun, as it did on that water, and we lay all night off an unlit coast, rolling on a long swell with the sail brailed up and the jars knocking. In the small hours I woke on the deck to a scraping and a grunt, and a hoof striking wood, and Valens's voice in the dark, low.

"The light."

I felt in the bag for it and thumbed it on.

Down among the jars lay the black. She had folded at last and gone over onto her side, her legs against the rail, and they would

not come under her. In the light her eye showed white, and Valens was in the straw at her head with her halter rope round his fist. It was a poor brown light, browner than in the cave, and it shrank as I held it on them.

Felix had raised himself on an elbow on the coil of rope he slept on. "Where's the flame? Why doesn't it smoke? Is it hers? Can I hold it?"

"Get round her quarters," Valens said. "Don't push. Take the tail when I say, and pull her toward you."

"What's it burning?"

"Felix."

Felix wriggled in behind her. Valens worked a sack in under her shoulder and told her in Latin, "Up, now, you old fool. Up," and on the second of them Felix had a grip on the tail and threw his weight back on it, and the black heaved. Her forelegs came under her first, and she sat up in the straw like a dog, trembling, with her hind end still down; then she got those under her too, and stood. Her ribs heaved. By then the light was only a yellow smudge on her flank, and I turned it off while it still had something left.

"Does it go back on?" said Felix, in the dark.

"Shut your eyes," said Valens.

Presently, from beside the black, he spoke across her.

"How much is left in it?"

"Not much."

"Don't spend it on mules."

"You asked for it."

"I did." I heard him settle into the straw between the black and the jars, where she could not go over again without going over onto him.

When the gray came, the coast was there, and the line of Lechaion's moles, and over all of it, rising behind the town, the

great rock of the citadel with a wall running along its crest. Felix was at the rail with his hands wrapped round each other.

"What's on the top of it?"

"A temple," I said. "Aphrodite's."

"Can you see Athens from it? Do they let boys up?"

"It's a long climb," said Valens, "for a boy who's been sick all day."

"That's the town, though? Corinth? Which way's the ship road, that they haul them over on?"

"East of the harbor," said Valens. "Along there."

Felix stared that way.

"I'd sooner not look at it," he said, and sat on the deck with his back to the rail.

From Lechaion the road ran dead straight over the flat land to the city, between market gardens and the grave plots of Corinthians, the citadel never nearer however far we walked, and we reached the gate past noon, the string strung out behind us and Felix asleep on the dun. In the brother's porch a dog on a chain rose and announced us to everyone in the lane.

"What name shall I take in to the master?" said the porter.

"Valens. He sent his freedman to Kirrha for me."

"And her?"

"My wife," said Valens.

A wet nose pushed into my hand, the dog's. "Round by the lane for the stable, and there are rooms over it," the porter said, and was done with us. Beyond him, at the back of the court, a woman was climbing an outside stair, a maid behind her holding a cloak over her against the drizzle.

* * *

"At the games for Titus's triumph," Plautia said, "the proconsul goes out to the god's precinct on the Isthmus with his whole

staff, and the magistrates who give the games go out with him, and that half of Corinth which is neither racing nor selling goes out after them to watch the half that is, for as many days as there is racing; and the boy's father, who has not missed a festival at which a proconsul might see him since he first had a beard to be seen in, will sit in the second row behind the governor's chair in a new toga, laughing a breath behind the governor." It was late, the shutters were barred, and her brother was home from Patrae and asleep in his own rooms. "The proconsul's office keeps one clerk through the festival, to sit on its door."

"Which clerk?" asked Valens.

The freedman of the house was out on the stair, and Valens stood just inside the door. He had not sat in that room. "There is a stool, Valens," she had told him at the door, and again when the wine was poured, and both times he had answered, "I'm well here."

"Our freedman says it will be the young one, who drinks, or the gray-haired one, and that both of them are fond of money." She had a cup of hot wine in her hands and did not drink it. "I will go in myself, on the second morning, at the hour the boys run, when the office is emptiest. I will have a reason for being there that no clerk can refuse a woman of my family without writing his refusal down, and a purse that he will not wish to write down at all, and my woman with me to carry my writing case. My woman reads."

"I carry your case," said Myrrhine, from the chest by the wall, in Greek.

"Not this time."

"She doesn't know where the flask goes. She doesn't know which side you get down from a litter. She'll stand on your hem."

"You will show her where the flask goes, and which side, and she will stand off my hem."

Myrrhine split her next lupin so hard that half of it shot under the chest.

"What reason will you give the porter?" I said.

"My dowry. The instrument of it was entered in the colony's books when I was married, with my father's seal on it, and those books went into that office with all the others. I have the right to read it, and to have it read to me, and to have a copy made with the advocate standing by. A clerk who tells a daughter of my father that she may not see her own dowry will have to say why, in writing, to a proconsul who once dined at my father's table."

"What goes in the purse?" said Valens.

"My mother's silver, which the advocate wanted for his fee and may go on wanting," said Plautia.

"And while he is fetching it?" I said.

"While he is fetching it," said Plautia, "my woman looks along his shelves."

"You'll be known," Valens said.

"By whom? Every man in Corinth who knows my face will be at the Isthmus, looking at boys."

"Your son," I said.

"Will be there as well, I am told, in the second row, in a new tunic, beside his father."

"You could go out to the Isthmus instead, and see him."

"From the women's benches at the top, over the heads of half Corinth, while one race is run. I have done that." The cup went to the floor by her chair. "This is the suit. The suit is the one thing that man wants of me that I have not already given him, and I will not be at the top of the benches while it walks out of a back door. And when he rides in from the Isthmus after the boys' race, with the dust on him, you will be on a ship out of Lechaion, and he may look for you in the archive, and the theater, and the baths."

Valens shifted where he stood. “I’ll be by the baker’s oven.”

“Where every slave of that house buys its bread.”

“The baker gives too much back.”

“You will be at the Isthmus with your mules,” said Plautia, “selling them at the horse fair to whoever asks, where twenty men who sat on the benches the day you got your sword may stare at you all they please and tell each other they have seen Lupus, and none of them will think to walk a morning back to Corinth and find out what his wife is doing.”

Valens said, “No.”

“I have not finished.”

“I’ll be at the back door.”

Plautia held his look, and he held hers, until she was the one who gave way.

“We will speak of the door when my brother has spoken to the baker,” she said.

“The book,” Valens said.

“You cannot have the book, Valens. It is the book of the magistrate who sat at those games, the whole of his year’s business, and it is boards, not a roll; there is no clerk awake or asleep who would not miss it gone, and you could not carry it across a forum under your cloak and not look like a man carrying a door.”

“What holds the boards?” I said. “A cord, or rings?”

“A cord. Through holes at the back edge, and knotted, and the knot sealed.”

“With his seal?”

“His, and his colleague’s.”

“A cord can be cut,” I said, “and tied again. A seal is wax.”

“Can you put a seal back so that nobody sees?”

"Not so that nobody sees," I said. "So that it slips past a drinker, in a doorway's light, with somebody talking at him. A sober clerk who is looking would find it."

"We must hope for the young one." She turned to Valens. "You have no use for the book. You want two of its boards. The leaf with your name on it is near the front, because the emperor's games were early in that year, and it is two boards that close on each other with the writing inside; once the cord is cut they come away together and go into my writing case among my letters. It will say Gaius Iulius Valens, freedman of Gaius, set free by his master before the magistrate of the games and before the emperor, with the witnesses' names under it, and the day."

I had been married to a man in that house for three months, by the porter's account and the cook's, and I had had one name for him.

"Iulius," I said.

"The lanista's," said Valens. "I had it with the sword."

"I heard you give all of it in that atrium," Plautia said, "your hand on the household altar, the day you were sworn to me. You said the Gaius quickly, in case somebody should take it back."

"It was new," said Valens.

"Were you there that day?" I said. "At the games."

"Where the wives sit," said Plautia. "From up there a man on the sand has a shield and a crest, and no face."

"When is the suit heard?"

"In Rome, before a judge the praetor gives us, on a day the praetor finds for it. The advocate says two years from this spring. My brother says one. The praetor has said nothing."

"I said I'd stand up," said Valens. "I'll stand up."

Plautia inclined her head to him, very slightly, the small bow a woman of her kind gave a porter who offered to carry what she meant to carry herself.

Down in the court somebody shouted for him, high and cracked.

"Valens! The dun's out of her halter! She's in the cook's cabbages, and he's after her with a ladle!"

It was Felix, below in the court with a lamp.

Valens went down. His tread left the stair; in a while a door banged in the stable yard.

Plautia waited until the court was still. She left the cup where it stood, and when she spoke again it was in a Latin plain enough for the stableboy. She asked it of me, and not of the coals: when he had his leaf, and his ship, and me, what was there left in Rome that would bring him to stand up before a court and tell it the truth about her?

Chapter 17

Games on the Isthmus

The boards left their dust on my fingers. Fine and gray, faintly greasy, the dust of old wax in a shut room; under it the wood of the tag had been worn smooth by thumbs. The books lay flat in their pigeonholes, five and six to a hole. Each was a stack of boards bound along one side by a cord, and from every cord a wooden tag hung on a loop.

Each tag carried two names cut short, and a numeral. In a colony two names made a year.

Behind me the clerk was eating figs.

A fig cake sat on the table by his elbow, the kind the farm women pressed in a mold and sold in the market by weight: a brown brick with the shapes of the fruit still raised on its face. He dug them out singly with the blunt end of his stylus. When we arrived he was digging, and while Plautia gave him her name and her father's he was digging still. The gray one, then. We had wanted the other. The second table, across the room, stood bare, its stool pushed in and a wine ring dried on the wood.

"When the governor came back," he said, "the colony's old books were carted over here, and nobody's sorted them since."

"Are they in this office?" said Plautia.

"They're in this office." His answer went to the cake. "The old years went up the ladder."

"Then you will go up the ladder. I will sit here in the light until you are down again."

"There's no one but me in today to mind the door."

"Do you expect a crowd?"

"The boys race out on the Isthmus this morning. There's not a soul left in Corinth to come through it."

"It will hardly tax me."

He found another fig. Plautia faced him across the table, on the bench, with her veil drawn forward and her hands in her lap, and then her hands were out of her lap and there was a bundle in a napkin on the table between them. It clinked faintly on the wood. The clerk raised one corner of the napkin with his stylus. Silver, a ladle and two spoons, the spoon handles ending in swans' heads. He let the corner fall back.

Her mother's. She had told me so at the brother's door, by the porch bench, while the bearers were lifting her, in the voice she might have used to tell me the spoons were cold. The bearers had carried her through a city that had emptied itself for the games and barred its doors behind it: shutters down along every street, a fuller's vats standing full and untrodden, and at the forum's edge the fountain pouring into its basins with no one there to fill a jar. At the office door they had set her down beside a builders' scaffold, and she had stepped under it to the door.

The clerk wrapped the napkin round them twice and put it under the fig cake. He rose, taking the cake.

"The year?"

"The year my father gave me in marriage. Before the great fire at Rome. Find me the instrument of the dowry, with his seal on it, and bring it out here into the light, and I will read it with you."

"Lady." He took himself and his cake off to the store behind.

I heard the ladder take his weight. A rung creaked, and another, and high up something heavy slid along a shelf.

"Which year did you say?" His voice dropped to us from up near the roof, flat.

"A year before the fire," said Plautia.

"There's three books of it."

"Bring all three."

The ladder said what he thought of that.

I went on reading tags.

They ran left to right, and shelf by shelf downward, in years, and inside each year in the order of the numerals. "*P. VETT. L. CANIN.*," Plautia had said through the litter's curtain that morning. "Vettius and Caninius, the year Nero was here. Of that year you want the first book, which is the magistrate's own, with his games in it and everything else he signed; the second and the rest are nothing to us." I found the year two holes down from where my hand was. *VETT. CANIN. II.* Then *III.* Then *IIII.* No first.

In its place lay a book with another pair of names on the tag, a year I had already passed. In the storerooms under the museum the accession numbers ran along the shelves in their sequence, year and lot and piece, and the one out of its place was always louder than anything written on it.

I retraced the shelves to the passed year. There, between its own second and fourth books, sat a book whose tag said *VETT. CANIN. I.*

Nobody had taken it anywhere. A copyist would have had a long walk.

"Well?" Plautia asked from the table.

"It is here. In the wrong year."

"Lost, or hidden?"

"Somebody who wanted it lost and knew where to find it again."

"Be quick," said Plautia, "before he wants it."

I slid it free. It weighed more than I wanted, a dozen boards deep, each a finger thick, and the cord threaded the spine and was knotted at its head. The knot was buried in a lump of red wax with two seals pressed into it, a pair: a ship, and a head in a helmet. I propped the book on my hip and opened the front board.

Inside, the wood was hollowed into a shallow tray of black wax, and the wax was crowded with a small, slanting hand that took no trouble for anybody. The beginning of the year. Oaths. A list of names. The hire of a bath. On the second board, a contract for road gravel.

In the store the clerk said, "Highest shelf in the place. The whole run of them."

I turned two boards together, then another pair. My hands were steady. My bladder was another matter. I had drunk a beaker of water in the brother's kitchen before dawn because Myrrhine had pressed it on me, and it had waited the length of the streets for this moment to want out.

The fifth board and the sixth closed on each other, written on their inner faces only, and a narrow strip of wood between them had been left raised at the edges so the two faces would not touch. I opened them.

The writing on these was larger and rounder, for the emperor's year. A day. A magistrate's name in full. Then, near the top of the left face, the letters came one under another down the wax, and I had to read them again; the stroke for the *L* in that hand was barely a stroke at all.

C. IVLIVS. VALENS.

Under it the rest went on in the same hand: a lanista's name, the emperor's, the arena, and *liber*, and the witnesses, nine names, the last of them squeezed in where the space ran out.

The ladder creaked. He was coming down.

I closed the leaf, and the book over it, and slid the book back into its wrong place, with my hand still inside the front board, keeping the place.

The clerk emerged with three books stacked against his hip and the cake balanced on his free palm, and a cobweb across his hair. He lowered the books to the table in front of Plautia, and sat.

"It'll be the middle one. Dowries are the middle of a year. Everybody marries in the spring."

"I was married in the autumn."

"That'll be the last." He worked it free from beneath the others and untied nothing.

"Is that wax my father's?" said Plautia. "I cannot tell it from here. Read it to me."

"You read, lady."

"I can read. I wish to hear it read, every line and the witnesses after, slowly, so that my woman can write down what I tell her to."

He freed the cord. He opened the boards and found the place with his stylus. With the same stylus he dug out a fig and ate it, and began.

"*Plautia, daughter of Sextus*," he read, chewing. "*Gave*." He swallowed. "*In the name of dowry*."

I took the knife out of the writing case.

It was at the bottom, beneath the pens and the letters, in a sheath of fish-skin: a little blade with a bone handle, for cutting pens. Myrrhine had packed the case three times over in the lamplight that morning, each time tighter, while Plautia was dressed in the next room. Between the packings she had marched me to and fro behind an empty chair to cure me of her mistress's hem. "You're on it again. You'll have her over in the street. Further back. She gets down on the right, always, from a child;

her nurse was left-handed, and nobody has ever told her otherwise." Then the case again. "The knife is her grandfather's," she had said, and put it in last, at the bottom, and laid the reeds on top. "Everything in this case comes home tonight. If it goes to anybody else, I shall know whose house."

"*A slave girl, Syrian, named Doris, aged eleven*," the clerk read. "*Valued at*." He named a figure and ate a fig.

"Again. The advocate has it otherwise," Plautia said.

He read it over, slower, with the fig in his cheek, as to a child who had asked twice.

I eased the book partway out of its hole again. The cord threaded every board at the spine, around and through. I put the blade to it below the boards, as far from the seals as it ran.

The cord was linen, twisted hard and waxed, and the knife was small. I sawed. Nothing. I sawed again and felt the twist begin to go, one strand and then the next, and the third, rasping like a nail drawn down a bedsheet.

"*Earrings, two pairs, gold, with drop pearls*." A fig. "*One bronze lampstand on three feet, a lion's paws*."

The cord parted with no warning, and the book slid in my hands and the edge of a board knocked against the shelf.

The clerk stopped reading.

"My woman has dropped her pen. She is clumsy," Plautia said. "I was warned. You were at the lion's paws."

He found his place again with the stylus. His head had not moved.

I worked the cut end toward the front, hole after hole, with my fingers. It came stiffly. It had lain in those holes five years and taken their shape.

"Whose hand is it written in?" said Plautia.

"A clerk's." He turned the board. "*Witnesses*." He began on them.

The fifth and sixth boards parted from the rest together, the leaf, closed on itself. I put it into the case between two of Plautia's letters and laid the pens over it.

The loose end wanted feeding down again into the boards behind, and every hole fought it. Plautia's mother's name went by, and her mother's brother's, and a Gnaeus somebody. A drop of sweat crept down the inside of my arm and stopped at the gold on my wrist. I missed the last hole, and missed it again, and then the cord went in. Two ends of cord stood out at the bottom of the book. I tied them in a reef knot, pulled it down hard, and pushed it in against the boards.

It showed. It was a second knot on a book that had one, small and pale and naked, with no wax on it, and a clean cut end of linen sticking up from it. There was no half of that. It was done well or it was a botch, and it was a botch.

I returned the book to the wrong year, knot to the back.

"*Done at Corinth*," said the clerk, and gave the day.

"My father kept two seals, cut by the same engraver, his own and his freedman's," said Plautia. "Which is that?"

The clerk tipped the book to the open door and peered at the wax. "Your father's. The freedman's had a chip out of the rim."

Feet hurried past the scaffold outside, and a boy in a short tunic was in the doorway, panting, the road's dust gray on his shins. His eyes traveled the room and settled on the clerk.

"From the legate Arrius Celer," he said. "He's outside, and he'll not come in under the poles. He wants Vettius's first book brought out to him, for the copyist."

The clerk sat a while with a fig on the end of his stylus.

"Now?"

"He's to be back at the governor's side before the men's race."

"Tell the legate," said Plautia, "that the lady Plautia is reading her father's seal, and will come out when she has read it."

The boy stared at her veil. The doorway was empty again.

"He has chosen the same morning we chose," Plautia said to me, low, "and for the same reason. He will not walk under a ladder, nor a builder's frame; he once sent a new litter back to its maker because a ladder had leaned against it in the yard."

The clerk ate the fig. He left his stool for the shelves. His hand found the wrong year's hole at the first try; he drew the book from it and clamped it to his side, spine inward.

That morning, on the brother's roof, in the cold before sunup, Plautia had stood at the parapet in her cloak and watched the procession go out along the street below to the eastern gate: the proconsul's chair, the lictors, the magistrates on their horses, the staff behind. She had pointed, once. A man in a white toga on a gray, with his head turned to the man beside him and laughing. A boy on a pony at his stirrup, in a tunic so clean it showed in that light.

"Is that the boy?" I had said.

"That is his tunic. I did not choose it."

"The lane door," he told Plautia, in passing, "is by the oven, if you'd sooner not be kept. He'll keep you till noon." He bore it off to the colonnade.

Plautia stood up.

"I entered by the front," she said. "I will leave by it. Carry my case out to the lane, and wait there for the litter."

My way lay through the store, under the ladder, with the case against my side.

* * *

The oven was built onto the office's rear wall, and the wall itself was warm to the shoulder, and the lane in front of it smelled of hot brick and scorched bran. The step down had a hollow worn in it. Below it stood Valens, with a baker's peel in his hands and his

forearms white with flour, which was the only disguise anybody had been able to think of for him, and it fooled nobody who had ever seen a baker.

The baker stood at the mouth of his oven, raking, his back turned. He was singing a song of endless verses and no tune.

Plautia's brother had seen to him. An evening or two after the plan the brother had come home from the forum and said only, "The baker will want a loaf's worth of trouble and no more," and called for his dinner to be brought. What it cost the house nobody told me. The baker had a new leather apron that week, and greeted the house porter by name.

Valens read my face before he read the case.

"Here," I said.

I opened the case on the step and took the leaf from among the pens. He took it by its edges, a hand to each, and his thumbs left flour on the wood of the frame.

"Open it," I said. "The wax will stand it. Do not touch the writing."

The boards parted between his hands.

It was dim in the lane, with the oven's glow on one side of us and a neighbor's wall close on the other, and the black wax gave back almost nothing. He tipped the leaf toward the oven. His mouth moved on the first word, and then it stopped moving, and he read the rest of it with his lips shut, to the end of the witnesses.

"Nine," he said.

"Are they known to you?"

"Three of them are dead."

He shut it.

"And the book?" he said.

"A knot, where there should be none. Anybody who turns it over will see it."

"When?"

"Whenever somebody wants to look. He is in the colonnade. Celer. The clerk has taken the book out to him. With the knot in it. Plautia has gone out to him by the front."

"Alone."

"With her bearers."

"Her bearers are hired men off the Kenchreai road. They'll take his money too, if he offers it."

The song broke off in the middle of a verse, and I turned.

The clerk stood in the back doorway. He had crossed the office for his bread with a coin in his fingers ready for the baker, and he stood now on the worn step with his coin still raised, staring at what Valens held.

The clerk stepped down to us. He had the cobweb still across his hair.

"That's out of the emperor's year," he said.

"It's mine."

Valens held it in his two floury hands, shut, chest-high, in plain view of the clerk, and he watched the clerk's hands. They were busy holding up a coin for the baker. The clerk's sandals were old, one strap mended in a different leather, and his jaw still worked at a fig.

The clerk held the coin out past us to the baker. "Two of the round ones."

The baker had the coin off him.

"He's not opened it," said the clerk, waiting. "He'll not open it. He has a copyist who'll keep it under his bed till everybody's forgotten it. He's paid the copyist a year ahead." He found a seed in a back tooth with his tongue. "You'd want to be gone before somebody decides to remember it."

"Today," said Valens.

"I'd not know about that." The baker put two loaves into his hands, hot, and he juggled them, one hand to the other. "My grandson runs with the boys today. My daughter's boy. Twelve. He'll have run by now." He squinted at the strip of sky between the roofs, toward the Isthmus. "I'd have liked to see him lose. His father thinks he'll run at Olympia. He's told the whole lane. If the boy loses today there'll be peace in my daughter's house till the grapes are in."

He took his loaves up the step, and the office had him again.

The baker returned to his oven and rested on his rake. "Two round ones each day since the Saturnalia," he said, "and the coin held up just so, and not one word to me about rain or sun. You're to stand there till noon, the brother said."

Valens said, "It's near enough noon."

I lowered myself onto the step with the case in my lap.

"He saw it," I said. "Your hands, and what was in them. He will walk out there with his bread and tell him."

"He'll eat his bread."

"How can you know that?"

"Look at him." Valens still faced the empty doorway. "He came out for bread with that man in the colonnade waiting on him. That's a man who's had enough of the day."

He undid his tunic at the neck and slid the leaf inside it, flat, against his chest, and pulled his belt tighter over it. He laid his palm on it through the cloth.

The baker had taken up his song where he had left it.

"Get down to Felix," Valens told me.

Felix had taken the mules down to Lechaion before sunrise with the household's freedman: the dun on the front rope, the black, and the two that had found no buyer, with my bag and his own across the dun's withers, and the fig in its jar. He had gone protesting. "It's the boys' day," he had called at the gate, "the

boys, and I'm to sit on a quay with mules? Who'll tell me who won? Do they cry it out at Lechaion when somebody wins?" and the answer was "Ask a sailor," and Felix had trudged off after the dun.

"Where are you going?" I said.

"Round."

"To him."

"She's got her face to him, with hired men round her and nobody at her shoulder. He'll talk at her till she agrees to something." He gave the baker his peel. The baker took it without stopping his song. "The ship's the one with the goose carved on her stern. Felix knows it. It goes out on the afternoon breeze, whoever's on it."

He untied the sacking from round his waist and dropped it by my feet.

"Valens," I said. "He knows your face."

"He can look at it, and leave her be."

He left for the colonnade with the flour still on his arms, and I stayed on the step through another of the baker's verses. I rose with Plautia's case and followed.

* * *

The lane let me out by the colonnade's last column, into shade and then a long slope of sun. The colonnade ran away from me along the forum's whole south side, two rows of columns deep, with doors behind them, all shut for the games but one, with the scaffold in front of it.

Men had been patching the stucco on two columns where the earthquakes had cracked it, and they had built up round them a frame of fir poles lashed with rawhide, planks laid across at the height of a man's head and again above that, a lime bucket left on the upper planks with its rope coiled on top. The lashings had

been put on wet and had dried tight as iron. A mule could have stood on it.

The clerk was under it, in his doorway, eating his bread.

Plautia stood a few paces out from him, under the roof, veiled, her litter grounded behind her and its four bearers sitting on the step in a row. Valens had got there first. He had walked in under the planks and stood a pace from her, between her and the forum.

Beyond the scaffold's end the forum paving was white in the sun, and on the paving stood Celer.

The toga was brilliantly new, and the Isthmus road had powdered it down one side. Close to, he was older than his laughing had been, and very carefully shaved, and his ears jutted from his head like the handles of a cup. His litter waited behind him with its curtains looped up. One slave held a sunshade over him and had let it slip. Another, the boy who had run in to the clerk, stood at his elbow with Vettius's book hugged to his chest in both arms, spine outward.

Behind the litter stood two other men. One was a stranger. The other had a seam of new skin above his left ear, pink and puckered, where nobody had stitched it.

I stopped at Plautia's litter, by the bearers, with the case.

"There," Celer was saying. "I told the lady Plautia. I said, he'll be about somewhere close, he always was, and here you are." His voice was pleasant and unhurried, the voice of a man telling a story to listeners who had begged for it. "Lupus. Free air's put flesh on you."

"Legate," said Valens.

"Oh, not that. We were never that, were we, you and I? Come out where I can see you properly." He waved at the sunlight beside him. "No? You'll forgive me not coming in. I don't go under those."

The man with the seam had found me. He touched two fingers to the place above his ear.

"Mistress," he said.

"The lady's come to read her own dowry," Celer went on, "and I've told her she ought to have sent to me for it. I'd have had it copied out fair for her, in a good hand, and sent round to her brother's with a slave. We'd have done that, wouldn't we, Onesimus?"

"Lady didn't ask," Onesimus said, his mouth full of bread.

"I hope you found it all in order," Celer said to her. "Your father's people were always so correct."

"I found his seal," said Plautia. "It is the one mark in all that book that is his. Did he eat, this morning, before you left him?"

"Like a wolf." Celer had his answer ready. "Bread and honey, and most of my bread besides. He's with my steward at the rail, in the new tunic, and he's been told he may shout as loud as he likes, and the Corinthian boy's the favorite, so he'll shout himself hoarse."

"He will be hoarse already. Since he could stand he has shouted before anyone gave him leave; tonight, when his nurse brings him honey in warm water that she has made too hot, he will not drink it."

"His nurse knows her business," said Celer. "I'm never in the nursery. Come out tomorrow, why don't you? Look down on us from the ladies' benches, where everybody can see how well we all get on. He'd like that."

"Will you let me speak to him?"

"Of course," said Celer. "Afterward. When all this has been tidied away."

His eyes went past her, and past Valens, to me.

"And this will be Mara."

My name, in his mouth. It had come to him from the road below Delphi, with that ear.

"I write for the lady."

"So I hear. In a Latin they must teach very carefully at Syracuse." His head went round to the litter, and the men behind it. "My man tells me you carry something heavy under your dress, too, that shines. I'd like to see it one day. And she's given you the gold off her arm." His eyes rested on the band at my wrist. "She would. She always gave away what was given her; I used to tell her so. One loved her for it."

Under the veil, Plautia's chin came up a finger's breadth.

Celer turned back to Valens. He came a step nearer, and another, to the very end of the scaffold, until the toes of his good shoes were on the edge of the shadow the poles threw on the paving, and stopped there. One hand lifted, open and easy, as it must have reached for the shoulders and forearms of a thousand men in that forum, to take a fellow by the elbow and walk him a pace or two aside and tell him something for his own good; and it waited there in the sun, a long arm's length short of Valens's arm, with the planks and the rawhide and the coiled rope over the space between them; and the shadow of a pole lay across his fingers; and he looked at his hand there, in the bar of shade, as though somebody else had put it out, and hid it in his toga.

"You were the best money I ever laid out, Lupus," he said. "Two years at her back, and never a scratch on the lady."

"You hired me," said Valens.

"Did I?" said Celer. "Well. We'll let the lawyers argue that. We could make all of this very easy. Ships leave Lechaion every day now the sea's open. If a man crossed to Italy and settled, and grew old in the sun on a farm of his own, with somebody to write his letters for him, I can't see why anybody in Achaea would ever

need to say his name again. My steward put up some notices, the autumn before last. Stewards will. Notices come down."

Valens stood with his floured hands hanging at his sides. Under the flour on his tunic, where the leaf rode, the cloth sat flat and square if you knew to look for it. I knew. Celer was looking at his face.

"And the paper in Rome," said Valens.

"Papers." Celer shook out a fold of the toga where it had creased over his arm. "There's a bill of sale with the lanista's mark on it, and there's an entry in a magistrate's book, and one says one thing and one says the other, and a judge goes to sleep after his lunch and wakes up and chooses." He put out his hand again, sideways, and laid it flat on the book in his slave's arms, and patted it. "Papers are no more than that. You know that well enough. You never needed them on your mountain."

Onesimus took another bite of his bread.

"Her brother's paying my road," said Valens. "To Rome."

Celer smiled at him.

"Then we'll see each other in Rome," he said. "All of us. I'm told it's very fine in the spring." He glanced at the sun's height over the temple roofs. "And if I'm not at the governor's elbow before the men run, he'll think I've died, and give my seat to somebody he likes better. Onesimus."

"Legate."

"Shut up your door and go out and see your boy. Go on. Nobody's going to rob the proconsul this morning."

"It'll be over."

"Go and see him crowned. You'll want my ring on something, for the book?"

"Not today, legate."

"Splendid man." He was already turning to his litter. "Come and see me after the games. The house, at the second hour, any

morning. Bring Mara." He settled himself into the cushions, and the slave with the sunshade lost it altogether and had to run after it. "We'll all dine. Plautia, my mother asks after you."

Plautia said, "Let her go on asking."

The bearers lifted. The shortest way from where he sat to the street he wanted lay straight down the colonnade, in the shade, under six paces of good planking. His men carried him round instead, through the glare of the forum, round the scaffold's end and in again under the roof beyond it, the boy jogging beside them; and the book went with him, lighter by two boards, while behind the curtains he talked to somebody about the heat.

Celer's seamed man went last. Where the colonnade turned, he looked round once.

Onesimus finished his bread, fetched his cake from inside, locked the door with a key on a thong, and tried it. He eyed us under his scaffold like a bench somebody had left in his way.

"If anybody asks me tonight," he said, "the book left here for the copyist, and I was at the Isthmus by noon. You were never in."

"The spoons were my mother's," Plautia told him.

"My wife will have them on a cloth in the market by the Kalends."

"Tell her the swans are Sicyonian work, and she is not to let them go for less than that."

He dug a fig out of the cake with his thumb and ate it. "If you hear how the boys came in, send me word."

"I hope he lost," I said.

"Gods hear you."

He left under the columns, by the eastern road.

* * *

Plautia watched the litter out of the forum by its farthest corner. Then she faced us, and put back her veil, and her face under it was very white, and dry.

"When the praetor names our day, a letter will come from my brother's house," she said to Valens. "Where will the letter find you?"

"Puteoli. After that, I can't say."

"Puteoli, then, and after that the gods." She looked at the flour on his arms. "You came out under the poles."

"You were by yourself."

"I have been by myself in front of that man since I was nineteen, Valens, and I have generally managed to stand up. And you told him Rome. To his face, in the forum, with his men behind him."

"That was where he was standing."

She put out her hand for the case.

I gave it to her. "There is a knife in the bottom of it," I said, "under everything. It is a good knife. It cut the cord."

Plautia moved the pens aside with a fingertip and drew the knife out in its fish-skin for me.

"It belongs with whoever knows what it is for."

"Myrrhine said it was your grandfather's."

"Myrrhine will find you," Plautia said. "She finds everything. You will write to me from Italy, in Latin, so that my brother cannot read it over my shoulder; his Latin is worse than yours, and he will not ask for help with it. Will you?"

"I will write."

"Did you stand on my hem?"

"Twice. In the street, by the fuller's."

"Good," she said, "she will be content," and the bearers rose together, and she climbed into the litter from the right, and her curtain stayed down.

I pushed the knife into my belt. “Should I have refused it?”

“Her woman can come to Puteoli for it. Walk.”

We left the colonnade for the sun, and the paving was hot underfoot, even through my sandals.

“When will he open it?” I said.

“He’s at the Isthmus till dark. Then he goes home and eats. Then he wants his book.”

“And then?”

“By then we’re a day out to sea, wind willing.”

“The three who are dead,” I said. “Who were they?”

“The doctor at the school. He sewed me up for six years. An oil-seller who had the stall by the gate. A trainer who had me from a boy. The other six are strangers to me.”

The forum was a long white floor with nobody on it but statues and pigeons, and a woman asleep against the base of an emperor with her basket in her lap. Past the city walls and the long road, not a sound reached us of the boys running. At the forum’s north side the ground fell away to the harbor road, and at the head of it stood the arch, with a gilded bronze chariot on top of it, its horses green along their bellies.

Celer’s man, the one with the ear, sat on the rim of the fountain basin next to the arch, in the shade, with his feet in the water.

He saw us and lifted one hand, friendly, as a neighbor might from his own doorstep.

“Keep walking. Don’t look at him.”

“He is watching which road.”

“Let him watch it. It’s the only road.”

We passed beneath the arch, and him, so near I heard the water move round his ankles. The skin between my shoulders prickled under Myrrhine’s dress until the first broad step, and then the street took us.

The road to Lechaion fell from the city in long steps, broad as a room, with colonnades along both sides and shops behind the columns, and up those steps from the harbor poured the whole of the morning's ship. They came in a crowd, everybody talking: Italians in traveling hats, a family with a goat, a priest with a box on a slave's head, and in the middle of them, taller than everyone round them by a head, six or seven athletes in a knot round their trainer. They were young, enormous, oiled for the road, with their strigils and flasks hanging off rings at their belts and clinking as they climbed. The trainer was a little bald man who climbed the steps backward ahead of them, talking, and missed no footing that I saw.

Boys worked the crowd with pine. They had armfuls of it, cut that morning, the green twists of it plaited into crowns. "The god's pine! Wear what the winners wear!" One pushed a crown at the athletes and was cuffed, cheerfully, by the trainer. Another danced down a step ahead of me. "Crown, mistress? For your man? Put it on him and they'll think he won something!"

"He has," I said, and the boy dived into the crowd after somebody richer.

By the following column a man stood behind a folding table of new silver, shouting it. "Judaea taken! The emperor's new money, from Rome, for the triumph! See her weep!" On every coin on the table a woman sat in the dust beneath a palm with her head in her hand, and a soldier stood over her, and the edges of the coins were still sharp from the die. A sailor paid for one and stowed it in his belt.

A sausage-man had set up his brazier against a column at the turn of the steps. The coils on his grill spat and smoked, and his smoke, thick with cumin, rolled along under the colonnade roof. He banged his tongs on the grill. "Lucanian, all of them! The

athletes aren't let have them, their trainers say so. Everybody else!"

We pushed down against all of it. Shoulders knocked mine. A hat brim caught my cheek. Valens went first and the crowd opened in front of him, and shut behind me before I was through.

The trainer saw Valens coming and stopped dead, so that the nearest of his boxers walked into him.

"Murmillo," he said, in a Greek that was not Corinth's, to Valens's chest. "You come down a stair like one. Whose school?"

"I lead mules." Valens went by him.

"Mules!" The trainer told it to his boxers, walking backward again. "He leads mules, he says. Did you hear him?"

At the turn by the sausage-man I stopped.

"Valens."

He was back beside me at once, searching the crowd above us. "Him?"

"I have to make water."

He stared.

"I have had to since the ladder." I pointed. "There. The cookshop."

Its counter stood open to the street behind the sausage-man, and the woman at it took my obol before I had said what for and jerked her head at a curtain. Past it was a yard no wider than her counter, with a vine on the wall and, under the vine, a pot with a board across it. On the street side a fat man in a festival wreath was explaining the javelin to two of the athletes over a bowl of chickpeas. I took the board and tried to think of nothing. The fat man broke off and called through the curtain to me.

"Would you say a man throws farther with the wreath on him, or off?"

"Off."

"You see," he told the athletes, and went on. I finished, and it took an age, and then it was over.

Valens was at the counter with a crown of pine in his fist.

"For Felix," he said. "He missed the boys."

"Now? You bought it now?"

"He'll ask who won. We'll not know. He can have this."

The fountain man had vanished from the climb behind us, or was hidden in it. That meant nothing; the steps were all people.

The city ended at the bottom of the road, at an old wall gone to rubble in places and an unwatched gate, and beyond it the way ran on through the market gardens to the sea. The sun was a little past its height. A cart crawled along in front of us, going our way, and in the distance the harbor and its moles and a thin brown smudge of masts.

"His hand," I said. "At the edge of the shade. You saw it?"

"I saw where his feet stopped."

On my face, the air moved. It came inland off the water, cool, a breath of it and then a steadier push, smelling of salt and weed and pitch, and it lifted the hair off my neck.

Valens raised his face to it.

"That's the breeze," he said.

"Felix will be on the quay with the mules," I said, "telling the master how to load them."

"Asking him how."

We ran.

I ran in a borrowed dress with the hem bunched in my fist and the camera on its strap under the cloth hammering my ribs. My sandals slapped. We overtook the cart. Valens ran beside me, not in front, one hand spread on his chest over the leaf under his tunic and the pine crown in the other, shedding needles on the road. My breath went short, then raw. A stitch came, and I ran through it. The carter called after us, wanting to know which of

us was winning. Behind the cart the road to the city gate was empty. By the first gardens Felix's crown was half bald, and Valens's fingers were sticky with it.

"Will they wait?" I said.

"No."

Somebody's washing was spread along a garden wall to dry, and Valens's shoulder swept a tunic off it into the road. The wind blew harder into our faces, and the gardens went by on both sides, beans and cabbages and a man with a hoe who straightened to watch us pass. The smudge at the end of the road was masts now, each one separate, and hulls under them, and the long arm of the mole. At the harbor, beyond the last of the gardens, a sail was going up.

Chapter 18

Lechaion

I reached the quay from the garden road with the taste of blood in my mouth from running, and the whole harbor reeked of pitch going soft in the sun. The stone was dry and glaring underfoot, and a wind straight in off the water flattened my dress against my legs; across the basin a man sat in a beached boat mending a net and whistling, as if the afternoon were his to spend.

What I saw first, and clearly, was the goose, rising above the stern of a ship halfway along the quay. It was carved out of the sternpost itself, the whole neck one unbroken curve that came back over the deck, so that the head eyed the water. Its white paint was lifting off the feathers in flakes, and its beak was red. A gangplank sloped from the stern to the stone, and on the end of it sat Felix, astride, with his heels hooked under the wood and a fist clamped on each edge.

Three sailors on the deck had hold of the plank's upper end and were trying to draw it aboard. Each time they hauled, it scraped along the paving a short way with Felix riding it. Behind him our four mules stood roped to an iron ring let into the quay, and at every scrape they flung their heads up and leaned back against their ropes, the dun loudest.

Over the goose's head they were hoisting the sail. The men round the mast hauled on a single rope, hand over hand, let it slip, and hauled again, and the yard climbed in jerks with the linen bunched under it. Lines hung down the sail's face through rows of small lead rings and held it gathered to the yard like a blind on its cords. Off the bow a rowing boat lay on the water with its oars shipped and a slack line running from its stern to the ship, and the rowers were eating.

"Valens!" Felix had seen us, and he shouted it without loosening his grip on the wood. "He won't take us! He's had them pulling at this since the shadow was over by that post, and I told him you'd come, I told him you'd come running and you'd tell him yourself, and he says it's not the fare and it's not the mules. Where've you been? Why are your arms white?"

Valens stopped at the foot of the plank with the pine crown mashed in his grip. He put his free hand flat against the ship's side and got his wind back in long hauls through the nose.

"Where's the freedman?"

"Gone back up for the men's race. He paid, and he said you'd be along, and he went. Are you along? Only you two? Where's the lady with the litter?"

At the stern rail, under the goose's neck, stood a broad man in a leather cap with his tunic hitched up through his belt. He had a sandal on his right foot, but the left was bare and very white, and he kept it clear of the boards.

"You'll be the muleteer," he said, with no great liking for the flour on him.

"Valens. A freedman from the city paid you."

"He paid me at sunrise, for a muleteer and a wife and a boy, and their mules, and a young fig with its roots in a jar." The master's Latin was quick and hard, a harbor Latin stuffed with sailors' Greek, and he stayed at the rail to use it on us. "I have the

boy, and I have the mules and the tree. Your boy's been on that plank since the third hour, telling the crew about a mountain. When they asked him, to pass the morning, how long his master had been married, he told them you aren't."

"I said she wasn't married." Felix twisted round on the plank to put his face up at the master. "That's all I said. They asked was she, and she isn't, or if she is, it's news to me. Who married her? When was it? Wouldn't I have been there?"

The master spread his hands. "Every man on my deck heard him."

My hem was still hitched up in my hand. The run was in my legs and my ears were full of my own blood.

"I'll pay the fare again," Valens said.

"It isn't the fare." The master squinted past the mole to where the water had gone dark and rough under the breeze. "My girl's aboard. She was married at the Kalends to a man at Puteoli she's never set eyes on, and I'm taking her to his mother's house, and his mother will have the name of every soul who slept on this deck out of her before she's got her cloak off. A husband with his wife and their lad, she'll swallow. A man your size, with that face, running a woman out of Corinth on a feast day, and a boy to say she's no man's wife, she will not swallow, and nor will the magistrate's people at Puteoli, if somebody's..." The rest of it outran me. "I carried a man's wife once. Her husband's brothers came aboard at Ostia with cudgels, and mine was six, and she saw it."

At the rail amidships a girl in a blue hood was eating a cucumber from the end, and watching us over it.

"You were told wife," Valens said.

"Wife is what I was told, with a purse to go with it, and then he was away to the races before I'd weighed what was in it. Your boy told me otherwise for nothing."

"Is there another ship for Italy?"

"Not out of this harbor before the Ides, and that one's carrying marble, and she won't take a mule."

"I asked them all," said Felix. "All morning, each of them along the mole, while you were up there. Not one of them's going over but him."

I found breath enough for Latin, barely. "I am a free woman," I said. "I am registered at Delphi, as a kinswoman of the house of—"

"They don't keep Delphi's rolls at Puteoli." He spoke to Valens. "I'll put no man's wife aboard, nor any man's woman either."

"Nobody's coming after her."

"Then she's nobody's, which is worse." The master scowled up at the yard. "Marry her, then, if you mean to, and be quick. That one at the plank can stand for it, and the boy. It wants no priest and no cake, only the two of you saying so with two others to hear it, and I don't care to be told how they manage it in Corinth. You have till the yard's at the top."

"Here?" Felix was up on his feet on the plank. "On the stones? With no torches? Who throws the nuts? You can't be married without nuts; they threw them at a bride at Kirrha till she hid behind her mother."

"Throw a nut at this ship and you'll swim after her."

The yard went up another length of rope while he said it, and stopped, and went up again. One of the men at the mast laughed. "Haul now, and laugh at Puteoli," the sailor at the head of the plank told him, and that put an end to it.

The girl in the blue hood had eaten through to the last of her cucumber, the bitter knob at the stalk, and was holding it up to look at. My mother had cut that end off every cucumber she ever bought and rubbed the two cut faces together at the sink until a

white froth came up between them, and rinsed it off under the tap, and then she had eaten the end herself, standing, with salt.

Valens faced me with flour dried white in the hair of his forearms and the crown hanging from his hand.

"Will you be my wife, Mara?"

"Yes. Will you?"

"Yes," said Valens.

Up at the plank's head the sailor, a gray man stained with tar, had his forearms folded on the rail to hear it. "Is that all of it?" he said. "Is that them married? Then get your mules up, by Pollux, the yard's nearly there. Pacuvius, they're done."

"I heard."

Felix had loosed his hold on the plank, and he was crying open-mouthed, like a boy half his age, out loud and without stopping, and the tears ran into the corners of his mouth; he scrubbed at them with the heel of his hand and they came faster.

"It's the nuts," he said. "There should have been nuts. Don't look at me."

"We are all of us watching the yard," I told him.

Valens held out the crown. Felix took it and put it on, and cried underneath it.

"From the boys? Were you there when they came in? Which one had it?"

"We were the only two people leaving," I said.

"I'd money on the small Sicyonian," the sailor told the harbor.

The master's daughter had taken the cucumber out of her mouth. "Father," she called along the deck, "was mine like that?"

"Yours had a cake," said the master, and the girl considered that and dropped the bitter end over the rail into the harbor. To Valens he said, "A muleteer, then, with a wife and a boy. As I was told at sunrise, and nobody on my ship has lied to anybody. Get

them aboard." He set the bare foot down on the boards with care. "And if any of you sees a sandal floating past the mole, it's mine."

By then Valens had the thong of his pouch undone. He took out the watch and laid it in my hand.

The case was warm from him. There was flour packed in the links of the band and a bloom of it on the crystal over the small nick by the two, and I wiped it clean with my thumb. Beneath, the finest of the three hands swept on, small and steady, the only thing moving on that quay that nobody was shouting at. I put my nail to the crown to give it its turns, and it took two and stood hard.

The hands were at twenty to one, and beside my foot the mooring post laid a short shadow on the stone, tipped a little east.

Valens was minding the dun.

I opened the clasp and put the steel about my left wrist, and it came down against Plautia's gold. Gold that soft took a scratch from anything, and it had a child's teeth in it already. I took the watch off again and held my right arm out to Valens instead.

He closed the clasp for me, and his thumb was too broad for the catch, so he found its lip with the edge of his nail and pressed. His fingers smelled of bread, and once the catch was home he released my wrist.

The watch sat on the wrong wrist and ticked.

Felix had the dun loose from the ring, and he brought her to the plank's end with the crown sliding sideways and his face still wet. "Best plank in Lechaion, that." She put one forefoot on the wood. The plank gave under it and sprang along its whole length between the quay and the ship, a slow bounce like a diving board after a jump, and the dun took her foot back and set all four on the stone and leaned away until the rope between her and Felix was a bar.

"On, you," said Felix. "You went on a boat before. You went on the boat at Kirrha and you hated it and you never died of it. Who ever died of a plank?"

He hauled. She leaned. He slid toward her a step at a time, his heels skidding on the wood.

"Hold her head, boy, and I'll warm her up behind," said the tar-handed sailor, and he edged past Felix with a rope's end.

"Keep off her heels," Valens called, and the sailor turned to answer him.

The dun kicked with both hind feet together, and the sailor went over backward across a coil of cable and landed seated in it.

"I stood witness for you," the sailor said. "I stood up and witnessed for you, and that's your mule."

Out on the water the rowers got to their feet and cheered him. "Give him another!" one of them shouted. At the ring the black had dragged her knot loose and was off, trotting, her rope snaking after her straight through a fish-seller's baskets, so that sprats skated over the stone in a bright spill; the fish-seller threw one after her.

"Who's paying for those?" the fish-seller shouted. "That black's yours, is she?"

"The boy's," said Valens.

"Mine? With what?" Felix, still hauling, had the crown over one eye. "With a crown that's got no leaves on it?"

"The yard's up!" the master shouted. "Muleteer! Aboard or off the plank, the lot of you, and I'm not particular which!"

The yard had risen hard under the masthead and stopped, and the men at the rope were making it fast to a pin, and the sail hung beneath it in its lines, waiting to be let down. On the mole somebody was lifting the stern rope off its post.

Valens had gone after the black. "Cover her eyes, Felix. Her eyes."

Felix peeled off his tunic. The crown came with it, and I caught it before it reached the slot of water by the hull. He stood on the plank in his loincloth with every rib showing, threw the tunic over the dun's face and knotted its sleeves beneath her head, and the dun stood still in the dark he had made her, with her ears turning.

I put the crown back on him.

He led her up by the knotted sleeves. She went with her nose low, feeling for the plank with each forefoot before she stepped; the plank sprang under her and she went on anyway. The other two came after her with no more urging than the dun's tail in front of their noses. Valens brought the black back with a sprat scale stuck to her nose and her flanks dark with sweat, and she went up behind them.

Felix's head appeared at the stern rail beside the goose, bare-shouldered and crowned. "Do I get my tunic back," he called, "or is she wearing it to Italy?"

"Ask her," I said.

The fig was all that was left on the quay, in its jar by the ring, and me.

Valens was on the plank again, coming for it, and took the jar's rim on his side, and I took mine, and the little tree shook all its leaves between us.

"Tread on the cleats," he said. "It gives in the middle."

We went up together under the goose, with the plank bouncing under the weight of us both and the jar kept level.

They drew the plank in after us.

Chapter 19

Puteoli

Puteoli · spring, AD 72

By the twelfth morning of my marriage Pacuvius's goose ship was coming round the last cape into the bay, and I had slept all eleven nights before it on her deck, between my husband and a mule. The mules stood amidships inside a square of hurdles lashed to ring-bolts, the four of them in a row with their heads over the topmost rail and their ears laid back at the sea. Valens slept along the outside of the hurdles with his shoulders to them, and I slept along Valens. Felix slept wherever a sailor had last moved him on from, which by the third night was the coil of the anchor cable up in the bows; Pacuvius's girl slept under an awning at the stern with her father across its opening on a folded sail. Nobody aboard that ship had a door to shut on anybody.

We had cleared Lechaion before evening and gone west down the gulf for two days, Achaea on one hand, the mountains of Phocis on the other, until the shores pinched in at the narrows; Felix hung over the rail there. "I could spit on the pair of them from here, Achaea to the left and the Locrians to the right, and never shift my feet. Which shall I do first?" Beyond the narrows the islands stood off in the haze. Beyond the islands came two days with no land anywhere, when the master went to the stern

each evening with a cup, poured some of it on the water, and prayed in a voice he never used on us. Italy, on the sixth morning, was a low brown line in the west that Felix refused to believe was a country. We went down its coast and round the toe of it, and the Straits took the best part of a day; the crew told Felix about the whirlpool on the Sicilian side, each man improving on the version before his, until he went and sat with the mules. The master's girl, Pacuvia, was sick for every mile of the Straits and well again by daylight. Every evening after that she sat under her awning and practiced the greeting she meant to give her husband's mother, "Mother of my husband, my father greets your house, and I enter it gladly," in a whisper at first and then aloud, until the steersman could say it with her.

On the eighth night, off some coast none of us could see, Valens put out a hand in the dark and closed it round my ankle, and did not let go till morning, as if the ship might take it into her head to drop me overboard. That was the nearest we came, in eleven days, to being married in private.

On the morning we made the bay, in the last of the dark, Pacuvia found me at the hurdles, where I was trying to get my hair into order of a sort without a comb. She had on her good blue, and a brooch in her fist.

"It won't hold," she said. "The pin. It goes in and it comes out again. She'll look at my brooch before she looks at my face, my father says she looks at everybody's brooch, and if it won't hold I'll have to fasten myself up with a thorn."

It was a bow brooch of bronze, the cheap kind, the pin cast together with the bow, and the pin had sprung where it coiled at the head, so that it lay slack against the catch and jumped free of it at a touch. The coil wanted closing by a hair. I had nothing to do it with except the knife Plautia had given me out of her case, which I still had in my belt. I worked the point of the little blade

in between the turns of the coil and levered them close against the flat of it, slowly, a fraction and then another fraction, with the girl's breath on my knuckles the whole while, until the pin came up against the catch with some spirit in it and held there when I shook it.

She pinned her hood with the brooch, unfastened it, and pinned it again twice more to be sure.

"My mother had one that did that," she said. "She stopped it with wax." She was already going aft. "Don't tell my father it was broken," she said over the bundles, and was gone to show him.

The bay opened as the sun rose. We came past an island that stood out of the water on cliffs, and a cape with a temple on its end and a fisherman's nets spread to dry along the temple's stair; when the cape had dropped astern the whole curve of the shore lay ahead, bending away north and then west beyond where my eyes could hold it, with towns along it and the white fronts of villas down at the water between the towns. The water was so still that a fishing boat a mile off drew lines on it with its oars, and the lines held.

I had been watching for the mountain since first light and getting it wrong. I had picked out a ridge behind the cape, and then, as we cleared it, a hump of hill beyond the big town on the north shore, because what I wanted was the outline painted on the wall over the ovens of every pizzeria on Passyunk Avenue, two humps with a fishing village at their feet, and the mountain had only the one.

It stood at the head of the bay where it had to stand, between Neapolis and a town I could not yet see. The slope began at the beach and rose so long and so gradual that a man might have walked it all morning without noticing he was climbing, and from the rail it was green. Vines ran in rows across the lower ground, with farms set down among them and their tiled roofs

catching the light; a belt of darker woods ran round the mountain higher up; above the woods was the top, broad and rounded and bare, with pale stone showing through the scrub.

With straw from the hurdles still on his tunic, Valens leaned his forearms on the rail beside mine.

"Fine mountain for vines," he said.

"Very fine," I said.

I agreed with him, and I was glad he had said it, and I studied the farms on its lower slopes until I could have drawn them.

The black had her teeth in the hurdle lashing again, and he left me to see to it.

I drew the Pentax up by its strap from under my dress, where it had hung since Lechaion, and the pushed-in place on the lens's front ring flashed as it cleared the cloth. I put it to my eye, and in the finder the mountain was small enough to cover with a thumb, very green, with the edge of the sail clipping the sky on the left and a gull flying through it once. I turned the ring until the farms came sharp, and my forefinger found the shutter button and rested there.

Seventy-nine. It came unasked, two figures with nothing round them, while the mountain stood small and green in the glass.

My finger left the button. I let the Pentax hang against my stomach on its strap for a time before I fed it back under my dress, and the mountain on the other shore went on being green.

Up in the bows Felix was shouting at a long ship that rounded the headland at the far western end of the bay, low and narrow and painted dark, with a bank of oars down each side working together and a small sail furled on a mast that raked forward over her bow. The oars came up wet and flashing, went in again, came up. She passed us at a great distance and fast; her wake crossed the still water and rocked the mules long after she had gone.

"What ship's that, the emperor's? Who's rowing it? How many are under there?" Felix had one foot on the rail. "Will they take a free man, if he goes and asks?"

"That's the fleet out of Misenum," Pacuvius called from his stern, "and they'll take a free boy if he goes and asks them, and they'll sit him on a bench under the deck where he never sees the sky, and he can row the admiral round this bay till his beard comes in gray. Go and ask."

Felix took his foot off the rail.

"I wasn't going to," he said.

* * *

Puteoli's mole marched seaward on arches. It was a road carried on piers, a long row of them, with the swell running in under each arch and out beyond it, and along its top went a paving with columns set at intervals and a statue on every column, men in togas streaked white by gulls. The piers were concrete, poured somehow under water and faced with brick, and the sea had eaten the brick off the lowest courses and bared the gray core, packed full of pebbles, with a fringe of green weed along each pier that lifted and lay down again with every swell. The crew got out the long sweeps and walked us in along it to a berth near the shore end, between grain ships from Alexandria that were broader than anything at Lechaion and carried a little three-cornered sail high on the mast above the yard.

The quay was crowded from the water's edge to the warehouse doors. Porters went to and fro on the planks of the Alexandrians with sacks on their shoulders and their heads down, and grain dust from the sacks settled in their hair. A man was selling something fried in oil out of a pan on a brazier, and a priest in white linen with his head shaved was arguing with him

about it. A dog slept at the foot of a plank, and the porters stepped round it.

Pacuvia went down our plank first, with the brooch at her throat, and her father behind her for once instead of at the rail. The mother-in-law was waiting at the foot, a small woman in brown, with one slave holding a parasol above her and another holding nothing, and she read the brooch before she read the face. The girl said her greeting, the whole of it, in her careful Latin, with her fingers laced in front of her, and the old lady heard her out to the end and answered her in Greek, quick Greek, the Greek of the quays, of which I caught perhaps half: that the house was up at the highest part of the town, that there was fish, and the girl thinner than she had been told. The question she put next was about us.

"Those on your father's deck, who are they?"

"Married people," the girl told her, and her Greek was suddenly as good as anybody's. "Corinthians. They had mules."

She looked at us once, and at Valens for longer, and turned to the porters about the girl's chest.

Where the mole met the land an awning had been stretched between two columns, and under it the harbor's man had a table, with tablets stacked at one end, and a slave behind him holding a case of styluses. Every bale and beast landed on that mole went past that table. When we reached it with the mules he had Pacuvius's list of cargo up in front of his face, so near that the wax all but touched the end of his nose, and he was reading it there, moving it from side to side by small degrees, while Pacuvius loomed at his shoulder, telling him what was on it quicker than he could read. The clerk was long in the neck, with his hair combed forward, and there was a smudge of black on the tip of his nose.

He lowered the list, wrote something on a tablet, and turned his long neck toward our mules.

"Beasts for sale?" he said.

"They work," said Valens. "They're mine."

"And that?"

The fig was on the stones at Felix's feet, jar and all.

"It's a fig," Valens answered.

The clerk made another note, and the slave behind him moved the case of styluses into the crook of the other arm. "Your name."

"Valens. Gaius Iulius."

The stylus stopped. "Freedman of whom?"

Valens reached under his tunic for the leaf and opened its two boards on the table. The clerk lifted it to his nose and read it there, slowly, one board and then the other. He left it lying open, came out from behind his table, and stood in front of Valens to peer up into his face from nearer than I had ever seen one man look at another in a street.

Valens let him, and stood as still as the column beside the table, gazing over the clerk's head at the water.

"Corinth," the clerk said. "Nero's year." He returned to his stool and wrote. "That was a lucky year for some. And the woman?"

"His," said Pacuvius, behind us. "Married at Lechaion, on the stones, in front of my crew, and I'll swear to it here or anywhere you like."

"And the lad?"

"I'm free," said Felix. "He freed me himself, at Kirrha, in front of the slaver and the whole quay. Shall I show you? There's nothing to show, he only said so. Isn't that enough here? It was enough at Kirrha."

The clerk brought his tablet up to his nose and read over what he had written. “Plenty,” he said, and waved us on, and reached for the next man’s list.

“If it’s letters you’re waiting on,” Pacuvius told Valens, “there’s a wine-shop at the foot of the street with a board hung behind its door, and every master on this run leaves his letters on that board, and not one of us carries a letter a step past it, me least of all. That’s the last I’ll say to you.” He was back up his own plank before anyone had thanked him.

The leaf went back under Valens’s tunic, with his belt drawn tight over it. We went along the waterfront, the mules behind us in a string, and he held his tongue until we were clear of the awning and the porters and the dog.

“He knew me,” he said.

“He has your name. It is in his wax now.”

“He walked round his table to look at my face.”

“He read the master’s list with his nose in it,” I said. “He read his own writing with his nose in it. He has black wax on the end of his nose from doing it.”

“He did that to no other man on the mole. He’ll know me again.”

“He’s wax on his nose like a pig’s been at a candle,” said Felix. “See it? Does he eat it?”

At the end of the quay Valens glanced behind us once. Under the awning the clerk had a sailor’s tablet up against his face, and the sailor was waving his arms at him.

The wine-shop was the first door off the quay, before the street started uphill into the town, and the board inside it was hung with ships’ letters, tied up in thread and tagged with the names of whoever had still to fetch them. Valens ducked in while Felix and I held the mules. While he was in there I watched the

women landing from the boats for Myrrhine, with her lady's knife in my belt and no ship but ours yet in from Lechaion.

"Anything that comes by sea from Corinth for Valens the muleteer," I heard him say inside, "keep it on your board for me."

"Who'll it be from?" the wine-woman said.

"A lady's brother."

"And where do I send when it comes? I don't send, mind. Somebody comes for it, or it stays on the board till it's eaten."

"Pompeii," he said. "I'll send to you."

Valens reappeared with a beaker of wine for each of us that nobody had asked him to buy, and we drank standing in the street with the mules' noses at our shoulders; by mid-afternoon we were out of Puteoli on the road east, with the harbor below us on the right and the smells of the town thinning out as we climbed.

* * *

The road to Neapolis went into a hill. A ridge ran down to the sea between Puteoli and the city, and somebody under Augustus had cut a road clean through the foot of it rather than go round: a tunnel as high as a house and wide enough for two carts to pass if both drivers were patient. At its mouth boys with pine torches were waiting for custom.

"Light you through, mistress? A copper, and you'll see your own feet."

"Do you live in there?" Felix asked. "Give me one. I've the steadiest hand on this road."

"You can carry your mule," the torch boy said, and Valens paid two of them and sent them on ahead.

The dust lay ankle deep and rose with each step into the torchlight, so that the boys in front walked in two balls of brown fog, and the dust was up my nose and in the creases of my eyelids

before we had gone fifty paces. The carts bound for Puteoli announced themselves from far off, their wheels and their drivers' voices booming along the rock, and then loomed out of the fog almost against us, with their lamps swinging and the oxen's breath on the air. The mules kept their ears flat in there and gave no trouble. Far ahead a small gray patch hung in the dark that I was slow to believe was the end. When the sun found us again beyond the hill, mules and people were one color. Felix spat brown at the verge. "That's half of Italy I've eaten already, and the rest of it's up my nose. Are there more hills like that before Pompeii?"

Neapolis spoke Greek, and I heard it before we were through the gate: a woman on a balcony scolding a child in Greek with its vowels drawn out longer than they were drawn in Phocis, "Come in off that roof, come in now, or your father hears where you were yesterday," and I stood under her balcony for the rest of it. There were Greek letters cut over the doors and Greek names on the shop boards, and in a colonnade by the market old men in Greek cloaks sat arguing about something with enormous pleasure.

"In a city this big," Felix asked one of them, "where's the fighting? Who's your best man? I'd put him down for you."

"Footraces," the old man said, "and the lyre, and poets. Every four years, for the emperor."

Felix left him with his face screwed up tight.

We slept that night at an inn beyond the city's eastern gate, on the road along the shore, where a little river reached the sea through a bed of reeds. A woman with a ring of keys at her belt met us in the yard.

"Mats upstairs, two coppers a head. The beasts are four the lot, and the boy sleeps with them or pays for a mat like anybody. Money first. The last lot left in the night and owed me."

The mules went into stalls round her yard. There was a fig growing in the yard, and Valens walked round it once and came away, and Felix went in with the mules. The inn's room for travelers was a long loft up in the roof with mats along both walls. Two carters from Nola, taking cheese to Puteoli in the morning and smelling of it, had taken the end under the gable already, with their cloaks over their heads, and we had the end by the ladder.

Through a slot where a tile had slipped against its neighbor, three stars showed, and part of a fourth. With a bit of lead and a hammer that tile would have been back in its course in the time it took to say so, and I lay working out how I would get up to it from the ladder.

"This town of yours." Valens's mouth was very near my ear. "Where do the beasts drink?"

"At the street corners. There are fountains every few houses. The water comes in under the paving, in pipes of lead."

"Carting? Who wants it?"

"Everybody. They are still building."

"Building what?"

"Building back. There was an earthquake, ten years ago, nearly to the season. It brought down half of what was standing."

"Ten years," he said. "They're slow."

"Some of us," said one of the carters, slow with sleep and muffled by his cloak, "have cheese to sell on the Puteoli quay by sunup, and a wife there who can tell from the cheese what time I sold it."

Valens laughed once under his breath, and settled. Soon his breathing changed, and so did the carters', and below us a mule knocked a hoof against her stall and was still.

In the morning the carters were gone before us, and Felix was in the yard with their news.

"They've a school for fighters there, the cheese men said, and an amphitheater that'll seat every soul in town and their neighbors with it, and the neighbors came to the games once and carried half their men home. They fought it out on the benches. Stones and knives. And the Senate at Rome stopped their games for ten years over it." He was outraged for them. "And all that while they had to go by it empty. They're back now, every spring, the cheese men said. Will it be this spring? Have we missed it?"

"We've a mule with a loose shoe," Valens said. "Hold her."

It was the black's off fore, in the iron sole they laced over a hoof for stony roads, and its straps had worked slack overnight. Valens had the hoof clamped up on his leg and the lacing threaded through its rings; he drew it tight, tried it with his thumb, and set the foot down, and the black stamped it twice on the stones of the yard to learn if she liked it, and decided against.

All that second day the road kept to the shore between the sea and the mountain. On the sea side there were villas in a string, built out on the rocks with their porticoes over the water, and below them fishponds hewn in the rock and fed by the tide; at one a slave stood in a little boat in the middle of the pond scattering something, and the water round his boat thrashed. On the land side the vines were trained up elms planted in lines across the fields, the vines' arms tied into the trees with withies and slung across in swags from one tree to the next, so that every field was a long colonnade of green. The Romans called that marrying the vine to the elm. Twelve days into my own, I was in no position to laugh at anybody.

On the left the mountain came down so near the road now that its farms were farms: dogs on the walls, washing spread on the roofs, a woman high up on a threshing floor who straightened her back as we passed below and watched us before

she took up her flail again. From that close it was simply farmland, tipped up on end.

We ate at noon on a bank at the roadside, bread and a hard cheese Felix had bought off the carters, with wine from a farm gate; it had been made on the hillside over our heads, and the jar it came in had been lined with pitch, and the wine had taken the pitch into itself. Valens drank his and lifted his eyes to the vines it had come from, and sent Felix back to the farm gate for another jug.

The road took us through the edge of a small town on a spur of ground between two streams, with its houses built close down to the sea, and on past more villas, and in the last of the afternoon down near the shore again to salt pans: shallow square beds of seawater shut off from the sea by low banks, crusted white at their edges, with men in loincloths raking the crust up into heaps that shone.

"Up on the crown with them," Valens told Felix there. "The edges won't bear a loaded beast."

We came to Pompeii from the shore road, up a long slope between tombs. I walked at the dun's shoulder and read every tomb front that faced me as we climbed, and there were plenty to read: curved stone benches with lion's feet at their ends, altars on stepped bases taller than a house, real doors of marble on two or three, shut fast, and on none of them anything painted in the shape of a door. At the top of the slope the gate barred the way with three openings in it, a broad one in the middle for wheels and a narrow one each side for feet, and the town's walls running off from it on both hands.

* * *

Past the gate the street ran downhill between high curbs, paved with big gray blocks of lava jointed in no pattern at all and worn

into two deep ruts by wheels, and at the first corner three tall stones stood across it in a line, spaced so that a cart's wheels would go between them and a person's feet over them. The mules had never met anything of the kind, so Valens himself walked the dun through between the stones, talking to her, with his other hand on the stone she was eyeing, and the others followed her because she had gone.

All of that town was being mended; half the houses on that first street had something wrong with their fronts and somebody seeing to it. One was held up by props, big timbers slanted out from its wall into the roadway and wedged against the curb, and the mules had to be led round them close under its eaves. On another a mason up a ladder was pointing the joints of a brick patch the size of a bed, singing to himself, and the song dropped down the ladder in pieces whenever his head came round. Where two streets crossed, a temple was getting new columns, fresh drums of pale yellowish stone stacked on old gray ones that had been left standing to the height of a man, and the next drum rose on a rope by small jerks while two boys trod a great wheel at the crane's foot and shouted to each other inside it. The black nosed into a trench where the paving had been lifted for a new lead pipe, and Felix dragged her out of it by the halter.

At the next corner, on a house wall painted red to above the doorframe, a crack had been filled and painted over, eaves to curb, and the red they had painted it with had dried pinker than the wall. It made a stripe a hand wide down the house's front. People were walking past it, and two doors down a woman was leaning on it, talking to a girl with a basket. My thumbnail was in the edge of the stripe, feeling where the new plaster had been laid over the old with nothing to key it to. A join showed or it did not. This one showed to everybody who came down that street, and the plasterer should have been made to stand in front of it from

dawn to dark and hear what they said. Valens called my name from the corner, and I took my thumbnail out of the house.

On almost every wall, over the shopfronts, between the doors, on the house fronts themselves, names had been painted up in red and black in tall careful letters, and every name was asking to be made something. Where Valens stood, a white panel had been plastered onto the wall expressly to carry one of them, and Felix had planted himself before it with his hands on his hips.

"Thirty pairs," Felix announced, loud enough for everyone at the crossing. "Thirty pairs of fighters, at the Ides, and beasts, and the awnings up for the sun the whole day. See? There. They're giving games."

What the panel said, in big red capitals, was that the muleteers asked you to make Marcus Satrius Proculus aedile, and that he was a man worthy of it.

"Thirty pairs," said Valens. "In a town this size."

Felix lingered by the panel, mouthing at the shapes of it, and then caught us up and went along ahead of the dun, facing us, to tell us which day the Ides fell on. "That's mid-month, so it's only days off. Will they have a net man? Who'll they put up against him? Can we get in, if we're carting that day?"

Further down, on a long straight street running east, we stopped at a crossing to let a cart by, and Valens said, low, "The muleteers have a man, then."

The woman whose counter we had halted beside spoke before we could move on.

"You'll take those beasts off my front or you'll buy something," she said, "one or the other, they're standing in my custom, and you'll not find a better hot wine this side of the forum, there's pepper in it, so you may as well buy it as stand there."

Her counter ran out to the street's edge, faced with offcuts of colored marble, green and yellow and a purple shot through with white, pieced together wherever a piece would fit; set into its top were the mouths of big jars sunk into the masonry, with wooden lids on them and a ladle hung on the lip of each. A pot steamed on a brazier at the inner end. The keeper of it was perhaps forty, broad, quick, with her sleeves pinned up above the elbow and a scald scar on one forearm. Valens bought three cups, and she filled them and kept talking.

"You've come off a ship and then a road, it's on you plain, the both of them," she said, "and the boy's walking still as though the street's heaving under him, that'll pass, it takes a day for every day you were on the water, my husband's brother says, and he should know, he's never been off one. Rooms is what you want, and tonight, near a gate for the beasts but not too near; there's an inn at the Sarno Gate will stable them and rob you, and one at the Stabian will stable them and rob you less. And work for him, there's not a man here with a beast and a back to him that's not carting, it's been carts and dust since the earth went, and the forum still looks like a builder's yard. Drink that before it cools."

The wine was hot, and the pepper in it shot up the back of my nose.

"Are there rooms to be had?" I said.

"Rooms, I said, and I've got them." She caught a pinch of my sleeve and talked on holding it, her fingers warm from the pot. "Next door. It was a cobbler's, and the cobbler died owing me the winter, and his nephew walked in from Nola and took the leather and left me the smell. A shop on the street, two rooms behind, a stair to the roof. Twenty-four sesterces the month and the first month now, and the water's at the corner, and you'll not wash anything in my jars. You're Greek, you've the walk, and you've

not been married long, you stand too near him for that. It wears off."

"Twelve days," I said.

"Well, then." She took her hand back to stir the pot. "Pomponia Grata. Everybody says Grata, and anybody who says otherwise is after something. My husband's in the back. If you hear dice, that's him, and if you hear shouting after the dice, that's me."

Valens paid her the first month from the purse at his belt, and the money vanished into her clothes, and she touched him on the arm as she went by him to the door next to hers. He looked at the place on his sleeve where her hand had been.

The cobbler's shop had a wide opening on the street with a row of grooved stones along the sill to take the boards of its shutters, and the boards stood stacked inside along one wall. The floor was beaten earth, and in a corner lay a wooden last, too broken to be worth taking, with a cobweb strung from it to the plaster. Behind the shop lay two rooms with a door between them. The back one had a bed frame whose cord had rotted through near one leg, a window set high up onto a light-well, and a stair of wooden treads climbing the outside of the house at the back to the roof.

Valens had the fig on the roof before he had looked at the bed. Felix took the mules off to the inn Grata had named, to be robbed less, and Grata sent her directions after him the length of three houses. "Left at the fountain with the bull's head on it, and straight on down till you've the gate in front of you, the yard's on your right, and if he stables that black of yours next to anything he values he'll be sorry, she's had a go at my awning already."

When the boy had gone, and the light in the window had turned yellow, Valens took a seat on the end of the bed frame, and the cord at the rotten end let him down an inch.

"Which gate is nearest?" he said.

"The Stabian. Back to the crossing with the fountain, then left, and down that street as far as it goes."

"Tomorrow I'm out at that gate after carting, with the string."

"Then I shall walk out by myself," I said, "in the afternoon."

"There'll be men sleeping in those tombs."

"In the afternoon they will be awake."

"Go when the road's full," he said, "and keep to it going and coming."

The door between the rooms was planks on leather hinges, with a bar to drop across it on the inside. He rose and shut it, set the bar in its brackets and lifted it clear, opened it, and closed it once more, slowly, to see how it hung on its leather.

"It sticks at the sill," he said.

I put my back against it and pushed, and it went the rest of the way into its frame.

* * *

Valens and Felix had left with the string in the dark, to a contractor at the Stabian Gate who paid by the load for anything with four legs that would carry rubble out of the town. I woke alone in a room with a door, and lay looking at the bar leaning beside it.

The cobbler had left the shop floor full of himself: crescents and tags of leather trodden into the earth everywhere, a scatter of nails, a bone awl with its point snapped off. I was on the floor prising the leather loose with the broken awl when Grata put her head in at the opening with a cup in each hand. She gave me one, stood on the sill and drank the other, and gave me the street.

"The fuller at the corner beats his wife on market days and she beats him back on feast days, so it comes out even. The baker over the way has a new oven that draws badly, so don't buy his

bread before the third hour. That house with the props in front of it belongs to a man in Nuceria who won't mend it till the town pays him to, and the town won't, so there it'll stand on its sticks till one of them gives in. And the woman at the fountain with the blue jar will take in your washing and lose half of it, and swear on her mother she never had it."

I had kept the fuller and his wife out of all that, and lost the baker entirely.

"The baker," I said. "Again, and more slowly."

"Him opposite, new oven, bad draw, buy late," said Grata, no slower and much louder, and pointed with her cup. The cup swung round at the leather on my floor.

"There's work in you as well as him, you've hands that are for something, I heard about you at that wall yesterday with your nail in it, half that street saw you. Put a board up at that shop and they'll be at your sill by market day with their broken things in a cloth, there's not a kitchen on this street that didn't have its shelf come down, and half of them are eating off the pieces yet." She drank. "That was my cousin did that wall. He's a bad plasterer and he's family, so it stays."

On the wall of her own house, beside her counter, there was new whitewash. It was still dark with wet at its edges, and through the white the shapes of red letters showed faintly, as they would until the second coat. It had appeared since we came, and Grata saw me looking.

"Don't lean on that," she said. "It's wet. My son's at the baths. A lad who means to stand for aedile one day has to be seen at the baths by the right people with nothing on, and the right people are always at the baths, and when any of them works, the gods know."

In the opening of her own shop next door a man in a sleeping tunic had appeared, scratching his chest and regarding the street with no love for it.

"Is there bread?" he said.

"There's bread at the baker's," said Grata. "Where the oven draws badly."

That afternoon I went to the Stabian Gate and out through it onto the river road, and found only a few tombs along it, two of them curved benches of stone with the dead men's names cut along the backs where the living sat, and a marker or two farther along toward the river, which wound through the flat country below the town with barges on it under brown sails; none of them had a door, painted or otherwise, and I was back in the town with the sun still up.

Valens came home at dusk with stone dust in the creases of his neck and furring his arms, Felix at his heels and full of the amphitheater. We ate on the roof beside the fig, bread and some of Grata's beans in a pot, with the light leaving the tiles round us and the smoke of other people's suppers rising over every quarter of the town.

"They've sunk it in the earth," Felix said. "The whole thing. You walk in at the top and look down. The loads go out past it, there's a dump in the fields beyond, and you come back by it empty, and you look right in through the arches at the end. Did you know it would be sunk? You could drop a house in it and never see the roof."

"They dug the bowl and banked the earth from it round the sides for the seats," Valens said. "That saved them stone."

"Can I go in, when the loads are done? Nobody was in it today. Will there be games at the Ides? There were thirty pairs on that wall."

Valens was cutting a new noseband for the black out of the one long strip the nephew had missed, and went on cutting.

"There were," Valens agreed.

Felix went over to the parapet in case the amphitheater showed from there. "Roofs, and somebody's washing, and your fig in the way of the rest of it," he said, and returned to his beans.

"Find anything at your gate?" he asked me. "Was there anything out there?"

"Barges on the river."

"Fighting ones?"

"Ones with cabbages in them."

"Not at that gate," I told Valens.

"How many gates are there?"

"Seven or eight. Three have tombs worth the walk."

He tried the noseband against his own hand for size, and pared more off it.

"The third?"

"The Nuceria Gate. Tomorrow."

"What's tomorrow?" said Felix. "Looking for what, at the gates? Are there fighters buried out there? Do they put their fights on the stones?"

"Some do," said Valens.

"Where?"

"Out where the dead are. Eat your beans."

On the next afternoon it was the Nuceria Gate.

Inside the passage a woman had a basket of roses on the step beside her, made up into garlands and loose, and she held one up at me as I came by. "For your people, lady. The road's half full of roses already. You'll not want to go out bare." I passed her empty-handed. "Greeks," she called after me, and more that the echo of the passage took.

The road outside ran beneath the town wall instead of striking off across the country, east and west, with the town above it to the north and the fields dropping away southward, and the tombs stood all along both its edges, close as houses in a street, the country behind them and their faces to the road. This was where the dead go out, and they had followed the road out in their hundreds and settled in. Families sat eating on the benches built along the tomb fronts for anybody passing. Behind a low wall a plot was crowded with little stones cut in the shape of a head on a pair of shoulders, faceless, some with a knot of hair carved at the back; the roses on an altar beside it were browning at the edges in the sun. In the shade of a tall tomb with a marble woman seated on top of it a man was asleep with his jaw dropped and a fly walking on his cheek, and a candidate's name had been put up in red letters on the tomb's side, the same as on any wall in the town. Farther on, a boy came driving geese along the crown of the road with a long stick, and the geese passed me with their necks out.

It was on the town side of the road, between a big tomb and a little walled plot. I knew it from twenty paces off, with not a letter of it read.

It was a small square house of rubble, plastered white, with a low gable over its front and no higher at the ridge than Valens's head, and its front looked over the road into the afternoon sun. On that front, from the ground nearly to the gable, a door had been painted, as near full size as the little house allowed, and painted to look like wood: two leaves, each in three panels, done in a yellowish brown, with the grain drawn on in darker strokes of a fine brush, and nail heads set down the edges as black dots with a fleck of white on each to make them shine. Each leaf had a ring for a handle, and under each ring the painter had put its shadow, falling the opposite way from every real shadow on that

road. Above the door, set in the gable, there was a slip of marble with an inscription on it. It said that Aulus Numisius Eros, freedman of Aulus, had made this for himself while he lived, and that he had lived fifty-one years.

Behind me an ungreased axle squealed, and I moved off the road for the cart.

I put the backs of my fingers to the white plaster next to the door. It was warm, with the whole day's sun in it. I moved them leftward onto the painted wood, the lower panel of the right-hand leaf, and it was cool.

It was faintly cool, cool as a glass of water left standing an hour by a kitchen sink. I moved back onto the white, and it was warm. Onto the painted jamb, done to look like stone: warm. Onto the leaf again: cool. Paint and white lay on a single coat of plaster, and where the brush had crossed from one to the other it had not even lifted. I knocked on the leaf with a knuckle, low and then high, as I had sounded many a plaster panel at home for a hollow behind it, and then on the white beside it. They gave back the same dull note, with rubble behind both. I spread my fingers and gave it the whole of my palm.

The air in front of it was the road's air, and the road's noise went on round me as before. Two tombs along, the family on the bench were passing a jug and laughing at some joke of the grandmother's; the geese were still shouting somewhere beyond the next tombs, and a mule was being cursed at the gate. The plaster against my palm was smooth and a little gritty and only just cool, and it stayed a picture of a door.

A small boy of that family was at my elbow. He had rose petals stuck to the bottoms of his feet.

"Is this one yours?" he said.

"No," I said.

"Ours is that one." He pointed, his arm out straight, at the bench where his people were. "He was my grandfather. He sold eels."

"Leave the lady be," his mother called across. "She's praying."

"Who to?" asked the boy.

"Come here and carry this."

The boy returned to his eels. The family soon had their baskets and their cloths together and went past me in at the gate, the boy last, walking on the outsides of his feet to keep the petals on. Whenever I tried the white plaster next to the door it was still giving back the sun's warmth; the door was cool.

When my hand left it, the coolness stayed in my palm for some distance, and was gone by the gate. The rose woman was still on her step.

"Out bare and back bare," she said. "They'll think you've no dead at all."

"I have some," I said, "but not here."

I meant to sit on the bed only while I got my sandals off. I woke with one of them off and the other on, the light in the high window turned orange, and the noise of the street in the room with me.

My bag lay open on the floor, dropped there the first night, and the toe of the old wool sock stuck out from among my things. I touched it with a fingertip. Inside the wool were the cassette's hard edge and the two small hubs in its face, and I turned one of them through the knit, a quarter of the way round, and it turned.

Grata had her lamps lit along the counter, and as I came to the sill she took one look at my hem.

"You've been out among the dead," she said, "you've the red off the Nuceria road all up your hem, it's the reddest dust in Campania and it never comes out, and you've slept through your supper and most of mine. Your man's been back since the lamps

were lit. He's on the roof with his tree and the boy, and the boy's telling the street about some dead fighter whose stone he's found out past the amphitheater, and your man's sitting there letting him. There's patience. Mine would have thrown a pot at him by now. Sit there. I kept you a bowl."

I took the bench at the front of her counter with the bowl she gave me, and emptied it, and did not know what had been in it, and it was good. Everywhere in the street the shops were putting their shutters up for the night, each board let into the groove of its sill with a knock of wood on stone, and the knocking came toward us from the crossing one shopfront after another, passed the cobbler's, where our boards still leaned against the inside wall because nobody had thought to put them up, passed Grata's lamps, and carried on toward the gate, while behind it the street filled with people going home to eat, and the noise of them came up after the knocking and filled the street between its walls and rose into the open windows over the shops, voices and feet and a girl on a balcony overhead singing the same two lines of a song to a baby, and then the same two lines, louder than the baby.

Chapter 20

The Mender's Shop

Pompeii · AD 72–73

A bronze pot has walked off from this shop, the big one, with the handle I had riveted on new at the Saturnalia. Whoever brings it back gets sixty-five sesterces. The thief knows who he is, and so do I.

It was up on the pier of a cookshop above the bull's-head fountain. Under it, in charcoal and a smaller hand, a reader had added that the thief was enjoying his soup. I had passed it every day for half a month with our water jar riding my hip before I stopped to read it. While I read, a woman with a basket of leeks halted beside me and read it aloud for the old husband on her arm.

"Sixty-five," he said. "For a pot. He could have two new ones and a lid."

"Two new, and not a handle between them worth the name." She hitched the leeks round to her other side. "Riveted, he says. He paid good money for that handle."

"He should have chained it to the wall."

"He should have chained you." She steered him off downhill, and over the leeks, without my asking, she called back to me. "It was his father's pot, that, and it lived through the earthquake

with a dent in its side, and he'll tell you the dent's the shape of Nuceria if you stand still for it."

The cook was in his doorway in a stained apron, digging at a splinter in his thumb with a pin. He stared after me, in case the jar was his pot.

At home I put it to Grata. "Where does one buy paint, in this quarter?"

"Nobody buys paint here, they're robbed for it," Grata said. Her forearms were on the counter; the steam off her pot went up past her face. "Them that paint for the candidates live behind the theaters, and they'll sell you a cup of red at the price of a jar of wine, and you'll hand it over, you've a payer's face. Soot's free. There's soot on my brazier every night of the year, and the glue-boiler three doors down will give you size for an egg, and soot in size is black, and black reads best on lime. You're putting up a board. I told you so the week you came, and here's the spring half gone." She caught my upper arm and squeezed it, as a wife at market would squeeze a hen to feel for the meat on it. "Spell it right. There's people on this street can read."

The pier beside our shop opening had been limewashed in the cobbler's time; the lime still took a mark. I stood on the cobbler's broken last to reach the top line. I lettered it with a brush of pig's bristle bound to a stick, dipping into a cracked cup of Grata's soot stirred into size.

Broken things mended here. Bronze, clay, glass.

Felix came in from the string at dusk, with lime in his eyebrows, and faced it with his fists on his hips.

"What's written? Which bit's the fish? Did you put me in it anywhere? Who's going to read it, anyway, when half this street can't tell an A from a fishhook?"

"There is no fish, and you are not in it," I said, and read it to him.

"That wants shouting." He dug lime out of one eyebrow with a fingernail. "Market day, I'll stand out on the curb and give it them. There's no voice on the Stabian road to touch mine. The contractor puts me at the head of the string so the carts coming up know to pull over."

Valens read it that night by lamplight on his way in from the mules, when Felix had already gone in to his blanket in the shop.

"Glass," he said. "Who breaks glass, in this street?"

"Everybody who owns any."

He went over it again, the lamp lifted to the pier. "Grata will want her name on it somewhere."

Felix did shout it on market day, from the curb, with his hands round his mouth.

"Cracked your pot? Dropped your lamp? Bring it to the dead cobbler's, next door to Grata's, and she'll have it whole for you by next market! Nobody on this road mends like her!"

Grata let him go round three times before she came out.

"Take that voice off to the forum, you've emptied my bench twice since the shutters were off, and there goes the third man with my cup in his fist and not a copper paid for it. Shout at the fullers."

By noon a woman was at my plank out of the glare, with a stewpot wrapped in her apron.

It was coarse gray ware, black with old fires to the shoulder, and cracked from the lip halfway down its belly. Lower down, my fingers found an older break with lead run through it in two places and beaten flat, raised on the clay like scabs.

"That's my mother's," the woman said. "She had a tinker put his dogs in it the winter I was born. Do it the same."

"Which are the dogs?"

She set a fingernail on each clamp in turn. "These. Lead. They've not shifted since."

"I can close it so that you will never find the crack again."

"I'd only break it in the same spot, looking for it." She folded her arms over the apron. "Make it tight. My oil lives in it."

I warmed the pot through beside Grata's coals till the clay was hot in my palms. Then I ran resin into the new crack from inside, coaxing it deep into the break with the tip of a heated nail, and pared it flush while still soft. When it had cooled, my own eye could barely find the line. She paid me in bronze and carried the pot off under her arm.

The cook arrived on the last day of that month with his pot on his shoulder. It was a big round-bellied thing of bronze gone brown, and under its lip two rivet holes stood empty where the handle had been.

"Found it in the ditch outside the Sarno Gate," he said, "handle gone and a frog in it. Nobody gets the sixty-five. A fellow told me where, wanting it, and I went and fetched it home myself, so he gets nothing. I want a handle on it."

"I cannot rivet bronze. The coppersmith in the next street could."

"He's the one I'd have said took it." He left the pot on my plank all the same, mouth to the wall. "You've your board. You'll know somebody."

"I will ask him for you."

"Ask him where he was the night it went."

I carried it round to the coppersmith that afternoon, a big soft-spoken man with burns all up his forearms. He knew the pot on sight.

"Riveted that handle on myself," he said. "This winter gone. Good rivets."

"He would like a new handle, and the same rivets."

"He'd like to know where I was the night it walked." He fingered the empty holes. "Tell him I was at my sister's in Stabiae,

and her husband will swear to it, and so will her husband's goat. Tell him a copper pot gets no handle off me twice for the one price." He swung the pot round so the dent faced him. "Shape of Nuceria. He tells everybody that."

"It looks like nothing."

"Like nothing on earth," the coppersmith agreed, pleased. He had it fitted with a new handle inside four days. The cook stopped at my plank with it as he went home.

"A handle you could lift a mule by, and he's charged me more than he first asked, like I was the one took the pot. Never again. Next time it walks, it can stay walked."

Valens, meanwhile, had pegged a second plank along the shop wall, for the things that waited their turn.

* * *

Felix broke our bowl on the roof stair in the first hot week of the summer.

It was red and glossy, from the potteries up the coast, with the potter's name stamped inside a little sole of a foot on its floor. We had paid too much for it at the market in our first days in the town. Every night since, we had eaten our supper from it on the tiles. Felix appeared on the stair holding up two pieces for me to see, his face ready to be blamed.

"It slipped on the top tread, where the wood's worn hollow, and the beans went everywhere, and Grata's cat's in them now. I had these two in the air before they ever reached the bottom. That's a drop of two of me."

The other pieces lay among the beans at the stair's foot, and I fished those out myself.

"I'll buy another," Felix said. "I've coppers put by from the contractor, more than you'd think. I'll get a finer one at the market tomorrow noon, with a picture on it."

"I will mend this one."

"What do we eat out of tonight?"

"We have the pot."

I mended it that night at the table in the back room, with the lamp pulled close. The resin was lentisk. The drug-seller under the forum colonnade sold its clear tears to women for sweetening their breath. I melted a little pine pitch in with it, in a mussel shell propped over the flame, until the two ran together. I warmed each piece near the lamp first, so the resin would not chill and go stringy on a cold edge. With a splinter of cane I drew a bead of it along one broken face and brought the faces to meet.

The break was clean; its faces went home into each other grain by grain, with a small dry seating I felt in my fingers rather than heard. The resin squeezed out along the join in a soft brown welt. I held the pieces until they cooled. I wound thread round the bowl to keep them so, and started on the next.

Valens lay on the bed behind me with his hands under his head, watching the lamp, or me.

"The foreman shorted us a load again today," he said.

"Did you let him?"

"The black bit him. He found the load after that."

"Was he hurt?"

"In his pride. And in the meat of his arm, a little." He shifted, and the new cord creaked. "He'll want her sold. He said so to the yard at large."

"Will you sell her?"

"I'll stand her further off from him."

The second piece seated. I wound the thread on.

"Will it hold soup?"

"Anything you put in it."

"Beans will do," he said, and slept.

When the rim piece went in, the mussel shell was cold beside me and the lamp was nearly dry. With the point of Plautia's little knife I shaved the welts down while they were still soft enough to cut like cheese, and left the bowl to stand the night out in its thread.

When it was light I cut the threads and carried it out to the sill.

In daylight the bowl was whole and red. The joins crossed the red in three fine brown lines; at the rim the last piece I had set sat lower than its neighbor by the thickness of a hair. My lower lip found that before my eye did.

A rubble cart was rolling downhill out of the crossroads with a load of broken roof tiles, an old carter walking at the mule's head. When it drew level I reached up and put our bowl on the heap of tiles.

He stopped his mule and came round to the cart's tail, lifted the bowl off the load, and blew the tile dust out of it.

"My wife's been at me for a bowl since the Floralia," he said. "Have you got any more you don't want?"

I gave him no answer. He stowed it in the breast of his tunic and walked on at the mule's head, with the cart creaking behind him and our bowl riding against his belly.

Past noon a girl of six or so came in, towing her mother by the hand, with a clay pig in her fist. The pig was a rattle the size of a plum, with a slit along its back, and it had cracked down one flank, so that the pellets inside dropped out at every shake.

"He won't talk," she told me, and shook him to prove it. Two pellets fell out onto my plank.

"He talked all winter," her mother said. "She took him to the baths. She takes him everywhere."

"He likes the hot room," said the girl.

I fed the pellets back in through the crack with the blade, and closed the flank over them with a bead of resin, and pinched it shut until it cooled, with the girl standing so close her nose was nearly on my plank. Once it was hard she put the pig to her ear and shook him, and he talked.

"He's better," she told her mother, and left shaking him at every step. Her mother paid me in a hard little cheese.

When Valens got home in the dusk Felix met him at the sill.

"She mended it all night and it was whole, I saw it, you could hardly tell where, and this morning she gave it away to the tile carter, a gray old fellow, and he took it off to his wife. Why would she give it away? Was there a fault in it? Can a mended thing go bad in a night?"

Over Felix's head, Valens met my eye.

"We'll manage with the cookpot," he said.

* * *

In the hot months the carting stopped at noon. Before that, from first gray, Valens worked the string to and fro, Felix with him, between the forum and a tip among the fields by the amphitheater. The town's broken stone left it a basketful at a time on mules' backs.

One morning I carried their bread up to them. The forum lay under a white haze of its own making. At its far end the big temple stood in a cage of poles roped together, with men climbing about in it. On the paving beneath, two quarrymen were breaking up a column drum that had split in the earthquake and lain where it fell ever since. They swung their sledges turn and turn about. At every blow the drum rang and gave up another chip of itself. Felix shoveled the pieces into the mules' baskets, and Valens led each mule off as it filled, with a rag knotted over his nose and mouth and his eyes red above it.

He pulled the rag down to eat. Under it was the one part of his face the dust had not reached.

"What's she sent?"

"Grata's olives."

"That's yesterday's bread."

"Grata says it is today's."

"Grata would." He ate it standing, while the sledges went on behind him, and gave the end of it to the dun.

Felix had left his shovel to stand by the quarrymen.

"You're swinging it too high, the pair of you, you're wasting half your arm on the air. Give it here and I'll have that drum in bits before the bread's eaten."

"Show us," said the older quarryman, and handed him the sledge and stood back. Felix got it up level with his collarbone, and it took him round in half a circle and struck the stones a hand's breadth from his own foot. The drum never felt it.

"It's an old drum," said Felix, handing back the sledge. "It's gone rotten in the middle. A blind man could tell that."

By the hot hour Valens was home; by mid-afternoon he was asleep on the roof.

I climbed up with the water jug and found him under the fig. The tiles were too hot for a bare foot. Under us the town lay shut behind its shutters, with nothing in the lanes but a dog going from one shade to the next. The fig had grown since the ship; its leaves were wider now than my spread hand. He had stretched himself along under the parapet with his head and chest in its shade and the rest of him in the full glare, his bare soles gray with the forum. The shadow of a leaf lay over his open lips and stirred when the leaf stirred. By his hip on the tiles lay a small heap of the summer's figs, hard little green things he had pinched off that morning before the mules went out.

I went below for the Pentax and climbed back with it.

He slept on. Through the lens the heat off the tiles kept him and his tree wavering, and the waver never settled. I took it, and wound on, and he slept through both.

He woke when the shade had slid off his face, and found me sitting up by the parapet with the camera in my lap.

"Did you spend one on me?"

"One."

"On a man asleep."

"And a tree."

He lay gazing into the fig overhead, at the undersides of its leaves with the sun showing through them, till it seemed he might sleep again.

"She wants water," he said. He fetched it himself, from our jar below.

Supper was beans again and they were cold and we ate them standing at the pot. Felix came upon the little heap of green figs by the parapet and pitched one at the baker's roof opposite, and missed.

"Pulling them off, are you? Are they bad? Grata's cousin sells figs at the gate a copper the double handful, and his are no bigger. Will you pull the next lot too?"

"These would never ripen." Valens edged the jar west along the parapet by its rim, into the sun's last edge. "Last year she carried them all summer and dropped every one in the autumn. Without them she makes wood."

"What's she for?"

"Next year."

Grata was hollering at the parapet from her counter.

"Your tree's dropping its leaves in my wine, I've had three out of the jars today, and I'll charge him for them by the leaf, you tell him."

Valens glanced over at the fig, which had not dropped a leaf since it budded.

"It hasn't," he said.

"He says it has not," I called over.

"It's the wind does it, and I'll charge the wind."

Once Felix was off to see to the dun and the black, Valens brought a tablet out of his pouch and wrote in it with the lamp by his elbow, slowly, the stylus held low. He closed the leaves and tied them shut.

"For Plautia," he said. "Where we are."

"Will the wine-woman send it on from the board?"

"Most months a ship goes over to Lechaion. She'll put it aboard one for a copper, and keep the copper if there's no ship."

He sent it to Puteoli with a carter bound there for lime on market day.

When the lamp was out and the tiles had given back most of the day's heat, he spoke again.

"Do you still walk out to your gate?"

"On the Kalends."

"And it's the same."

"It is the same."

Near the theater a dog barked, and another answered it. His hand found my hip in the dark and lay there.

* * *

That autumn grapes rolled into town on carts that dripped; the streets smelled of must and wasps.

One night of the vintage the bed walked on its legs and the lamp hook rattled on the wall, and next door Grata's cups chimed together on their shelf. I lit the wick, dug Fenn's notebook from beneath my spare tunic in the bag, and on the first of his blank

leaves at the back I wrote the date and *small shake, lamps, nobody woke*, and put the light out.

A bone-turner who lived one street over brought me his money box in the week the must was put up in jars. It was a squat clay pot the shape of a little beehive, with a slot in its top for coins, and it lay in four pieces in the turner's cap.

"I broke it to get at what was in it," the turner said. "They're made for that. Only now the money's gone, and I've a mind to start again in the same one. There's no luck in a new box. This one's been full twice."

He was a small man with a curl of bone caught in his hair. Through all our talk his cap stayed cupped under the pieces, for fear one of them should fall again.

"I can make it keep coins," I said. "Whether it fills is your affair."

"It buried my wife's mother," he said, "and after her a horse."

I joined it for him next day and left the slot as it was, and he collected it that evening.

"I've no money. That's the trouble with mending a money box." He grinned at me. "But I've this." He felt in his belt and produced a finger-long rod of bone, polished, with a point to it, and carved at its other end into a round spoon smaller than half a pea. "Teeth this end. Ears the other. Don't mix them."

The point went straight into my mouth.

Two years, near enough, I had cleaned my teeth with a chewed twig of lentisk and my own tongue. Every night I fell asleep running that tongue over the places behind, where the stick never got, and they were waiting for my tongue at dawn. The bone went into every place there was. It found the gap beside my sixth-grade filling, and slid along behind the bottom front teeth, where Dr. Pinsky's hooked pick had scraped every spring

and fall. I stood in the shop doorway with my back to the street and worked my way round my whole mouth, tooth by tooth.

Felix found me at it when he came in for the string's waterskins.

"Bone, is it? Did he turn it himself? Can I have a go after you?"

"When you have one of your own."

That night, on the tiles, I worked at my back teeth until dark, and then passed the little rod across to Valens.

"Which end is for the ears?"

"The spoon."

"Then I'll keep to the other." He worked at one of his back teeth with the point, frowning at the town, and returned it.

Grata caught me at it from her counter the following morning.

"You'll have the street thinking it's a religion, you at your teeth in the door every morning with all Pompeii passing. The fuller's wife asked me was it a vow, and I'd no cause to tell her different. I told her you'd promised your teeth to some god of the Greeks, and you've to scrape them for him every morning until he comes for them." She slid a cup over to me. "She's at her own with a pin now, I saw her at it on her step. That's my husband's cousin's, off his vines on the Nola road, it's thin, but it's this year's."

"It is not a vow."

"It is now. I've told her so. You'll do me a board too, while you're at the soot. You've the hand for it, everybody's seen, and the painters want wine by the letter and more for the ladder. Put that Grata says. Put that a copper buys you a drink here, and two buys you better, and four buys you Falernian, and put Falernian big, because it is, or next door to it, it comes from that side of the bay."

I lettered it for her that afternoon on the pier at the end of her counter, standing on her upturned water bucket.

Grata says: a copper here and you drink. Give two and you'll drink better. Four, and it's Falernian.

She had a carter read it back to her before she would pay me.

"Four, and it's Falernian," the carter finished, and squinted along her jar mouths. "Which of these is that, then?"

"The one you'll pay four for. The price tells you which."

She paid me for the soot, which was her own, in wine.

On the doorpost of the fullery at the corner, among the scratched tallies of who owed for what, a better hand than most had put one line.

I sing of fullers and their owl, not of arms and the man.

It was the first line of the *Aeneid* with the hero taken out and the laundry put in. I needed two readings to see it, and grinned at the paving all the road back.

The fuller's wife at the corner came in the week after with a scent bottle of blue glass wrapped in a tuft of wool, in three pieces and a scatter of chips.

"He threw it at me," she said, "so I threw it back, and he ducked, which he never does. It was his mother's. He'll be sorry within the week and be looking for it on its shelf. Make it so he can't tell. I want him looking at that shelf for a year thinking it never broke and wondering what it is he's sorry for."

"Glass is hard to hide. I can come close."

"Come close, then. And not a word to Grata, or she'll be telling it at every counter by noon."

The glass would not have stood the heat, so I mended it cold, with the resin thinned until it ran like oil; the bottle's own blue did half my work. I laid the chips into their places with a wetted fingertip, singly, and when I had done none of it could be seen

unless the sun came in sideways and found a line. She called for it while Grata was at the baths.

"There's his mother's bottle," she said, "that nobody ever threw at anybody." She wrapped it up again in the same wool.

A month later she was ahead of me at the fountain, telling the line.

"Twice he's had it from the shelf to look at, and back it goes. Yesterday he brought me home a comb, and couldn't say what for."

Grata was in the line.

Felix bought us a bowl at last at the vintage fair, with his own coppers, a brown one with a hare painted chasing itself round the inside.

"Break that, anybody, and see what you get. Nobody touches it but me. I carry it up and I carry it down. I've never dropped a thing in my life I meant to hold."

The turner's box came to me once more before the year turned cold, in four pieces again.

"Full again in under a month," the turner said. "Don't tell my wife it was full."

When the rains set in there was no carting on the bad days, and Valens spent them in the shop with me out of the weather, mending the string's tack on my plank beside me. Water ran down our street round its stepping stones. Customers came in dripping and stood about after their business was done. One fellow had fetched his lamp at noon. "I'll wait till it eases," he told us, and at dusk he was still in the opening. Felix came in, and left, and came in, too wet to be any use and too restless to stay dry.

"The fig," I said, one afternoon of that. "In this rain."

"She's wrapped." Valens drew a stitch tight through a girth with the thread's tail in his teeth. "Sacking round the jar, and

round her stem to the first fork. She doesn't mind the wet. It's the cold that creeps over at night she minds."

"You did that in the dark."

"She can't climb down to me."

Felix, at the opening, watching the rain go past: "He went up and wrapped her, and he was no sooner down than up to see had he wrapped her right. I heard him on the stair. I hear everything in this house; I could tell you what the both of you eat in your sleep."

That night the rain got in at a cracked tile over the bed and fell onto Valens's foot. He moved the foot, and the drip moved after it, or seemed to. He rose in the dark and dragged the whole bed toward the wall, scraping, and stretched out again in the dry. The drip went on landing where his foot had been.

* * *

Gaius Iulius Polybius for aedile, all of you. He brings good bread.

It appeared on the red house past the temple crossing in a single night at the end of the winter, when every house front was breaking out in candidates. Felix had me out of bed for it.

"They're painting the red house," he whispered at the door to our room, so loudly Grata could have heard. "Three of them, with a ladder and a light. Come and tell me what it says. Grata reckons it's Polybius paying for every wall from here to the gate."

I followed him out with my cloak over my sleeping tunic. A boy waited at a ladder's foot, holding a lamp up on a pole. On the ladder a man with a pail of lime and a broad brush was laying a panel of fresh white over the house, from the eaves halfway to the paving. He took the cousin's pink stripe in two strokes of the brush. It went under the white; in the lamplight the whole wall looked paler for it, like a face just shaved of its beard.

On the curb a thin fellow sat with his pots of red in a row, eating bread and waiting for the lime to dry enough for lettering.

"Who are you painting?" said Felix. "What does he pay you? Will you paint a fighter's name, if I bring you one?"

"Polybius," said the painter, chewing. "Enough. No."

He dried his fingers on his tunic and climbed, while the whitewasher came off. "You, lantern, hold that light still or I'll paint *you* on the wall."

"Four more walls before the cock," the whitewasher grumbled, wringing his brush out on the stones. "Four, and my wife thinks I'm at the mill with the donkeys, and Polybius pays at the month's end, and last month he paid us in loaves."

"Good loaves," the painter called down.

"Chalk," said the whitewasher. "Ask anybody."

Felix sat among the painter's pots and tipped his face up to the ladder. The lantern boy's light sagged by degrees until he was told about it, and then it rose. The painter worked downward, filling his brush from a pot hooked on the rung beside him. I stayed in the road in my cloak till my soles were numb, reading it out to Felix as the words arrived.

"His bread comes last," I told him, when the painter got down to it. "It says it is good."

"All that red, and a ladder, and three of them out of their beds, and me out of mine half the night. For bread."

With the last letter on, the painter climbed off and wiped his brush and scratched something small on the lime under the panel with a nail, for the light to show him.

"What's he putting?" Felix asked me. "Is he putting the fighter? He said he wouldn't. He's putting it, isn't he, he's putting a fighter after all."

"Come and read it in the morning," the painter said, and shouldered the ladder, and the three of them carried their pots and their light off to the next wall.

At daybreak I found this under the panel, small and scratched rather than painted:

Infantio wrote it. Lantern-boy, hold the ladder.

By daylight the panel glared white and its letters glared red. Where the cousin's stripe had run down the house there stood a faint ridge under the lime. The painter had found it in the dark. He had set the upright of the I in Iulius straight down it, so that the letter stood exactly on the crack from the eaves to the lowest stroke.

"Which one's the crack?" Felix wanted to be told, when I had read it him again.

I showed him.

"Polybius is standing on it," Felix said, delighted. "Right on top of it, the whole height of him, and he doesn't know."

Valens came by us with the string, going out to the yard, and Felix caught at his arm.

"Can you read the new one? You can't, can you, only she can, in this house."

Valens studied the panel with the dun's halter in his fist, down to the last red letter.

"It's red," he said, and led the dun on.

Grata had the panel read to her by her son as he set off to bathe, before her shutters were down.

"Polybius," she told me. "His loaves are half chalk, and his grandfather swept out somebody's kitchen in Rome, and he'll get it, they always get it who paint first and pay the painters' wine. He'll have every wall from this corner to the basilica by the Ides, and the plasterers will be at their wits' end." She put her hand on my forearm and gave it a little push, the way she moved

customers along her counter. “Go on with the boy, he’s waiting on you, he’s been on that curb since the cock.”

From there Felix took me to the fountain, to read him the pier at its back.

“No candidates on this pier. It’s people wrote all this.”

Successus the weaver loves the innkeeper’s slave girl, Iris, and she does not care for him at all.

Someone had answered it in a deeper hand:

Jealous, are you? Don’t come pushing in where there’s a better-looking man.

“Which one’s the better-looking man? Which inn? Is Iris the one with the bucket by the Sarno Gate?”

“The wall stops there.”

“Successus can keep his weaving.” Felix ran his eye up the pier, over all the scratched things he could not read, much pleased with them. “I’d have her off the pair of them by the Ides, if I put my mind to it, and I’d never touch a loom.”

Higher than any of them there was one more.

I’m amazed, wall, that you haven’t come down in a heap, with all the drivel you’ve had to carry.

“Who wrote that? What’s drivel? Does it mean us?”

“It means everybody.”

“That’s wrong.” Felix slapped the pier with his open hand. “It’s been standing since before any of us was born, Grata told me, and it’s the straightest pier on the street.”

* * *

The fountain at our corner was a stone trough fed through the bull’s mouth on its back slab. The bull ran water day and night, over the trough’s lower lip and away along the gutter. At the spout end, where people leaned a hand to drink, the rim had been worn to a smooth dark dip. The bull’s left horn had lost a chip,

years before; the broken place had gone as dark and smooth as the rest of him. The water struck the trough with one unchanging slap; a week in that street had taught my ears to leave it out. A dog stood in the gutter below with the overflow running round its feet, drinking.

One morning in the summer I was there with our jar, in the line of women and slaves, waiting my turn. The line was talking about a wedding.

"Fourteen," said a woman with a red jar, "and him forty."

"Forty-two, he says. He's been forty for three years."

"With the dowry in figs."

"In fig trees. That's different. You can't eat a tree."

"You can sell one."

"Who'd buy a fig tree off a man of forty-two?"

"Another man of forty-two."

"You can sell anything, if you've a face for it," said a slave girl at the spout.

"Fill and get on," the woman with the red jar told her, "and leave the talk to them that's got dowries."

A child crawled round the trough's corner through the overflow. He was a year old or not much over, naked but for a crescent of leather hung on a cord at his throat, and wet to the chest. He grabbed the worn place in the rim and pulled himself up on it and stood, rocking. In his fist, raised to me, he had a pebble.

I turned my hand up. He laid the pebble in my palm, small and black and round, wet, and cold from the trough's bottom. Then he kept two of his fingers on it, after it was in my palm, until he was sure it would stay.

I was crying.

The jar was on my hip and the stone was in my hand. The crying heaved up through me. My mouth was open. I could not shut it.

His father came after him round the trough, a man whose hands were stained blue from somebody's vats.

"I never touched her," he told the line. "You saw. I never came near her." He hoisted the boy onto his hip. "He gives them to everybody, lady. He gave one to a mule this morning. It's only a pebble, that's all he does, he gives pebbles."

From his father's hip the boy watched me and sucked his cord.

"I was at the bakery door all along," his father insisted, and took the boy off with him. "Everybody saw where I was."

It ended when it ended. I filled the jar at the spout and carried it home.

Grata was at her counter with a customer, a man buying oil and disputing the measure. She looked once at my face and reached down a cup, filled it and set it before me on the counter, and went on telling the man about his measure. The stone in my other hand had dried by then. It was gray, and not black at all.

"You'll get it no cheaper in Nuceria," she was telling him. "Suppose you do, you'll have walked to Nuceria for it, and walked home again, and that's two days' wages gone on your feet, and your sandal's through at the toe already, I've been looking at it all this while."

"Grata tells me you cried at the fountain," said Valens that night on the roof.

"A child gave me a stone."

He waited, in case more came. When none did he held out his hand, and I put the stone into it. He looked at it by the lamp, small and dry and gray, and passed it back to me, and took up his supper.

"That's a good stone," he said.

* * *

The Greek woman at the cobbler's mended my jug, and it holds. Take her yours.

It turned up scratched into the lime under my black letters in the month they picked the olives, small and slanting, overnight. Felix had me read it to him daily for a week.

"Read me the one about you," he would say at the pier, with the waterskins slung on him, and stand mouthing it after me.

"Who wrote it? The jug woman? I'll find her out." He rubbed a smut off the lime beside it with his sleeve. "There's a name scratched on every wall in this town but mine."

The stoker from the baths at the crossing came in that same month, black to the elbows and smelling of the olive stones they burned under the floors. He had a lamp in three pieces in a fold of his tunic, and he laid them out on my plank with one black finger, as carefully as a gambler laying out dice.

"The furnace stair did it," he said. "Third step up. It's always the third. The stone's gone hollow in the middle, and it's dark down there as a cow's belly."

It was a plain round lamp with FORTIS stamped in tall capitals on its foot. It had broken across the shoulder in a crooked line, and a wedge of the rim had broken loose beside it.

"The potters' row," I said, "sells this lamp by the basket."

"I could buy forty." He jerked his head toward the baths. "There's a shelf of them down there, all off the one mold, all with that same name on their bottoms, and whichever of the boys gets down there first in the morning takes the nearest. Hermes takes mine. He swears he doesn't. This one's mine. I've had it three summers."

"I could put it together so the break would not show."

"And then how do I know it from the other thirty-nine?" He scratched in his beard. "Leave me the crack. Leave it where the boys can see it's spoken for. It's dark on that stair, and I'll want to find it with my thumb."

"What name goes on the tag?"

"Zosimus. Of the crossing baths. Down at the furnace, not up with the bathers." He was gone again, telling a man with a handcart that he'd have Hermes's ear for him yet.

Round the filling hole the clay was black from his thumb. The broken edges were the only clean clay on it. They were pale and dry and sharp, and they smelled of nothing. When I brought the two big pieces together they met at once, the break so new that nothing had yet got into it.

I heated the pieces and joined the shoulder, and when the welt swelled from the break I let it stand. Along the shoulder I trimmed it to a thread's thickness proud of the clay. I warmed the knife and stroked the top of the welt smooth so it would not catch his skin. The wedge from the rim went in after. When all of it had set I took a pinch of Grata's brazier soot and rubbed it into the join with my fingertip, until the break ran black across the pale clay from the oil hole to the rim and on across the wedge.

Valens walked in while the lamp was still on my plank with the soot fresh in its line. He halted before it. He set his thumb on the black line at its start and ran it along the welt to the rim, slowly, and back.

"Who's this for?"

"The furnace man at the baths."

"Left like that."

"He wants to find it in the dark."

He left the lamp standing and went to wash.

Zosimus was back two mornings later, on his way down to light the furnaces. It was still dim in the shop. He cradled the

lamp in his palm and shut his eyes, and his thumb travelled the shoulder and stopped on the welt. It went back over it, and stopped again.

"That's it," he said, with his eyes still shut.

"Keep it off the furnace mouth," I said. "The join will soften in a great heat."

"It's never been near the furnace mouth." He opened his eyes, offended for the lamp. "It lights the stair and it lives on the shelf. Hermes's goes in the fire. He dropped it in the fire twice, the fool, and raked it out, and now it's black, and he thinks it's mine."

He put the lamp back in the fold of his tunic, and was away to the baths with his palm over it.

The fig above us had kept its fruit that year, and it ripened late, with the olives, when every other fig in the town had been eaten or dried.

Valens knew the day. Each morning he climbed up and took one in his fingers and weighed it and left it, and on the morning it came away into his hand by its own weight, with its neck gone soft and a bead of something sweet standing at the eye of it, he brought it down to the shop with two more and put them on my plank among the broken things.

I ate all three. They were warm from the roof, and I wanted nothing else that whole day.

Grata had opened a new jar of fish sauce that month. It stood at her counter's brazier end, and every morning, once it was open, the smell rolled over the paving, salt and rot and something under both. I had taken to going round the long block to the fountain so as not to pass it. The jar had turned, I decided. All that week Grata watched me take our jar off the roundabout way, and never spoke of it to me. To whoever was at her counter she talked about oil, or about the scent bottle at the fullery.

“Blue glass, his mother’s, and he’s looking at that shelf yet and can’t think why, and she reckons I had it from her at the fountain. I had it the hour it broke. The street heard it go, every door of it.”

When the week was out I sat one evening on the bench before her counter, over a cup of her hot wine I had not drunk, and she lifted the lid to ladle some onto a carter’s bread, and I covered my mouth.

“That jar has gone off,” I said, behind my hand.

The carter sniffed toward the jar over his cup. “That fish of yours would turn a mule,” he told Grata, and pushed his bread across for more of it.

Grata clapped the lid on. She put her arm over the counter and rested two fingertips on the inside of my wrist, beside Plautia’s gold, and kept them there while she talked.

“My fish is the same fish it was at the Kalends, and you ate it then and wiped the bowl out after with your bread. Three mornings you’ve gone as green as a leek at the smell of it, and you’ve the look about the eyes my sister had with each of hers, and you’ve not drunk my wine tonight, and you’ve not told him either, or he’d be standing in my door grinning at nothing the way husbands do. It’ll come with the heat. You’ll curse that stair every day of the last month, and him along with it, and he’ll be no use to you, none of them are. It’s not my fish. It’s a child you’ve got.”

Chapter 21

The Wolf's Old Name

Pompeii · winter, AD 73–74

"And a bear, a live one, in a cage on a cart. They had him in at the barracks gate with me right there by it, and he put his paw out through the bars at me in passing, and I never moved, the porter saw me not move. Did you ever see a bear close to? Have they got bears in Syracuse? His claws were longer than my fingers."

Felix filled the shop opening with the morning behind him and a mule's nosebag in each fist. I had vomited into the night pot at cockcrow, quietly, while he slept on, and I sat on the cobbler's old last sipping water, waiting for the shop to hold still.

"Where is Valens?"

"Loading at the yard. He sent me back for these. We cut behind the big theater to save the hill, and the painter's up a ladder on the barracks wall putting the show up on it, all of it, so I stopped." He swung the nosebags wide to show me the size of the wall. "A hunt in the morning with the bear, and four pairs after, and the man giving it is a Fabius who wants to be aedile, and there's awnings if the sun's out. For the Saturnalia. One of the four is a Thracian that's never been beaten. Will he take us? Will you ask him for me? He says no to anything I ask before I've got to the end of asking it."

"It is a month to the Saturnalia."

"Twenty-six days. The painter told me." He leaned in and peered at me. "You're green again. It's that fish of Grata's. It's gone off, I've said so. My nose finds it out in the stable."

"Go on to Valens. He is standing in the yard waiting on his nosebags."

"You'll ask him, though."

"You have a mouth."

He was gone, and back for the second nosebag, which he had put down to show me the claws, and ran again.

I finished with the shutters. On the second plank, among the things waiting their turn, lay a spice-seller's scales: a bronze beam the length of my forearm, a pan on three chains, and the hook from which the whole of it hung, with the pin gone that ought to have held beam to hook. The pan still smelled of his cumin. For a breath I stood again at my father's stove, where a dented tin of it had stood all through my childhood and gone into everything he cooked, eggs included. I filed down a nail of bronze to fit the hole and peened its ends over, and hung the scales from my lintel to see whether they swung true.

Before noon the carter who ate Grata's fish on his bread came by with his cart empty and a friend up on the board beside him. The two of them looked into my shop as they passed. The friend grinned at me and patted his own belly, and the carter cuffed him for it, not hard, and they both laughed and rattled away gateward.

Grata crossed to me soon after with the end of a loaf and a piece of cheese on it, and left it on my plank, clear of the scales.

"I've told nobody, so you can take that look off your face. That one's told the whole road to the Sarno Gate, he'd sell his mother's secrets to a mule for a carrot. Get that down you. Your man doesn't know yet. I'd know it if you had, he'd have been at my

counter for a jug by first light, and then they lie on their backs all the next day and leave the work to you." She lifted the scales' pan on one finger and let it fall back on its chains. "Tell him before the carter tells him, that's all I'll say, and the cheese is sheep's, it'll sit."

"He is not home till dusk."

"The carter's got the whole afternoon, then, and he never talks faster than when he's chewing."

I ate the cheese. It sat.

All afternoon I mended what came in and listened to the street. Each time a man laughed outside I lifted my head. A woman brought a lamp whose nozzle had snapped off. A boy brought a horn comb in two halves, and stayed to watch.

"It's my sister's," he said. "She's to be married at the start of next month."

"She will want it for the wedding, then."

"She'll want it tonight. It lives in her box, and she counts what's in her box every night before she sleeps, and I took it to comb the dog." He leaned his chin on my plank. "The dog was sitting on it. You can't blame the dog."

I could not. I had it whole for him before the shade had crossed the street, and he ran. The sun left the paving and climbed the fronts of the houses opposite, and the street began to smell of supper cooking behind every shutter.

They came in as the light failed. Felix led the string round to the stalls, whistling. Valens had something in his hand.

"Did anyone speak to you on the way home?" I said.

"The lime carter. At the crossing." In his hand were two leaves of wood bound face to face with a cord, and wax in the knot. "He'd been to Puteoli. He looks at the board for me."

"Valens. I am going to have a child."

He stayed on the sill.

"Who knows?"

"Grata. The carter who eats at her bench. By now, the carter's friends." It was not the question I had pictured him asking, and I heard how my answer sounded. "I wanted you to have it from me, ahead of the street."

"Since when?"

"Last night. Grata knew before I did."

"Grata." He left the tablet on the plank unopened. "When?"

"With the heat. Summer, she thinks."

He lifted the lamp from its hook and took it to the back. His feet climbed the roof stair, and stopped, and after a silence he called down for the big knife.

He was crouched at the stair's head when I reached him with it, with the lamp beside him, pressing his thumb into the middle of the tread. Under it the board gave, very slightly, and rose again.

"This is where Felix slipped."

"In the summer. With the bowl."

"It's worn through to the soft. A foot goes off it sideways." He took the knife and set its point under the tread's end, where the peg met the stringer, and began to work. "There's oak behind the inn yard. I'll have a new one in by morning."

"Will it take my weight?"

"It'll take the both of you."

I left him to it. For an hour I heard him overhead, the knife biting and the old tread groaning off its pegs, and a quiet while he went for the oak, and then the knife again. Felix let himself in from the stalls and went to his blanket. When Valens came down at last he was carrying the old tread. In the middle it was hollowed deep, and polished there like horn by every foot that had used it since the house was built.

It went on the hearth for burning. He caught me watching him.

"It's a stair," he said.

"So I see."

"Are you sick with it?"

"In the mornings."

"Grata's fish."

"Everything is Grata's fish."

We read the tablet with our curtain drawn, the lamp between us on the bed, because of Felix. Valens broke the wax and read it first, as he read everything, slowly and without a sound, start to end. Then he turned the leaves to face me.

It was from Plautia's brother, in a scribe's hand, round and even.

To Gaius Iulius Valens, greeting. The praetor has given us our day and our judge. The matter of my sister's dowry will be heard at Rome, in the Basilica Julia, in April. My freedman will wait at the wine-seller's by the harbor at Puteoli from the Kalends of March to the Ides, with money for the road for you and yours. Any witness not with him when the Ides is out we will take to have stayed at home. Farewell.

Under it, in another hand, smaller and pressed harder into the wax, the letters crowding toward the edge:

Four lines since Corinth. Is she well? Bring her, and I will see for myself.

"She wants you to come," I said.

"She wants you. Her brother wants me." He shut the leaves on it.

"Four lines?"

"There was the dun's hoof to tell her about."

"It says you and yours."

"You. And whatever you're carrying."

"You told her you would stand up."

"I told her in Corinth." He stood the tablet on the shelf above the bed, by the oil jar, and stretched out. "The Ides is far enough."

He pinched the wick. The smell of cut oak reached us through the dark.

I lay in the dark, my palm on the blanket over my stomach, with nothing yet to find there. All my palm found was supper. I thought of the maternity floor at Pennsylvania Hospital, where I had once carried a pot of tulips up to a colleague; of its smell of floor wax and lilies.

"There's no step on that stair now will turn your foot," Valens said.

Felix heard it from the baker's boy along with the loaves. He ran in through the shop while Valens was at the door tying the lead rope to the dun's headstall, and brought up short against my plank, loaf in fist.

"Is it true? The baker's boy says the carter says Grata says. When does it come? Is it a boy? Where's it going to sleep? Not in the shop, I hope, with me, I'll never get a night's rest again." He wheeled round on Valens. "You knew. You knew it last night, and you let me go to bed."

"I knew it last night."

"And I went to bed like a fool, and slept." He glared at me too, for good measure. "It'll want its own bowl. I'll get it one next market, with a murmillo on, with the fish on his helmet. The potter by the Herculaneum Gate does them in red with the shield in black, and he wants a whole copper for one, and I'll pay it."

"It'll want teeth before it wants a bowl," said Valens.

"I'll keep the bowl till it's got them."

He went out after the string telling the dun about it. Valens lingered in the doorway. Opposite, Grata was taking her shutters down board by board and calling something to her cat.

"She'll want more for the rooms," he said. "With a child through her wall."

"She gave me cheese."

"Cheese is cheap."

"She told me to tell you before the carter could."

"You did." He went after Felix and the mules.

* * *

Fabius had hired every mule string in the town to sand his arena. The contractor took the money for it and paid his own muleteers in bone, a little disc each with a seat number scratched on it, and Felix had all three of ours strung at his throat before the bear was dead.

I missed the bear. I came out at midday with bread for Valens, by the lane that ran between the palaestra wall and the vineyards, through a crowd already pressing toward the stairs, and found him where Felix had said, in the long passage that ran under the seats into the arena at its north end. The last of the string waited by the tunnel's opening with their baskets empty. Valens was raking the sand smooth where the bear had been dragged out over it, a long dark smear running away across the oval, and the rake brought the smell up with it.

He took the bread and ate it with the rake leaning on his shoulder.

"The women sit at the top."

"I know which rows are ours."

"Sit at the end of a row. By the stair." He tore the crust in two and gave the dun half. "When it lets out they all go for the stair together."

Out on the oval the sand lay pale under the sun. The walls round it were painted with things I had no time to look at, beasts running, a man with a whip, and above the walls the seats went

up in their bands to the top, filling. Somebody up there was already singing.

A short bald man walked up the tunnel from the arena end with three young fighters behind him. He was bandy-legged, in a good cloak, with a rod of polished wood in his fist, and he walked straight past us onto the sand and stood on it. The fighters hung back in the shade. He took two steps, and stopped, and pressed his heel into the sand before he put his weight on it, and then the other heel.

"Who laid this?" he said, with his back to us.

"The contractor's strings," said Valens.

"Who raked it?"

"I did."

"It's soft yonder, under the tribunal. They'll go down there." He returned to us off the sand and stood looking down at Valens's feet. "Do that again."

"Do what?"

"What you did just now, when you stepped down to the sand. With your heel."

Valens had gone no nearer him than the sand's edge, to find what was soft, and before his weight went onto it he had tried it with his heel. I had watched him do the same on ice, and on the deck of Pacuvius's ship when it was wet.

"I taught you that," the bald man said. "At Corinth, in the old school under the hill, with the Syrian that had no wind and the boy from Argos that cried. I taught you that before I ever put a shield on you. Heel, and then the weight." The pleasure in him stayed round his eyes. "Lupus."

Felix had been perched on the passage wall with his seat tokens, swinging his legs. His legs stopped.

"Nicanor," said Valens.

“You’re bigger in the arms.” Nicanor tipped his rod at the empty string. “I heard you’d been sold on and died in Asia. Somebody told me you’d drowned off Kenchreai. I said, that one doesn’t drown, he walks home on the bottom.” He spoke over his shoulder to the young fighters. “This is him. The murmillo Nero freed. Nine times at Corinth, and he never lifted his finger to the editor in any of them.”

The three young men looked at Valens with the rake in his arm. One of them, the youngest, with a fresh scar still pink through his eyebrow, looked at him longest.

Felix slid down and stood by the dun with the string of bone tokens in his fist.

“I rake sand,” Valens said.

“So you do. Fabius is up in the tribunal. He’ll hear of this before the Thracian’s out.”

“He’ll hear it from you.”

“He’ll hear it from these three, at the oil, before he’s sat down.” He jerked his chin at them. “Go on, you. Up and get your oil.” They went, the youngest looking back till the dark took him. Nicanor watched them go. “The middle one’s going to die today. He drops his shield when he’s tired, and the Thracian knows it.” He followed them into the tunnel’s shade.

“Is he right?” I said.

“He’s been wrong.” Valens wiped the rake’s teeth clean on the tunnel wall. “Not often.”

I climbed the outer stair with the women. It was steep, and I climbed it in a press of wives and slave girls and grandmothers, one with a basket of eggs, until we came out at the top under the open sky. The women sat up here, the whole top ring of the bowl; the law said so, and the women seemed glad of it, because from here they could see who sat beside whom on every bench below. I

took the end of a row next to the steps, beside a girl with a baby asleep on her shoulder.

The whole oval lay under me. On the near side, low down, was the tribunal with its awning, and a youth whose toga showed very white against the shade, sitting under it with his friends. Lower, in the men's rows, I found Valens because Felix was beside him, standing up, until somebody pulled him down.

Horns. A water organ in the depths of the place that wheezed and caught. The first pair walked out and round the sand together and saluted the tribunal, and the crowd shouted their names at them, and they fought. I watched the first exchange and then I watched the girl's baby instead, who slept through the horns and the shouting with his lips apart, and only woke when the crowd went quiet. The quiet meant one of them was down. When I looked, the one on the sand had his finger up toward the tribunal, and the young man under the awning looked round at his friends and lifted his hand. The crowd breathed out. A slave trotted onto the sand with a palm branch and gave it to the one standing, who held it up and turned with it to every side of the arena in turn, and somebody threw him a purse.

The second pair was the Thracian and Nicanor's middle one. I did not watch that. I watched the girl beside me unwrap a sausage, and when the crowd let out a noise it had not given the first pair, low and drawn out, I went on watching her eat it. Afterward I saw the middle one walked away between two slaves, on his own feet, with his shield arm held across his chest in the other hand.

Then, with the arena empty, a man in a red cloak walked out to the middle of the sand, a boy at his heels with a board, and lifted his arms until the benches quieted.

"Thanks to the gods, and to Gaius Fabius Rufinus, who gives you this day," he cried, and his voice rose through the bowl to us

whole, every word, “there is among you on these benches one who took his freedom at Corinth from the hand of Caesar himself! Lupus, murmillo, nine times victor! Lupus, who sits among you!”

The whole bowl swung on itself to look.

Felix was up again, pointing down at the crown of Valens’s head, his arm straight out. The nearest men turned, then those behind them, and then a whole block of benches together, and the shouting started from that place and spread. *Lupus.* It ran the oval and ran it again. A man two rows below Valens reached up and slapped him on the shoulder, and another stood on his bench to see.

Valens’s right hand came up off his knee. It rose as high as his ear, with the palm open toward the tribunal, the way the pair on the sand had held their hands up when they first walked out. It hung there while the shouting went once more round the bowl.

Then he gripped the back of Felix’s tunic with that hand and sat him down.

“That’s the muleteer,” said somebody behind me. “Him that lodges at Grata’s.”

“With the Greek wife.”

“That mends.”

I felt them find me, face after face down the row. The grandmother with the eggs leaned across the girl and her baby and pressed an egg on me. It was boiled, and still warm from being sat on in her basket.

“For the child,” she said. “Grata says the heat. Eat it now, you’ll want it later and it’ll be cold.”

I had not told anybody in that whole bowl of people anything. I sat there holding the egg.

“Is that yours?” the girl with the baby asked. “The one with the boy that won’t sit?”

"Yes."

"Mine's on the stair selling cushions." She shifted the baby to her other shoulder. "He charged me for this one. His own wife. A copper, and that's the price, he says, and it's flat as a griddle cake, look, there's no wool in it at all, he's sold the wool out of it to somebody at the top."

"To whom?"

"To a woman with a cushion, I should think." She pressed the flat one with her free hand, gloomily. "He'll have sold her mine and charged me for the cover."

Below, Felix had swung about on his bench and was telling the men behind him something with his hands, a shield on one arm and a blade in the other fist, and the men were listening to him.

The herald waited, and when no one stood to be cheered, he spread his arms at the crowd as if to say he had tried, and the third pair came out.

Nicanor and a smooth young freedman, in a clean tunic and with a tablet open in his hand, were standing in the tunnel when the show let out, and the crowd parted round them. Valens had the string roped together and was leading the dun out; he stopped because the freedman stepped into the dun's path, and the dun stopped because Valens had.

"Gaius Fabius Rufinus sends his greeting," the freedman said. "He gives another show at the Parilia. He asks that Lupus open it. An exhibition between the pairs, with the practice sword, against the best of his own murmillos. No blood. Two thousand sesterces for the afternoon, half of it now, and a seat at his dinner after."

"No," said Valens.

The freedman's stylus waited above the wax and wrote nothing. Behind him Nicanor was looking at the dun's feet.

"My master asks what Lupus would take," the freedman said.

"Lupus died in Asia," said Valens. "Or drowned off Kenchreai. Ask Nicanor." He clicked to the dun. She went on, and the freedman had to step out of her way or have his foot trodden on.

Nicanor took a groom's place at the black's head.

"Your lad never shut his mouth through the whole of the third pair. He's built for it."

"He's built for a shovel."

"I've seen worse start." He glanced back for Felix, who was behind us leading the last mule. "Who does he belong to?"

"His own. I freed him."

"Then I'll not need to ask you." Nicanor halted where the sand ended and let the string go by him, and lifted his rod to me as I went past, a courtesy no one had paid me before.

At the bottom of the outer stair, where the crowd thinned onto the road, somebody had already worked on the pier with a nail. Among the old names and tallies, low down, fresh scratches showed white through the dirt on the plaster: a helmet with a fish along its crest, drawn by someone who knew one close, and under it, in big uneven capitals, LVPVS. The final S ran off the stone, where whoever cut it had been jostled.

Valens walked past it with the string. Three paces on, he stopped.

"The fish faces the wrong way," he said.

On the road home his back was as straight as a post. He kept catching himself at it, letting his shoulders down, and a dozen paces on they were up again.

Felix kept beside the dun the length of the road, and through the gate, and as far as our door, and he asked not one thing.

* * *

That night Valens washed at our basin well past what the dust of one day needed. He scrubbed his face and his nape and his

forearms to the elbow, and then the hand that had lifted to the benches, alone, the palm and between the fingers. He dried it and looked at it, and plunged it again.

The street had it by morning. The coppersmith shouted it to Valens from his doorway as the mules passed, and a boy ran after him calling it.

In the afternoon Fabius's freedman came to my plank. In daylight he was younger, and his nails were very clean. He read my board on the pier from the paving, every word, before he came in.

"The wife of Lupus," he said.

"Valens's wife. He is at work."

"My master raises it to three thousand." He laid a purse by a glass cup that was waiting its turn on my plank, and the cup chimed. "For an afternoon, at the Parilia, with a stick of wood and no blood. And his name painted on the walls as far as Nuceria, under my master's own. Fifteen hundred there, for earnest. He'll not ask for it if the answer stays the same."

It was a fat purse. It was more than the contractor would pay Valens between one vintage and the next, and the child was due in the summer, and the purse sat on my plank and did not go away.

"Take it back to him."

"He'll only send me again. I saw a Lupus once, at Nuceria, when I was little. Not him. Another one, a Lupus from Capua, there's always a Lupus. My father had me on his shoulders. I told my father I would be a murmillo, and he laughed so hard he had to put me down, and the next year he sold me to the Fabii."

"What became of him?"

"He keeps a cookshop at Puteoli now, by the fish market. He's fat. I went in once." He looked up at my scales. "Your husband never asked for the finger? Not once, in nine?"

"You would have to ask him."

"He'd not tell me." He tucked the purse away.

Going, he stopped at Grata's and drank a cup standing, and paid for it. When he was gone she came across and stood in my opening with her arms crossed under her bosom.

"He'll be back. They come back when it's money. You sent it off, I saw you, and quite right, it's not the sand he's for, a man built like that, he's for sitting on a bench in the shade where the street can see him and pouring for. If I'd one like that I'd not have him carting rubble for a contractor that shorts him, I'd sit him on my bench in a clean tunic and let the custom come to look. My husband's never lifted anything heavier than a wine cup." She looked over at her own counter, where her husband was not. "You'll tell him I said so. You'll not, I know you. I'll tell him myself."

She had it ready for Valens when he got in at dusk, with her forearms on the counter and a jug already poured.

"Sit down on that bench, you'll sit down, I've had men stop at my counter all day asking which door is the wolf's, and me with no answer for them but the door I let to a muleteer. Twenty times on the sand, the baths have it, and a sword off Caesar, and you've drunk my thin wine on that bench these two springs without a word, and paid, and that's better than the aediles do. That's the Falernian. You needn't eye it, it's paid for, it's paid for by the whole street. The fuller's woman sent it." She was round the end of the counter in a moment. "Look at the state of you." She brushed the sand off the shoulder of his tunic with the side of her hand, and the far shoulder, and let her hand stay on it after the sand was gone. "Fabius's man's been in twice. He's a poor sort of freedman, he's got clean nails, he'll be in again tomorrow, so you'll sit on that bench where I've an eye on you and let him find you there, and I'll pour."

She had her earrings in, the gold ones with the little pearl that she kept for the baths. They were new to her counter.

Valens drank the Falernian standing.

"That's good wine," he told her.

"It's the best on this street, and you'll not have it free twice, so you'll sit next time."

He thanked her for it and crossed to our door, and she was left with her hand in the air.

"She wants us out," he said, once our curtain was drawn.

I had unhooked the scales from the lintel, for the spice-seller was to fetch them early, and I nearly let the pan go.

"She brushed your shoulder."

"She was looking for the place to start." He let himself onto the bed and began to unwind the rag from his wrist, where a rope had burned him that morning. "She's got a fighter under her roof now, and Fabius's men in and out at her counter, and a baby to keep her awake by summer. She'll have the rent raised before the month's out, and if I won't pay it she'll have the excuse she wants to put us in the road."

"She gave you Falernian."

"She gave me the fuller's wife's Falernian, in front of her bench. So the street sees she's no quarrel with me, when she puts us out. She's never liked me. She watches me across that counter all day long."

"She had her earrings in."

"For Fabius's freedman. So he'd see she has gold to lose, if he brings his trouble to her door."

I lowered the scales onto the plank, very carefully, and turned to the lamp until my mouth behaved.

"Fabius has gone up to three thousand," I told him. "His freedman put the earnest down on my plank so that a customer's cup rang."

He was still. “Where is it?”

“I sent it home with him.”

“And Rome?” I asked.

“Fabius isn’t Rome.”

“Fabius is why you will not go.”

He raised his eyes from the burn.

“At the show,” I said. “You thought your hand went up unseen.”

“I saw you see it. You were the only woman on the rim not eating. My hand went up to them. I hadn’t told it to.”

“Nobody at the Basilica,” I said, “will want you to lift your hand. They will want you to say what happened. That is all.”

“They want my name. Said aloud, before a judge, and Celer’s advocate, and every idler in the basilica that morning. And then a clerk has it in ink. Here it’s scratched on one pier, low down, in a boy’s letters. After Rome, Celer knows where I sleep. His freedmen know. So does any man on those benches with a mind to sell it him: a Lupus with a Greek wife, in a cobbler’s shop in Pompeii, beside a fish stall.”

“Celer knows already. You told him you were coming to Rome. He heard you.”

“I said that because he’d offered me a farm.”

“And when it is over he will have paid back a dowry and lost. Men who have lost do not come looking. They go home and dine.”

He did not raise his voice; he never did. “A child’s coming. Since the ship I’ve been nobody here, and I’ve slept all those nights through.”

“You sat me by the stair at the show.”

“That was the crowd.”

“There is always a crowd. Every place we have been, you have looked for the way out of it before you looked at anything else.

Our first night under this roof you asked me which gate was nearest, and then you tried that door twice before you had so much as unrolled a blanket."

"The door was sticking. There's always a way out. I find it first."

"I know you do."

I took the bed's foot.

"You can be nobody in Pompeii for the rest of your life," I said. "You can cart stone and pay Grata's rent and wait, morning after morning, for a man in the street to look at you twice. And he will. Nicanor knew you by your heel. Felix will have told every boy in the barracks before the Kalends." Beyond the curtain Felix stopped turning over. "Or you can go to Rome and say it once, aloud, and have it written, and be believed, and come home. And then if somebody looks twice, let him look."

"Have you got the other blanket in there?" It was Felix, from the shop. "I'm not listening. Have you, though? It's gone cold enough out here to crack the water jar."

I pulled the second blanket off our feet and pushed it round the curtain's edge to him. It was snatched, and the shop creaked with him rolling himself up in it, and then was quiet.

"Be believed," Valens said.

"Yes."

"By who? The judge? The judge has never seen me. He's seen Celer, at dinner."

"Plautia believed you, and her brother is paying your road on the strength of it. I believe you."

"You weren't there."

"No. I was not there. I believe you anyway."

"And after it I come home and cart stone, the same as now."

"You cart stone. I beat the dust of it out of your tunic every week."

"And they'll ask about you. Celer's advocate will. Who is the witness's wife. Who her father was. Which house in Syracuse. He'll have a man at Syracuse before the heat, knocking on doors."

I had a name in a clerk's book at Delphi, and a kinswoman whom everybody there believed had sailed, and nobody at all in Syracuse. I told him none of it, and he let it lie.

He lay back and closed his eyes. Next door Grata was laughing at something her husband had said, from low down in her chest.

* * *

Felix missed the string two mornings running in the last month of the winter. On the third Valens went out with the string alone. At nightfall he mentioned that he had not had to give his name once all day; the other muleteers said it for him now. He ate leaning on the doorpost. Then he left, lamp and all, and I threw my cloak on and caught him up at the fountain.

We went on past it in the dark, and turned left for the theaters, with every shutter closed along the way and the lamp throwing our two shadows ahead on the paving stones. I had had a burning under my breastbone since the Saturnalia and no Latin word for it. I called it, to Grata, the fire under the bone. Grata had laughed at me for it and given me a lump of chalk to suck, and it had worked.

"Where will he be?"

"Where Nicanor is."

"Is he old enough for them?"

"The slaver said twelve, at Kirrha. Slavers say what sells."

"Fifteen, then. Sixteen."

"Of an age to swear himself to a lanista, if one will have him. There's no paper on him. I never had one made. Nobody can stop him but Nicanor."

"Can you?"

"I gave him that much. I can't unsay it to keep him off the sand."

"You could tell him what it was. The sand."

"He was there. He saw a man walked off it between two slaves holding his own arm on."

"He saw a palm," I said. "And a purse thrown."

The street fell away, and the high back wall of the big theater rose dark ahead.

The barracks were at the theaters' back, in what had been a great walk of columns round an open yard where people strolled between the plays, before the earthquake. Now the columns were walled up, with a gate and a porter, and from the yard behind it came the knock of wooden swords on wooden posts. Over the gate a lamp burned on a bracket. The plaster on the gateposts was scratched over with names and fighters and tallies, up past where a man's arm would go.

Felix was sitting under the lamp with his back to the gatepost, his knees drawn up. He had a nail in his hand. He was working at the plaster beside his shoulder and did not hear us until Valens's shadow went over him.

He had scratched a palm branch. It was not much bigger than my hand: a stem, with short strokes slanting upward off it to left and right, close together. Each cut showed fresh and white. He had cut the stem twice over, so that it sank deeper.

"Nicanor says I've the shoulders for it, or will have," Felix said, before we had a word out. He kept his seat against the post. "He had me in the yard this afternoon with a stick. Too old to start and too thin to finish, and I'm to try him again when I've a beard. You were worse, he says, your first month, that you couldn't keep a shield up while a man said his own name, and you were bigger than me." He drew the nail down the last of the palm's strokes, slowly, deepening it. "He says you never told me

because you're ashamed. Are you? Why would you be? They shouted it round the whole bowl. I heard them."

"Grata's kept you some supper," said Valens.

"Will you speak to him? He'd have me tomorrow if you said."

Valens reached for the nail. Felix rose, and kept it.

"I asked him today. I'll ask him tomorrow, and the day after that." He was taller than me now, I saw, and had been for some time. "He'll get tired of saying it before I get tired of hearing it."

Off he stalked homeward, nail in hand and shoulders up, and never turned his head to see if we were following.

"Go after him," I said.

"He'll go home. He's hungry."

The porter had gone in at the sound of Felix's voice. Now the gate opened a crack and Nicanor stood in it, in an old tunic, with chalk on his hands from the posts. Behind him the young men went on at the posts without him.

"Three days he's sat on my step," he said. "He eats my porter's bread. I send him off and he comes back with a nail."

"Send him off again."

"I have. He comes back. He'll outlast me at it, that one. Fabius's man was at my gate today. I said you'd lost your wind."

"I have."

"You've lost nothing. You tried my sand with your heel." He looked the way Felix had gone. "If he comes to my gate with a beard on him, and nobody's said no to him by then that he'll listen to, I'll take him. You know I will."

"You take them all."

"I took you." He looked at the cloak I held shut across my belly. "Go home. Both of you. It's cold for her out here."

He shut the gate. The bar went across on the inside. Somewhere in the yard a wooden sword clattered on the paving, and a young voice swore at it, and someone laughed.

Valens held the lamp to the palm. Inside, the wooden swords went on knocking, slower now, with Nicanor's voice between the blows, too far off for words. I fitted a fingertip into the topmost stroke. The plaster crumbled at the edge of it, a little, and the white came away on my skin.

"He cannot write his name."

"A palm. I've eyes."

"You could teach him to write his name under it."

"Felix thinks I can't read."

"Felix believes whatever suits him."

"Then he'd know I'd let him think it four years."

Over the palm, high on the gatepost where a tall boy could reach on his toes, LVPVS showed again, smaller this time and neater, with a little wreath round it. Valens slid his knife in where the wreath's two ends met and lifted the wreath off whole.

"Rome," I said. "Somebody has to give Plautia's brother's freedman an answer. You have until the Ides."

"I can count to the Ides." He lowered the lamp. The palm went into shadow, and the name. He stood with the light hanging at his knee, looking at the dark plaster where they were, and I wanted him to say Rome, or say no, and he did neither of those things. He turned to me instead. What was he to tell the child, he asked me, when it was grown and came to that gate and read the wall, and asked him what he had been?

Chapter 22

The Basilica Julia

Rome · spring, AD 74

Rome reached me first through the curtains of a hired chair, as noise: a stonecutter's mallet going somewhere overhead until a man on a scaffold drowned it, bawling down for his bucket, and was drowned in his turn by a peddler crying that he would take broken glass for sulfur matches, and the peddler by a dog that kept pace with the bearers half the length of a street giving its opinion of them, and all of it, whenever the poles swung riverward, by the smell of the Tiber, which was black mud, old drains and wet rope.

Nothing on wheels came inside the walls by daylight except the builders' carts. Everyone else walked or was carried, and at the Capena Gate the brother's freedman had taken a single look at my belly and gone off to bargain for the chair. I had wanted to see this city since I was eight and found it in the R volume of my father's encyclopedia, a tissue overlay of the Forum laid across a color plate of its ruins, and now I was inside it, tipping uphill in a box that smelled of the last passenger's hair oil, with my knees together and both hands on the child, while Valens walked at the front poles with our bag on his shoulder.

"What is out there?" I said through the gap in the curtain.

“People.” He stood aside for a porter with half a sheep across his back. “A temple. Another temple. They’re building everything at once.”

The freedman had arrived at the harbor wine shop in Puteoli on the morning of the Kalends of March and found us already at a table, with our bag between our feet and a jug we had been making last since dawn. He had paid for everything since without being asked, and he watched Valens, when he thought nobody saw, as a buyer might watch a mule he had been promised was quiet.

Felix had stayed in Pompeii with the string, which the contractor had taken for the spring, and with Grata to feed him. He trailed our cart as far as the Herculaneum Gate, kicking a stone along ahead of him, and at the gate he booted it over the verge and turned home for the mules.

The house the brother had taken for the suit stood high on the Quirinal in a street of blind walls and good doors. It belonged to a widow who let it by the month to people with business at law, and we had a month in it before the court sat. Her husband’s family still lived in the hall, in a row of painted cupboards along one wall with their little doors shut; the crack of one showed the yellow wax of somebody’s nose.

Plautia was standing by the rain pool when the bearers set the chair down. She kept her place while I was extracted from it, which took the porter and Valens both, and while I found my feet on the widow’s marble, and I had leisure enough for her hair.

It was built up over her forehead in the Roman fashion, a high front of tight curls in rows, each row stepped back above the one below it, and the way it stood told me there was a frame inside: a crescent of cane, I thought, or of wire wrapped in hair, with every curl pinned to it separately and the whole of it lashed to the plait

behind. Somebody had worked on it since before dawn, and it made her a hand taller and covered both her ears.

"You are welcome to this house," she said, "which is not my brother's, and not mine, but belongs to a widow who lets it, together with her husband's ancestors, to anyone who has a lawsuit and the rent, and who has promised us that the bedroom behind the garden is the quietest on the hill; it is yours, and tonight you will learn what the Quirinal means by quiet. How many months?"

"Five. Nearly six."

"I asked my brother to bring you. Shaking you up the Appian Way in that condition was his own idea."

"The carriage was very good. It was the chair that rocked."

She looked at the freedman, and the freedman found something that needed him in the vestibule.

"My brother has hired a hairdresser who does the hair of a consul's wife," she said. "I am supposed to appear never to have left Rome in my life. Do I?"

"You look taller."

"That was not my question." She crossed the marble then and took both my hands, and held them out from my sides so that she could see the rest of me, and her fingers were cold. "Valens. Does it weigh on her?"

He had dropped our bag. "She doesn't say."

"No. She would not." Plautia let my hands go and turned to him. "My brother had the freedman's purse counted out for two, and then for one again, and he would have sworn to you that it would be one, or none at all."

"We were at Puteoli on the Kalends."

"So the freedman wrote. He was a little hurt by it; he had brought a book along to read while he waited, and never got past the first column. Myrrhine will show you the room."

In the evening the men dined with our advocate, and Plautia and I climbed a ladder onto a corner of the roof where the widow kept rosemary in pots, a row of them along the parapet in good red ware with a stamped rim, one of which had been mended across the belly with lead staples by somebody who knew what he was doing. From there, over the near roofs and the smoke of the valley between, the second hill over lay dark already, pricked by a few lamps.

"That is a good pot," I said. "Whoever stapled it was better at his trade than whoever threw it."

"Take it. Take it home with you to Campania; you have more use for a pot than I do." She had her hand on its rim before she remembered. "It belongs to the widow."

"So it does."

She left her hand on the rim, then took it away and put both hands under her cloak. "When the judge sits, my brother's advocate will read my dowry out to the court piece by piece, as though I were the hold of a ship, and the advocate across the aisle will say that the sixth part he kept back from it was the price of my character, which the law allows him, and nobody will ask me a single thing, because I am the one person in the whole matter whom nobody needs to hear. What will they ask him?"

"His name."

"First. Then about me."

"And he will say what happened."

"He has no other way of speaking. In two years he never told me a thing was well when it was not, not the weather and not my husband's temper. Of everything about him, that alone ever frightened me."

She turned to the far hill. "The Esquiline. My son is over there with his nurse, in a house his father has taken for the year, because a candidate for the praetorship must be seen to dine in

Rome. He was born the autumn after the fire, when half this city was still black, and his father's mother had him wrapped in a shawl that smelled of smoke for a month, because nothing in her house would wash clean." She did not point. "I have stood here every evening for eleven days. Did he come because you asked him to?"

"He brought me."

"You have not answered me."

"It is the only answer I have."

"Then I shall take it. On the day, you will sit beside me, and you will not touch my veil, whatever I do with my hands."

* * *

The Basilica Julia was bigger inside than the concourse at Thirtieth Street Station and much louder, because four courts sat in it at once, all of them unwalled. Two stories of arcades ran round a nave as long as a city block, and the nave floor was laid in slabs of colored marble, yellow and purple-veined and gray, which rang under the hobnails of everybody walking on it. The courts sat on wooden platforms, each with its own crowd packed round it, and between them hung curtains on rods that kept out nothing whatever. Ours was in the south aisle, between two piers. Behind the curtain on our left a court of a hundred men was hearing a dispute over a will, and somebody there had brought friends to clap for him; on our right, a gaming board had been cut in the floor, where two clerks' boys were throwing dice until an attendant moved them on.

The judge had a chair on the platform and three of his friends on stools below him, to advise him. He was a lean old senator with the broad purple stripe on his tunic, and he listened with closed eyes and his hands folded on his stomach, so that for most of the first hour I took him to be asleep. At the platform's corner a

slave sat beside a water clock, a bronze bowl on a stand with a jar beneath it. When an advocate rose the slave pulled a peg, and the water began to run, and when the jar was full the advocate's time was gone.

Plautia sat on the front bench behind our advocate, her veil drawn up to the eyes, between her brother and me, with Myrrhine at my elbow. Her brother was a heavy man with her nose and none of her stillness. Valens was along the pier with the witnesses.

Celer came in late with eight or ten friends about him, all talking. He was browner than at Corinth, and his toga was new again. He saw Valens before anyone, and his face lit.

"Valens," he said, and crossed to us. "They tell me it's Valens now. I've been practicing it on my steward. And Mara has come all this way." He smiled down at me past Plautia's veil. "You'll have found Rome's all stairs. We're born to it here; the rest of you suffer. Somebody should have warned you." He went to his bench, and his friends sat round him like a family at the theater.

Our advocate, when he rose, was a short, square man with a hoarse voice and no gestures at all, and he read the dowry out in it: so much in coin and so much in land, a Syrian girl named Doris, earrings, a lampstand on lion's paws.

"At the divorce," he said, "the defendant gave back all of that but a sixth, which he kept for misconduct. Misconduct proved by two coached house slaves, and by the defendant's word, which he gave very sorrowfully, and by nothing else. One other person under that roof knew what was true. He is here. The court can hear him tomorrow."

The jar filled. Celer's advocate rose.

He was young, with a beautiful voice, and he kept his left hand inside the fold of his toga and spent the right one on the air.

"The court will not hear that man tomorrow," he said, "nor on any day. He is my client's property, bought off the lanista at Corinth a full month ahead of Caesar's games, and paid for in silver." He raised the bill, two boards bound with cord, with the seals pressed over the cord in a row. "I need not remind this court that a slave is not heard against his master. If the lanista afterward, with Caesar watching and the crowd on its feet, chose to free a man he had already sold, the show was the lanista's, and the clerk only copied it into his wax. Written fair, a mistake is still a mistake."

"Then the court should see the copy," said our advocate, and handed up the leaf.

At that distance its color told me which it was, for the wax had darkened since Corinth.

"There is no seal on this." Celer's advocate turned it over when it had been passed to him in its turn. "It has been cut from a book, with a knife. Will my friend tell the court where he had it?"

"Gladly, when his client tells the court what has become of the rest of the book." Our advocate kept his voice exactly where it was. "It is the first book of Vettius and Caninius, in Caesar's Greek year. The seals are on its knot, and the knot is wherever the book is. The leaf has the day, the lanista, the man freed, and the names of everyone who stood by and watched."

Celer laughed. It was a warm, easy laugh, and two of his friends laughed with him before they saw that nobody else had.

The judge looked out at us. "How is it proved?"

"By the men whose names are on it."

The brother's silver had brought two of them from Corinth, and all morning they had kept the end of our bench in their traveling cloaks. The first was an old dyer whose nails were still blue at the roots. He gave his name, and it was the fourth name on the leaf.

"I witnessed for a dozen that afternoon," he said. "The magistrate had us all in a row by his table in the shade, a lot of old men with nothing better to do, and they were brought from the arena to our table one after another to be freed, with the blood still on some of them. That man's face is nothing to me. I remember a murmillo bled on my good cloak, and his lanista paid me for it, too much. That may have been him."

"Did the lanista free him?"

"It was the lanista's hand on him while his name went down in the wax. I saw that."

The second was a fat merchant who had been seasick, he told the court, from Lechaion to the Italian shore and had no hope of being well again before the autumn. His name was the seventh.

"That's my name, and my father's after it. I was there. Caesar sat in his chair on the tribunal with a cloth wound round his throat, to keep his voice for the evening, and he never said a word all afternoon. They carried the practice sword up to him, and he put out a finger and touched it."

Celer's advocate let both of them go without a question.

"Nobody doubts that these honest men sat in the shade at Corinth and watched a clerk write," he said to the judge. "Neither of them can say whose man was written down. My client's bill can."

The youngest of the judge's three friends had the bill on his knees. He was turning the first board toward the light from the arcade, and then he leaned up to the judge's chair and said something, and the judge sat forward.

"My friend's uncle was consul that year, for his turn," said the judge. "Your bill makes him consul in a month he spent at his villa at Tibur, complaining of the fellow who had the office."

"A steward's slip of the stylus," the young advocate said.

"My uncle will be sorry to hear it," said the young man on the stool. "He'd have liked the extra months."

That laugh went all round our aisle and into the next court, Celer's bench included. He sent his slave over with a cup of something cool for the seasick witness, and while the clock's jar was being emptied he leaned out from his bench toward Plautia's brother.

"Your man has a carter's lungs. I'd hire him myself if I could get him away from you; mine sings."

The brother looked at him and said nothing, and Celer, quite content, sat back among his friends. Our advocate, without gestures, returned to the steward's slip, set it beside the leaf and the dyer's cloak, and talked hoarsely until the jar was full again. The judge put the witness off until morning and went to his lunch.

* * *

The widow's back bedroom was quiet until well after dark, and then the carts came.

Everything that could not cross Rome by day crossed it in the dark. It went past under our wall, on iron tires, over paving that threw the noise straight up: timber and lime, a train of wine jars clinking in their straw, a whole herd of something with hoofs, and the drovers swearing at all of it in more accents than I knew. The bed shook a little with the heavier loads. The child turned over and back, then pushed a foot out against my ribs; I lay holding it through my own skin and listened to Rome being fed.

"That one's losing a wheel," Valens said, close by my ear.

"From up here?"

"It knocks every turn." He was lying on his back with his arms folded under his head, and his elbow touched my hair. "Hear it. He'll have it off before he reaches the river."

We listened to the knocking go away downhill. The child shoved again, and I lifted his hand from the pillow and set it on the place.

"There," I said.

He lay still under it. It came again under his palm, a hard small push, and went, and returned an inch further round.

"That's a heel," he said.

"You can tell that through me?"

"It's the shape of one." He left his hand where it was.

"Where do I stand," he said, "tomorrow?"

"Where the dyer stood, next to the slave with the clock."

"And look at who?"

"At the judge."

"Celer sat on his left today, with the light behind him."

"You need not look at him at all. Look to the back," I said. "At the end wall, where the idlers lean. Talk to them."

He was silent until I thought he slept. A second cart went by with a bad wheel, or the earlier one returning; somewhere near the river a drover started singing.

"I'll talk to them," he said, and turned on his side toward the wall, and through the carts, and the singing, and the knocking of the next wheel and the next, he slept.

* * *

On the bench opposite ours a little man in a dun cloak had brought his dinner in a napkin, half a loaf and a raw onion the size of a fist. He peeled the onion with his thumbnail while our advocate was getting up and began to eat it in bites, and whenever the curtain beside him stirred, the smell reached us.

Celer's advocate objected again. "The court will remember whose property it is about to hear."

"I'll hear him first," the judge said, "and decide afterward what he's worth."

Valens went to the end of the platform in a tunic of the brother's, fresh from the fuller and tight across his back. He looked over the judge's head and ours, over the women's places and the men standing behind them, and past them down the aisle to the last pier, where the idlers leaned, in from the glare, and he said it to them.

"Gaius Iulius Valens. Freed at Corinth."

He pitched it as he would hail the string in a crosswind, and it went the length of the aisle and out beneath the arcade. Beyond the curtain, the reader of the will lost his place in it, and had to be told where he had got to. At the back, an idler who had been asleep against a pillar there came off it upright and asked the man next to him something, and the man next to him said the name back.

Plautia's hands were in her lap, and she had taken the fringed edge of her veil between two fingers.

"Where were you born?"

"Thrace."

Opposite, the little man in the dun cloak bit into his onion, and Valens's eyes went to it.

"They grew those," he said. "Every house. By the autumn you could smell the village before you saw it."

"The court is not buying onions," the judge remarked.

Our advocate supplied the next question, and the next, and Valens answered them as he answered everything, in as few words as would carry the thing across.

"How did you come to Corinth?"

"I was taken as a boy, and sold there, into the school."

"And freed?"

"At Caesar's games, the last afternoon. The wooden sword came down to me from the tribunal, and I was walked to the magistrate's table, and I stood while his clerk wrote."

"Whose hand was on your shoulder while he wrote?"

"The lanista's."

"And afterward, who paid you?"

"The legate's steward. On the Kalends, in silver, with my keep and a cloak for the winter, to go where the lady went, a pace back."

"In silver," our advocate repeated. "To his own slave." Then, to Valens: "Tell the judge about the night."

"It was summer. Vitellius had Rome." He kept his eyes off Plautia, and she kept hers off him; she had the whole fringe of her veil wound round her fingers now. "The steward came for me two hours after dark and said the master wanted me in the atrium. Every lamp in the atrium was lit, more than for guests. The lady was there by the household gods, in what she slept in, with a cloak somebody had put round her. The master had two of the house slaves standing at the pool. He asked them what they'd seen, and they said they'd seen me in her bed. Her hairdresser said it first. She was a girl, and she wept while she said it. The stable boy said it after her, to the steward. The master said he was sorry. He said it to me, and to the lady, and he said it to the gods in the cupboard."

"Were you ever in her bed?"

"I was never inside her door. I lay outside it, on the tiles, with my back against the wood. If she'd wanted out in the night she'd have had to step over me."

The man with the onion sneezed.

It was a sneeze that started far off and gave notice of itself. His head went back, and his hand rose with the onion still in it,

and the whole aisle had time to watch him draw his breath for it before it came, and when it came it was enormous.

"Salve," said the bench round him, all together. "Salve," said the women's bench, and the idlers at the back. One of the judge's friends said it. The judge, eyes still closed, said it.

"Thank you," said the sneezer, half rising to bow left and right. "Thank you. And to you. Thank you."

Valens kept the next word ready and waited while the court finished wishing the man good health.

It started under the child: I felt it begin there, a jolt low down, and the child jolted back at it, and then it was up in my shoulders and would not leave them. I bent forward over the child, as far as it allowed, and gripped the bench's edge in my two fists, and the bench shook under them. Myrrhine's thigh was against mine, and I felt her feel it, and to my left Plautia went stiller than she already was. My eyes ran, and my nose ran with them. My heels had begun knocking on the marble by themselves, and nothing in my legs would stop them. Somewhere in all that I sweated through my shift, which was the worst thing yet and made it much worse. He sneezed again, smaller, and one old voice at the rear of the aisle said "Salve" to him all by itself, kindly, and that finished me.

The front of the court had gone to a blur. I heard the judge say, "Take the lady outside," and heard the beautiful voice of Celer's advocate say that the defendant had no objection whatever to the lady's being taken outside, none, and then there was a hand under my elbow and a staff close by my cheek, and one of the basilica's attendants was lifting me off the bench without any hurry at all; from his manner, this was his daily work. Myrrhine took my other arm, and together we walked the aisle past the sneezer, who twisted round on his bench to watch me go, wiping his nose on his wrist and very interested.

Behind me Valens's voice began again, level, on whatever came after the floor outside her room, and the curtain swung across it.

* * *

The attendant set me down on the Basilica's steps with a word to Myrrhine that I did not catch, and returned to his staff and his morning. I sat where I had been put. For a while the laughing went on by itself in my shoulders, without me, and then it ran down and left me with wet cheeks, a wet shift and a light, sick, scoured feeling, as after an hour's crying.

Myrrhine shook out the cloak she had over her arm and spread it on the step.

"Up a little. Sit on this. It's only my second-best, and the fuller on this street wants a sestertius to look at a stain, I asked him yesterday about the lady's, so I'll do it myself and he can whistle." She sat down beside me and took off one shoe, and then the other. They were Roman shoes, red, bought on the second day, and they had been hot coals to her ever since. "If you want to laugh again, laugh now, out here, where it costs nothing."

"Did he see?"

"Everybody saw. The judge saw, and he was asleep."

"Valens."

"I was holding you up; I'd only an eye for you. She was shaking too, my lady. Under the veil. I had my arm round you and my hand on her. I felt it. You didn't see that."

"Laughing?"

"I didn't ask her."

I wanted to look at the step.

Beside my hip the step had a gaming board scratched in it, a grid of little round cups scored in the marble in three rows. Two porters in leather aprons were playing on its neighbor, with

walnuts, and arguing about a walnut. In July of 1991 these steps had been a platform of broken brick and marble with grass growing in the joints. I had sat on the top of it with my sandals off and a peach from a stall near the station, twenty-six, three weeks into my first summer abroad, and found a board like this one where my hand lay, and put my fingertips into each of its cups in turn until a custodian in a blue shirt blew his whistle at me for sitting on the monument. I had left with my peach and my face hot. That board had been worn into shallow dishes by thumbs. This one still had the chisel in it, and my fingertips came away from its cups gray with grit.

"Is it a game?" said Myrrhine.

"I never learned the rules."

"That makes it a game." She stood. "Will you go back in?"

"Not to the court."

"Walk, then. Your legs will stop shaking if you give them something to do."

She got me to my feet. I had known this place as stumps and lines in the grass, as columns that stopped at the knee and a guide's paper plan held flat against the wind, and it was all standing. Facing the Basilica's steps, where I had sat with my peach under three tall columns holding up a scrap of cornice and no more, the temple of Castor stood whole on its high platform, every column of it, with its roof on and the acanthus on its capitals painted, and men sitting on its steps to do business in the shade. The round temple of Vesta had a wisp of smoke rising from the middle of its roof. Outside it, a line of women waited with little dishes in their hands, and a girl in white above them was spooning gray ash into each dish from a crock: calf's ash, a horse's dried blood and bean stalks, against the Parilia, to be burned and stepped through. Ovid had stood in that line once

with his hands full, and the women in it now gossiped and moved up.

"What are they buying?" said Myrrhine.

"It is given."

"Nothing's given," said Myrrhine, and went to look at the crock herself, barefoot, with her red shoes in her hand.

* * *

The stair to the gallery climbed inside the Basilica's far end, steep and worn. At the top of it the idlers, with the women who had no seats below, leaned on a parapet over the whole of the nave, and I squeezed in between two pillars. From the parapet the courts were four crowds round small platforms, their curtains moving whenever somebody pushed through, and I heard all of them at once, four rooms of one party.

Our judge's head shone bald under me, and the slave at the clock had changed his jar. Celer's advocate had closed on Valens, with his free hand open.

The woman wedged in beside me had a swaddled baby sleeping in the crook of her arm. "Where's this gladiator?"

"The one standing still."

"Oh, him." She turned her shoulder, baby and all, to the will again.

"In the street behind her litter," the advocate was saying, "at the door of her bath, on the floor outside her room at night, so you tell us, with one door between you: a man young and strong, unmarried, used to taking what the crowd threw him, and she not thirty and, by every account but my client's, unhappy. Did you never want her?"

"I watched the street."

"The street."

"Who was on the roofs, and where the dogs were."

"And the steward paid you, you say. Masters give slaves an allowance; that is not wages."

"He paid me what he paid the cook's freedman. Ask the cook."

"I would rather ask you." The advocate turned a little, so that the benches had his profile. "You were a gladiator. For how many years did you kill men on the sand, for money, for the crowd's pleasure?"

Valens let the question go by, his gaze at the aisle's end, and the water ran in the clock.

"That's not in the matter," said the judge. "Go on."

"As the court pleases," said Celer's advocate. "It knows my client's family, and it can see the witness."

Our advocate stayed on his bench. "The court is asked to take a consul's dates against a steward's," he said.

The water ran out. Celer's advocate let his hand drop and took his seat. Our advocate said he had nothing to add that the court had not seen with its own eyes, and the judge promised his sentence on the third day, in this place, at mid-morning. Then he put on his outdoor shoes, which a slave held for him, and the platform began to empty.

Valens stepped down and looked first at the place where I had been, and Myrrhine's place beside it, both empty. He stood looking at them while the crowd went round him, until our advocate returned for him and touched his arm.

* * *

He found me that evening in the widow's back bedroom with my shift soaking in a basin, which Myrrhine had offered to see to; I had refused her.

"Was it the sneeze?" he asked.

"The judge said salve."

He settled on the bed's foot and thought about it. "He did."

"I am sorry. After it began, you were gone. Everything was."

"They asked me the rest." He unlaced one boot.

"And you answered?"

"What they asked. The cook's freedman would've backed me. They never sent for him."

"Was Celer watching you?"

"All through. His feet never moved." He unlaced the other boot and set the pair under the bed with the toes outward, ready, the way he always set them. "At Corinth, when he was kept waiting for his dinner, his right foot used to go on the floor under the table until the dish came."

He was asleep before the lamp wanted trimming. Later Plautia scratched at the curtain and came in without waiting to be asked, with her built hair taken down for the night and plaited loose over one shoulder, which made her look younger and less sure of her hands. She carried something folded.

"Myrrhine tells me you will not let her have your shift."

"It is not her work."

"All the work in this house is hers; she has decided so." She laid the folded thing across the blanket at his feet, and I saw that it was a shift of her own, fine Egyptian linen with a border worked in green at the neck, much better than mine. "It will be long on you. Turn the hem up. Were you watching his face, when he said where he slept?"

"No."

"Nor was I. I had my eyes on my hands." She considered them now, in the lamplight. "Myrrhine says that I shook. I have not laughed where any friend of that house could see me in five years, and I had no intention of beginning on the bench of a court. What I did, I cannot say. I would be grateful if nobody told me." She went out as she had come, without a good night.

In the morning Myrrhine looked at the shift on me and said she would have it back off me before I left Rome, and wash it first, and that I was not to grow any bigger in it in the meantime. The shift was too long for me and I wore it anyway.

The judge took his three days, and in them Myrrhine and I walked the Sacred Way down and over the Velia to the valley beyond it, where Nero had had a lake.

The lake was gone, and in its place stood the beginning of the amphitheatre, not a third built. The outer wall rose in arcades of pale stone, two tiers of arches high in some places and a single tier in others, and above that it was all scaffold: poles lashed with rope in a lattice the height of the curve, planks laid across them, men on the planks, ladders between them, and above everything, at intervals, the arm of a crane with a great wooden wheel at its foot and men walking inside the wheel like hamsters. Oxcarts came in at a crawl, one behind the other, loaded with stone from the quarries in the hills toward Tibur, by road, at the pace of the oxen. The noise was the noise of the whole city poured into one valley. Everything was the color of the stone, the men included.

The blocks went up dry, without mortar. I watched a gang set one on the top course: they lowered it onto the one below, levered it into line, and then a boy with a ladle edged along the scaffold from a brazier and poured lead into the socket where an iron cramp tied it to its neighbor. The lead fumed white and sweet-smelling, and the boy blew on his ladle and trotted off to the fire for more. The stone had holes in it of its own, like bread. I stood at the barrier and watched them fill the next socket and the next.

It was a place for men to fight in, while Rome watched them. I was thinking that, in the white dust, when a carter bellowed at us to stand off from his oxen, and Myrrhine hauled me back, and the cart went past so close that the stone on it left its dust on my arm.

"And what will it be?" said Myrrhine.

"Games."

"They've a theater for games already. Two. I've seen them."

"The emperor's building it out of Judaea."

"He got it cheap, the emperor," said Myrrhine.

We went home by the Argiletum, for its shops, and she walked the whole of it barefoot, over whatever the paving had on it, talking. She had been given to Plautia at her wedding, out of her father's house, a girl of twelve to carry the bride's slippers.

"I had the boy on my hip the whole of his first year. He bit my ear and hung on, and laughed, and his ears went red, and I couldn't get him off."

"Will he know her?"

"He knows her. He'll make out that he doesn't, because the nurse will be watching." She stopped at a cobbler's stall and turned a sandal over, and put it down, and we went on. "He's his father's, that way. He'll have learned it."

At every crossroads on our road home, men were building heaps of straw and bean stalks higher than their heads, for the Parilia, which fell the morning after the judge's third day.

* * *

The judge gave his sentence in fewer words than our advocate had spent on the dowry's earrings.

"I find for the plaintiff," he said, and behind the left-hand curtain somebody's friends began clapping for their own man and kept it up. "The defendant will restore the dowry whole, the sixth part he kept back for the lady's conduct together with the rest, within the time the law gives him. As to the bill of sale, I have given it the weight it deserves, and my young friend's uncle sends the defendant his compliments."

Plautia's brother leaned across to our advocate. "The sixth?"

"With the rest."

Nobody said the name of the witness. Plautia's brother cracked his knuckles, one hand and then the other, and rose, and his sister after him, and I saw the wound cloth come loose from her fingers.

Her brother faced Valens, now standing beside the bench.

"My sister will want to thank you, and make a poor job of it," he said, "so I'll do it now, and spare you both. Thank you. The freedman will take you to the Capena Gate whenever you choose, with his purse." He thought, and added, "And a better chair."

"I would rather walk to the gate," I said. "I should like to see the city once from outside a box."

"He can walk beside you and carry the chair's price, in case you change your mind at the first hill."

Celer came across the aisle to shake our advocate's hand, and the brother's. "Perfectly right, of course. I'd have found the same myself; I said so to my man at breakfast, and he'll swear I did." Then he went out first, still talking, and waited for us outside in the sun.

A slave stood on a ladder against the nearest pier there, tying a swag of greenery under the cornice for tomorrow. Celer stepped down two steps and along, round the foot of the ladder, and climbed back beyond it without once losing the thread of what he was saying to the brother.

"... and I'm told your man said something on the second day about the Cornelian law. Nobody wants the Cornelian law. Do we? My steward's old and wretched about it all, I've had him in tears twice; he'll see to the silver, he likes to be useful. We'd all like a quiet summer." One of his feet had begun to go on the step. He turned to Plautia with the air of having just thought of it. "The lady shall have the boy to dine at her brother's every market day while she's in Rome, and at Corinth whenever she sends for him,

and the nurse with him, of course. And let's have no more talk of laws. I had him brought down this morning. I thought, why not begin today? It's spring."

Plautia gave him no word.

Celer kept Valens for last. "You've a carrying voice, Valens. I'd forgotten it."

"You never heard it," said Valens.

Celer laughed, delighted. "And Mara. I hear there's to be a child; my congratulations, truly. They grow so fast. You look round, and there's a boy at the bottom of the steps who wants his dinner." He descended to his litter, and his friends went with him.

The boy waited where the steps met the street, with a Greek pedagogue's hand on his shoulder. His toga had a purple border, and his hair had been wetted and combed flat, and his ears poked out on either side. He held himself very straight, and when the pedagogue released him he climbed toward his mother a step and then the next, each one counted out for him beforehand by somebody, and stopped two below her.

"Mother, I greet you," he said. "I hope that I find you well, and I am to say that I am glad to see you." He stared at her hair. "Your hair's different. Does Uncle's dog still bite? The one on the chain? Does it remember me?"

"It bit a magistrate last summer," said Plautia.

He climbed the last two and caught the edge of her veil, where it hung at her elbow, and held on to it. She kept her hands empty and let him hold it. The porters were at their walnuts again on the step by my feet; one of them won something, and swore happily.

Then Plautia lifted her eyes from her son, and found Valens on the step above me, and looked at him a while.

“Marcus,” she said, “this is Valens. He used to carry you. Greet him.”

Chapter 23

An Inn on the Appian Way

The Appian Way, near Tarracina · spring, AD 74

The blanket had been made for a horse.

The landlady handed it over at the ladder's foot, folded small, with the care she might have shown the best thing in her house, and perhaps it was. It was gray wool felted thick. A band across its middle was worn thin and shiny where a girth had gone round it for years, and a corner of it was wet. From that corner outward it smelled of horse.

"Washed," she said. "At the Kalends."

"Have you a second?"

"One to a bed. There's one bed."

"We'll share it."

"You'll share it with more than him."

I believed her about the Kalends. She had a hen in the crook of her other arm, a brown hen asleep with its head drawn in, and she had kept it on her arm since we arrived out of the rain.

We had come the length of the marsh road that day, all of it under rain. From dawn our way lay straight between reeds, as though a surveyor had laid it out with a string and then forgotten to stop. Beside it ran the canal, brown as lentil soup, with mules on the towpath hauling barges at a walk. Every ditch had frogs in

it. Our driver, a Capuan with a single eyebrow that went right across, sang to them full-throated for the final two hours, to hear something else. The road left the marsh at the foot of a cliff. A temple of Jupiter was supposed to be up there; we saw rock going into a cloud and took it on trust.

The inn was the first roof after the reeds. It was rubble and timber, long and low, with stalls under one end and rooms over the stalls. By its door hung a painted sign that the weather had worn down to a cockerel and half a word. The landlady had been waiting in the doorway in a man's cloak with the sleeves turned back.

"Room over the mules," she had said. "Dry. Dry as anything is tonight."

The driver took his pair round to the stable, Valens with him. The driver would have left them standing in their wet harness all night if nobody watched him, and somebody did.

The common room had a hearth, a long table and a smell of eels. A drip fell through the roof halfway down the table into a bowl. While I dripped in my turn, with the blanket in my arms, the landlady crossed to the bowl and frowned into it. She spoke to the roof in a dialect I could not follow at all and shoved the bowl an inch to the left. The drip found it again.

She had found my eyes on the hen. "Fox. Had the other six. Not this one."

"She sleeps in the house?"

"She sleeps on me." She lowered the hen to the hearth bench. It sank at once into a brown loaf, and she left to see about the eels.

I sat. My ankles had swollen in the carriage so that my sandal straps cut into them. I had been hungry since Forum Appii, where I had eaten last. Grata had told me in the winter that this was the

child eating, and that I should feed it what it asked for. So far it had asked for everything.

Two tilers sat at the table's far end, with a load of roof tiles for Tarracina standing out in the wet. They had their boots off and their bare feet steaming at the hearth.

"He sold you a mule with a cough," the older one was saying.

"He sold me a mule. The cough was later."

"The cough came with it. In a basket. He threw it in for nothing."

"Will you tell him so?"

"I'll tell his mule."

They paid me no attention. Valens arrived streaming and stopped a pace in. He came and sat opposite, on the wall bench, with the door in his eye.

The driver came in on his heels, wiping his eyebrow. "He rubbed my mules down himself," he complained to the tilers. "Both. With my own sacking. I stood and held the lamp."

The older tiler turned on his bench to look Valens over. "That your carriage out there? The Capuan's?"

"Hired."

"He'll have you over at Fundi. He has everybody over at Fundi."

"Not with that near mule," Valens said. "She won't let him."

The eels came in a pot. They had been caught in the canal and tasted of it, of mud and weed, stewed with leeks in something that had once been wine. The bread was the hard round sort with eight scored sections that broke apart in the hand, and the inside was gray. There was a dish of salt with a fly in it, which the landlady fished out with her finger.

I ate. Valens broke a piece of bread and held it.

"That's not a towpath out there," the younger tiler told the room. "That's a river with mules in it."

The landlady came to the drip bowl and threw its water into the hearth, which hissed. She tucked her arms into the cloak. She was watching Valens.

"You came by the canal," she said.

"From Forum Appii."

"The towpath. Is it under?"

"Past the halfway post, a hand deep, for two hundred paces. The barge mules were going through it. They didn't like it. They went."

"Brown mule leading? A white blaze?"

"A gray, leading. Two browns behind."

She considered it. "He'll have swapped them at the halfway post," she said. She gathered up the hen and told it so. "He'll have swapped them. He's sense enough for that, hasn't he? He's that much sense." She kept to the hearth.

"Going down, or coming up?" she asked me.

"Down. Home."

"Where's that?"

"Pompeii."

"Never been. Fundi, once, for a wedding. It rained."

Somebody down the table shouted "Acca!" for more wine, and she brought it without letting the hen go, pouring one-handed.

"His off-side mule's going short," Valens said. "Near fore."

"Will it get us to Capua?"

"If he stops singing at it."

"The driver says Sinuessa in two days," I said.

"If it stops raining."

"And if it doesn't?"

"It won't," the older tiler put in from his end.

"Three," Valens said.

Valens pushed his bowl over to me. There were still four pieces of eel in it.

"You're not hungry?"

"Eat it."

His eel was cold. I was hungry the way I was always hungry now, which was all the time, and I ate his.

Horace had traveled this road a hundred years before us, with a party of friends and a bad stomach. He complained in verse about the canal water, and the frogs, and a drunk boatman singing to his girl through the night, and the inns. I had read him at nineteen, in a carrel, and thought he was making most of it up. He had made up none of it. There was a small, mean comfort in that. I sat with it, and it did not last.

Since the city gate he had been like this. He had walked beside me to the gate, with the freedman behind us carrying the price of a chair I never sat in. He had climbed up after me into the carriage the brother had hired as far as Capua. Since then he had answered whatever was put to him, the driver and the post-house men and me, with a word or two apiece. He was not short with anybody.

"I missed it," I said. "All you told them."

"You heard it at Kirrha. At the stream."

"That was to me."

"It was the same. Near enough the same."

The day he spoke I had been outside on the steps of the Basilica, sitting on Myrrhine's cloak. I had heard the beginning, as far as what he slept on outside her door, and then I was gone. The dyer and the merchant and the young man's uncle had done most of the deciding. He had stood up for an hour in front of half of Rome even so. It was what I had come for, and I had laughed it away.

Something bit me on the ankle, under the table, and then again above it.

"There's fleas," I said.

"Rain brings them up," said the landlady, at the hearth. "They don't like it either."

"Is there anything for them?"

"Pennyroyal. I'm out."

The younger tiler laughed at that. He scratched his own shin to show her she was right, and returned to the cheating carter and the mule.

The rain came harder. It drummed on the roof over the table. The drip in the bowl went from a tick to a thin, steady string, and the landlady gave the roof a word that I did know.

Valens stood. "Bed."

"Shout if the roof comes in," the landlady said to our backs. "It never has yet. Not on a guest."

He climbed first and reached back for the lamp, then for my hand. Climbing a ladder with the child in front was a matter of getting the belly up it ahead of the rest. I got through the hatch in stages, the blanket on my shoulder and his hand round my upper arm, onto boards that sagged underfoot.

There was no ceiling. The roof tiles were right over us on their rafters, red and rough in the lamplight, with a crack in one of them that leaked a fine spray. The rain on them was very loud. It was a close, hard sound, nearer than in any room I had slept in since Delphi, every tile taking its own share. Under it the animals below shifted and blew, and their smell rose between the boards.

The bed was a wooden frame strung with cord, with a tick of straw on the cords. I spread the blanket on the straw, and the tick crackled under it.

"It was a horse's," I said.

“A big horse. Cavalry, by the girth mark.” He ran a thumb along the worn band. “He’s dead, or sold.”

He hung the lamp on a nail by the shutter.

“Your boots are soaked,” I said.

“They’ll dry.”

“Not in here.”

“Then they won’t.” The door was three boards on leather straps. He lifted its latch and dropped it, twice, and studied the gap underneath. Nothing in the room would bar it. He searched for a stool, and there was no stool. He left it.

He sat on the bed’s edge. The cords dipped toward him, and when I sat beside him they slid me against his side, all my weight at once.

He let me lean. His forearms were on his knees and his hands loose past them, and his eyes were on the floor between his boots.

“It’s done,” he said. “They believed me.”

“Yes.”

The rain went on doing what it was doing. A mule underneath us kicked its stall, once, and settled.

Usually there was a next thing: the road in the morning, or the driver’s off-side mule, which had been going short on the near fore since the bridge. Nothing came.

“When it rained like this,” he said, “my mother ran out for the onions.”

I kept quiet.

“In her shift. She’d come back in with them round her neck, wet through, laughing at us.”

Who we were, he left out. The rain sheeted on the tiles now. The crack over the door spat water onto the floor, and he sat on in it.

Under the floor the door of the stalls banged back against its post. Mules came in out of the rain, three by the sound of their feet, and stood blowing and streaming beneath us, and a man swore at them. The landlady's voice met him at the yard door, high and furious.

"Noon, you said. Noon!"

"Bridge was under."

"The bridge is always under. And where's my hen been all afternoon, would you say?"

"On you."

"I brought eels."

"I've eels! And the gray, what have you done to the gray?"

"Let me get them dry first. You can shout after."

The hen joined in.

Valens was listening, his head up.

"The gray's lame," he said. "Off hind. He's walked it through the water."

Down there the man was laughing now, a tired laugh, and the landlady was giving him her opinion of the towpath, and the canal, and whoever had dug it, while the hen complained. Then she stopped, somewhere about the canal, and nobody down there said anything more.

"He'll want to poultice that."

"Will you see to it?"

"He'll do it. He's brought it this far."

I knelt behind him on the cords, which took some arranging, and took the hem of his tunic and pulled it up. He raised his arms for it. It came off and went on the floor.

His back was to the lamp, and the little flame put everything on it in relief. The marks ran slantwise from his left shoulder toward his right hip, more than a dozen, raised and pale and shining a little, harder than the skin round them. Two crossed

low on the right side, where the man with the whip had changed his footing. One crossed the shoulder blade and ran on down, and the old stitches had puckered its upper end. Between them the skin was brown, so that his back looked combed.

The judge had found for the plaintiff. Every mark was where it had always been.

I put my cheek to it, between the shoulder blades, where two of the ridges ran close together. It was warm. The wool smell of the tunic was still on it, and rain, and mule. I felt him breathe under my face. For a while that was all.

I lifted my cheek, got off the bed and took my own clothes off. I stood barefoot in the leak's spray and let him see.

"Look, then. All of it's yours, and most of it's swollen."

My belly stood out high and round, with the navel pushed out flat. A brown line had come in March, running down from it to the hair, and nothing would scrub it off. My breasts had grown heavy since the winter and the veins showed in them, blue under the skin. The nipples were wider and darker.

He looked, and his face gave me nothing to read.

"Not my breasts," I told him. "They're sore from the carriage."

"Will it hurt the child?"

"Grata says not, until the eighth month."

"Grata says what she thinks will rile me."

I pushed at his chest, and he went back onto the blanket. It must have scraped him, and he lay with all his marks against it and did not shift. He got his boots off without his hands, toe against heel, and they fell somewhere on the boards. The rest of his clothes I took from him.

Getting a knee across him needed two tries and his hand cupping my elbow. The bed creaked throughout.

"Your left knee," he said. "The cords are lower on this side."

When I was there, astride him, my knees taking my weight and the belly resting on his stomach, he lifted both hands to my hips to hold me steady, as he would steady a load on a bad slope.

I took his hands off my hips. I lowered them to the blanket, palms up, one each side of his head, and left them there.

"Let me," I said.

For a breath he only looked at me. The fingers stirred once on the felt and went loose.

I could not reach his mouth over the child. I tried, and the child objected, so I kissed what I could reach, the hard place over his heart and the stubble along his jaw when I stretched. The muscles of his belly jumped under my thighs every time.

He was hard against me. I reached beneath the child for him and put him to me, and sank onto him, the child's weight sinking with me. He shut his eyes. His breath left him and was a while returning.

"Mara."

"I know."

I began to move, slowly. The cords answered every movement. The rain drove across the tiles and the leak hissed on the boards. The lamp's flame leaned over in the draft from the gap under the door and straightened. I could smell the lamp oil and the horse in the blanket, warmed now by his back, and the mules below, and my own sweat and his. A flea crept up the inside of my calf, and I did not care about it at all.

He let me look at his face with nothing in front of it.

I took the nearer hand from beside his head and drew it beneath the child, between us. I set his thumb to me and pressed it there under mine until he had the way of it. He had it. I rocked on him and on his hand, with my other palm on his chest to keep my balance, and his eyes opened and held on my face. I came, a long, slow, shaking time, while his thumb waited on me.

Then he raised the hand still lying open.

It found the back of my thigh, then my hip, then the small of my back, and held on there. His head rose and I bent to it and got my arms round it. His face went in against my collarbone, under my chin. His breath was hot on the sore skin of my breast, and I allowed it. He was moving with me now, a little, up into me. He made no sound until the end, and then my collarbone had it before my ears did. His arms locked round my back, hard. I held his head and spoke his name into the top of it, Gaius Iulius Valens, the one in the court's wax, and then only Valens.

"Stay," he said. "A while."

He kept hold of me until my left calf knotted under me.

"Leg," I said. "Leg, leg."

He took my foot behind me and pushed the toes back, and it let go.

Getting off him was no more graceful than getting on. I took the outside of the bed, the door side, and dragged the blanket from beneath him and over us. The tick crackled and threw up a breath of old straw.

He rose on his elbow to see the door past me.

"I'll be up in the night," I said. "Twice, at least. This side's mine."

"The latch is wood."

"Then I'll hear it."

Somebody down in the stalls was talking low to the gray. He turned over, to face the wall, and the door was behind him, and so was I.

I fitted myself to his back. The belly fitted the hollow of it, my breasts to his shoulders, and my arm went over him with the hand open on his chest. I felt the marks against me all along my front, where the belly pressed him, ridge after ridge.

The child woke. It kicked him in the back, twice, so hard I felt it go through me into him.

His shoulders dropped, and the long muscles beside his spine let go in turn, down to the hip, and he lay back against me.

"It's awake," he said, into the wall.

"It's been awake since Forum Appii."

"Does it do that all night?"

"Most nights. It likes the carriage least."

"It's right."

By and by he slept.

The rain swept the roof in long, soft rushes now, with a hush between them, and down at the foot of the bed, under the blanket where it was warmest, the fleas that had lived in that wool longer than any horse climbed out of it singly to learn what had been brought them, and found his ankle first, and then mine, and set to work on us both, unhurried, with the whole wet night ahead of them and the rain coming down.

Chapter 24

Lucius

Pompeii · summer, AD 74

I hated the midwife.

The ninth hour

She arrived in the dead heat of the day, while the paving burned up through a sandal sole and every shutter in the street was drawn half to. A boy came behind her with the birthing stool roped onto his back, its legs to the sky. She was short and very broad, in a brown tunic gone black under the arms, and at Grata's counter she stopped and drank off a whole beaker at one go before she looked round for me.

The water had come at noon. I was mending at my plank in the shop with a lamp in bits and the glue warming, and it ran down my legs into the cobbler's leftover scraps on the floor. Grata had been watching me all month from behind her pots. She saw me get to my feet, and knew, and had me out of the shop and through her own back door before I had wiped my hands.

"Not in yours," she said. "That bed's a disgrace, and the fountain's the nearest water, and your roof lets in, I've heard it. You'll have it in mine. There's a well in my court and a door on my room and nobody's old leather underfoot. Walk about. You'll

want to sit, and you'll walk instead. I've sent for Statia. She's the best this side of Nuceria and she knows it, so don't tell her."

Her back room ran the depth of the house under a low ceiling, with a slit of window high in the court wall and a door beside it that stood open for the air. There was no air. Beyond the wall her brazier kept the stewpots going for the evening trade. Flies walked on the ceiling. Somebody had swept the beaten earth of the floor so often that it shone at the center like an old saddle.

"How long will it be?" I asked her.

"As long as it likes. You'll ask me that every hour and I'll tell you the same every hour, and somewhere near midnight you'll leave off asking and start telling me what you think of me, and that's when it's getting on. My first took a day. My second came while I was lacing a sandal, and that sandal's unlaced yet. You'd know if I lied, it's in your face, so I'll not." She gave my hip two brisk pats and was off to her pots.

Statia came in wiping her mouth on her wrist, and smiled at me, and that was how I met her teeth. The two at the front had grown crossways, the left laid over the right like a pair of shears half shut, and the one beside them was brown down to the gum. Where an eyetooth belonged there was a hole, and her breath found the hole whenever she said an *s*. In the Soranus I had read, midwives had long slim fingers and the nails cut close. Hers were short and square and pared to the quick, and I gave her that. He had nothing to say about teeth.

"Up," she said. "Show me how you go. To the wall. Back."

Grata's loom leaned in the farthest corner, a blanket half woven on it in red and brown stripes. It was a longer way off than it seemed, and the return was longer.

"Hm," said Statia.

She set her two palms on the belly and moved it about the way a woman at market tried a melon she meant to buy. Her

palms were hot and dry. She pressed low, left side, right side, and something in there pressed back at her.

"A girl," she told Grata. "Carried wide. Wide's a girl."

"You said a boy for her at the fullery."

"She carried two. Nobody's right about two." She turned on me. "First?"

"Yes."

"You're no girl yourself, for a first. It'll be slow. Slow's not bad. Slow's only slow." She went on feeling. "Who've you got coming? Your mother? Sisters?"

"Nobody's coming."

"Not a soul?"

"She's got me," said Grata. "She's got the street. Half of it's stood at my counter since noon asking, and the other half's the fullery, and she'll be round, mark me, she can't keep off a birth. There'll be women enough. It's room you'll be short of."

Statia grunted and took her hands away.

Her boy had stood the stool just within the door, and I looked at it because it was something to look at. It was a heavy chair of dark wood with arms and a back, and the seat was cut away at the front in a crescent, so that a woman perched on the rim with nothing underneath. The arms were rubbed pale where hands had held them. At some point in its life one arm had come adrift of the seat and been put back with a peg and glue, and the glue had set in a brown run down the leg like candle drip. I could have cleaned it off in an evening, with a knife and some warm water.

Statia unpacked her bag onto Grata's chest in a row, and put her little knife at the end of it in a fish-skin sheath. She set it out the way I laid out a bench.

The pain came then, a slow, deep clench that began low in my back and wrapped round to the front, and I held the post of Grata's bed until it went.

Statia was pleased. “There. That’s one.”

Grata shut her counter at the tenth hour. She had kept it open right through the Saturnalia. The front boards went up with a clatter. A carter complained outside, and Grata told him there was wine at the Nola Gate and he could go and be robbed there.

Valens had the mules bedded by the eleventh hour. He stood in Grata’s door and looked at me.

“It’s begun,” I said.

“Since when?”

“Noon.”

“Felix said.” He turned to Statia. “What’s she want?”

“Nothing off you,” said Statia.

“Water?”

“There’s a well, and I’ve got arms.”

“You’ll be no use to anybody,” Grata told him, “you’ll have that face on you from now till morning, I’ve watched it on three husbands and one of them mine. Sit on my well and stay out of my road.”

He did not go to the well. He crossed to me first and stood close, his arm against mine. Neither of us spoke, and in a while the next pain came, and I got both hands round his forearm and hung on it. It held like a beam. When the pain went he glanced at the marks my nails had left on him.

“Harder, if you want,” he said. “That arm’s carried lime since dawn.”

* * *

Lamp-lighting

Grata lit the lamp on the shelf herself, her best, with two spouts, and talked to the goddess while it caught.

“Lucina,” she said. “Juno Lucina. You know this house. You took three out of me in it and the youngest feet first, and I gave

you a cake for each of them, so you know I pay. This one's not mine, she's Greek, but she's under my roof and she's in my bed, so she's mine tonight. A quick one and a whole one, and there's honey on the cake. Quick and whole and a boy, if she wants a boy, and there's a lamp in it for you as good as this one. Better. I'll go to the forum for it."

"Girl," said Statia.

"Then the lamp's for whole."

She came and drew the pins from my hair. They were bone, and she pulled them singly and dropped them in the fold of her skirt and spread the hair down my back with her fingers. It was wet at the neck. She untied the cord of my tunic and drew it out of its loops and threw it on the bed. After that she hunted the room for knots. She found one in the cord of the shutter and one in the strap of Statia's bag, and she undid the strap while Statia watched her, expressionless.

"There's one in your own belt," Statia said.

Grata undid her belt.

From the bag Statia took a little bundle in a rag, and unwrapped from it a brown stone the size of a walnut, smoothed all over and bound in a net of linen thread. She tied it to my left thigh, up near the groin, under the tunic, winding the thread twice round. When I moved, it rattled. There was a smaller stone loose inside it.

Pliny had a page on these. The eagle carried them up to her nest, he said, and without one she could not lay, and a woman in labor wore one on the same principle. Now it knocked against my leg every time I turned.

The pains came closer. Between them I paced Grata's room from loom to door, and got to know both ends.

"How many have you lost?" I asked Statia, at one of them.

She was rinsing her hands in the basin and did not stop. "Children or mothers?"

"Mothers."

"Some." She flicked her fingers dry onto the floor. "None yet this year."

"Statia," said Grata.

"She asked. I don't tell lies to the ones that ask. Go on to your wall, Greek, and leave the reckoning to me."

The wall had not moved.

Valens carried a jug from the well to the door, and Statia took it off him on the sill and sent him back to the well. The water was cold. In all Pompeii that evening it was the only cold thing, and I drank it standing, and it dropped into me like a stone into a cistern.

At the court door Grata's husband stood, lamp up. I had laid eyes on him perhaps a dozen times in all, and always on his way from one bench to another with a cup; he was a soft, sunburned man with a voice that carried better than he did. He was talking past me to Valens, who had settled on the curb of the well after all. Dice clicked in his fist as he went on.

"Down at Puteoli," he said. "On the fish quay, behind the tunny sheds. A Chaldean. Does the grain ships' stars before they sail. My brother's had him do his. Old as Saturn and mad with it, mutters gibberish to himself over it, not Greek, not Syrian, nothing you ever heard, and then he tells you your day in Greek like a schoolmaster. Cheap, though."

"What would I want with stars?" Valens asked.

"For the boy. You mark the hour he comes, and you take it down to the Chaldean, and he casts it. Everybody does."

"A girl," Statia called over.

"For the girl, then."

"It's not come yet," said Valens.

"Well, when it comes. Mark it, is all I'm saying. You'll want his stars read."

The pain took me then, round the back and through, and I braced on the jamb and leaned my weight into it. When it had gone the husband had gone too, and Grata was saying something about men who stood in doors with their mouths open.

"Mind my counter," she shouted after him. "You've leaned on it every night there is, you could find it blind."

* * *

Bedtime

The street put itself to bed. Shutters, a child grizzling and stopping, a cart at the corner with a load of something that clanked; after that, crickets.

The twins' mother came round from the fullery at the end of it, as Grata had promised, with one twin asleep on her collarbone and a sprig of something gray in her spare hand. She would not come in. She held the sprig out to Grata across the sill.

"Dittany," she said. "Cretan. It's the real one, I got it from a sailor's wife, you burn it under her. I burned it under me and look." She hitched the twin. "Two. Took no time."

"You took from one dawn to the next," said Grata. "I held your leg for it."

"It felt like no time."

"It felt like dawn to dawn to my leg." Grata took the dittany. "Go home, you'll wake that one, and if you wake that one you'll wake both, and then the whole street's up and him too, and he'll beat you for it and you'll beat him back on the next feast and nobody gets any sleep from now till the Vinalia."

The woman looked past her at me, propped on my feet by the loom.

"She's carrying wide," she said, delighted. "That's a girl."

Grata sent her home. She put the dittany on the coals of her brazier in the shop, and a sweetish smoke came round into the room and hung under the ceiling.

Statia ate the lentils. Grata's lentil pot sat inside the doorway, out of the way, and Statia lowered herself to the floor next to it and dipped in with three fingers, and talked with her mouth full.

"There's one near the water tower," she said, "calls herself a midwife. Lays them flat. On their backs, like a beetle. Then she wonders why it takes two days." She wiped her fingers on her tunic. "Lays them flat and goes home to her dinner. And her wool's off a black sheep, I know it for a fact. Black wool, at a birth." She dipped again. "Walk."

Passing the stool, I touched the run of glue down its leg. The run was hard and glassy, with a hair caught in it.

"Leave that be," said Statia.

"Somebody glued it too hot."

"My mother glued it. She had it off her mother, and that arm came off under a tanner's wife twice your size. It's held since before Nero. You can mend it when you've had as many on it as I have."

My legs had begun to shake at the knee between the pains, a small fine shaking that took no notice of me. The floor shone where I paced it.

In the court a man's feet crossed the paving, stopped at the well, returned. They halted at the door. They went off. Presently they were there again. The gate to the lane opened and shut, and much later it creaked, and the feet recrossed the court and stopped outside.

"Men out," said Statia. She rose and opened the door. "You. Off my door. Go and do something with your hands."

"I'm doing nothing at your door."

"You're doing it very loud." She shut it on him.

Through the planks he tried again. “Call me if there’s anything to carry.”

“Nothing wants carrying till it’s here,” Statia told the door. “After, you can carry it, and welcome, and see how you like it.”

There was no air now at all. The lamp’s two flames stood up straight on the shelf, and the flies had settled for the night on the ceiling. Grata wet a cloth from the jar and laid it across my nape, and it was warm before it settled. In my freezer at home there was a bag of peas I kept for the back of the neck in August; I had bought it for that purpose only, and never cooked a pea of it in four summers. The cloth slid down my back, and Grata caught it and wet it again.

The pain came, and returned, and my hands were on the wall, and this time I made a noise. It was low and long and I had no say in it.

“Good,” said Statia, at my shoulder. “That’s the right noise. Make that one.”

* * *

Midnight

In the court a dry rough scraping kept on, and stopped, and began again.

Between two pains I asked for the door, and Statia let me have it. She held my elbow while I stood in it. The air out there was cooler by a little, and smelled of the well and of split pine from Grata’s woodstack. Over the court the sky was thick with stars, and beyond the roofs a dog was barking at nothing, steadily, the way it had barked every night that summer.

A lamp sat on the well curb. Felix was next to it, hunched on the paving, nursing a second lamp in his lap. In the light stood the dun, tied short to the iron ring in Grata’s wall. Her eyes were heavy and her lower lip hung loose. She was asleep on her feet.

Valens had her near fore up, tucked between his thighs, the sole of the hoof turned to the light. He had the curved knife. He took a thin paring from the edge of the wall, and it peeled off pale and curled, and dropped. Curls of horn lay everywhere round his feet, a drift of them, like the floor under a lathe. He laid the knife on the curb and drew the rasp across the hoof's rim, once and again, and ran his thumb round to feel what he had done. With the point of the knife he cleaned the cleft of the frog, gently, though it was clean, and blew into it softly, though there was no dust.

"He's done her four times," Felix whispered to me. "Every foot, four times round. Her feet were done at the Kalends. There's nothing left on her to take off. I told him."

"There's a flare on this one," said Valens, without lifting his head.

"There's no flare. He's taking off what isn't there." Felix shifted the lamp. "Worse than a cut, or not so bad? We didn't hear you, did you shout? Will you have it by cockcrow?"

I answered none of it.

Valens lowered the hoof to the stones and ran his hand down the back of the dun's leg from knee to heel. She woke, and blew, and set her weight down on it. He spoke to her too low for me, and then he moved round to the off fore and took that foot up, and she lifted it for him unasked and dozed off again.

The pain caught me there in the doorway. I gripped the doorpost and bent over it, and in the lamplight Valens dropped the hoof and came two steps toward me before Statia said, "Back to your mule," and he stopped where he was. He waited out the pain with me from there. Afterward he returned to the dun and found the foot again.

"How far?" he asked over the hoof.

"Statia says halfway. She said halfway at lamp-lighting."

"Then she's wrong one time or the other." The rasp went across. "She say anything else?"

"She says it's a girl."

"It isn't anything yet."

Felix yawned so wide his jaw clicked, and rested his head against the well. The lamp in his hands tipped and righted.

"Straight."

"It is straight. It's the ground's crooked." The flame steadied. "When can I see it?"

"When it's here."

"That midwife's eaten a whole pot of Grata's lentils, I watched her do it through the window. Does she eat at every birth? Do they have to give her supper? Two years I've slept within smell of Grata's lentils and never had a spoon, and I've asked."

"Ask her again."

"I'm asking you."

The next pain started in my feet and climbed. Statia's grip was on my arm, and the door was shutting, and the last thing out there was the rasp going again, slow, and the lamp jumping in Felix's fists as he jerked awake.

* * *

Past midnight

The stool.

Grata behind me, perched on the bed, her knees bracketing my back. Her arms under mine and her hands locked over my breastbone.

"Lucina. Lucina, you heard me."

Statia low in front of me. Her hands.

"Not yet. Noli. Not yet."

"I can't."

"You can. You are. Short breaths on it, like a dog in the sun. So."

"I want to stop."

"You'll stop when it's out."

Oil. Her hand, slick, and her voice going on in Oscan underneath it.

Somebody wiped my mouth.

Water poured into a basin from high up.

The rasp in the court. It stopped.

Statia's face rose into the lamplight. Her mouth was open. The left tooth lying over its neighbor. I fixed on it. The pain was everywhere and had no edges to it, and the tooth had edges. I held on to the tooth. I hated it. I hated it with the whole of me, and I held on.

"Now. With it. With it."

"Iam. Iam."

"Again."

The rasp, outside. Going. Going.

Wool over my face, wet, brown. A sleeve. Mrs. Dunphy wore brown, a brown cardigan gone thin at the elbows, and she was at the board with the chalk in her fingers, crying, the long division half written. Brown. The sleeve went.

Statia said something that was not Latin.

"Wait for it. Wait."

A cart rumbled past, streets off. Outside Felix was asking something, and Valens gave him a single word, and the asking stopped.

"He's coming, she says he's coming. Lucina, you old cow, you took my cake, you keep your word."

"Hush, you'll put her off."

"I'll put the goddess off, and welcome."

Grata's breath at my ear, in, out.

"Lucina. Two cakes. Two, and the lamp."

A sound left me that was nobody's I knew.

"There. There it is. I've the head. I've the head. Stop now. Stop, stop. Little breaths."

The rasp, outside, had stopped.

* * *

Cockcrow

A cock went off somewhere toward the forum. A second took it up from nearer, from some yard on our street, and a third farther down, and then they were all at it the length of the town, while the lamp burned low on the shelf.

Statia said, "Now," and I pushed with everything there was, and burned where he was coming, and then gave. He arrived in one rush, long and slippery and heavy, into her hands, and he was crying before she had him turned. It was a thin, cross, cracked sound, very close, and it filled the room to the ceiling and woke the flies.

Statia lifted her face to me over him and grinned. That came first, before him: her teeth in the lamplight, the crossed pair and the brown one, and below them in her two square hands a creature gray-blue and furious, streaked white and red, with his fists up by his ears and his mouth wide.

"Mas," she said. "Carried wide, the little liar."

Behind me Grata held me so tight there was no breath to be had. "A boy. Lucina, a boy. A cake and honey and a lamp, I'll have to find a lamp now. A boy."

Statia laid him on my belly while she tied the cord. She tied it with red wool twice over and cut beyond the tie with a little knife. He lay on me wet and hot and heavier than anything that size had any right to be, and kept on telling us all about it. I found

his back with my hand. It rose and fell under my fingers, and his spine was all there, a row of small hard beads.

Statia took him up again, and spread a cloth on the floor at the stool's feet, and laid him down on it on his back.

"My man wears that to the Floralia," said Grata.

"It's a cloth now. Fetch the father."

Grata went to the door and opened it. Valens was right there. Behind him on the paving the rasp lay by the mule's hooves, and Felix curled asleep beside the well with his mouth agape.

He took one step in and stopped.

"Lift him," Statia said.

His gaze went from the child on the floor to me on the stool, and held.

"He's yours. Lift him up."

He crouched by the cloth. His hands went out and hung above the child, not touching. They were big and scored with old cuts. The child cried up at them.

"He'll not break," said Statia. "Here. Give me that one." She caught one of the hands by the wrist as if it were a tool she was lending him, and fitted it under the child's head, and spread the fingers. "That's the neck, that's the head. That holds him. Now this one." She pushed the other in under the small of the back, farther, until the child's bottom sat in his palm. "There. Up."

He rose with him too fast, in a single heave, and froze. He held the child away from himself on straight arms, high, level with his own face, with his elbows locked and his shoulders up round his ears, and he was not breathing. It was how a man held a jar he had caught just short of the stones, in the instant before he knew whether it was whole.

The child stopped crying. His eyes came open, or nearly, and looked at nothing.

"In," said Statia. "In to you. Bring him in."

Valens drew the child down and in against himself till he lay in the bend of one arm, the other palm spread over him.

"Whole?" he asked me.

"Whole," said Statia. "Look for yourself."

"Whole," I said.

"Now give him here. There's work yet. Sit, before you drop him."

He sank where he stood, onto the ground beside the stool with his back to Grata's wall, and did not give him back. The child lay on his forearm with its head in his palm. He studied the face, and then the hands, which had worked free of the cloth and were opening and shutting on the air, and then the face again.

"He's cold."

"He's wet," said Statia. "Give him here and he'll be neither."

In the end she had to unfasten the child from him, finger by finger.

The shaking was back in my legs, and the stool rocked under me. Grata climbed down to the front of me and pinned my knees with her palms till it passed.

Outside the cocks were still at it.

* * *

After the cocks

The afterbirth came, and Statia held it to the lamp the way Grata judged fish, and was satisfied.

She washed him in warm water from the basin, quickly, holding him along her forearm with his head cupped in her palm, and he hated it and said so. She rubbed fine salt from a dish into every fold of him, to close his skin, and then oil, and then she bound him. She wound him in long bands of soft wool with his arms down by his sides and his legs straight, turn on turn, until

he was a tight white parcel, red and furious at the top end, and she laid him beside me on Grata's bed, inside my arm.

I lay and watched him. He gazed back with gray eyes that had no use for anything yet.

I was tired and it was hot and I wanted water and nobody had brought any, so I waited.

He turned his face against me and gaped on my arm, and found nothing there, and complained. I pulled the neck of the tunic down.

"Not that," said Statia from the floor. "Not yet. That first milk's thick, it's no good to him, it's cheese, it'll sit in him and curdle. Honey on a finger for now. Grata knows a girl two streets over with milk to spare, she'll have him three days, and after that you."

"No."

"You'd kill him on his first day, would you?"

"Give me the honey if you like. He's having this."

"Greeks," said Statia, to Grata.

"Let her," Grata said. "She's mended every pot on this street with stuff she makes up as she goes, and none of them's come apart on me yet. Let her."

He didn't know the way of it, and I knew little more. He missed, and roared, and missed again, and then of a sudden he had it, and pulled, hard, with a strength out of all proportion, and his eyes closed. Statia watched, mouth pursed, and let the cheese go.

Valens appeared from the court with a cup. Nobody had sent him. It was from the well, cold, and he did not hand it to me, because both my arms were full; he brought the rim to my lips and tipped it for me, slowly, a sip and then another, and took it away when I had had enough, and stood holding the empty cup.

A drop of it had fallen on the child's cheek. The child screwed up his face at it and kept his hold.

Grata brought a basin and washed my legs from the knee down, in water that had been warm an hour ago, and talked throughout.

"You did it quiet, for a Greek, I'll say that for you. Her from the fullery had the street out of bed with her two, and the aedile's men round to see who was killed, and you only the once, at the end, and that one was worth hearing, they'll have had that at the amphitheater. Now I've a lamp to find. The good ones are all at that thief behind the forum who wants a day's takings for a decent lamp, and he'll have them off me, I promised, she heard me." She wrung out the cloth. Her eyes were wet, and she was cross about it, and blamed the dittany.

Grata crossed her shop, took down one shutter board and stuck her head out, though there was not a soul to hear. "A boy," she said. "And the mother whole, and him big as a calf, and the baker can have that with his bread." She put the board up again.

Her husband followed her in from the shop with his lamp burned out and his tunic on inside out. He blinked at the bed, and then at Valens, who was on the sill again, empty-handed.

"Did you get the hour?"

"The cocks," said Valens.

"Which cock?"

"All of them."

The husband appeared to think that would do. He went to find his bed.

"And you," Grata told Valens, "can put that face away, you're stood there like somebody led you home a horse you never bid on and you can't find the halter. Go and sleep an hour on my bench. You'll sleep nowhere, I know it, but it's said."

Felix turned up at the door.

"Can I see him? Did he come at the cocks? Has he got a voice on him? I heard a voice."

"He's got a voice," Grata said. "Wash your face first, there's a stable on it."

He came anyway, as far as the bedpost, and looked at the parcel at my breast, and Grata had to call him twice before he heard her.

* * *

First light

Gray showed in the window slit, and the lamp looked yellow and foolish against it, and Grata pinched it out.

Statia went. She took her boy and her stool and the stone off my leg. On the sill she stopped to tie her bag strap again, a good hard knot, and then spoke to me.

"Round about midnight," she said, "you had a look on you like you'd have my eyes out with your thumbs."

"Only at midnight?"

"Don't flatter yourself. They all get it, about then. It's how I know it's going right." She hoisted the bag. "When they're fond of me at midnight, I start to worry."

Her boy went first with the stool, and she behind him, and I heard her in the shop telling Grata it had been wide regardless, and a boy was no excuse.

Valens had settled beside the bed, his back propped on the wall. The child was in his arm now.

Lying there, I had the top of the child's head in view in the early gray, the dark hair on it still stuck flat in whorls from the washing. Toward the brow there was a spot where the bones had not yet come together. They had been made in pieces and left open at the joins, so that they could ride over one another on the way out and spring back after, and the skin over the gap was so

thin that it lifted and settled with his heart, if I kept still and watched. Nobody had to mend it.

"You'll not name him till the ninth day, like decent people," Grata told us both from the door, "and I'll hear it then along with the street and look surprised."

She went out. Her steps crossed the shop, and the shutter boards started coming off, one, and then another.

"The dun's feet," I said, once she had gone.

"Done."

"Felix says four times."

"Felix sleeps." He watched the child for a while. "She'll walk tender on the paving a day or two. It'll do her no harm."

"Were you afraid?"

He moved his thumb on the bands, where the child's chest was. "She stood on three legs from lamp-lighting on. She'll be stiff."

He spoke once more, low, to the child. "Lucius."

"Lucius," I said, and the child slept through us both.

* * *

Morning

I was mostly asleep. The street was at its work beyond the wall, and out front Grata was telling a carter he could have the news with his wine for the one copper, and none of it on credit. The light was full in the window slit. Down the lane the string clattered past for the gate with Felix shouting at it, and one mule's hooves went short and careful on the stones. Somebody had my right wrist.

It was Valens, on the bed beside me. The child slept against my left side. Valens had my hand palm down on his knee. He was working the watch's little crown a click at a time, and I felt each

click in the small bones of my wrist. When it would turn no farther he tucked my hand under the sheet.

Chapter 25

Augurinus

Puteoli · early spring, AD 75

It was the first fair week after the sea opened, and the fish quay at Puteoli smelled of brine, pine tar and the wet straw the tunny came packed in. The sheds stood one beside the next behind the quay with their doors propped open, and inside them men were cutting fish as long as themselves on stone slabs. The blood ran off down channels in the floors and under the sills into the gutter, and the gulls stood in it to their ankles and fought over what came out.

We had brought eleven mule-loads up the shore road from Pompeii, roof tile for a builder on the slope above the harbor, and he had paid in silver, which was rare enough that Valens hefted the purse under the man's eye before he thanked him. That was the morning. The afternoon's errand was Grata's. While in Puteoli we were to take the boy's hour to the Chaldean behind the fish sheds, because her husband had recommended it in the summer and nobody had done it, and a child without his stars cast was a child let out of doors in the dark. I had told her I would. Her husband's few words about a language no one had heard before had gone about with me since the summer, at odd hours, and I had not let them get as far as a name.

A boy with a basket of sprats on his head showed us the place for a copper. Behind the third shed a wooden stair climbed the outside of a warehouse wall to a door just below the roof, and its treads were gray and salt-furred.

Valens spent a while eyeing the stair. He had Lucius on his forearm, facing out, with both fists full of his father's tunic and his feet going against his father's belt, and at eight months Lucius was busy with the gulls.

"The third tread's split."

"I will step over it. You hold the boy, and if the Chaldean is mad I will be down again quickly."

"I'll follow you up."

"It is one small room, Grata says, and he talks about hours, and the boy will try to eat the charts."

He set his boot on the bottom tread and gave it his weight, then the next, and got off it again and stood aside. "Not two on that. I'll be at the bottom."

Lucius made a grab for my hair as I passed and got a fistful of air, which he studied.

The split tread was the third, as promised, and I lengthened my stride past it. At the top the door was wide, and a sea captain emerged as I reached the landing, a broad bald man with a tablet tied shut and clamped to his ribs and his lips going over something he had been told; he went down past me sideways, the way men went down ladders at sea, eyes fixed on the harbor to the last tread.

The room up there ran the length of the warehouse, low enough that I might have touched the beams without stretching. One big window gave on the harbor. Its shutter had been lifted off its pins and propped beside the frame, so that all the bright afternoon came in, with the gulls in it and the smell of the sheds.

The walls had the sky on them. Somebody had whitewashed the plaster and drawn over it in charcoal, circles inside circles and long arcs with small Greek letters strung along them like beads on a wire, and some of the lines had been gone over in red. Others had been rubbed out with a thumb and drawn again slightly askew of the old line, until each wall was gray with old skies under the new one.

Wax tablets were stacked by the dozen against every wall, their wax gone nearly black with lamp smoke and thumbing. Beneath the window stood a table, and on the table a tray of fine pale sand an inch deep, raked smooth, with a figure drawn in it and a bronze rod lying across one corner. A roll of papyrus was weighted open beside the tray with a stone at each end. On the sill, in a chipped pot, a basil had grown leggy reaching for the light, and next to the pot lay a little brass oblong with the sun on it.

It was a cigarette lighter.

The man at the table sat half turned from me, bent over his work. He was thin as a heron, in a long-sleeved robe of faded blue that anyone who had not traveled east of Misenum would have agreed was Chaldean, with a gray felt cap on the back of his head, and he was drawing in the sand with a forefinger, fast, the nail black with ink. The left hand lay beside the tray and trembled on its own, steadily, with no part in what the right hand was doing.

Grata's instructions were to put the fee down first, because a Chaldean would not lift his eyes for less, so I laid two coppers on the corner of his table.

"A moment, lady." His eyes never lifted. It was beautiful Greek, a schoolmaster's, with each ending where it belonged. "I have a ship's hour unfinished, and the ship sails at dawn whether I have finished it or not."

He drew a line in the sand and swept it out again with the edge of his hand. He patted the front of his robe, then searched one sleeve and the other, and went over himself everywhere, a man hunting his keys on a doorstep in the rain, and muttered.

"Where the hell'd you get to?"

The words went into me before their sense did, and I answered them.

"It's on the sill, by the basil," I said.

"Thanks," he said, and stretched over to the sill, and his fingers found the lighter and shut on it, and he stopped like that, with his arm out and the brass in his fist.

He swung round on his stool to face me. He had a long face with all its flesh gone to the bone, a white stubble, and eyes of a washed-out blue under brows that had stayed black when nothing else had. His mouth came open.

"Jesus H. Christ," he said.

He said it like the men on my father's block, on Sunday afternoons in the fall, when the Eagles fumbled on somebody's radio, with the vowels in his nose and the last word bitten off short. He said it dressed as a Chaldean, with the harbor of Puteoli at his back.

The client's stool caught me, which was luck, because my legs had gone. A laugh came first, with the other thing right behind it, so close that they were one breath leaving and another fighting to get in past it, and neither would give the other room. I laughed because he had said thanks. That was the part I kept tripping on: in five years the first English anybody had spoken to me was thanks, for finding his lighter. The crying had its own reasons and kept them to itself. The tears ran straight off my chin. My hands saw the drops falling toward his sand and toward the papyrus with its rings of stars. They lifted the papyrus off the table by its two edges, stones and all, and raised it high and clear of me, level,

as far out as my arms would go, while the rest of me laughed and wept and had no air for either.

He was round the table faster than a man his age had any business moving, and struck me on the back, high up, a rapid patter of light blows, the treatment for a fishbone.

"Hey, hey, easy," he said. "Breathe, would you? Come on, kid, in and out, you're turning colors on me."

One of the stones slid off the papyrus and dropped on my foot, and I said "Ow," and that was English too, and set me off again.

The stair shook under somebody heavy taking it by twos, and the third tread cracked right through as it took him. Valens came onto the landing and into the doorway with Lucius clamped to him, took in the room in one look, and found me.

"You're all right," the Chaldean was saying. "You're not choking. Tell me you're not choking."

"I'm not choking. I'm not, really."

"Then quit it, will you, you're scaring your friend half to death."

"He's my husband."

"Your what?"

On the sill Valens had halted, a hand to the jamb, as he halted in any doorway to learn a room before entering it, but the room had stopped mattering to him. He watched our mouths. Words were going between us fast and flat, words with nothing in them that was Latin or Greek or anything spoken on any quay he had ever worked, and it cost us no effort; we were barely listening to ourselves. The color came up out of his collar. It climbed his neck and darkened his face from the chin to the hair, slowly, the whole of it, and his hand left the jamb. He pressed his mouth to the top of Lucius's head and did not lift it. Lucius objected, and nobody attended to him.

"Husband," said the Chaldean, and looked to the doorway at last, and he stopped hitting my back. "Holy smoke. Tell him I'm harmless. Tell him I've got a bad hand and I never hurt anybody in my life."

Telling anybody anything was beyond me. He saw that, and bowed from the waist, a real bow, with one hand pressed to the breast of his robe, and spoke in Greek.

"Sir, forgive me my manners; I am old. Your wife has had a shock, and the fault is mine. Come in, I beg you, and sit down, and do my poor house an honor; the stair is sound."

"It isn't. I broke it coming up."

"So you did, and I thank you for it, it was a terrible stair." He was in the other language again halfway through turning round. "Okay. Let's start over, like civilized people. Where'd you come through?"

I laid the papyrus flat again, square with the table's edge, and weighted one end with the stone that was left and the other with my hand. "The Corycian. Above Delphi."

"The Corycian, where else. When did you go in?"

"In May. May of ninety-eight. Our ninety-eight."

He repeated it slowly, testing it like a board he had been told would hold. "Ninety-eight." He glanced at the harbor and back. "Thirty years. You left thirty years after I did, and you walk in my door, and that's. What's your name? I'm sorry. What's your name?"

"Mara. Mara Reyes."

"August Fenn." He offered his good hand, and I took it; it was dry and very light, and it gripped hard. "Augie, back home. Augurinus, here, which is a joke nobody in this country gets but me."

"Augie," I said. "Augur. Augurinus."

He stared, and then he put his head back and laughed up at the beams, a high cracked laugh that went on longer than the joke could carry.

"Since Claudius I've been waiting on somebody to get that," he said, once he had breath. "I told it to a priest of Serapis once, in Greek, very slow, and he wrote me down as a madman and charged me a drachma for the privilege."

"I know who you are," I said.

"You know." He let my hand go. "How'd you know me? No. Hold that. Hold it, I want it later, I want to take my time over it. Where'd you grow up?"

"Philadelphia. West Philly. Out Baltimore Avenue, past Forty-eighth, where my father lived."

"Get out of here. Baltimore Avenue." He said it softly, tasting it. "The 34 runs out Baltimore Avenue, clear out to the cemetery and past it."

"It still does. It's still a trolley."

"Well, whaddaya know." He perched on the edge of his own table, which put the sand tray at his hip and the skirt of his robe in the sand, and he did not notice. "Don't tell me a thing. I mean it. I won't have it secondhand, I want to walk out of that door and find it all out for myself. Who's president, I couldn't care less. The moon, forget the moon. Did they get to the moon?"

I began to answer.

"Don't you dare," he said. "I'm going to watch it on the TV like everybody else. One thing, I'll let you tell me one thing, and then not another word. The Phillies."

"They won the World Series in 1980."

His mouth worked on nothing for a second.

"Against Kansas City. I was fifteen. Tug McGraw struck out the last man and jumped about four feet in the air, and my father

took me down Broad Street for the parade, and we couldn't see anything but the backs of people's coats."

"Tug who?"

"McGraw. A relief pitcher. He slapped his glove on his leg after the big outs."

"Never heard of him. Nineteen eighty. You know what they did in sixty-four? Six and a half games up with twelve to play. Twelve. You could've parked a Buick in that lead. And Mauch starts Bunning and Short on two days' rest down the stretch, like they're made out of iron, and then Chico Ruiz steals home on them, steals home, with Frank Robinson at the plate, who does that, nobody does that, and that's the ballgame, and they drop ten in a row, and I'm sitting in a bar on Girard Avenue watching grown men cry into their beer, and I'm one of them." He stopped. "The World Series. You're on the level?"

"I swear it. They had a parade."

"Well." His face did something complicated and then smoothed out. "Your old man took you to the games, then? He was a fan?"

"Sometimes, the summers he wasn't away digging. He was away a lot."

"Digging what?"

"Old things. He was an archaeologist. Cyprus, and then Sicily."

"An archaeologist, for crying out loud. He'd have had a ball here. Is he still..." He saw something in my face, I suppose, though my face had not held his interest much. "Ah. Hell."

"The house is still there. I was clearing it out."

"Hell," he said, lower. Then he slapped the wood at his hip, so that the sand jumped in its tray. "Okay. I'll go see them once I'm back, the Phillies. They'll be lousy by that time, nobody stays good that long, but I'll go see them anyhow. And you found

Pompeii's. You must have, you're here, and nobody comes to Campania for the fish."

"How do you even know about—"

"The freedman's place, with the door done on its front in paint. Eros's." He was beaming at me. "That's mine. I've had my eye on that door since sixty-two. This is swell. Nothing this good's happened to me since Nero was a pup. Late summer, seventy-nine."

Down on the quay a man was crying sprats. The gulls went over.

"What?" I said.

"Seventy-nine. You heard me. We'll walk in together, you and me. I had it figured I'd be going alone." He laughed, one short bark. "Never did care for that part."

My hand was still on the end of the papyrus. I lifted it. I had pressed the roll flat so hard that the base of my palm had left a print in the ink of one of his circles, a little smudged moon where there had been no moon before, and I looked at that.

"What happened to you?" I said.

He let that one in; I saw him decide to. He shifted his seat on the table and found a rung of the stool for his feet, and turned the lighter over in his fingers.

"July twenty-second, sixty-eight," he said. "I hiked up there first thing, in the cool, with a new flashlight and a spool of kite twine, because I figured if I went in deep I'd want a way out, which shows you what I knew. I tied the end of the string to a rock at the mouth of the slot. You know the slot?"

"I crawled it on my knees."

"Course you did. I went in on my belly, and it was cold, cold all along, and then the floor tipped on me like a boat. I don't mean I slipped. The floor tipped. Next thing, I'm on all fours in snow." He showed me with the other hand, the palm going over.

"Snow, in July. There was snow to here, and stars, and no string, and I plunked down in it and thought, Augie, you hit your head in there and you'll freeze to death on a Greek mountain, and somebody's going to find you in the spring and put it in the Inquirer, local man, and I stretched out to wait for it, and it didn't happen, so I got moving."

"What year was it?"

"Forty-one. It took me till the thaw to find that out. You know who was emperor?"

"Claudius."

"Claudius, brand new. They'd stuck a knife in his nephew that winter, and the guards found Claudius behind a curtain in the palace with his feet showing and made him emperor because they couldn't think what else to do with him. I'd read the Graves book on the plane over to Athens. And I'm standing in the market in Amphissa in somebody's dead uncle's sheepskin, and a guy selling leeks tells me who's emperor, and I say 'Claudius?' out loud, like a sap, and he asks me have I got a problem with it." He knuckled one eye. "I didn't have a problem with it. I didn't have a word of Greek either. The Greek I had came from a book Father Kostas lent me, all ships and dead kings, and you try buying bread with it."

"I tried. They laughed at me in the market at Delphi for a month."

He was off again, talking across me. "That's right, you can't. And the stars. The Navy taught me the sky. Celestial navigation, nineteen fifty-two, on a tin can off Korea, and a Chaldean's mostly a guy who knows the sky and where it'll be a week from Tuesday. The rest is keeping a straight face." He showed me the straight face, and it was very good. "So I got the Greek, and I put the stars into Greek for the merchants, and I came over here to Italy, because Italy's where the money is and Italy's where the

ground moves. I teach the rich men's boys their triangles in the mornings, in a house on the hill, and they throw olive pits at my neck when I turn round to the board. You feel it down your way? The ground? Little ones, every week. You feel them?"

"I feel them."

"I knew you would." He pointed past me at the wall, where a long red curve wandered across the charcoal, rubbed and redrawn. "That's them, every one I ever felt and every one I ever heard tell of between this quay and Neapolis, and they come in runs, like surf, a couple of big ones and then quiet for months and then a lot of little ones close together that don't mean much, and you get to know it the way you get to know a pitcher. Listen, are you thirsty? You want some wooder?"

He said it the Philadelphia way, with a d in the middle of it and the vowel pulled out long. Pat, my father's neighbor, had said it that way, hosing down her steps every evening all summer, even the evenings it rained.

"Please."

He fetched three cups on a board from a jar in the corner, and wine in them, not water; the difference had escaped him. He carried one cup to the doorway and offered it to Valens with another little bow, and Valens freed a hand from the child and took it, and gave his thanks in Greek, and tried it. His face met the wine, and I saw it.

"It's terrible," Fenn told me. "It's the worst jar on this quay, and I paid real money for it, so I'm drinking it down to the lees. You finish what you pay for. Otherwise why'd you pay?"

I drank mine, and it was terrible, and I drank it. It had been resinated against going sour and had gone sour regardless, and someone had added honey after that, as an apology. Valens had set his cup on the floor beside his boot, with great care, at some distance from himself, and forgotten it.

Fenn reached across me and took one of my two coppers off the table's corner. "Put your money away, I'm not taking it," he said, but he went on looking at it. Vespasian's thick neck was on it, and the emperor's bad-tempered mouth, worn smooth on the high places. "What I'd give for a nickel. Horn and Hardart, Chestnut Street. You duck in, wet through, and there's a whole wall of little glass doors, chrome and glass, a piece of pie behind every door, and you put your nickel in the slot and the little door lets go, click, and you open it up and take your pie out. Coconut cream. The top was always a little damp, like it had been crying. Anyhow."

"They're gone," I said. "New York kept one going longest, and that's closed too."

"Don't say that. Don't."

"I'm sorry."

"I'll go and look." He flicked the copper back to me, and I trapped it against my breastbone. "Where was I? Right. The shakes. This town breathes, did anybody tell you that? Puteoli. It rises and sinks like a fat man asleep. There's iron rings in the old quay wall near the fish steps, mooring rings, and when I first came over from Misenum you had to get down on your belly on the stones to tie up to them, and now they're half in the wet, and the harbor people swear the sea's come up, and the sea hasn't gone anyplace, it's the town. It's the dirt the town sits on. I scratch a mark by those rings every Kalends with a nail, and the marks walk. Slow, slower than a clock hand, but they walk, and when they walk faster the shakes come, and there's eleven years of marks on that wall that nobody's noticed but me and a guy who sells octopus and thinks I'm counting his customers." Valens had shifted Lucius higher and half turned toward the stair, and Fenn's eyes flicked to the movement and back, and he hurried. "And the hot ground on the hill, where the yellow smoke comes

out, you ever go and look? The springs go hot and cold. There's a bathhouse keeper up there who tells me when his pool goes cloudy, I pay him in horoscopes, his wife believes every word, and it goes cloudy before the shakes, every time, give or take. That's the part that kills you."

Lucius had begun to complain in earnest, with his face pushed into the side of his father's neck, rooting there for something his father did not have. Valens found my eyes over the small dark head.

"He's hungry," he said.

"Give him to me."

He carried him down the room into my arms, and I loosened my tunic at the throat and gave Lucius what he was after, and he took it with a grunt of grievance at having been kept waiting. Fenn looked at the ceiling. Then, with a great scraping, he turned his stool round until he sat with his shoulder blades to the room and his nose to the red curve, and went on at the wall, louder than before.

"You can turn around. Nobody minds that here."

"I'm comfortable," he said, and stayed as he was.

The shadows on the floor had moved when a boy bawled at the window from the quay below; the broken tread had turned him back, and his master was asking after the ship's hour.

"Dawn is propitious," Fenn called to the window behind him, in Greek. "Tell your master the moon favors him, and he may pay me when he is back."

The boy's feet went off along the quay, and Fenn was in the bathhouse keeper's pool again, in English, before they were gone.

In a corner a sleeping mat had been rolled tight and tied with a cord, as a sailor rolls his bedding. Two robes hung on a peg, and a lamp stood on the floor beside the mat with no stand to put it on. Next to the doorway, where I had passed it without seeing it,

stood a bag of oiled leather with its straps buckled and a stick pushed through the handles for carrying, packed full. There was dust on top of it, an even gray fur. My hand had gone to the flap of the satchel at my hip.

"Did you ever get married?" I asked. "Here, I mean. Was there anybody?"

"Me?" Round he came on the stool, honestly surprised. "What would I do that for? I'm not staying. You don't go buying furniture in a hotel." He waved a hand at his room, and rested his case. "There was a widow in Neapolis who did my laundry and thought I ought to, for a while, and she was a nice woman, she made a fish stew you'd have walked to Neapolis for. But you can't do that to a person. Marry them and then go home on them. That's a lousy thing to do to a person."

Lucius, fed and drowsy, was handed along the room to his father. At some point Valens passed behind my stool, saying nothing, took the basil pot off the sill and moved it along to the end of the sill where the sun lay full, and turned it so that the leggy side faced the room. Fenn fixed me with his pale eyes.

"How'd you know where Pompeii's was?" he said. "You can't have had it from anybody back there, I couldn't have found Pompeii's on a map myself till sixty-two. Who put you onto it?"

"The god did. At Delphi."

"Get out."

"I asked the oracle where the door home was. Women can't ask the god directly, so my husband carried it in for me, and the answer came back about the road the dead take out of a city, and a tomb with a door that wasn't one. And afterward the Pythia told me herself, at her own door with her knees aching, that it meant Pompeii."

He left the stool for his table. "You asked the Oracle of Delphi, and it told you. Thirty-four years I've been working this out with

a stick in the sand, and you climb the hill at Delphi and ask. It never crossed my mind. I lived in Phocis two years, and I never walked up that hill and asked."

"She didn't tell me when."

"No, well. They never tell you when. That's what they've got me for." He sobered. "Sixty-two. February. The bad one. You heard about it?"

"Pompeii's still putting itself back together. I live there now. They're up ladders on every street, they've been up them since I came."

"They'll be up ladders when..." He let that go, short of wherever it had been heading. "Yeah. Well. I was in Misenum. I'd got myself in with the fleet down there, the Navy's the Navy, even this one, and I was doing their captains' stars, and I'd gone down with a fever you wouldn't believe, flat on my back in a room over a wineshop, seeing things. It came in the night, and I blamed the fever. I thought the fever had moved into the building. Three days after, I'm sitting up, and there's a carter in the wineshop under me, a Pompeii man, telling the room about a tomb outside the walls whose door breathed cold the night the ground came up. His words, breathed cold. There'd been people out on that road all night, out of their houses, scared to sleep under the roofs, and a whole family sitting on the bench by that tomb felt it on their legs, cold as a cellar, coming off a door that's nothing but paint, till close to dawn. Everybody downstairs laughs. Big joke. Ghosts in the paint. I didn't laugh."

"You went."

"I crawled off that cot and went, soon as my legs would hold me, and I fell down twice on the road. And it was shut." For once he was quiet. "Shut tight. Warm in the sun, like everything else on that road. I'd missed it by four days. I had a fever, and I missed it."

The lighter had gone still in his fingers. He slid it away inside his robe.

"What makes you sure it'll open again?"

"Because they breathe with the earth. That's all I've got, and it's enough. The ground moves hard, and the door opens a crack, and that's how the Corycian went for me. And look at Delphi, built on a fault, with a god in a hole in the ground. Here's how I figure it, and I've had time to figure. It's not a lot of doors. It's one door. One door with many mouths, and it lets you in by one mouth and out by another, and it's no good asking which, or when you'll come out, because it's not a train with a timetable. But it keeps books. It takes back the one it brought. It brought you, so it'll take you. You be at Eros's door when it opens, and you walk in."

"Back to when?"

"Search me. Near where you went in, I hope, I'd hate to come out in the Middle Ages and get burned for a witch." He grinned. "I've got a feeling it's fair, that it owes me sixty-eight. I'll come out an old guy and walk up the front steps and ring the…" He broke off and drank. "And it doesn't stay open, that much I do know. When it goes, it goes for hours. A night, tops, never days. You're there when it breathes, or you're hearing about it in a wineshop three days later with a fever."

Lucius had begun to struggle. Valens lowered him to the floor, and Lucius set off at once across the boards on his hands and knees, very fast and very intent, with his bottom high. He went past the stacks of tablets without a glance and made for the table, where Fenn's robe trailed down, and hauled himself upright by the robe until he found the rim of the sand tray at the level of his eyes. He sank both fists into it. Then he put one of them in his mouth.

“Hey, look at that,” Fenn said, and did not move the tray. “Go ahead, buddy. That’s last Tuesday’s.”

Lucius slapped the sand, hard, and the figure in it went, and Valens started forward.

“Leave him, sir,” Fenn said. “He is improving it.”

Lucius tried the sand again, spat it down his front, and regarded Fenn with deep suspicion.

“Would it take him?”

Fenn looked at the child properly then, with his whole face, as he had stared at me over his lighter. He had sand on his robe to the knee.

“Or anybody at all?” I asked. “Somebody it didn’t bring. If they were holding on to you when you went in. If you carried them through.”

“Beats me.”

“You must have wondered.”

“Wondered with who?” He said it mildly. “I’ve always been on my own. There was never anybody to try it on.” He watched Lucius a while longer. “No idea. Nobody knows, and there’s no way of finding out but the one.”

Lucius had found the bronze rod and was trying to fit it into his ear. Valens crossed the room and relieved him of it, and Lucius flung himself backward in a fury, and Valens caught his head short of the boards with no appearance of haste, and swung him up.

“Does he know the door?” It was to me.

“He knows it.”

He gave me a moment, and when nothing more came, he carried the roaring child out of reach of the tray. He stood rocking there, shifting his weight from one foot to the other, and the roaring wore down into sobs and then into a sort of complaint, and then it stopped.

"He's a big one, your husband," Fenn said. "What's he do, when he isn't breaking my stairs?"

"Mules. He runs a string of them along the coast."

Fenn weighed Valens with a look, and Valens looked steadily back, and Fenn was the first to find a use for his cup. "Nothing surprises me anymore." His cup turned out to be empty, which seemed to offend him. "What were we on?"

"How you know it's seventy-nine."

The number escaped me unchecked. I had never yet said it aloud on this side, and it sounded littler than I had expected, a number off a classroom wall.

"Right. You'd find out anyway. I've been wrong before."

"How wrong?"

"Twice. I had it for seventy-one. I'd worked it from the shakes, every big one since sixty-two, and they said spring of seventy-one, plain as day, so I took a blanket and a jar of something and I parked myself on Eros's bench three nights like a guy waiting for a streetcar. Nothing. Paint. Cold paint at night and warm paint in the day, and nothing. So I worked it all over again, and this time it said seventy-three, in the autumn, and I sat out there three more nights."

"When in the autumn?"

"October, around the Ides. It rained the second night." He made a face. "Nothing."

A Girard Avenue man had sat on Eros's bench in the wet with a blanket over his ears and waited for a door to open.

"I was a mile from you," I said. "That second night, in the rain. I was in bed by the forum."

"Well, cripes," he said at last. "You could've brought me an umbrella."

"You never said you'd be there."

"I don't go telling people where I sit nights." He scratched his stubble with the black nail. "So after seventy-three I quit being cute about it. I'm a dope, but I'm not that big a dope. What happens to Pompeii in seventy-nine, I've had that down cold since high school, and so have you. Every kid who ever sat through second-year Latin knows it. The mountain blows its top and Pompeii goes under, and it's all in Pliny." He opened his hands. "Biggest breath the earth's going to take around here for ten centuries. If sixty-two opened Eros's door for half a night, figure what seventy-nine does. So I took that and ran the tables backward from it, and they fit. That's the thing. Once I had the end, the runs fit, and the gaps fit. You're on that road the night the mountain opens, and you're through and gone before the worst of it. I've got it all on paper."

He left a space for me to ask to see it on paper, and I left it empty.

"You worked it backward," I said.

"I worked it with the stuff I had."

"You were wrong about seventy-one, and you were wrong about seventy-three, and then you took a year out of a schoolbook and made the shakes agree with it."

"They agree on their own. Nobody made them."

"They agree because you knew the answer before you did the sum. Tell somebody the answer's twelve and they'll make the column come out twelve, and never—"

"It didn't go like that."

"Either the ground told you seventy-nine or it didn't, and it didn't. You told it." My voice was climbing, getting quick, the voice I used on the phone with insurance companies, and I could not bring it down. "Twice you sat out there on the strength of your tables, and the door didn't open, and now the third time's different because this time you looked it up?"

"Because this time it's the granddaddy of them all."

"Nobody knows what a mountain does to it. Not you, not anybody. Maybe it shuts it for good. Maybe it opens next spring, on some little shake nobody even notices, and never again. You don't know."

"I saw what sixty-two did."

"Sixty-two was a quake, and you missed it, and you're guessing."

"Sure I'm guessing." He was patient with me, as he must have been with grain-ship captains displeased with their stars, and that was the worst of it. "I've been guessing since I landed. That's all anybody's got here. The difference is, this one's got the end of the world behind it."

"So it's your best guess."

"My best guess."

I looked at the window. The harbor was full of light, and past it the bay, and beyond the water, low and blue with distance, the long green flank of the mountain with a small white cloud sitting on top of it. I brought my eyes back to the room.

"I've been writing them down," I said. "The shakes. Since seventy-two. Every one I've felt in Pompeii, which night, what it shook."

"Terrific. Where?"

"In the back of your notebook."

He sat very still on the edge of his table.

"My notebook."

My satchel hung on its strap at my hip, holding everything else that had crossed with me through the cave, none of which I would trust to a rented room while I was a day's journey off. I undid the flap and took the notebook out. The black oilcloth had gone dull and blunt at the corners. The elastic was long gone; I

had thrown the dead pieces of it away in Delphi. On the cover it read A. J. FENN.

He looked at it. He did not reach for it.

"Where'd that come from?"

"There's a dealer on Antique Row, down on Pine. She had your chart, the Venetian one with your coordinates written on it, and the notebook came with the chart, in a cigar box. She'd bought them at an estate sale." I heard the words as they went out, and could not unsay them. "In Chestnut Hill. The October before I came over. Ninety-seven."

He did not ask whose.

He gazed past me at the bay with the light on it, and the bad hand began to go on the table, harder than before. He covered it with the other and held it down hard. I had the name. Mrs. Szabo had put it across her counter to me between a price and a shrug, the way she would have put down a teacup. I watched him not ask.

"The 23 still run up Germantown Avenue?"

"It's a bus now. They retired the trolley a few years ago."

"A bus," he said, and later, "a bus," once more, and nodded slowly, and let it be.

In the doorway Lucius was asleep, his face crushed into his father's neck, mouth wide. Valens stood without moving, so as not to wake him, and watched Fenn down the room with the look he kept for a horse gone lame that had still to find it out. I offered him the notebook.

"It's yours," I said. "Take it. Your writing's all in the front, down to the goat that ate your postcard."

"I know." He lifted the covering hand off the other, carefully, to test whether it would stay, and it stayed. "Keep it. I know what's in it."

"You haven't seen it in thirty—"

"Kid, I wrote it." He smiled, a good smile, and it cost him something, and he paid. "Back in your bag with it. Write your shakes in it. The back pages could use the work."

I returned it to the satchel and did up the flap.

He stood, and slapped at the sand on his robe, and some of it rained into the tray and the rest onto the boards. "Now. You read? English, I mean, you still read it? You didn't lose it, over here?"

"I didn't lose it."

"I lost some. Words go. You go looking for one and find a hole where it used to be, and you stand there in the hole like a chump. I'll write to you. Give me an address."

"Pompeii. The mender's shop beside Grata's cookshop, east of the forum, the street with the fullery. Any carter on the road knows Grata."

"Grata." He took the charcoal to the wall and wrote it across somebody's sky, in a neat square hand I had pored over, nights, at home in Philadelphia. "A mender's shop. You mend things? Like what?"

"Whatever comes in. Pots, lamps, now and then a bronze."

"Huh," he said, and he looked my hands over slowly, taking his time about it now. He faced the wall again. "I'll send you my tables, every figure, worked out. You can check my math. You'll see. You'll come around."

He stood back from his wall to read his work, and his eye strayed to the sill as he stood, and stopped.

"Who moved my basil?"

"My husband did," I said. "While you were telling me about the ground. He thought it wanted the sun."

"It's been in that spot eleven years." That was to me; then, past me, in his courtly Greek, to Valens: "Sir, my basil. You have moved it."

"It was reaching," Valens said. "All one way. It wants the light on its other side, or it grows like that." He left the leggy stems to speak for themselves. "Turn it every few days. Water it less."

Fenn leaned over and nudged the pot a shade further toward the room with his good hand.

The window's light had gone from white to gold, and the shadows of the stacked tablets lay out long across the boards, and Valens stirred in the doorway.

"The light's going," he said. "We should see to the mules."

"Wait," Fenn said, turning fast and going into Greek. "Sir, the boy. Your wife came here for the boy's stars, and I have cast him nothing. Give me his hour and I will do it tonight and send it to you with my letter, and it will cost you nothing."

Valens regarded him over the sleeping head. "Will they be true?"

"They will be in good Greek," said Fenn, "and very handsome. A long life, under his own fig tree."

"Grata will like that."

"Everyone likes that."

He had the hour from me, as near as any of us had it, and the season, and he set it down in charcoal under Grata's name and blew the dust off it. I got to my feet, and my legs held. My other copper was still on the corner of the table. I reached for it, and then, at a loss, I let it lie.

"You'll be on that road," Fenn said to me, in English again. "My job's the blanket, yours is the umbrella, and when we come out I'm taking you to a ballgame, snow or no snow. Connie Mack, up in the cheap seats with a hot dog. You ever been to Connie Mack?"

I had been driven past where it had stood. My father had pointed it out to me once from the car on Lehigh Avenue, a fenced

lot with a church going up on it, and explained the fire to me. I kept the fire to myself.

I told him his arithmetic was wrong.